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BY

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Founder, Ikkish Prep | First Edition, 2026



IKKISH PREP Golden Grammar Rules

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PREFACE

English grammar is often the deciding factor in competitive examinations — the section that separates those who pass from those who excel. Yet for most students, grammar remains an intimidating maze of confusing rules, vague exceptions, and endless lists to memorise.

This book was born from a single conviction: grammar should be taught the way a mentor explains it — not as a cold list of dos and don'ts, but as a logical system that makes sense once you understand the 'why' behind each rule. Every one of the 139 rules in this book has been chosen specifically because it appears in SBI PO, SSC CGL, IBPS PO, and other major banking and government examinations. Nothing here is filler.

Each rule follows a consistent structure: a clear Concept Explanation, side-by-side Correct and Incorrect examples, a complete list of Exceptions, and a Pro-Tip that reveals the specific examiner trick designed to trap you. Nine high-priority rules also include Quick Reference Tables — because some concepts are simply clearer as a table than as a paragraph.

At the end of the book, you will find a full Practice Exercise Bank with one question per rule, followed by a complete Answer Key. Attempt every question before checking the answers — that is where the real learning happens.

Use this book actively. Underline. Make notes. Return to the rules that confuse you. Grammar is not memorised in a day, but with consistent revision using this structured guide, it will become your strongest section.

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2026



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Omprakash Maurya is the founder of Ikkish Prep, an online education platform built on a single mission: to make high-quality competitive exam preparation accessible to every student across India, regardless of their background or financial means.

Having witnessed firsthand how aspirants from small towns and rural areas struggle to access structured, exam-relevant guidance, Omprakash Maurya channelled that insight into building Ikkish Prep — a platform where technology and pedagogy work together to deliver a preparation experience that is both intelligent and deeply human.

His vision for Ikkish Prep extends beyond test scores. He believes that genuine understanding — not rote memorisation — is what creates confident, capable individuals who can succeed not just in exams, but in the careers and lives that follow. The Golden Grammar Rules series is a direct expression of that philosophy: rigorous, exam-focused, and always student-first.

Under his leadership, Ikkish Prep continues to develop content, tools, and learning experiences that bridge the gap between aspiration and achievement for lakhs of students preparing for India's most competitive examinations.



ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

To every student who has ever sat up late the night before an exam, going over grammar rules one more time — this book is for you. Your determination is the reason this work exists.

To the Ikkish Prep community — your questions, struggles, and breakthroughs have shaped every page of this book. You taught us what students truly need.

To the educators and grammarians whose life's work in standardising English grammar for Indian competitive examinations laid the foundation upon which this book builds. The rules in this volume are grounded in that rigorous academic tradition.

To my family, for their unwavering support and patience through the long hours that any meaningful work requires.

And finally, to the idea that quality education should have no barriers — may this book be one small step toward that larger truth.

— Omprakash Maurya

Ikkish Prep, 2026



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SAME TRAP, DIFFERENT RULE (INDEX)

This index groups rules by the examiner traps they contain. Use this for quick revision before the exam.

■ Intervening Phrase Trap

Rule 17, Rule 26, Rule 58

■ Inversion Trap

Rule 5, Rule 11, Rule 12, Rule 24, Rule 34, Rule 35, Rule 40, Rule 91, Rule 92, Rule 102, Rule 127

■ Uncountable Noun Trap

Rule 21, Rule 22, Rule 37, Rule 53, Rule 54, Rule 66, Rule 70, Rule 91, Rule 92

■ Conditional Trap

Rule 18, Rule 29, Rule 30, Rule 31, Rule 40, Rule 47, Rule 86, Rule 88

■ Pronoun Case Trap

Rule 20, Rule 59, Rule 120

■ Tense Mismatch Trap

Rule 3, Rule 6, Rule 7, Rule 8, Rule 12, Rule 19, Rule 29, Rule 31, Rule 32, Rule 38, Rule 55, Rule 56, Rule 57, Rule 77, Rule 83, Rule 84, Rule 85, Rule 87, Rule 88, Rule 107, Rule 114, Rule 118

RULE 1

Importance: 100/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Basic Principle

A singular subject requires a singular verb, and a plural subject requires a plural verb. This is the fundamental rule of subject-verb agreement.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Proximity Trap': Examiners frequently place a plural noun within a prepositional phrase immediately before the verb (e.g., 'The catalyst for these biochemical reactions trigger...'). This lures the candidate into agreeing the verb with the nearest noun ('reactions') rather than the actual singular subject ('catalyst').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The fundamental tenet of English syntax is that the verb must concord with its subject in number and person. A singular subject necessitates a singular verb, while a plural subject requires a plural verb. In the present tense, this is most evident with the third-person singular, where the verb typically takes an '-s' or '-es' suffix (e.g., 'the economy grows'). A critical challenge for aspirants in competitive exams is identifying the true subject when it is separated from the verb by prepositional phrases or modifiers. The verb must agree with the head noun of the subject phrase, regardless of any intervening plural nouns that may appear closer to the verb.

- >> Identify the 'head noun' (the primary subject) of the sentence; the verb must agree with this noun regardless of any descriptive modifiers attached to it.
- >> Ignore intervening prepositional phrases or parenthetical inserts (e.g., 'of the delegates', 'during the session') when determining whether the subject is singular or plural.
- >> Evaluate collective nouns based on intent: treat them as singular when the group acts as a single unit and plural when the focus is on the individual actions of the members.
- >> Recognize that additive phrases (e.g., 'as well as', 'along with', 'together with', 'in addition to') do not create a compound subject; the verb agrees strictly with the primary subject preceding these phrases.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The rapid advancement of renewable energy technologies mitigate the effects of carbon emissions.

OK CORRECT

The rapid advancement of renewable energy technologies mitigates the effects of carbon emissions.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The meticulous analysis of the quarterly financial reports indicate a significant downturn in the company's revenue.

OK CORRECT

The meticulous analysis of the quarterly financial reports indicates a significant downturn in the company's revenue.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The exhaustive legislation regarding the preservation of indigenous forests, coupled with the strict enforcement of poaching laws, have significantly reduced the rate of deforestation in the Amazon basin.

OK CORRECT

The exhaustive legislation regarding the preservation of indigenous forests, coupled with the strict enforcement of poaching laws, has significantly reduced the rate of deforestation in the Amazon basin.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Nouns that appear plural but are singular in meaning (e.g., 'Mathematics', 'Ethics', 'The News') take singular verbs.
- >> Conversely, nouns that are inherently plural despite lacking a plural suffix (e.g., 'Police', 'People', 'Cattle') require plural verbs.
- >> For fractional or percentage expressions (e.g., 'three-quarters of', 'a majority of'), the verb agrees with the noun following the preposition 'of'.

**PRO-TIP**

Tip: Implement the 'Bracket Method': Mentally isolate phrases starting with 'as well as', 'along with', or 'including' by placing them in brackets. If the sentence remains grammatically sound with the verb agreeing only with the primary subject, the structure is correct.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Detect the error in the following sentence: 'The persistent erosion of traditional cultural values, exacerbated by the globalized nature of digital media, indicate a profound shift in societal norms.'



RULE 2

Importance: 100/100

Pronoun-Antecedent Agreement

A pronoun must agree in number, gender, and person with the noun (antecedent) it refers to. Common errors involve singular antecedents with plural pronouns.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Intervening Plural Noun' trap: Examiners strategically place a plural noun within a prepositional phrase (e.g., 'Each of the diplomats...') immediately before the pronoun. This tempts the candidate to mistakenly match the pronoun with the nearest plural noun ('diplomats') instead of the actual singular distributive subject ('Each').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

An antecedent is the noun or noun phrase to which a pronoun refers. For a sentence to be grammatically sound in formal English, the pronoun must maintain strict agreement with its antecedent in three dimensions: Number (singular vs. plural), Gender (masculine, feminine, or neuter), and Person (first, second, or third). In competitive examinations like SBI PO and SSC CGL, the most frequent errors occur with indefinite pronouns such as 'each', 'every', 'either', 'neither', 'anyone', and 'everyone'. Despite the presence of a plural noun in a prepositional phrase following these words (e.g., 'Each of the students'), the antecedent remains singular, necessitating a singular pronoun. Failure to maintain this agreement results in a 'Pronoun-Antecedent Agreement' error.

>> Distributive pronouns such as 'each', 'every', 'either', 'neither', 'anyone', and 'everyone' are grammatically singular and must be followed by singular pronouns (e.g., his, her, its).

>> When two or more antecedents are connected by 'or' or 'nor', the pronoun must agree in number and gender with the antecedent closest to it, following the 'Proximity Rule'.

>> Collective nouns (e.g., Committee, Jury, Board) require singular pronouns when the group acts as a unified entity, but plural pronouns when the members act individually or are in conflict.

>> Prepositional phrases appearing between the subject and the pronoun (e.g., 'one of the delegates') must be ignored; the pronoun must agree with the head noun of the subject phrase, not the noun within the prepositional phrase.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Every citizen in the electoral district is expected to exercise their right to vote in the upcoming referendum.

OK CORRECT

Every citizen in the electoral district is expected to exercise his or her right to vote in the upcoming referendum.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Each of the delegates from the international summit has expressed their desire to collaborate on the climate treaty.

OK CORRECT

Each of the delegates from the international summit has expressed his or her desire to collaborate on the climate treaty.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Neither of the researchers specializing in quantum entanglement has successfully presented their findings to the international peer-review committee.

OK CORRECT

Neither of the researchers specializing in quantum entanglement has successfully presented his or her findings to the international peer-review committee.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When a collective noun is used to emphasize the individual members of a group rather than the group as a single unit, a plural pronoun is mandatory.

>> Example: 'The judicial panel were divided in their interpretations of the constitutional amendment.'

**PRO-TIP**

Tip: For SBI PO and SSC CGL, strictly adhere to prescriptive grammar. While modern colloquial English and some style guides accept 'they/their' as a singular gender-neutral pronoun, these competitive exams treat it as a grammatical error. Whenever the antecedent is 'Each', 'Every', 'Either', or 'Neither', always opt for a singular pronoun.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Spot the error in the following sentence: 'Each of the social workers assigned to the rural development project has documented their observations regarding the groundwater crisis.' (A) Each of the (B) social workers assigned (C) to the rural development project (D) has documented their observations (E) No error



RULE 3

Importance: 100/100

Tenses: Sequence of Tenses (Main Clause Past)

If the main clause is in the past tense, the verb in the subordinate clause must also be in a corresponding past tense (e.g., present becomes past, future becomes conditional).

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Contextual Fact' Trap: Examiners often use statements that appear to be general truths but are actually time-bound or subject to change. For example, 'The diplomat stated that the current geopolitical climate is unstable.' Many candidates mistakenly leave 'is' in the present tense, thinking it is a fact. However, a 'climate' or 'administration' is temporary, not a universal law; therefore, it must be 'was unstable'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Sequence of Tenses is a fundamental grammatical principle ensuring temporal harmony between the principal (main) clause and the subordinate clause. According to this rule, if the verb in the principal clause is in a past tense, the verb in the subordinate clause must also be in a corresponding past tense. This shift is mandatory to maintain logical consistency. The standard transformations are: Simple Present becomes Simple Past; Present Continuous becomes Past Continuous; Present Perfect becomes Past Perfect; and the Future (will/shall) becomes the Conditional (would/should).

>> Establish temporal alignment: If the principal (main) clause is in the past tense, the subordinate clause must typically align with a corresponding past tense.

>> Tense Shift mapping: Simple Present transitions to Simple Past; Present Continuous transitions to Past Continuous; Present Perfect transitions to Past Perfect.

>> Modal Shift: Future modals 'will' and 'shall' must be converted to their conditional forms 'would' and 'should'.

>> Universal Truth Exception: The present tense is strictly retained in the subordinate clause if the statement expresses a scientific fact, a universal law, or an immutable truth, regardless of the principal clause's tense.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The historian argued that the treaty signed in 1919 is a primary catalyst for the subsequent geopolitical unrest in the region.

OK CORRECT

The historian argued that the treaty signed in 1919 was a primary catalyst for the subsequent geopolitical unrest in the region.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The board of directors announced that the merger will be finalized after the regulatory approval is obtained.

OK CORRECT

The board of directors announced that the merger would be finalized after the regulatory approval was obtained.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The environmental agency reported that the receding glaciers in the Arctic indicate an accelerated rate of warming and will lead to catastrophic sea-level rise.

OK CORRECT

The environmental agency reported that the receding glaciers in the Arctic indicated an accelerated rate of warming and would lead to catastrophic sea-level rise.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The rule of sequence is suspended for universal truths or permanent scientific laws.

>> Example: 'The astrophysicist explained that light travels at a constant speed in a vacuum.' (Here, 'travels' remains in the present tense because it describes a fundamental law of physics).

PRO-TIP

Tip: Utilize the 'Temporal Anchor' method. Identify the principal verb (the Anchor). Once confirmed as past tense, perform a 'Permanence Audit' on all subsequent verbs. Ask: 'Would this statement remain true 1,000 years from now?' If the answer is 'No', the verb must be shifted to the past to maintain sequence.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: The legislative committee noted that the unchecked proliferation of deepfake technology (poses/posed) a severe threat to the integrity of democratic elections.



RULE 4

Importance: 100/100

Prepositions: Fixed Prepositions

Many verbs, adjectives, and nouns are followed by specific prepositions (e.g., 'accused of', 'fond of', 'agree with/to/on'). Incorrect usage is a common error.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Synonym-Substitution Trap': Examiners leverage words with similar meanings to confuse the candidate. For example, because 'comply' is paired with 'with', students often erroneously write 'adhere with' instead of the correct 'adhere to' or 'abide by'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Fixed prepositions are specific prepositions that **MUST** follow certain verbs, adjectives, or nouns. There is no logic — they are fixed by convention and must be memorised. In SBI PO and SSC CGL, examiners replace the correct preposition with a wrong but 'logical-sounding' one. The table below lists the most commonly tested fixed prepositions. Study them until they feel automatic — one wrong preposition can cost you a mark.

- >> Identify the governing headword (verb, adjective, or noun) to determine the specific prepositional requirement dictated by standard English usage.
- >> Analyze the semantic context to distinguish between multiple possible prepositions for a single word (e.g., 'Agree with' a person vs. 'Agree to' a proposal).
- >> Eliminate redundancy by ensuring no preposition follows transitive verbs that take a direct object (e.g., use 'discuss the issue' instead of 'discuss about the issue').
- >> Select the preposition based on the nuance of the object; for instance, 'consist of' refers to physical components, while 'consist in' refers to a defining quality or abstract essence.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The new environmental policy is conducive for the preservation of endangered biodiversity in the Western Ghats.

OK CORRECT

The new environmental policy is conducive to the preservation of endangered biodiversity in the Western Ghats.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The defendant was accused for embezzling funds from the corporate treasury to finance his extravagant lifestyle.

OK CORRECT

The defendant was accused of embezzling funds from the corporate treasury to finance his extravagant lifestyle.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The appellate court's verdict was predicated upon the premise that the legislative amendment was fundamentally non-compliant to the constitutional mandates of the republic.

OK CORRECT

The appellate court's verdict was predicated upon the premise that the legislative amendment was fundamentally non-compliant with the constitutional mandates of the republic.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Certain governing words shift their preposition based on the semantic role of the object.
- >> For instance: 'Agree with' is used for people or opinions, 'Agree to' for proposals or terms, and 'Agree on' for a mutually decided point or date.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Be vigilant regarding 'Transitive Verb Traps'. Verbs such as 'discuss', 'describe', 'mention', 'emphasize', and 'reach' are transitive in these contexts; they act directly on the object. Avoid inserting prepositions like 'about', 'on', or 'to' immediately after these verbs in their active form.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The proposed digital privacy framework is ostensibly designed to protect citizens, yet it remains impervious for scrutiny by independent auditing bodies.'



RULE 5

Importance: 96/100

Correlative Conjunctions: 'Not only... but also' (Parallelism and Inversion)

'Not only' must be followed by 'but also', and both parts must connect grammatically parallel structures. If a sentence starts with 'Not only', it takes inversion.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most common trap involves 'Parallelism Disruption,' where the examiner inserts a subject pronoun (e.g., 'it', 'he', 'they') after 'but also' when the first part of the pair is followed by a verb. Another sophisticated trap is the 'Inversion Omission,' where a sentence starts with 'Not only' but follows a standard subject-verb order, which is grammatically incorrect in formal English.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

This correlative conjunction must balance the sentence. If 'not only' precedes a noun, 'but also' must precede a noun. If it precedes a verb, 'but also' must precede a verb. Furthermore, if the sentence begins with 'Not only', the subject and auxiliary verb must be inverted (Not only + auxiliary verb + subject).

>> Structural Parallelism: The grammatical components following 'not only' and 'but also' must be identical in form. If 'not only' is followed by an adjective, 'but also' must be followed by an adjective; if it is followed by a verb phrase, 'but also' must be followed by a verb phrase.

>> Subject-Auxiliary Inversion: When 'Not only' is placed at the beginning of a sentence for emphasis, the first clause must follow an inverted word order (Auxiliary Verb + Subject + Main Verb), similar to the structure of a question.

>> Optimized Positioning: To avoid ambiguity, 'not only' should be placed immediately before the specific word or phrase it modifies, rather than before the subject, unless the entire clause is being emphasized.

>> Alternative Pairings: The standard 'but also' can be modified; 'also' may be omitted if 'as well' or 'too' is placed at the end of the sentence, provided the structural parallelism is maintained.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The new environmental policy not only aims to reduce carbon emissions but it also promotes the use of renewable energy sources.

OK CORRECT

The new environmental policy not only aims to reduce carbon emissions but also promotes the use of renewable energy sources.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Reserve Bank of India has maintained a cautious stance on interest rates to curb inflationary pressures in the last quarter of 2022.

OK CORRECT

The Reserve Bank of India has maintained a cautious stance on interest rates to curb inflationary pressures since the last quarter.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Not only the diplomatic mission failed to secure a ceasefire, but the international community also struggled to provide humanitarian aid to the conflict zone.

OK CORRECT

Not only did the diplomatic mission fail to secure a ceasefire, but the international community also struggled to provide humanitarian aid to the conflict zone.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When 'not only'.

>> 'but also' connects two subjects of different numbers (one singular, one plural), the verb must agree with the subject closest to it (the Proximity Rule).

>> For example: 'Not only the lead scientist but also the research assistants were surprised by the results of the experiment.'

PRO-TIP



Tip: Utilize the 'Symmetry Test': Mentally delete 'not only' and 'but also' from the sentence. If the remaining fragments cannot stand as two separate, grammatically identical structures, the parallelism is flawed. For example, in 'not only [Verb A] but also [Verb B]', the symmetry is perfect.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: The proliferation of artificial intelligence not only threatens traditional employment sectors but also it raises profound ethical questions regarding data privacy and algorithmic bias.



RULE 6

Importance: 95/100

Tenses: Present Perfect Usage

The present perfect tense is used for actions that started in the past and continue to the present, actions completed recently with present relevance, or experiences.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Temporal Conflict' Trap: Examiners often embed a specific time marker (e.g., 'in the previous century', 'during the 2011 census') deep within a complex sentence containing multiple clauses. The goal is to distract the candidate from the contradiction between a definite past date and the use of the Present Perfect (has/have + V3).

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Present Perfect Tense (Structure: Subject + has/have + Past Participle/V3) is utilized to bridge the gap between the past and the present. It is employed in three primary contexts: 1. Actions that commenced in the past and persist into the present, often accompanied by 'since' (point of time) or 'for' (duration). 2. Actions completed at an unspecified time in the past where the result or relevance is significant in the present. 3. Life experiences where the exact timing of the event is irrelevant. Unlike the Simple Past, the Present Perfect does not specify a finished time period; it focuses on the state of completion or the continuity of the action relative to the current moment.

>> Use the Present Perfect for actions that commenced in the past and persist into the present, utilizing 'since' for a specific starting point and 'for' for a duration of time.

>> Apply this tense to actions completed at an indefinite point in the past where the result or impact is still significant in the current context.

>> Strictly prohibit the use of the Present Perfect when the sentence contains specific past-time markers such as 'yesterday', 'in 1995', 'last decade', or 'two weeks ago'.

>> Mandate the use of the Simple Past (V2) when the action is tied to a definite, concluded time frame.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The global average temperature has risen steadily since fifty years.

OK CORRECT

The global average temperature has risen steadily for fifty years.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy departed from the capital before the treaty had been officially signed by both nations.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy had departed from the capital before the treaty was officially signed by both nations.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The Ministry of External Affairs has ratified the bilateral security treaty during the diplomatic summit convened last October.

OK CORRECT

The Ministry of External Affairs ratified the bilateral security treaty during the diplomatic summit convened last October.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When 'since' functions as a conjunction introducing a subordinate clause, the verb in that subordinate clause must be in the Simple Past, while the main clause remains in the Present Perfect.

>> Example: 'The judicial system has faced immense scrutiny since the landmark judgment was delivered by the Supreme Court.'

PRO-TIP



Tip: In Error Spotting sections for SBI PO or SSC CGL, implement a 'Time-Marker First' scan. Before analyzing the subject-verb agreement, identify words like 'ago', 'last', 'yesterday', or specific years. If a definite time is established, any instance of 'has/have + V3' is an immediate grammatical error and must be converted to the Simple Past (V2).

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Error Detection: 'Artificial Intelligence has revolutionized the accuracy of diagnostic medicine in several premier hospitals during the clinical trials conducted in 2022.'

RULE 7

Importance: 95/100

Tenses: Past Perfect Usage

The past perfect tense is used to describe an action that was completed before another action in the past.

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner frequently employs 'Tense Parallelism' to mislead candidates, using the Simple Past for both actions or incorrectly assigning the Past Perfect to the subsequent event. Another common trap is using 'had' in both clauses of a 'before/after' sentence, which is grammatically redundant and incorrect.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Past Perfect Tense is employed to denote an action that was completed prior to another action occurring in the past. In a sentence containing two past actions, the one that occurred first is expressed in the Past Perfect (had + past participle), while the subsequent action is expressed in the Simple Past. This creates a chronological sequence, effectively acting as the 'past of the past.' This tense is indispensable for maintaining clarity in complex narratives and formal reporting, ensuring the reader understands the exact order of events without ambiguity.

>> In a sentence describing two distinct actions in the past, the action that occurred first must be expressed in the Past Perfect Tense (had + V3).

>> The action that occurred second, or more recently in the past timeline, must be expressed in the Simple Past Tense.

>> Strict adherence to this sequence is required when using time-sequencing conjunctions such as 'before', 'after', 'by the time', and 'until' to avoid ambiguity.

>> In correlative inverted structures like 'Hardly... when', 'Scarcely... when', and 'No sooner... than', the first clause must utilize the Past Perfect to signify an action that happened immediately before the second.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The system administrator updated the security protocols before the malware had infiltrated the network.

OK CORRECT

The system administrator had updated the security protocols before the malware infiltrated the network.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The Managing Director will sign the memorandum of understanding as soon as the legal counsel will review the final draft.

OK CORRECT

The Managing Director will sign the memorandum of understanding as soon as the legal counsel reviews the final draft.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

By the time the legislature passed the landmark environmental bill, the protestors already dispersed from the capital square.

OK CORRECT

By the time the legislature passed the landmark environmental bill, the protestors had already dispersed from the capital square.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When the sequence of events is described as a series of consecutive actions (a narrative list) where one action follows the other immediately without a gap, the Simple Past may be used for all actions.

>> Additionally, in very informal speech, the Past Perfect is often omitted if 'before' or 'after' makes the sequence obvious, though this is considered incorrect in competitive exams.

PRO-TIP

Tip: When encountering negative adverbs like 'Hardly', 'Scarcely', or 'No sooner' at the start of a sentence, look for 'Inversion' (Auxiliary + Subject + Verb). Ensure that 'had' precedes the subject and is paired with the correct conjunction ('when' for Hardly/Scarcely and 'than' for No sooner).

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Spot the Error: The excavation team discovered that the local villagers had altered the site before the government had designated it as a protected monument. (A) The excavation team (B) discovered that the local villagers (C) had altered the site before (D) the government had designated it as a protected monument. (E) No Error



RULE 8

Importance: 95/100

Tenses: Time Clauses (Future Actions)

In clauses of time (beginning with 'when', 'while', 'as soon as', 'before', 'after', 'until', 'unless') referring to future actions, the simple present tense is used, not the future tense.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Symmetry Trap': Examiners often create a rhythmic balance by placing 'will' in both the main and subordinate clauses, tricking the candidate into believing that parallel structure is required for grammatical correctness, whereas it actually constitutes a tense error.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In complex sentences where a main clause and a subordinate clause of time are present, if the main clause refers to a future action (typically using 'will' or 'shall'), the subordinate clause—introduced by temporal conjunctions such as 'when', 'as soon as', 'until', 'before', 'after', 'once', or 'the moment'—must be expressed in the Simple Present Tense. Despite the action occurring in the future, the use of the future tense ('will/shall') within the time clause is grammatically incorrect in formal English and is a frequent point of testing in competitive examinations.

- >> Identify temporal conjunctions such as 'when', 'as soon as', 'until', 'before', 'after', 'once', or 'unless' that initiate the subordinate clause.
- >> Determine if the primary action of the sentence occurs in the future, typically indicated by modal verbs like 'will' or 'shall' in the main clause.
- >> Ensure the verb within the time-based subordinate clause is expressed in the Simple Present tense, even though the temporal reference is to a future event.
- >> Critically differentiate between a Time Clause and a Noun Clause; if the clause functions as the object of a verb—answering 'what' rather than 'when'—the future tense is mandatory (e.g., 'I do not know when the treaty will be signed').

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The biodiversity in the region will decline significantly when the deforestation will continue unabated.

OK CORRECT

The biodiversity in the region will decline significantly when the deforestation continues unabated.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The board of directors scrutinized the financial statements meticulous to ensure regulatory compliance.

OK CORRECT

The board of directors scrutinized the financial statements meticulously to ensure regulatory compliance.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislative assembly will not ratify the amendment unless the steering committee will provide a comprehensive impact assessment report.

OK CORRECT

The legislative assembly will not ratify the amendment unless the steering committee provides a comprehensive impact assessment report.

EXCEPTIONS

>> This rule does not apply to Noun Clauses.

>> For instance, in the sentence 'The scientists are unsure when the asteroid will impact the lunar surface,' the clause 'when the asteroid will impact...' is the object of the adjective 'unsure,' making the use of 'will' grammatically correct.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Utilize the 'Double-Will' Filter: In high-pressure exams like SBI PO or SSC CGL, if you encounter a sentence containing a time conjunction and two instances of 'will', the 'will' located inside the subordinate clause is almost invariably the error.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The space agency will commence the lunar landing sequence once the lander will establish a secure communication link with the orbiting module.'



RULE 9

Importance: 95/100

Adjectives vs. Adverbs: Usage and Distinction

Adjectives modify nouns and pronouns, describing their qualities. Adverbs modify verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs, describing how, when, where, or to what extent.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most sophisticated trap involves placing an adverb after a linking verb (e.g., 'The witness remained silently'). Examiners often use complex subjects (e.g., 'The constitutional validity of the amendment') to distract the candidate from the fact that the verb ('remained' or 'seemed') is a linking verb requiring a subject complement (adjective).

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, the distinction between adjectives and adverbs is determined by the part of speech they modify. An adjective is employed exclusively to qualify or describe a noun or a pronoun, answering questions such as 'What kind?', 'Which one?', or 'How many?'. In contrast, an adverb modifies a verb, an adjective, or another adverb, providing essential detail regarding the manner, time, place, or degree of the action or quality. A frequent error in competitive examinations is the 'adjective-for-adverb' substitution, where a descriptive word is used to modify a verb without the necessary adverbial inflection (typically the '-ly' suffix).

- >> Employ adjectives strictly to modify nouns or pronouns, providing specific attributes or characteristics (e.g., 'the systemic failure').
- >> Use adverbs to modify verbs, adjectives, other adverbs, or whole clauses to indicate how, when, where, or to what extent an action is performed (e.g., 'failed systemically').
- >> Linking verbs (copular verbs) such as 'be', 'seem', 'appear', 'become', 'feel', 'sound', and 'remain' must be followed by adjectives because they attribute a quality to the subject rather than describing the action of the verb.
- >> Distinguish between 'flat adverbs' (e.g., 'fast', 'hard') that do not take the '-ly' suffix and words where the addition of '-ly' fundamentally alters the meaning (e.g., 'late' vs. 'lately').

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The atmospheric pressure dropped sudden during the meteorological event.

OK CORRECT

The atmospheric pressure dropped suddenly during the meteorological event.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The board of directors will discuss about the strategic realignment of the company's assets in the next quarterly meeting.

OK CORRECT

The board of directors will discuss the strategic realignment of the company's assets in the next quarterly meeting.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Despite the geopolitical tension, the envoy appeared calmly throughout the summit, and the proposed treaty sounded realistically to the delegates.

OK CORRECT

Despite the geopolitical tension, the envoy appeared calm throughout the summit, and the proposed treaty sounded realistic to the delegates.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Certain words ending in '-ly' are adjectives, not adverbs (e.g., friendly, lovely, lonely, scholarly).
- >> These must be used as adjectives or modified into adverbial phrases (e.g., 'in a friendly manner') to describe an action.

PRO-TIP



Tip: To determine if a verb is a linking verb, try replacing it with a form of 'to be' (am, is, are, was, were). If the sentence remains grammatically logical, it is a linking verb and requires an adjective. For example: 'The solution smells strange' $\rightarrow$ 'The solution is strange' (Logical $\rightarrow$ Use adjective).

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The algorithm functioned efficient, ensuring that the urban planning software remained accurate despite the massive influx of real-time data.'

**RULE 10****Importance: 95/100****Redundant Prepositions**

Avoid using unnecessary prepositions after certain verbs (e.g., 'comprise' does not take 'of', 'discuss' does not take 'about', 'enter' does not take 'into' for physical entry).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently test the subtle distinction between 'despite' and 'in spite of'. A common error is the hybrid 'despite of'. Another trap involves using 'comprise' in the active voice but adding 'of' to mimic the structure of 'consist of'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, certain transitive verbs are frequently followed by unnecessary prepositions due to a mistaken attempt to clarify the relationship between the verb and its object. According to traditional grammar conventions (as seen in Wren & Martin), these verbs directly act upon their objects; therefore, inserting a preposition creates a redundancy that is considered a grammatical error in competitive examinations. Common culprits include 'discuss' (often wrongly paired with 'about'), 'enter' (wrongly paired with 'into' for physical entry), 'comprise' (wrongly paired with 'of' in active voice), and 'resemble' (wrongly paired with 'to' or 'with').

- >> Eliminate 'about' when it follows transitive verbs such as 'discuss', 'describe', or 'mention'.
- >> Avoid using 'into' after 'enter' when referring to the physical act of entering a place or building.
- >> Do not use 'of' after 'comprise' when it is used in the active voice to signify 'consisting of'.
- >> Avoid following 'resemble' with 'to' or 'with', as the verb directly takes an object.
- >> Ensure 'despite' is never followed by 'of'; use 'in spite of' if the preposition 'of' is required.
- >> Avoid using 'back' after 'return' when the context clearly implies returning to a point of origin or a previous state.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The lead scientist described about the atmospheric anomalies observed during the solar eclipse.

OK CORRECT

The lead scientist described the atmospheric anomalies observed during the solar eclipse.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

No sooner had the Monetary Policy Committee announced the repo rate hike when the stock market witnessed a sharp decline.

OK CORRECT

No sooner had the Monetary Policy Committee announced the repo rate hike than the stock market witnessed a sharp decline.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Despite of the legislative deadlock, the diplomatic envoy entered into the parliament house to propose a ceasefire, a move that resembled to a desperate attempt to avert war.

OK CORRECT

Despite the legislative deadlock, the diplomatic envoy entered the parliament house to propose a ceasefire, a move that resembled a desperate attempt to avert war.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The phrase 'enter into' is grammatically correct when used figuratively, such as 'entering into an agreement,' 'entering into a contract,' or 'entering into a discussion.' Additionally, 'comprise' can be followed by 'of' when used in the passive voice (e.g., 'The committee is comprised of experts').

PRO-TIP

Tip: Distinguish between the functional role of a word as a verb versus a noun. For instance, as a verb, 'lack' is transitive and requires no preposition ('The treaty lacks clarity'), but as a noun, it requires 'of' ('There is a lack of clarity in the treaty').



TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The archaeological site comprises of several subterranean chambers and intricate frescoes dating back to the Mauryan Empire.'



RULE 11

Importance: 95/100

Correlative Conjunctions (Pairing and Parallelism)

Correlative conjunctions must always be used in pairs (e.g., 'both...and', 'either...or', 'neither...nor', 'not only...but also', 'hardly/scarcely...when', 'no sooner...than').

EXAMINER TRAP: The most frequent trap is the 'Conjunction Swap', where 'than' is replaced by 'when' (or vice versa) in 'No sooner' and 'Hardly' structures. Another advanced trap is the 'Parallelism Break', where the examiner pairs a noun phrase with a full independent clause, disrupting the symmetry of the sentence.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Correlative conjunctions always work in PAIRS — the first word introduces the idea, the second completes it. The most common exam errors are: (1) Using 'when' instead of 'than' with 'No sooner', (2) Forgetting subject-verb inversion with 'Hardly/No sooner', (3) Breaking parallelism after 'not only...but also'. Study the table below — memorise each pair and its special rule.

>> Strict Pairing: Adhere to the designated pairs: 'Both' must pair with 'and', 'Either' with 'or', 'Neither' with 'nor', 'Not only' with 'but also', 'No sooner' with 'than', and 'Hardly/Scarcely' with 'when'.

>> Proximity Rule for Verb Agreement: In 'Either...or' and 'Neither...nor' constructions, the verb must agree in number and person with the subject closest to it.

>> Negative Inversion Requirement: When a sentence commences with negative correlatives such as 'No sooner', 'Hardly', or 'Scarcely', the auxiliary verb must precede the subject (Inversion) to maintain formal syntax.

>> Structural Parallelism: The grammatical element following the first conjunction must mirror the element following the second. If a prepositional phrase follows 'not only', a prepositional phrase must follow 'but also'.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Neither the reforestation initiatives or the carbon tax policies were sufficient to halt the ecological decline.

OK CORRECT

Neither the reforestation initiatives nor the carbon tax policies were sufficient to halt the ecological decline.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Ambassador remarked that the bilateral trade agreement will facilitate unprecedented economic growth in the coming decade.

OK CORRECT

Direct: The Ambassador remarked, 'The bilateral trade agreement will facilitate unprecedented economic growth in the coming decade.' Indirect: The Ambassador remarked that the bilateral trade agreement would facilitate unprecedented economic growth in the following decade.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

No sooner had the archaeologists unearthed the subterranean chamber when they discovered an array of undeciphered manuscripts dating back to the Bronze Age.

OK CORRECT

No sooner had the archaeologists unearthed the subterranean chamber than they discovered an array of undeciphered manuscripts dating back to the Bronze Age.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In highly formal or literary contexts, 'also' may be omitted in 'not only'.

>> 'but' constructions if the meaning remains unambiguous.

>> Additionally, 'neither' may be used as a standalone pronoun/determiner without 'nor' if the negation is implied by the context.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Adopt a three-step verification process: First, verify the pair (e.g., Neither $\rightarrow$ Nor). Second, if the sentence starts with a negative, check for Subject-Auxiliary Inversion. Third, draw a mental line between the two conjunctions and ensure the parts of speech on both sides are identical.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The emerging AI architecture not only optimizes data processing speeds but it also enhances the predictive accuracy of the neural network.'

RULE 12

Importance: 95/100

Direct and Indirect Speech Transformation

This rule governs the conversion of direct speech into indirect speech, involving systematic changes in tenses, pronouns, time/place expressions, and sentence structure for statements, questions, commands, and exclamations, with exceptions for universal truths.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Interrogative Inversion' trap is most common, where the examiner maintains the verb-subject order of a question in indirect speech (e.g., 'He asked where was the archive' instead of 'where the archive was'). Another trap involves incorrectly backshifting a permanent fact or a present-tense reporting verb.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Direct speech reports the exact words of the speaker enclosed in quotation marks, while Indirect (Reported) speech conveys the essence of the statement without quoting verbatim. The transformation requires four systematic adjustments: 1. Tense Shift (Backshifting): When the reporting verb is in the past tense, the verb in the reported speech shifts back (e.g., Present Simple to Past Simple, Present Perfect to Past Perfect, and 'will' to 'would'). 2. Pronoun Shift: Pronouns are adjusted to maintain the logical perspective of the reporter (the SON rule: Subject, Object, No change). 3. Time and Place Expressions: Deictic words are converted to reflect the change in context (e.g., 'now' to 'then', 'today' to 'that day', 'yesterday' to 'the previous day', 'here' to 'there'). 4. Structural Changes: Assertive sentences use the conjunction 'that'; Interrogative sentences use 'if/whether' for yes/no questions or the WH-word for open questions (converting the question format into a statement); Imperative sentences use 'to + infinitive'; and Exclamatory sentences are transformed into assertive statements using reporting verbs like 'exclaimed with joy/sorrow'.

>> Tense Backshifting: When the reporting verb is in the past tense, the verb in the reported speech must shift back (e.g., Simple Present to Simple Past, Present Perfect to Past Perfect, and 'will' to 'would').

>> Pronoun Alignment: Pronouns must be adjusted to maintain the logical perspective of the reporter, ensuring the subject and object reflect the change in speaker and listener.

>> Deictic Shift: Time and place markers must be converted to reflect the shift in context (e.g., 'now' becomes 'then', 'today' becomes 'that day', 'yesterday' becomes 'the previous day', and 'here' becomes 'there').

>> Structural Conversion: Assertive sentences are introduced by 'that'; Interrogatives use 'if/whether' for yes/no questions or the WH-word for open questions, converting the question structure into an assertive statement; Imperatives use 'to + infinitive'.

>> Tense Stability: Backshifting is not required if the reporting verb is in the present or future tense, or if the reported content is a universal truth, a scientific fact, or a permanent legal statute.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The diplomat stated that the ceasefire agreement is still in effect across the border.

OK CORRECT

The diplomat stated that the ceasefire agreement was still in effect across the border.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The board of directors emphasized the necessity of streamlining operations, reducing redundant costs, and to enhance shareholder value.

OK CORRECT

The board of directors emphasized the necessity of streamlining operations, reducing redundant costs, and enhancing shareholder value.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The Commission Chairperson inquired the lead scientist why had the atmospheric data been skewed during the initial trial.

OK CORRECT

The Commission Chairperson inquired of the lead scientist why the atmospheric data had been skewed during the initial trial.

**EXCEPTIONS**

>> Tense backshifting is bypassed when the statement represents a timeless truth.

>> For example: 'The professor explained that the laws of thermodynamics are universal' is correct, even though 'explained' is in the past tense.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Prioritize the reporting verb. If it is in the present tense (e.g., 'The Secretary claims'), the tense of the reported speech remains unchanged. For questions, remember that indirect speech transforms a query into a statement; therefore, the question mark is removed and the subject must always precede the verb.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: The Lead Architect explained that the structural integrity of the skyscraper will be compromised if the foundation is not reinforced by next month.

**RULE 13****Importance: 95/100****Parallelism (Grammatical Structure)**

This rule ensures that elements in a list, series, comparison, or those joined by correlative conjunctions maintain a consistent grammatical form for clarity and correctness.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently employ 'distractor clauses'—long, complex modifiers placed between the first part of a correlative pair and the second part. This distance is designed to make the candidate forget the initial grammatical structure, leading them to overlook a mismatch in the final clause.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Parallelism, or parallel structure, is the requirement that elements of equal importance within a sentence be expressed in the same grammatical form. This ensures logical symmetry and clarity. In competitive examinations, this rule is primarily tested in three scenarios: 1. Lists or Series: If a sentence lists multiple actions or items, they must all be nouns, all be adjectives, or all be verbs (e.g., all gerunds or all infinitives). 2. Comparisons: When comparing two things using 'than' or 'as', the structures being compared must be grammatically identical. 3. Correlative Conjunctions: Words joined by pairs such as 'Either...or', 'Neither...nor', 'Not only...but also', and 'Whether...or' must be followed by the same part of speech. A failure to maintain this balance results in a 'faulty parallelism' error.

>> Maintain consistency in grammatical forms (e.g., all gerunds, all infinitives, or all noun phrases) when presenting a series of items or actions.

>> Ensure that the structural composition of elements being compared using 'than' or 'as' is identical to avoid logical ambiguity.

>> Apply strict symmetry to correlative conjunctions (e.g., 'Not only... but also', 'Either... or', 'Neither... nor'); the grammatical category following the first conjunction must match the category following the second.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The environmental committee recommended reducing carbon emissions, protecting endangered species, and that reforestation be prioritized.

OK CORRECT

The environmental committee recommended reducing carbon emissions, protecting endangered species, and prioritizing reforestation.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Having analyzed the quarterly fiscal reports, the investment strategy was revised by the Board of Directors.

OK CORRECT

Having analyzed the quarterly fiscal reports, the Board of Directors decided to revise the investment strategy.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The newly enacted legislative framework requires the administration not only to amend the existing land-use laws but also that it implement a rigorous monitoring system for industrial waste.

OK CORRECT

The newly enacted legislative framework requires the administration not only to amend the existing land-use laws but also to implement a rigorous monitoring system for industrial waste.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While strict parallelism is mandatory for formal and competitive examinations, authors of literary or rhetorical prose may occasionally employ 'broken parallelism' to create a specific stylistic effect or emphasis, though this is technically categorized as a grammatical error in a testing context.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Utilize the 'Bracket Technique': Mentally isolate or bracket the phrases immediately following each part of a correlative pair. If the first bracket contains a verb phrase (e.g., [to amend...]) and the second contains a noun clause (e.g., [that it implement...]), the sentence lacks structural equilibrium and is incorrect.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The research paper argues that the integration of Artificial Intelligence into healthcare can lead to more accurate diagnoses, the reduction of human error, and providing personalized patient care.'

RULE 14

Importance: 95/100

Sentence Structure: Dangling Modifiers

A *dangling modifier* is a phrase or clause that modifies a word not clearly stated in the sentence. The subject of the modifying phrase must be the same as the subject of the main clause.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most frequent trap is the 'Passive Voice Pivot.' Examiners often place the logical agent at the end of the sentence using a 'by' phrase (passive voice) and place an inanimate object as the subject. Candidates often read for meaning rather than syntax, failing to notice that the opening modifier is logically attached to a subject that cannot perform the action.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

A dangling modifier is a syntactic error that occurs when a modifying phrase (typically a participial phrase) is placed in a sentence without a clear or logical subject to modify. According to traditional grammar conventions, when a sentence begins with a modifying phrase, the noun immediately following the comma (the subject of the main clause) must be the agent performing the action described in that phrase. If the subject of the main clause is not the intended agent, the modifier is said to 'dangle,' resulting in a sentence that is either logically absurd or grammatically incorrect. In high-level competitive exams, this is used to test a candidate's ability to maintain logical consistency between the modifier and the subject.

>> The noun immediately following the introductory modifying phrase must be the agent performing the action described in that phrase.

>> Avoid using passive voice in the main clause when the introductory phrase is active, as the passive construction often displaces the logical subject.

>> Maintain logical consistency by ensuring the subject of the main clause is the intended target of the modification.

>> Distinguish between dangling modifiers and 'impersonal modifiers' (e.g., 'Considering the evidence', 'Judging from the reports'), which are grammatically acceptable regardless of the main clause subject.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

Walking through the ancient ruins, the architecture seemed remarkably well-preserved.

OK CORRECT

Walking through the ancient ruins, the historian noted that the architecture seemed remarkably well-preserved.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The board of directors discussed the proposed acquisition of the startup in the annual general meeting.

OK CORRECT

In the annual general meeting, the board of directors discussed the proposed acquisition of the startup.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

Having analyzed the socio-economic impact of the new legislation, the policy was deemed insufficient by the parliamentary committee.

OK CORRECT

Having analyzed the socio-economic impact of the new legislation, the parliamentary committee deemed the policy insufficient.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain conventional phrases known as impersonal modifiers—such as 'Considering the circumstances', 'Given the current climate', or 'Judging by the data'—do not require a matching subject in the main clause and are not considered dangling.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Apply the 'Immediate Subject Test': Isolate the phrase before the comma and the first noun after the comma. Ask: 'Can this noun physically or logically perform the action described in the phrase?' If the answer is 'No,' the modifier is dangling, regardless of whether the intended agent appears later in the sentence.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Using a sophisticated CRISPR-Cas9 technique, the gene mutation was successfully edited by the research team.'



RULE 15

Importance: 95/100

Sentence Structure: Misplaced Modifiers

A *misplaced modifier* is a word or phrase that is placed incorrectly in a sentence, making it unclear which word or phrase it is modifying. It should be placed as close as possible to the word it modifies.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often place a modifier after a noun that is thematically related to the topic, tricking candidates into relying on their general understanding of the subject matter rather than analyzing the precise syntactic proximity of the modifier.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

A misplaced modifier occurs when a word, phrase, or clause is improperly separated from the word it is intended to describe. According to the principle of proximity in English grammar, modifiers must be placed as close as possible to the noun or verb they qualify to ensure clarity and logical coherence. When a modifier is positioned incorrectly, it may inadvertently modify an unintended word, resulting in ambiguity or an illogical meaning. In high-level competitive examinations, these errors are often subtle, requiring the candidate to analyze whether the modifier logically attributes a quality to the nearest noun.

- >> Position the modifier immediately adjacent to the target noun or verb to eliminate semantic ambiguity.
- >> Place limiting modifiers—such as 'only', 'almost', 'nearly', and 'merely'—directly before the specific word or phrase they are intended to restrict.
- >> Avoid inserting modifying phrases between the subject and its predicate if the placement disrupts the logical sequence of the action.
- >> Carefully audit the sentence to ensure the modifier does not inadvertently qualify a nearby noun that is contextually plausible but logically incorrect.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The astronomer observed a distant galaxy using a state-of-the-art telescope.

OK CORRECT

Using a state-of-the-art telescope, the astronomer observed a distant galaxy.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The burgeoning infrastructure projects in the metropolitan area have progressed with leaps and bounds over the last decade.

OK CORRECT

The burgeoning infrastructure projects in the metropolitan area have progressed by leaps and bounds over the last decade.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislative committee proposed a set of stringent reforms for the healthcare sector during the plenary session that aimed to reduce patient wait times.

OK CORRECT

During the plenary session, the legislative committee proposed a set of stringent reforms for the healthcare sector that aimed to reduce patient wait times.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Sentence modifiers (e.g., 'Fortunately', 'Interestingly', 'Unexpectedly') can be placed at the beginning of a sentence to qualify the entire clause rather than a specific noun or verb.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Distinguish clearly between 'Misplaced' and 'Dangling' modifiers. In a misplaced modifier, the word being modified is present in the sentence but poorly positioned. In a dangling modifier, the target word is entirely missing, necessitating a structural rewrite of the subject.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The software architect developed an algorithm to detect anomalies in network traffic that was capable of processing petabytes of data in real-time.'

RULE 16

Importance: 95/100

Idiomatic Expressions: Correct Usage

Many idiomatic expressions have fixed structures and meanings. Using incorrect prepositions, articles, or words within these idioms is a common error tested in exams.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Synonym Substitution' trap is common, where the examiner replaces a word in a fixed idiom with a close synonym (e.g., replacing 'bone of contention' with 'stick of contention' or 'stone of contention') to test if the candidate recognizes the phrase as a fixed unit rather than a literal description.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Idiomatic expressions are phrases where the meaning is figurative and cannot be deduced from the literal definitions of the individual words. In high-level competitive examinations such as SBI PO and SSC CGL, the 'fixed' nature of these expressions is tested. An idiom is considered a single lexical unit; therefore, altering its internal components—such as substituting a preposition, changing an article, or replacing a noun with a synonym—renders the expression grammatically incorrect. Examiners frequently introduce errors by replacing the conventional preposition (e.g., using 'with' instead of 'by') to mislead candidates who rely on literal translation rather than idiomatic convention.

- >> Treat an idiom as a single, immutable lexical unit; any modification to its internal structure typically invalidates the expression.
- >> Do not substitute fixed prepositions based on literal logic (e.g., 'at a loss' must not be changed to 'in a loss' despite 'in' often denoting a state).
- >> Strictly avoid replacing key nouns or verbs within an idiom with synonyms, as idiomaticity depends on specific word pairings.
- >> Adhere to standard British English conventions as they form the primary basis for evaluation in SSC and Banking examinations.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The diplomat tried to beat around the hedge to avoid answering the provocative question about the treaty.

OK CORRECT

The diplomat tried to beat around the bush to avoid answering the provocative question about the treaty.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The diplomatic envoy attempted to iron over the discrepancies in the bilateral trade agreement before the summit.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy attempted to iron out the discrepancies in the bilateral trade agreement before the summit.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The dispute over the distribution of water rights between the two riparian states has remained a bone in contention for several decades.

OK CORRECT

The dispute over the distribution of water rights between the two riparian states has remained a bone of contention for several decades.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Certain idioms may have regional variants (American vs. British), but for the purpose of SSC CGL and SBI PO, the standard Oxford or Cambridge dictionary form is considered the only correct version.

PRO-TIP



Tip: When encountering an unfamiliar phrase in the 'Error Detection' section, check if it functions as a fixed idiom. If the phrase sounds almost correct but has a slightly off preposition or noun, it is likely a test of idiomatic precision rather than standard grammatical syntax.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Despite the systemic failures of the urban planning commission, the lead architect refused to throw in his towel until the revised blueprints were approved.'

**RULE 17****Importance: 95/100****Phrasal Verbs**

Phrasal verbs (verb + preposition/adverb) have idiomatic meanings. Correct usage involves knowing the specific preposition/adverb required and their meaning.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often test 'inseparable' phrasal verbs by placing a pronoun (it, them, him) between the verb and the particle. For instance, using 'look it into' instead of 'look into it'. Another common trap is the use of a base verb after 'look forward to' or 'get around to', ignoring the fact that 'to' here is a preposition requiring a gerund.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Phrasal verbs are idiomatic expressions formed by combining a base verb with a particle (a preposition or an adverb). The critical characteristic of a phrasal verb is that its meaning is often non-literal and cannot be deduced by looking at the individual words. For competitive exams, it is essential to distinguish between Transitive phrasal verbs (which require a direct object) and Intransitive phrasal verbs (which do not). Furthermore, transitive phrasal verbs are categorized as Separable, where the object can be placed between the verb and the particle (e.g., 'turn the lights off'), or Inseparable, where the particle must immediately follow the verb (e.g., 'look after the child'). Errors in these exams typically stem from the use of an incorrect particle or the misplacement of the object in inseparable combinations.

- >> Distinguish between transitive phrasal verbs, which require a direct object to complete their meaning, and intransitive phrasal verbs, which can stand alone as a complete predicate.
- >> Determine the separability of transitive phrasal verbs: separable verbs allow the object to be placed between the verb and the particle, whereas inseparable verbs require the object to follow the particle immediately.
- >> Verify that the chosen particle (preposition or adverb) accurately reflects the specific idiomatic meaning required by the context, as the same base verb can yield vastly different meanings with different particles.
- >> In phrasal-prepositional verbs (Verb + Adverb + Preposition), ensure the final preposition is followed by a noun or a gerund (V1+ing), as these structures never take a base verb infinitive.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The environmental advocate sought to bring up a systemic change in the way the municipality manages electronic waste.

OK CORRECT

The environmental advocate sought to bring about a systemic change in the way the municipality manages electronic waste.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Each of the candidates who applied for the executive position have been scrutinized thoroughly by the selection committee.

OK CORRECT

Each of the candidates who applied for the executive position has been scrutinized thoroughly by the selection committee.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislative committee spent several weeks brushing up the intricacies of the proposed treaty to ensure no legal loopholes remained.

OK CORRECT

The legislative committee spent several weeks ironing out the intricacies of the proposed treaty to ensure no legal loopholes remained.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Certain phrasal verbs can function as both verbs and nouns; however, the noun form is typically written as a single word (e.g., 'The system had a breakdown' as a noun vs. 'The system broke down' as a phrasal verb).



>> Additionally, some phrasal verbs can be either separable or inseparable depending on the specific nuance of the meaning intended.

PRO-TIP

Tip: To master phrasal-prepositional verbs, remember that the terminal 'to' in expressions like 'be accustomed to' or 'look forward to' is a preposition, not an infinitive marker. Therefore, it must be followed by a Gerund. Example: 'The diplomat is accustomed to negotiating in high-pressure environments' (Correct) vs. 'The diplomat is accustomed to negotiate...' (Incorrect).

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Despite the initial setbacks and the volatility of the experimental data, the research team refused to give _____ the quest for a sustainable fusion reactor. (Fill in the blank: up / away / out)

**RULE 18****Importance: 95/100****Verbs: Subjunctive Mood (Wishes, Unreal Conditions, and Mandates)**

The subjunctive mood is used to express wishes, hypothetical situations, or commands, taking the base form of the verb or 'were' for all subjects.

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner typically places a singular subject (e.g., 'the Secretary', 'the administration', 'the treaty') immediately before the verb in a 'that' clause. This creates a psychological lure to apply standard Third-Person Singular agreement (adding 's'), whereas the subjunctive mood requires the base form regardless of the subject's number.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In sentences expressing a wish or an unreal condition (often starting with 'I wish', 'If only', or 'As if'), the verb 'to be' always takes the form 'were', regardless of whether the subject is singular or plural. For commands or suggestions (e.g., 'It is essential that...', 'I demand that...'), the base form of the verb is used without 's' or 'es'.

- >> Use 'were' instead of 'was' for all subjects (I, he, she, it, the government, the entity) when expressing a wish or a hypothetical condition that is contrary to current facts.
- >> Employ the base form of the verb (the infinitive without 'to', devoid of 's', 'es', or 'ed') in 'that' clauses following verbs of demand, suggestion, or necessity (e.g., insist, mandate, propose, urge, recommend).
- >> Apply the base form of the verb in 'that' clauses following adjectives of urgency or importance, such as 'imperative', 'essential', 'crucial', or 'vital'.
- >> Maintain the indicative mood (was/were) only when the condition described is a real possibility or a factual inquiry rather than an imaginary scenario.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

If the climate summit was more effective, global temperatures would have stabilized sooner.

OK CORRECT

If the climate summit were more effective, global temperatures would have stabilized sooner.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Managing Director, as well as the senior vice-presidents, are reviewing the quarterly fiscal reports.

OK CORRECT

The Managing Director, as well as the senior vice-presidents, is reviewing the quarterly fiscal reports.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The parliamentary committee recommended that the Ministry of Home Affairs implements a more stringent vetting process for diplomatic envoys.

OK CORRECT

The parliamentary committee recommended that the Ministry of Home Affairs implement a more stringent vetting process for diplomatic envoys.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> In informal spoken English, 'was' is frequently used in place of 'were' for hypotheticals; however, in formal writing and competitive examinations (SSC/Banking), the subjunctive 'were' is mandatory.
- >> Additionally, verbs like 'suggest' can be followed by a gerund (e.g., 'He suggested revising the law') instead of a subjunctive 'that' clause.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Identify 'Trigger Words' such as 'Imperative', 'Crucial', 'Mandate', or 'Insist'. Once these are spotted, immediately bypass your standard subject-verb agreement logic and 'strip' the following verb of any suffixes like -s, -es, or -ed.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead astrophysicist insisted that the research team conducts a double-blind analysis of the telemetry data to eliminate observational bias before the findings are submitted to the journal.'



RULE 19

Importance: 95/100

Tenses: 'Since' vs. 'For'

'Since' is used to indicate a specific starting point in time, while 'for' is used to indicate a duration or period of time. Both are typically used with perfect tenses.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Last' Ambiguity: Examiners frequently use 'last' to trigger errors. 'Since last year' specifies a starting point (the beginning of that year). However, 'for the last year' indicates a duration of 365 days. The presence of the definite article 'the' before 'last' usually signals a duration, necessitating the use of 'for'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

This is one of the most tested traps in SBI PO and SSC CGL tense questions. 'Since' tells us WHEN the action started (a specific point). 'For' tells us HOW LONG the action has been going on (a period/duration). Both are used with the Present Perfect or Present Perfect Continuous tense. The quick test: if you can replace the word with a specific date or event, use 'since'. If you can replace it with 'a total of X days/years', use 'for'.

- >> Employ 'since' when the temporal reference is a precise point in time, a specific date, or a milestone event (e.g., since 1947, since last Tuesday, since the treaty was signed).
- >> Employ 'for' when the reference is a measurable quantity of time or a duration (e.g., for a fortnight, for three centuries, for several hours).
- >> Ensure the primary verb is in the Present Perfect or Present Perfect Continuous tense to correctly indicate an action that commenced in the past and persists into the present.
- >> Distinguish 'since' as a temporal marker from its use as a subordinating conjunction acting as a synonym for 'because'.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The rainforests of the Amazon have been experiencing rapid depletion since three decades.

OK CORRECT

The rainforests of the Amazon have been experiencing rapid depletion for three decades.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Neither the Chief Executive Officer nor the board members is amenable to the proposed merger.

OK CORRECT

Neither the Chief Executive Officer nor the board members are amenable to the proposed merger.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislative body has deliberated upon the proposed constitutional amendment for the submission of the draft report in January.

OK CORRECT

The legislative body has deliberated upon the proposed constitutional amendment since the submission of the draft report in January.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While 'since' and 'for' are typically paired with perfect tenses, 'for' can be used with the Simple Past or Future tenses to describe a completed or planned duration (e.g., 'The diplomat stayed in Geneva for two weeks' or 'The summit will last for five days').

PRO-TIP

Tip: Utilize the 'Point vs. Period' diagnostic: If the time phrase answers the question 'When did this begin?', use 'since'. If it answers 'How long has this been occurring?', use 'for'.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the segment containing the error: 'The research team has been monitoring the seismic activity for the deployment of the high-sensitivity sensors last month (A)/ to ascertain if the tectonic (B)/ shifts have intensified (C)/ in the oceanic ridge (D)/ No Error (E).'



RULE 20

Importance: 95/100

Pronouns: Subjective vs. Objective Case

Subjective pronouns (I, he, she, we, they) are used as subjects of a verb or after a 'be' verb. Objective pronouns (me, him, her, us, them) are used as objects of a verb or preposition.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often rely on 'hypercorrection,' where candidates use the subjective case in compound objects (e.g., 'between the Secretary and I') because it sounds more formal. They also use linking verbs to tempt the candidate into using an objective pronoun (e.g., 'The culprit was him').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, pronouns are categorized by 'case' based on their syntactic function. The Subjective Case (I, we, he, she, they) is used when the pronoun functions as the subject of a verb or as a subject complement following a linking verb (the 'be' verb). The Objective Case (me, us, him, her, them) is employed when the pronoun acts as the direct or indirect object of a transitive verb, or as the object of a preposition. A critical point for competitive exams is the 'Complement of the Subject' rule: after verbs like 'is', 'am', 'are', 'was', and 'were', the subjective case must be used (e.g., 'It is I' rather than 'It is me'). Furthermore, in compound structures, the case of each pronoun must be determined by its individual relationship to the verb or preposition, regardless of the other pronoun present.

>> Use the subjective case when the pronoun is the agent performing the action of the verb (the subject).

>> Apply the subjective case after linking verbs (am, is, are, was, were, become, seem) to form a subject complement (predicate nominative).

>> Use the objective case when the pronoun is the direct or indirect recipient of the action of a transitive verb.

>> Employ the objective case whenever a pronoun follows a preposition (e.g., 'between', 'among', 'for', 'with', 'by').

>> In formal elliptical comparisons using 'than' or 'as', use the subjective case if the pronoun is the subject of an implied verb (e.g., 'He is more adept at quantum computing than she [is]').

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The scientific community debated the findings, but it was him who first noticed the discrepancy in the data.

OK CORRECT

The scientific community debated the findings, but it was he who first noticed the discrepancy in the data.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

He is one of the most distinguished scholars who has contributed significantly to the field of quantum physics.

OK CORRECT

He is one of the most distinguished scholars who have contributed significantly to the field of quantum physics.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Among the high-ranking diplomats attending the climate summit, the most influential representative was her.

OK CORRECT

Among the high-ranking diplomats attending the climate summit, the most influential representative was she.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In contemporary informal speech, the objective case is frequently used after linking verbs (e.g., 'It is me').

>> However, in the context of competitive exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL, the formal subjective case ('It is I') is mandated.

PRO-TIP



Tip: To resolve confusion in compound structures, use the 'Removal Method': temporarily remove the other person from the sentence. You would never say, 'The legislation was passed by I'; therefore, 'The legislation was passed by the Senate and I' is incorrect. It must be 'The legislation was passed by the Senate and me'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Ministry of External Affairs clarified that the diplomatic impasse was resolved through a series of clandestine negotiations between the Prime Minister and he.'



RULE 21

Importance: 95/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Less' vs. 'Fewer'

'Less' is used with uncountable nouns (e.g., 'less water', 'less information'). 'Fewer' is used with countable nouns (e.g., 'fewer students', 'fewer books').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often use 'collective plural' nouns or nouns that sound like a mass but are technically countable (e.g., 'personnel', 'assets', 'discrepancies'). They may also place a plural noun immediately after 'less' in a complex sentence to see if the candidate can identify the countability despite the distracting adjectives or prepositional phrases surrounding the noun.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, the distinction between 'less' and 'fewer' is predicated on the countability of the noun being modified. 'Fewer' is the comparative form of 'few' and is used exclusively with plural countable nouns—entities that can be enumerated individually (e.g., employees, reports, errors). Conversely, 'less' is the comparative form of 'little' and is employed with uncountable (mass) nouns—entities that are perceived as a collective mass or abstract concept and cannot be counted individually (e.g., patience, luggage, information, wealth). In high-stakes competitive examinations such as SBI PO and SSC CGL, this distinction is a frequent target for 'Error Spotting' and 'Sentence Improvement' questions.

>> Deploy 'fewer' exclusively with plural countable nouns—entities that can be enumerated as discrete units (e.g., legislative amendments, ecological species, carbon emissions, technical glitches).

>> Deploy 'less' with uncountable (mass) nouns—entities perceived as an indivisible whole or an abstract concept (e.g., geopolitical tension, atmospheric pressure, sovereign debt, intellectual property).

>> Apply 'less' when referring to singular measurements of time, money, distance, or weight, even if the noun is plural, because the amount is viewed as a total collective unit (e.g., 'less than twenty kilometers', 'less than five thousand rupees').

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The new environmental policy resulted in less pollutants being released into the atmosphere.

OK CORRECT

The new environmental policy resulted in fewer pollutants being released into the atmosphere.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

If the Monetary Policy Committee will raise the repo rate, the cost of borrowing for commercial banks will increase significantly.

OK CORRECT

If the Monetary Policy Committee raises the repo rate, the cost of borrowing for commercial banks will increase significantly.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Despite the implementation of rigorous security protocols, the cybersecurity firm observed that less vulnerabilities were exploited in the second quarter than in the first.

OK CORRECT

Despite the implementation of rigorous security protocols, the cybersecurity firm observed that fewer vulnerabilities were exploited in the second quarter than in the first.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When referring to collective measurements of time, money, weight, or distance, 'less' is preferred.

>> For example: 'The journey to the remote outpost took less than ten hours' (not 'fewer than ten hours'), as the time is viewed as a continuous duration rather than ten individual hours.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Utilize the 'Countability Litmus Test': Attempt to insert a specific number before the noun. If 'ten [nouns]' sounds grammatically natural (e.g., 'ten errors', 'ten citizens'), the noun is countable and requires 'fewer'. If it sounds unnatural (e.g., 'ten informations', 'ten patience'), the noun is uncountable and requires 'less'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The diplomatic mission failed because there were less opportunities for dialogue between the two warring factions than the international community had anticipated.'



RULE 22

Importance: 95/100

Nouns: Countable vs. Uncountable

Countable nouns can be counted and have plural forms; uncountable nouns cannot be counted individually and typically have only a singular form. This distinction affects article and quantifier usage.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most frequent trap involves adding an 's' to strictly uncountable nouns—such as 'furniture', 'equipment', 'luggage', 'information', 'poetry', 'scenery', and 'evidence'. Examiners often pair these nouns with 'many', 'a few', or 'several' to mislead candidates into treating them as countable entities.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, nouns are categorized based on their ability to be counted as discrete units. Countable nouns refer to entities that can be quantified individually (e.g., 'report', 'candidate') and possess both singular and plural forms. They are used with articles 'a/an' and quantifiers such as 'many', 'few', and 'several'. Conversely, Uncountable nouns (Mass Nouns) refer to substances, abstract concepts, or collective masses that cannot be divided into separate units (e.g., 'advice', 'information', 'luggage', 'furniture', 'scenery'). These nouns typically exist only in the singular form, do not take the indefinite article 'a/an', and are paired with quantifiers like 'much', 'little', and 'a great deal of'. For competitive exams, the primary challenge lies in nouns that appear countable to a non-native speaker but are strictly uncountable in standard English, meaning they can never be pluralized by adding '-s'.

- >> Countable nouns in their singular form can be preceded by the indefinite articles 'a' or 'an'.
- >> Countable nouns are compatible with quantifiers such as 'many', 'few', 'several', and 'a number of'.
- >> Uncountable nouns cannot be pluralized by adding '-s' or '-es' and never take 'a' or 'an' directly.
- >> Uncountable nouns must be paired with quantifiers such as 'much', 'little', 'a great deal of', and 'an amount of'.
- >> To specify a quantity for an uncountable noun, a partitive phrase (e.g., 'a piece of', 'a shred of', 'an item of') must be employed.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The environmental agency provided several useful advices to the local administration regarding waste management.

OK CORRECT

The environmental agency provided some useful advice to the local administration regarding waste management.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

If the central bank lowered the repo rate, commercial banks will reduce the interest rates on home loans.

OK CORRECT

If the central bank lowered the repo rate, commercial banks would reduce the interest rates on home loans.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legal counsel argued that the sheer volume of informations provided by the witness was contradictory and unreliable.

OK CORRECT

The legal counsel argued that the sheer volume of information provided by the witness was contradictory and unreliable.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Certain nouns can function as both countable and uncountable depending on the semantic context.
- >> For instance, 'experience' refers to general knowledge (uncountable), but 'experiences' refers to specific events encountered (countable).
- >> Similarly, 'paper' as a material is uncountable, whereas 'papers' refers to official documents or academic essays.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Apply the 'Quantity Test': If you cannot place a specific number (e.g., 'one', 'two') directly before the noun without adding a partitive phrase, the noun is uncountable. Additionally, always distinguish between 'number' (used for countable nouns, e.g., 'a number of citizens') and 'amount' (used for uncountable nouns, e.g., 'a significant amount of patience').

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The cybersecurity firm reported that a significant amount of softwares used by the government were outdated and vulnerable to zero-day exploits.'



RULE 23

Importance: 93/100

Semi-Modals: 'Had Better' vs 'Used To' vs 'Be Used To'

'Had better' is used for strong advice and takes the base verb (V1) without 'to'. 'Used to' denotes past habits, while 'be used to' denotes being accustomed to something and takes a gerund (V1+ing).

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner frequently leverages the structural similarity between 'used to + V1' and 'be used to + V1-ing'. They often insert a form of 'be' (is/am/are/was/were) before 'used to' but follow it with a base verb to trick the candidate into treating it as a past habit rather than a state of familiarity.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

'Had better' means 'should' or 'ought to'. It is followed directly by the bare infinitive (base form of the verb) without 'to'. Conversely, 'Used to' takes the base verb to show a past habit (I used to smoke). However, if 'used to' is preceded by a 'be' verb or 'get' (I am used to / I got used to), it must be followed by a gerund (verb+ing).

>> Use 'Had better' followed by a bare infinitive (V1) to express strong advice or a warning of negative consequences. Never insert 'to' between 'had better' and the verb.

>> For the negative form of this construction, place 'not' after 'better' (e.g., 'had better not').

>> Use 'Used to' followed by a base verb (V1) to describe habitual actions or states in the past that are no longer true in the present.

>> Use 'Be/Get used to' followed by a gerund (V1+ing) or a noun to indicate that someone has become accustomed to or familiar with a particular situation.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The environmental agency had better to implement the new emission norms before the next climate summit.

OK CORRECT

The environmental agency had better implement the new emission norms before the next climate summit.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

If the diplomatic envoy would have negotiated the treaty more prudently, the escalation of the conflict would have been avoided.

OK CORRECT

If the diplomatic envoy had negotiated the treaty more prudently, the escalation of the conflict would have been avoided.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The presiding officer had better to maintain strict decorum in the house, especially since the freshman legislators are not used to follow the parliamentary protocols.

OK CORRECT

The presiding officer had better maintain strict decorum in the house, especially since the freshman legislators are not used to following the parliamentary protocols.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While 'used to' describes past habits and states, 'would' can also be used for past habits but NOT for past states.

>> For example, 'I used to be a scholar' is correct, but 'I would be a scholar' (referring to a past state) is incorrect.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Be-Ing' check: If the phrase 'used to' is preceded by a form of the verb 'to be' or 'get', the following verb must be in the '-ing' form (gerund). If no 'be/get' verb precedes it, use the base form (V1) to denote a past habit.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead architect had better to refine the structural blueprints immediately, as the construction crew is not used to operate with such imprecise specifications.' (A) had better to refine (B) structural blueprints immediately (C) is not used to operate (D) No Error



RULE 24

Importance: 92/100

Sentence Structure: Question Tags

Question tags depend on the polarity of the main statement: positive statements take negative tags, and negative statements take positive tags.

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner frequently utilizes 'quasi-negative' adverbs like 'seldom' or 'scarcely'. Because these words do not contain the explicit negation 'not', candidates often misidentify the statement as positive and incorrectly apply a negative tag.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

A question tag is a short question at the end of a statement. If the main statement is positive, the question tag must be negative. If the main statement is negative, the question tag must be positive. The auxiliary verb in the tag must match the tense of the main verb, and the pronoun must match the subject.

- >> Opposite Polarity Principle: Positive statements must be followed by negative tags, and negative statements must be followed by positive tags.
- >> Auxiliary Alignment: The auxiliary verb in the tag must correspond exactly to the tense and the auxiliary verb used in the main clause.
- >> Pronoun Substitution: The subject of the tag must always be a pronoun that matches the gender and number of the subject in the main statement.
- >> The 'Let's' Convention: Sentences beginning with 'Let's' (Let us) invariably take the tag 'shall we?'.
- >> The 'I am' Irregularity: The statement 'I am' requires the irregular negative tag 'aren't I?'.
- >> Semi-Negative Influence: Words with inherent negative connotations—such as 'hardly', 'scarcely', 'seldom', 'barely', 'few', and 'little'—render the statement negative, thus requiring a positive tag.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The biodiversity of the Amazon rainforest is declining at an alarming rate, aren't they?

OK CORRECT

The biodiversity of the Amazon rainforest is declining at an alarming rate, isn't it?

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The legal counsel is understanding the complexities of the international trade agreement.

OK CORRECT

The legal counsel understands the complexities of the international trade agreement.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The Supreme Court has barely acknowledged the petition regarding the environmental breach, hasn't it?

OK CORRECT

The Supreme Court has barely acknowledged the petition regarding the environmental breach, has it?

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Imperative sentences generally take 'will you?' or 'won't you?' regardless of the polarity (e.g., 'Please maintain silence in the gallery, will you?').
- >> Furthermore, while 'I am' takes 'aren't I?', 'I am not' follows the standard rule and takes 'am I?'.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Be vigilant with indefinite pronouns. When the subject is 'Everyone', 'Somebody', 'Nobody', or 'Anyone', the corresponding pronoun in the question tag must be 'they'. Consequently, the verb in the tag must also shift to plural to agree with 'they' (e.g., 'Everyone has submitted the report, haven't they?').

TEST YOURSELF



Q: The implementation of the new data privacy framework has hardly mitigated the risks of cyber espionage,
_____?



RULE 25

Importance: 90/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Singular Indefinite Pronouns

Indefinite pronouns like 'each', 'every', 'everyone', 'someone', 'somebody', 'nobody', 'no one', 'anyone', 'anybody', 'everything', 'something', 'nothing', 'anything' always take a singular verb.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Proximity Trap': The examiner inserts a plural noun (e.g., 'algorithms', 'legislators', 'specimens') immediately preceding the verb. This induces the candidate to match the verb with the closest noun rather than the actual singular subject ('Each' or 'Everyone').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, certain indefinite pronouns are categorically singular, regardless of the perceived number of people or things they represent. Pronouns such as 'each', 'every', 'everyone', 'someone', 'somebody', 'nobody', 'no one', 'anyone', 'anybody', 'everything', 'something', 'nothing', and 'anything' refer to individuals or entities in a generalized or singular sense. A common pitfall in competitive exams is the 'intervening phrase'—a prepositional phrase (usually starting with 'of the...') that follows the indefinite pronoun and contains a plural noun. Aspirants often mistakenly align the verb with this plural noun instead of the singular indefinite pronoun. According to traditional conventions, the verb must strictly agree with the singular pronoun subject.

- >> Identify the primary subject to determine if it is a singular indefinite pronoun (e.g., Each, Everyone, Nobody, Anyone).
- >> Isolate the subject by mentally disregarding intervening prepositional phrases (e.g., 'of the candidates', 'among the delegates') that contain plural nouns.
- >> Ensure the verb is in its singular form to maintain agreement with the singular indefinite pronoun, irrespective of the proximity of plural nouns.
- >> Distinguish between 'each' as the subject and 'each' as an appositive; if 'each' follows a plural subject, the verb remains plural because the plural noun is the primary subject.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Everyone in the diplomatic mission want to attend the summit.

OK CORRECT

Everyone in the diplomatic mission wants to attend the summit.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The volatility of the emerging markets has become more higher since the announcement of the new trade tariffs.

OK CORRECT

The volatility of the emerging markets has become higher since the announcement of the new trade tariffs.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Each of the complex algorithms utilized in the latest cybersecurity framework have demonstrated a vulnerability to quantum decryption.

OK CORRECT

Each of the complex algorithms utilized in the latest cybersecurity framework has demonstrated a vulnerability to quantum decryption.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> When 'each' follows a plural subject, it acts as an appositive rather than the primary subject.
- >> In such cases, the verb must remain plural.
- >> Example: 'The regional governors each have the authority to declare a state of emergency.'

PRO-TIP



Tip: Employ the 'Isolation Technique': In Error Spotting questions, mentally strip away all modifiers and prepositional phrases located between the indefinite pronoun and the verb. If the remaining core is 'Everyone... are' or 'Each... have', you have identified the error.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'While the delegates debated the terms of the climate accord, everyone among the participating nations were urged to reduce carbon emissions by 2030.'



RULE 26

Importance: 90/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Additive Phrases (As well as, Along with, etc.)

When a subject is joined by 'as well as', 'along with', 'together with', 'and not', 'in addition to', 'but', 'besides', 'like', 'unlike', 'with', 'rather than', 'except', 'no less than', 'nothing but', the verb agrees with the first subject.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Proximity Trap': Examiners deliberately place a plural noun or a complex list of entities immediately before the verb. This tricks the candidate into instinctively choosing a plural verb based on the nearest noun rather than the actual grammatical subject at the start of the sentence.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, when two or more nouns or pronouns are connected by additive phrases such as 'as well as', 'along with', 'together with', 'in addition to', 'accompanied by', 'besides', 'rather than', 'no less than', or 'nothing but', they do not create a compound subject in the same manner as the conjunction 'and'. These phrases are considered parenthetical or additive rather than coordinative. Consequently, the verb must strictly agree in number and person with the first subject mentioned. The nouns following these phrases are grammatically incidental and do not influence the plurality or singularity of the verb.

- >> Identify the primary subject, which is the noun or pronoun appearing immediately before the additive phrase.
- >> Treat the additive phrase and all subsequent nouns as parenthetical or supplementary information that does not influence the number of the verb.
- >> Ensure the verb aligns strictly with the primary subject in both number (singular/plural) and person.
- >> Distinguish these expressions from the conjunction 'and'; while 'and' creates a plural compound subject, additive phrases leave the subject's original number intact.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The ozone layer as well as the polar ice caps are showing signs of critical degradation.

OK CORRECT

The ozone layer as well as the polar ice caps is showing signs of critical degradation.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

No sooner the Chairperson had announced the merger when the company's share prices surged exponentially.

OK CORRECT

No sooner had the Chairperson announced the merger than the company's share prices surged exponentially.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The Prime Minister, accompanied by the Cabinet Secretary and a high-level delegation of diplomats, have arrived at the summit to negotiate the bilateral security treaty.

OK CORRECT

The Prime Minister, accompanied by the Cabinet Secretary and a high-level delegation of diplomats, has arrived at the summit to negotiate the bilateral security treaty.

EXCEPTIONS

>> If the primary subject itself is plural, the verb remains plural regardless of whether the additive phrase contains singular or plural nouns (e.g., 'The delegates, along with the ambassador, are attending').

PRO-TIP

Tip: Use the 'Mental Eraser' technique: Mentally strike through or place brackets around the additive phrase and everything following it up to the verb. If the remaining sentence ('The Prime Minister... has arrived') sounds correct, your verb agreement is accurate.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Governor-General, in addition to the provincial administrators and the local chieftains, were tasked with implementing the land revenue reforms.' (A) The Governor-General (B) in addition to the provincial administrators (C) and the local chieftains (D) were tasked with implementing (E) No Error

RULE 27

Importance: 90/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Correlative Conjunctions (Rule of Proximity)

With 'neither...nor', 'either...or', 'not only...but also', the verb agrees with the subject closest to it.

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner frequently inserts lengthy intervening phrases—such as appositives, relative clauses, or prepositional phrases—between the second subject and the verb. This is designed to obscure the second subject's number and trick the candidate into agreeing the verb with the first subject or a noun within the intervening phrase.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

When two or more subjects are connected by correlative conjunctions such as 'neither...nor', 'either...or', or 'not only...but also', the verb does not agree with the first subject. Instead, it adheres to the 'Rule of Proximity', which dictates that the verb must agree in number and person with the subject closest to it. Consequently, if the subject nearest to the verb is singular, the verb must be singular; if the nearest subject is plural, the verb must be plural.

- >> Identify the correlative conjunction pair governing the sentence (e.g., Neither...nor, Either...or, Not only...but also).
- >> Locate the two distinct subjects connected by these conjunctions.
- >> Isolate the subject situated immediately before the verb (the proximate subject).
- >> Determine the number (singular or plural) and person of this second subject.
- >> Apply the verb form that matches this second subject, completely disregarding the number of the first subject.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

Neither the legislative assembly nor the appointed ministers is responsible for the lapse in administrative oversight.

OK CORRECT

Neither the legislative assembly nor the appointed ministers are responsible for the lapse in administrative oversight.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

Hardly had the diplomatic envoy reached the summit than the ceasefire agreement was unilaterally revoked.

OK CORRECT

Hardly had the diplomatic envoy reached the summit when the ceasefire agreement was unilaterally revoked.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

Not only the lead researcher but also the software engineers, who developed the neural network for the quantum computer, has expressed concerns regarding algorithmic bias.

OK CORRECT

Not only the lead researcher but also the software engineers, who developed the neural network for the quantum computer, have expressed concerns regarding algorithmic bias.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While the Rule of Proximity is the primary guide, if both subjects connected by the conjunction are singular, the verb remains singular; conversely, if both are plural, the verb remains plural.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Employ the 'Isolation Technique': Mentally strike out the first subject and the correlative conjunction entirely. Read only the second subject and the verb as a standalone phrase. If the remaining pair is grammatically sound, the agreement is correct.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Either the archival records of the colonial era or the testimony of the surviving witnesses _____ (confirm/confirms) the occurrence of the uprising in the southern province.



RULE 28

Importance: 90/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: 'One of the...who/which/that'

When 'one of the' is followed by a relative pronoun (who/which/that), the verb in the relative clause agrees with the plural antecedent (the noun before 'one of the').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners rely on the 'proximity error,' placing the singular word 'one' at the start of the sentence to subconsciously influence the candidate to use a singular verb, despite the grammatical subject of the relative clause being the plural noun.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In complex sentence structures where 'one of the' is followed by a plural noun and a relative pronoun (who, which, or that), the relative pronoun acts as the subject of the relative clause. This pronoun refers back to the plural noun (the antecedent) immediately preceding it, rather than to the word 'one'. According to traditional grammar and competitive exam standards (such as Wren & Martin), the verb within this relative clause must agree with the plural antecedent. Therefore, a plural verb is required to maintain grammatical consistency with the group being described.

- >> Locate the relative pronoun (who, which, that) appearing immediately after a plural noun.
- >> Identify the antecedent, which is the plural noun preceding the relative pronoun; this noun serves as the subject for the verb within the relative clause.
- >> Assign a plural verb to maintain agreement with the plural antecedent.
- >> Apply a singular verb only if the phrase 'the only one of the' is used, as this shifts the subject focus to the singular 'one'.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Quantum computing is one of the few technologies that simplifies complex cryptographic calculations.

OK CORRECT

Quantum computing is one of the few technologies that simplify complex cryptographic calculations.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Himalayas constitute a formidable natural barrier, while Ganges remains most revered river in the region.

OK CORRECT

The Himalayas constitute a formidable natural barrier, while the Ganges remains the most revered river in the region.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The Magna Carta remains one of those seminal historical documents that establishes the fundamental principle that no one is above the law.

OK CORRECT

The Magna Carta remains one of those seminal historical documents that establish the fundamental principle that no one is above the law.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> When 'the only one of' is used, the verb must be singular.
- >> Example: 'He is the only one of the diplomats who has successfully negotiated the peace treaty.'

PRO-TIP

Tip: To verify the verb, mentally isolate the relative clause and replace the relative pronoun with the plural noun. Instead of reading 'one of the documents that establish', read it as 'documents establish'. If this sounds grammatically correct, the plural verb is mandatory.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Error Spotting: 'Universal Basic Income is one of those socio-economic proposals that seeks to alleviate extreme poverty by providing a guaranteed financial floor for all citizens.' (Identify the error).



RULE 29

Importance: 90/100

Tenses: Conditional Sentences Type 1 (Real/Probable)*Type 1 conditionals express real or probable situations: 'If + Simple Present, Will + Base Verb'.*

EXAMINER TRAP: The Symmetry Trap: Examiners exploit the candidate's logical intuition that because both the condition and the result occur in the future, both clauses should use the future tense. This leads the student to accept 'will' in the if-clause, which is a grammatical error.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Type 1 Conditional, also known as the 'Real Conditional,' is used to express a condition that is realistic and a result that is highly probable to occur in the future. It describes a cause-and-effect relationship where the condition is possible. Structurally, the sentence is composed of two clauses: the 'If-clause' (the condition) and the 'Main clause' (the consequence). According to standard English grammar and competitive exam conventions, the If-clause must be in the Simple Present Tense, while the Main clause must be in the Simple Future Tense (will/shall + base form of the verb). A critical grammatical constraint is that the future tense ('will') must never be used within the if-clause, regardless of the future orientation of the sentence.

- >> The condition (if-clause) must be expressed in the Simple Present tense, regardless of the future time reference.
- >> The consequence (main clause) utilizes the Simple Future tense (will/shall + base verb) to denote the result.
- >> Future markers such as 'will' or 'shall' are grammatically prohibited within the if-clause.
- >> The conjunction 'Unless' (meaning 'if...not') adheres to the same rule, requiring the Simple Present tense.
- >> Modals like 'may', 'might', or 'can' may replace 'will' in the main clause to indicate varying degrees of certainty, permission, or ability.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

If the global temperature will rise by two degrees, many coastal cities will face severe flooding.

OK CORRECT

If the global temperature rises by two degrees, many coastal cities will face severe flooding.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The exhaustive informations provided in the annual reports suggest that the company's fiscal health is improving.

OK CORRECT

The exhaustive information provided in the annual report suggests that the company's fiscal health is improving.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

If the electoral commission will overlook these administrative discrepancies, the legitimacy of the mandate will be questioned by the opposition.

OK CORRECT

If the electoral commission overlooks these administrative discrepancies, the legitimacy of the mandate will be questioned by the opposition.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The word 'will' may be used in an if-clause only when it denotes 'willingness' or a 'polite request' (e.g., 'If you will please take a seat, the proceedings will begin shortly'), rather than a future condition.

PRO-TIP

Tip: In high-stakes exams like SBI PO or SSC CGL, scan the sentence for the 'If' marker. Immediately isolate the verb in that specific clause; if you spot any form of the future tense (will/shall/going to) before the main clause begins, it is almost certainly the error point.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify and correct the error: 'If the research team will discover a more efficient catalyst, the cost of hydrogen production will decrease significantly.'



RULE 30

Importance: 90/100

Tenses: Conditional Sentences Type 2 (Unreal Present)

Type 2 conditionals express unreal or hypothetical situations in the present/future: 'If + Simple Past, Would + Base Verb'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently employ the 'Double Would' trap by incorrectly placing 'would' in the if-clause. Additionally, they often use 'was' instead of 'were' for singular subjects to test the candidate's mastery of the Subjunctive Mood.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Second Conditional is utilized to articulate hypothetical, imaginary, or improbable situations in the present or future. It describes a state of affairs that is contrary to current facts. According to traditional grammar and competitive exam standards, this structure employs the 'Subjunctive Mood' to indicate unreality. The sentence is divided into two parts: the 'If-clause' (condition) and the 'Main clause' (result). The mandatory structure is: [If + Subject + Simple Past], [Subject + would/could/might + Base Verb]. It is imperative to understand that while the verb in the if-clause is in the past tense, the meaning refers to the present or future time.

- >> The condition clause (if-clause) must employ the Simple Past tense to signify that the situation is contrary to current facts or highly improbable.
- >> The result clause (main clause) must utilize a modal verb—specifically 'would', 'could', or 'might'—followed by the base form of the verb to express the hypothetical consequence.
- >> In formal English and for competitive examinations, the subjunctive 'were' must be used for all subject pronouns (I, he, she, it, they) when the verb 'to be' is required in the if-clause.
- >> A modal verb such as 'would' must never be placed within the if-clause; its placement is strictly reserved for the result clause.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

If the government spends more on sustainable urban planning, the city's traffic congestion would decrease significantly.

OK CORRECT

If the government spent more on sustainable urban planning, the city's traffic congestion would decrease significantly.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Stringent measures to curb inflation has been implemented by the Monetary Policy Committee.

OK CORRECT

The Monetary Policy Committee has implemented stringent measures to curb inflation. (Active) Stringent measures to curb inflation have been implemented by the Monetary Policy Committee. (Passive)

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

If the legislature would amend the antiquated statutes immediately, the prevailing legal ambiguity would be resolved.

OK CORRECT

If the legislature amended the antiquated statutes immediately, the prevailing legal ambiguity would be resolved.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In colloquial or informal spoken English, 'was' is frequently used instead of 'were' for singular subjects; however, this is considered grammatically incorrect in the context of SSC CGL, SBI PO, and other formal standardized tests.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Be vigilant for the 'If + Subject + were to + Verb' construction (e.g., 'If the sun were to expand...'). This formal variation is used in high-level writing to emphasize the extreme improbability or the theoretical nature of the condition.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the part containing the error: If the telescope was capable (A) of detecting dark matter (B), astronomers (C) would gain a deeper understanding of the early universe (D). No Error (E).

**RULE 31****Importance: 90/100****Conditional Sentences Type 3 (Unreal Past)***Type 3 conditionals express unreal situations in the past: 'If + Past Perfect, Would Have + Past Participle'.*

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Double Would' Fallacy: Examiners frequently insert 'would have' into both the conditional (if) clause and the result clause. In standard English, 'would' belongs exclusively in the result clause; the condition must always be anchored in the Past Perfect ('had + V3').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Type 3 Conditional is used to describe a hypothetical situation in the past—a condition that did not happen, and therefore, its consequence did not occur. It is often used to express regret or criticism. According to traditional grammar conventions (Wren & Martin), this structure consists of two parts: the 'If-clause' (Condition) and the 'Main clause' (Result). The If-clause must be in the Past Perfect Tense (had + past participle), and the Main clause must use the Conditional Perfect (would have / could have / might have + past participle). It is a counterfactual statement; it describes an 'unreal' past.

- >> The 'if-clause' (condition) must be constructed using the Past Perfect tense (had + past participle).
- >> The 'main clause' (result) must utilize the Conditional Perfect structure (would/could/might + have + past participle).
- >> The sentence must denote a counterfactual scenario, meaning the events described did not actually take place in reality.
- >> Syntactic inversion is permissible for formal emphasis: the word 'if' is omitted and 'had' is placed at the beginning of the clause (e.g., 'Had the treaty been signed...').

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

If the government would have implemented stricter emission norms a decade ago, the current air quality crisis would have been averted.

OK CORRECT

If the government had implemented stricter emission norms a decade ago, the current air quality crisis would have been averted.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy emphasized the need for a consensus of opinion regarding the proposed trade agreement.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy emphasized the need for a consensus regarding the proposed trade agreement.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Had the diplomats reached a consensus on the ceasefire during the summit, the escalation of the border conflict might be avoided.

OK CORRECT

Had the diplomats reached a consensus on the ceasefire during the summit, the escalation of the border conflict might have been avoided.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While standard grammar forbids 'would' in the if-clause, in very rare instances of formal rhetoric, 'would have' may be used to express a specific 'willingness' or 'volition' of the subject, though this is seldom tested in SSC/Banking exams and is generally treated as an error in those contexts.

PRO-TIP

Tip: In high-difficulty SBI PO papers, watch for 'Inversion' (Had + Subject + V3). Many candidates mistakenly identify this as a question or an error in verb placement. Remember that 'Had I known' is functionally identical to 'If I had known'. Additionally, ensure the auxiliary 'have' remains invariant regardless of the subject's number or person (e.g., 'The committee would have', never 'The committee would has').

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'If the software architects would have anticipated the vulnerability in the encryption protocol, the catastrophic data breach of 2023 could have been prevented.'



RULE 32

Importance: 90/100

Tenses: Stative Verbs

Stative verbs (e.g., 'know', 'love', 'see', 'hear', 'believe', 'own', 'seem') express states, not actions, and are generally not used in continuous tenses.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently employ temporal markers such as 'currently', 'nowadays', 'at this juncture', or 'at the moment' to trick candidates into choosing the continuous form, even when the verb is stative and necessitates the simple tense.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Stative verbs describe a state, condition, or situation rather than a physical action. Unlike dynamic verbs (e.g., run, eat, write), stative verbs refer to mental states, emotions, senses, possession, or permanent characteristics. According to traditional grammar conventions, these verbs are not used in the continuous (progressive) tenses because a 'state' is viewed as static rather than an ongoing process. These verbs generally fall into categories such as Emotion (love, hate), Possession (own, possess, belong), Cognition (know, believe, understand), and Senses (seem, appear, sound).

>> Verbs of Cognition: Verbs such as 'know', 'believe', 'understand', 'realize', and 'remember' describe mental states and must be used in simple tenses.

>> Verbs of Possession and Composition: Verbs like 'own', 'possess', 'belong', 'consist', and 'comprise' describe a state of ownership or makeup and cannot take the -ing form.

>> Verbs of Emotion and Preference: Verbs such as 'love', 'hate', 'prefer', 'appreciate', and 'desire' are typically stative and avoid progressive forms.

>> Verbs of Perception and Appearance: Verbs like 'seem', 'appear', 'sound', and 'look' denote a state of being and are used in simple tenses.

>> Contextual Flexibility: Certain verbs shift from stative to dynamic based on meaning; for instance, 'think' is stative when expressing an opinion but dynamic when describing the active process of deliberation.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The Earth's atmosphere is consisting of primarily nitrogen and oxygen.

OK CORRECT

The Earth's atmosphere consists of primarily nitrogen and oxygen.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Hardly the Chairperson had convened the meeting when the board members raised a formal objection.

OK CORRECT

Hardly had the Chairperson convened the meeting when the board members raised a formal objection.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The judiciary is currently believing that the legislative amendment infringes upon fundamental rights, and the administration is appearing to be indifferent to the crisis.

OK CORRECT

The judiciary currently believes that the legislative amendment infringes upon fundamental rights, and the administration appears to be indifferent to the crisis.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Some verbs function as both stative and dynamic.

>> For example, 'have' is stative for possession ('He has a degree') but dynamic for action ('He is having lunch').

>> Similarly, 'see' is stative for perception ('I see the point') but dynamic for meeting ('I am seeing the consultant tomorrow').

PRO-TIP



Tip: In SBI PO and SSC CGL Error Detection, be hyper-vigilant with verbs of composition (consist, comprise) and perception (seem, appear). If the verb describes a permanent attribute, an inherent property, or a fixed state, the '-ing' form is almost always incorrect regardless of the time indicator used in the sentence.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the segment that contains a grammatical error: 'The newly implemented (A) / digital infrastructure (B) / is comprising of (C) / several cloud-based modules to streamline public service delivery (D) / No error (E).'



RULE 33

Importance: 90/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: Avoiding Double Comparatives and Superlatives

Do not use two comparative forms (e.g., 'more happier') or two superlative forms (e.g., 'most strongest') together.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently insert intensifying adverbs like 'far', 'much', 'even', or 'considerably' immediately before the error to distract the candidate. For instance, in the phrase 'far more better', the student might perceive 'far more' as a combined intensifier and overlook that 'better' is already a comparative, making 'more' redundant.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, the degree of comparison for an adjective or adverb is expressed through two distinct methods: either by adding a suffix (such as '-er' for comparatives and '-est' for superlatives) or by using the modifiers 'more' and 'most'. A grammatical error occurs when both methods are employed simultaneously, resulting in a 'double comparative' or 'double superlative'. This is considered a redundancy because the suffix already inherently conveys the meaning of 'more' or 'most'. For instance, since 'stronger' already means 'more strong', adding 'more' before it is superfluous and logically incorrect. This rule is a frequent testing point in error-spotting and sentence-improvement sections of competitive exams.

- >> Do not combine the comparative suffix '-er' with the modifier 'more' (e.g., avoid 'more faster').
- >> Do not combine the superlative suffix '-est' with the modifier 'most' (e.g., avoid 'most strongest').
- >> Irregular comparative and superlative forms (such as better, worse, farthest, least) are already complete and must not be preceded by 'more' or 'most'.
- >> Ensure the distinction between a double comparative (error) and the comparison of two different qualities of the same subject (correct).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The current rate of glacial retreat in the Antarctic is more faster than the observations recorded a decade ago.

OK CORRECT

The current rate of glacial retreat in the Antarctic is faster than the observations recorded a decade ago.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Many a seasoned diplomat have struggled to navigate the complexities of the current geopolitical crisis.

OK CORRECT

Many a seasoned diplomat has struggled to navigate the complexities of the current geopolitical crisis.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The parliamentary committee concluded that the proposed amendments to the civil procedure code were more stringenter than those implemented during the previous legislative session.

OK CORRECT

The parliamentary committee concluded that the proposed amendments to the civil procedure code were stringenter than those implemented during the previous legislative session.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> The word 'more' may be used before a comparative adjective if the sentence is comparing two distinct qualities of the same entity rather than comparing the entity to another.
- >> Example: 'The diplomat was more tactful than persuasive' (Comparing tactfulness vs. persuasiveness in one person).

PRO-TIP



Tip: When encountering irregular adjectives like 'well/better/best' or 'bad/worse/worst' in the options, immediately check for 'more' or 'most'. These are high-frequency traps in SBI PO and SSC CGL exams because the ear often accepts the emphasis of 'more better' in colloquial speech, but it is strictly prohibited in formal written English.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The integration of Large Language Models into healthcare diagnostics has made the triage process most easiest for clinicians, although ethical concerns regarding data privacy persist.'



RULE 34

Importance: 90/100

Conjunctions: 'No sooner...than' Inversion

When 'no sooner' begins a sentence, it is followed by an inverted structure (auxiliary verb + subject + main verb), and then 'than' introduces the second clause.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most common traps involve replacing 'than' with 'when' (to trick candidates into applying the 'Hardly/Scarcely' rule) or using 'then' (due to phonetic similarity). Additionally, examiners often omit the inversion by placing the subject before the auxiliary verb (e.g., 'No sooner the committee had reached a consensus...').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The phrase 'No sooner' acts as a negative adverbial. In English grammar, when a sentence begins with a negative or restrictive adverbial, the subject and the auxiliary verb must be inverted (Subject-Auxiliary Inversion). This means the auxiliary verb (had, did, does, do, is, was, were, has, have, can, could, will, would, shall, should) must precede the subject, mirroring the structure of an interrogative sentence. Furthermore, 'No sooner' is a comparative expression; therefore, it must be paired exclusively with the conjunction 'than' to introduce the second clause. A common pitfall in competitive examinations is the use of 'when' or 'then' instead of 'than', or the failure to invert the subject and verb.

>> When 'No sooner' begins a sentence, the subject and auxiliary verb must be inverted (Auxiliary + Subject + Main Verb).

>> If using 'had' as the auxiliary, the main verb must be in the past participle form (V3).

>> If using 'did' as the auxiliary, the main verb must be in its base form (V1).

>> The second clause must be introduced specifically by the conjunction 'than'.

>> Substituting 'than' with 'when', 'then', or 'before' is a grammatical error.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

No sooner the scientist discovered the anomaly than the laboratory alarm sounded.

OK CORRECT

No sooner had the scientist discovered the anomaly than the laboratory alarm sounded.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

More than one candidates have demonstrated exceptional proficiency in the quantitative aptitude section of the examination.

OK CORRECT

More than one candidate has demonstrated exceptional proficiency in the quantitative aptitude section of the examination.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

No sooner had the legislative assembly ratified the new environmental protocol when the industrial lobby launched a massive protest.

OK CORRECT

No sooner had the legislative assembly ratified the new environmental protocol than the industrial lobby launched a massive protest.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Inversion is not required if 'No sooner' does not initiate the sentence.

>> For example: 'The diplomat had no sooner entered the summit than the negotiations collapsed.'.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Remember the 'Comparative Logic': 'Sooner' is the comparative degree of 'soon'. In English, all comparative forms (e.g., faster, better, taller) are paired with 'than'. This makes it easy to distinguish 'No sooner...than' from 'Hardly/Scarcely/Barely...when', as the latter are not comparatives.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'No sooner the cybersecurity agency detected the breach then the critical servers were shut down to prevent further data leakage.'

RULE 35

Importance: 90/100

Conjunctions: 'Hardly/Scarcely...when' Inversion

When 'hardly' or 'scarcely' begin a sentence, they are followed by an inverted structure (auxiliary verb + subject + main verb), and then 'when' introduces the second clause.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most frequent pitfall is the 'Conjunction Swap,' where 'than' is substituted for 'when' to mimic the 'No sooner...than' structure. Additionally, examiners often present the sentence in standard word order (Subject + Auxiliary) to test the candidate's knowledge of mandatory inversion after negative adverbs.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

This rule is employed to describe two events that occur in very rapid succession. When the negative adverbs 'Hardly' or 'Scarcely' are placed at the beginning of a sentence for rhetorical emphasis, the sentence must follow an inverted structure. Instead of the standard Subject + Verb order, the auxiliary verb (typically 'had') must precede the subject. The structure is: [Hardly/Scarcely] + [Auxiliary Verb] + [Subject] + [Main Verb (Past Participle)] + [when/before] + [Simple Past Clause]. It is a critical grammatical requirement that 'Hardly' and 'Scarcely' be paired with 'when' or 'before'; pairing them with 'than' is a common error in competitive examinations.

- >> Initiate the sentence with 'Hardly' or 'Scarcely' to create rhetorical emphasis on the immediacy of the sequence.
- >> Implement subject-auxiliary inversion by placing the auxiliary verb (usually 'had') before the subject.
- >> Ensure the first clause utilizes the past perfect tense (had + past participle).
- >> Link the subsequent action using the conjunction 'when' or 'before'.
- >> Maintain the second clause in the simple past tense to denote a completed action.
- >> Strictly exclude the use of 'than', which is reserved exclusively for 'No sooner'.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

Hardly the prime minister concluded the address when the protests erupted across the capital.

OK CORRECT

Hardly had the prime minister concluded the address when the protests erupted across the capital.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The comprehensive information disseminated by the Ministry of Finance are instrumental in stabilizing the volatile market.

OK CORRECT

The comprehensive information disseminated by the Ministry of Finance is instrumental in stabilizing the volatile market.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

Scarcely had the scientists sequenced the viral genome than the pharmaceutical industry began developing a targeted vaccine.

OK CORRECT

Scarcely had the scientists sequenced the viral genome when the pharmaceutical industry began developing a targeted vaccine.

EXCEPTIONS

>> If 'hardly' or 'scarcely' are used in the middle of the sentence rather than as introductory elements, subject-auxiliary inversion is not required (e.g., 'The delegation had scarcely arrived when the negotiations stalled').

PRO-TIP

Tip: Adopt a two-step verification process: first, verify the correlative pair (Hardly/Scarcely $\rightarrow$ when); second, check the syntax of the opening clause. If the adverb starts the sentence, the auxiliary verb must precede the subject. If this pattern is absent, the sentence is grammatically flawed.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'Hardly the legislative assembly had passed the land reform bill than the opposition filed a petition in the High Court.'

**RULE 36****Importance: 90/100****Articles: Definite Article ('The') Usage (Categories)**

'The' is used before superlatives, ordinal numbers, musical instruments, names of rivers, oceans, mountain ranges, holy books, newspapers, and certain countries (e.g., 'The USA').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often create confusion by mixing individual peaks (no article) with mountain ranges (article), or by omitting 'the' before a country's formal political title (e.g., 'Republic of India') while correctly omitting it before the common name ('India').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The definite article 'The' is utilized to specify a particular noun or to refer to entities that are unique or well-known. In competitive examinations, its usage is strictly categorized as follows: 1. Superlatives: It must precede adjectives in the superlative degree (e.g., the most diligent, the fastest). 2. Ordinal Numbers: It is used before words indicating order or rank (e.g., the first, the penultimate). 3. Musical Instruments: It is employed when referring to the instrument as a skill or a class (e.g., the violin, the flute). 4. Geographical Features: It is mandatory before names of rivers (The Amazon), oceans (The Indian Ocean), and mountain ranges (The Andes). 5. Sacred Texts and Periodicals: It precedes holy books (The Vedas) and established newspapers (The New York Times). 6. Political Entities: It is used for countries that are plural in form or contain words like 'Republic', 'Kingdom', 'Union', or 'States' (e.g., The Philippines, The United Kingdom).

>> Apply before superlative adjectives to denote the highest degree of a quality (e.g., the most sophisticated, the least volatile).

>> Use before ordinal numbers that indicate rank, sequence, or order (e.g., the first, the third, the penultimate).

>> Place before musical instruments when referring to the ability to play them or the instrument in a general professional sense (e.g., the violin, the oboe).

>> Use before names of rivers, oceans, seas, mountain ranges, and deserts (e.g., the Nile, the Atlantic, the Himalayas, the Sahara).

>> Require before sacred texts, official government gazettes, and established global newspapers (e.g., the Vedas, the Gazette of India, the New York Times).

>> Use before countries that are plural in form or contain political descriptors such as 'Republic', 'Kingdom', 'Union', 'Federation', or 'States' (e.g., the Netherlands, the Islamic Republic of Iran, the United Kingdom).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Mars is most intriguing planet in solar system.

OK CORRECT

Mars is the most intriguing planet in the solar system.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Most of the strategic intelligence gathered by the agency have been classified as top secret.

OK CORRECT

Most of the strategic intelligence gathered by the agency has been classified as top secret.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Republic of Korea and United States of America signed a bilateral treaty to enhance security across Pacific Ocean, ensuring stability in East Asia.

OK CORRECT

The Republic of Korea and the United States of America signed a bilateral treaty to enhance security across the Pacific Ocean, ensuring stability in East Asia.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Individual mountain peaks (e.g., Mount Everest, Mount Fuji) and most individual islands (e.g., Easter Island) do not take 'the'.

>> Similarly, continents (e.g., Asia, Africa) are used without the definite article.

**PRO-TIP**

Tip: In high-level competitive exams, look for 'the' before adjectives acting as nouns to describe a specific group of people (e.g., 'the marginalized', 'the affluent'). Additionally, always check for 'the' before 'only', 'very', or 'first' in complex, multi-clause sentences where they are easily overlooked.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the errors in the following sentence: 'French Revolution marked first major upheaval in European history, profoundly impacting the way the people perceived the power of monarchy and the influence of Catholic Church.'

**RULE 37****Importance: 90/100****Uncountable Nouns: Singular Usage**

Some nouns are always singular and uncountable, taking a singular verb (e.g., 'information', 'advice', 'furniture', 'luggage', 'scenery', 'poetry', 'machinery', 'news').

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Intervening Phrase' trap: Examiners often place a plural noun within a prepositional phrase immediately after the uncountable subject (e.g., 'The evidence provided by the multiple witnesses...'). This lures the candidate into using a plural verb to match the nearest noun rather than the actual singular subject.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, certain nouns are categorized as 'uncountable' or 'mass nouns.' These nouns represent concepts, masses, or collections that cannot be counted as individual units. Consequently, they possess no plural form (they never end in -s or -es) and must invariably be paired with a singular verb. Common examples include 'advice', 'information', 'furniture', 'luggage', 'baggage', 'scenery', 'poetry', 'machinery', and 'news'. To quantify these nouns, one must employ a partitive expression such as 'a piece of', 'an item of', or 'a bit of' rather than using numbers or the word 'many'.

>> Uncountable nouns must never be pluralized by adding suffixes such as '-s' or '-es' (e.g., 'information' instead of 'informations').

>> Strict subject-verb agreement requires that these nouns be paired exclusively with singular verbs (e.g., 'The luggage is' not 'The luggage are').

>> Quantifiers associated with countable nouns, such as 'many', 'few', or 'several', are prohibited; instead, use 'much', 'little', 'some', or 'a great deal of'.

>> To quantify these nouns or refer to individual units, utilize partitive phrases such as 'a piece of', 'an item of', 'a slice of', or 'an amount of'.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The research laboratory requires several new equipments to conduct the high-energy physics experiments.

OK CORRECT

The research laboratory requires new equipment to conduct the high-energy physics experiments.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Reserve Bank of India currently implements stringent monetary policies to curb the escalating inflation rate.

OK CORRECT

The Reserve Bank of India is currently implementing stringent monetary policies to curb the escalating inflation rate.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy provided comprehensive informations on the border dispute, but the conflicting advices from the ministry hindered the negotiation process.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy provided comprehensive information on the border dispute, but the conflicting advice from the ministry hindered the negotiation process.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain mass nouns can be used in a countable sense when referring to specific types, categories, or technical contexts.

>> For example, 'waters' may be used when referring to territorial seas, and 'cheeses' or 'wines' when referring to different varieties of the product.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Be cautious with nouns ending in '-s' like 'News', 'Mathematics', and 'Ethics'; these are singular. Additionally, distinguish between absolute uncountables (e.g., 'furniture', 'machinery', 'luggage') and dual-nature nouns (e.g., 'experience' is uncountable when referring to general knowledge, but countable when referring to a specific event).

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Spot the error: 'The archaeological team reported that the debris found at the site of the ancient civilization provided invaluable insights into the social hierarchy of the era.' (A) The archaeological team (B) reported that the debris (C) found at the site of the ancient civilization (D) provided invaluable insights into the social hierarchy of the era. (E) No Error

**RULE 38****Importance: 90/100****Active and Passive Voice Transformation**

This rule covers the transformation of sentences between active and passive voice, including the use of transitive verbs, and the correct formation of passive structures with various tenses and modal verbs (e.g., 'be' + past participle, 'being' + past participle, 'been' + past participle).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often insert intransitive verbs into passive constructions (e.g., 'The accident was occurred yesterday') to trick candidates into accepting a grammatically impossible structure. Another sophisticated trap involves the omission of 'being' in continuous passive forms or using the present participle instead of the past participle after 'been'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Voice denotes the relationship between the action expressed by the verb and the participants identified by its arguments. In the Active Voice, the subject performs the action (Subject + Verb + Object). In the Passive Voice, the subject is the recipient of the action (Object becomes Subject + Auxiliary 'be' + Past Participle + by + Agent). A fundamental prerequisite for passive transformation is that the verb must be transitive (possessing a direct object). The transformation follows a strict tense-based paradigm: 1. Simple Present: is/am/are + V3; 2. Present Continuous: is/am/are + being + V3; 3. Present Perfect: has/have + been + V3; 4. Simple Past: was/were + V3; 5. Past Continuous: was/were + being + V3; 6. Past Perfect: had + been + V3; 7. Simple Future: will/shall + be + V3; 8. Modals: modal + be + V3. In professional and formal writing, the passive voice is preferred when the actor is unknown, irrelevant, or when the focus is shifted to the result of the action.

- >> The verb must be transitive, meaning it must possess a direct object to be converted into passive voice.
- >> The object of the active sentence shifts to the subject position in the passive sentence.
- >> The principal verb is always converted into its Past Participle (V3) form, regardless of the original tense.
- >> The auxiliary verb 'be' (is, am, are, was, were, be, being, been) must be conjugated to match the original tense and the number/person of the new subject.
- >> The original subject is relegated to the end of the sentence, usually introduced by the preposition 'by' (though it may be omitted if the agent is implicit or irrelevant).
- >> For continuous tenses, the participle 'being' is inserted before the V3; for perfect tenses, 'been' is utilized.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The ancient ruins preserved by the archaeological society for decades.

OK CORRECT

The ancient ruins have been preserved by the archaeological society for decades.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Reserve Bank of India is monitoring the inflationary trends closely since the onset of the fiscal year.

OK CORRECT

The Reserve Bank of India has been monitoring the inflationary trends closely since the onset of the fiscal year.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

While the treaty was signed by both nations, the specific terms of the ceasefire are still being negotiate by the diplomatic envoys.

OK CORRECT

While the treaty was signed by both nations, the specific terms of the ceasefire are still being negotiated by the diplomatic envoys.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain verbs, known as stative or intransitive verbs (e.g., 'appear', 'seem', 'occur', 'belong'), cannot be used in the passive voice.



>> Additionally, 'quasi-passive' verbs (e.g., 'The rose smells sweet') follow a different logic where the subject is not the agent but the sentence is not structurally passive.

PRO-TIP

Tip: For SBI PO and SSC CGL, master 'Impersonal Passives' (e.g., 'It is widely believed that...') and 'Double Object' verbs (e.g., 'grant', 'offer'). In the latter, you can create two distinct passive sentences depending on whether you emphasize the recipient (Indirect Object) or the thing given (Direct Object). In formal administration or scientific reporting, 'Agentless Passives' are preferred to maintain an objective, impersonal tone.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The new urban planning strategy was designed to reduce congestion, but the implementation of the project is being hindered by a lack of municipal funding.'



RULE 39

Importance: 90/100

Eliminating Redundancy and Superfluous Words

This rule focuses on identifying and removing words or phrases that are redundant, repeat meaning, or do not add essential information, making sentences concise and clear.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often pair a complex, academic word with a simple synonym (e.g., 'reiterate again' or 'advance forward'). Candidates often mistake this for 'formal emphasis' or 'sophistication' and fail to identify the redundancy.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Redundancy, often referred to as 'pleonasm' or 'tautology,' occurs when two or more words with the same meaning are used together, adding no new information to the sentence. In high-stakes competitive examinations like SBI PO and SSC CGL, the objective is to achieve 'economy of expression'—conveying the maximum meaning with the minimum number of words. Errors typically manifest in two ways: (1) Pairing an adjective with a noun that already inherently possesses that quality (e.g., 'true fact'), or (2) using a preposition or adverb that repeats the direction or action already implied by the verb (e.g., 'return back'). A sentence is considered grammatically flawed in formal English if it contains words that are logically implied by other words in the same phrase.

- >> Remove adjectives that reiterate a quality already inherent in the noun (e.g., avoid 'unexpected surprise' or 'past history').
- >> Eliminate adverbs or prepositions that repeat a direction or action already established by the verb (e.g., avoid 'return back' or 'descend down').
- >> Avoid tautological phrases where the meaning of one word is subsumed by another (e.g., use 'consensus' instead of 'consensus of opinion').
- >> Strip away redundant modifiers that do not add specific nuance to the verb's primary definition (e.g., avoid 'summarize briefly' as the act of summarizing is inherently brief).

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The research team had to repeat the entire observation process again to ensure the data was accurate.

OK CORRECT

The research team had to repeat the entire observation process to ensure the data was accurate.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The astrophysicist explained that light traveled at a constant speed in a vacuum.

OK CORRECT

The astrophysicist explained that light travels at a constant speed in a vacuum.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The constitutional amendment was viewed as a fundamental basic of the new democratic framework, though it faced stiff opposition from the conservative wing.

OK CORRECT

The constitutional amendment was viewed as a fundamental of the new democratic framework, though it faced stiff opposition from the conservative wing.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In specific legal drafting or high-literary rhetoric, tautologies are occasionally employed for absolute precision or emotional emphasis; however, such usage is strictly considered an error in competitive examinations.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Deletion Test': If removing a word leaves the meaning of the sentence 100% intact without losing any nuance, that word is superfluous. Be particularly wary of 'Directional Redundancy' and 'Inherent Qualities'.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The aerospace engineers decided to merge together the two propulsion systems to optimize the satellite's fuel efficiency.'

RULE 40

Importance: 90/100

Inversion of Subject and Verb

This rule describes instances where the normal subject-verb order is reversed, typically when a sentence begins with a negative adverbial phrase or in certain conditional clauses where 'if' is omitted.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most frequent traps involve 'Correlative Mismatches': pairing 'No sooner' with 'when' (instead of 'than') or 'Hardly/Scarcely' with 'than' (instead of 'when'). Another sophisticated trap is placing the inversion in the 'Only after' clause itself rather than the main clause (e.g., 'Only after did the committee meet...' instead of 'Only after the committee met did they decide...').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Inversion occurs when the standard English word order (Subject + Verb) is reversed to (Auxiliary Verb + Subject + Main Verb). This grammatical structure is primarily employed for emphasis or formal tone and is triggered in three main scenarios: 1) When a sentence begins with a negative or restrictive adverbial (e.g., Hardly, Scarcely, No sooner, Seldom, Rarely, Never, Little). 2) In conditional clauses where the conjunction 'if' is omitted (e.g., using 'Had', 'Should', or 'Were' to start the sentence). 3) When a sentence begins with 'Only' followed by a time expression or adverbial phrase (e.g., 'Only then', 'Only after'). In these instances, the auxiliary verb must precede the subject to maintain grammatical correctness.

>> When a sentence begins with a negative or restrictive adverbial (e.g., Hardly, Scarcely, No sooner, Seldom, Rarely, Never, Little), the auxiliary verb must precede the subject to create an interrogative-like structure.

>> In formal conditional clauses where the conjunction 'if' is omitted, inversion is mandatory using 'Had' (for past perfect), 'Should' (for possibility), or 'Were' (for hypothetical present/future).

>> When a sentence begins with 'Only' followed by a time expression, adverbial phrase, or clause (e.g., 'Only then', 'Only after', 'Only when'), inversion must occur in the main clause that follows.

>> Standard word order (Subject + Verb) is maintained if the negative adverbial is placed in its habitual mid-sentence position rather than at the beginning.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

Seldom the global temperature remains stable for an extended period due to anthropogenic climate change.

OK CORRECT

Seldom does the global temperature remain stable for an extended period due to anthropogenic climate change.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

Myself and the Legal Counsel will represent the organization during the arbitration proceedings.

OK CORRECT

The Managing Director herself reviewed the quarterly financial reports to ensure absolute compliance with the regulatory framework.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

Hardly the legislature had ratified the treaty than the diplomatic crisis escalated into a full-scale conflict.

OK CORRECT

Hardly had the legislature ratified the treaty when the diplomatic crisis escalated into a full-scale conflict.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Inversion is not required when the negative word is an adjective modifying the subject rather than an adverb modifying the clause.

>> Furthermore, inversion does not occur in the dependent clause starting with 'Only after' or 'Only when'; it occurs strictly in the subsequent main clause.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Adopt a three-step verification process for these sentences: 1. Identify the 'Trigger Word' at the start. 2. Check for the 'Auxiliary + Subject' sequence. 3. Verify the 'Correlative Pair' (No sooner $\rightarrow$ than | Hardly/Scarcely $\rightarrow$ when). If any of these three are missing, the sentence is grammatically flawed.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Only after the cybersecurity agency detected the breach the government implemented the new encryption protocols across all administrative departments.'

**RULE 41****Importance: 90/100****Modals: Can, Could, May, Might, Must, and Have to**

Modal verbs express ability, possibility, permission, or obligation and are always followed by the base form of the verb without 'to'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently create errors of redundancy by pairing a modal with a phrase of similar meaning, such as 'can be able to' or 'might be possible to'. Another sophisticated trap is the subtle misuse of 'must' in place of 'have to' when the sentence clearly refers to a legal mandate or an external regulatory requirement.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

'Can' shows present ability, while 'could' shows past ability or polite requests. 'May' shows strong possibility or formal permission, whereas 'might' shows remote possibility. 'Must' implies strong internal obligation or logical certainty, while 'have to' implies external obligation imposed by rules.

>> Use 'Can' for present ability or general possibility, and 'Could' for past ability, conditional possibility, or formal requests.

>> Use 'May' for formal permission or a strong likelihood, and 'Might' for a remote, weaker, or hypothetical possibility.

>> Use 'Must' for internal obligation (speaker's conviction) or logical certainty, whereas 'Have to' is used for external obligation (laws, institutional rules, or mandates).

>> Strict Grammatical Structure: Modal + Base Verb (V1). No 'to' precedes the main verb, and no suffixes like '-s', '-ed', or '-ing' are attached to the base verb.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The research team can to isolate the viral strain in a controlled laboratory environment.

OK CORRECT

The research team can isolate the viral strain in a controlled laboratory environment.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The board of directors decided to keep the details of the acquisition strictly between the Chairperson and I.

OK CORRECT

The board of directors decided to keep the details of the acquisition strictly between the Chairperson and me.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

To safeguard national security, the intelligence agency must to monitor the encrypted communications of suspected insurgents.

OK CORRECT

To safeguard national security, the intelligence agency must monitor the encrypted communications of suspected insurgents.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Semi-modals such as 'ought to', 'have to', and 'used to' are exceptions to the bare infinitive rule as they inherently include the particle 'to' as part of their structure.

PRO-TIP

Tip: In high-stakes exams like SBI PO or SSC CGL, immediately scan for 'Modal + to + Verb' or 'Modal + Verb-s/es'. These are immediate red flags. When choosing between 'may' and 'might', look for contextual clues such as 'remote possibility' or 'hypothetical scenario' to justify the use of 'might'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The colonial administration might to have overlooked the indigenous land rights of the tribal population during the 19th-century land acquisition process.' (A) might to



have (B) overlooked the indigenous (C) during the 19th-century (D) No error



RULE 42

Importance: 90/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: 'A number of' vs. 'The number of'

'A number of' (meaning 'many') is followed by a plural verb, while 'the number of' (referring to a specific quantity) is followed by a singular verb.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Proximity Trap': Examiners often insert a complex prepositional phrase or a plural noun (e.g., 'of constitutional amendments') immediately before the verb. This lures candidates into matching the verb with the nearest plural noun instead of the actual singular headword 'The number'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In competitive English grammar, the distinction between 'A number of' and 'The number of' is a frequent area of testing. 'A number of' functions as a quantifier meaning 'several' or 'many.' Since it emphasizes the plurality of the noun it modifies, it must be followed by a plural verb. Conversely, 'The number of' refers to a specific, singular numerical value or the total count of a group. In this case, the grammatical subject is the singular noun 'number,' not the plural noun that follows the preposition 'of.' Consequently, it requires a singular verb.

>> Employ a plural verb when the subject phrase begins with 'A number of' followed by a plural countable noun, as it acts as an indefinite quantifier meaning 'several'.

>> Employ a singular verb when the subject phrase begins with 'The number of', as the grammatical subject is the word 'number' itself, referring to a specific singular total.

>> Distinguish the focus: 'A number of' emphasizes the individual elements within a group, while 'The number of' emphasizes the quantitative figure or collective sum.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

A number of endangered species has migrated northwards due to the rapid increase in global temperatures.

OK CORRECT

A number of endangered species have migrated northwards due to the rapid increase in global temperatures.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The economic growth of India is more rapid than most other developing nations.

OK CORRECT

The economic growth of India is more rapid than that of most other developing nations.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The number of constitutional amendments passed during the emergency period have been subject to intense judicial scrutiny by the Supreme Court.

OK CORRECT

The number of constitutional amendments passed during the emergency period has been subject to intense judicial scrutiny by the Supreme Court.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When 'numbers' is used in the plural form (e.g., 'Large numbers of immigrants'), it always requires a plural verb, regardless of the preceding determiner, as it denotes multiple groups or vast quantities.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the Substitution Test: Replace 'A number of' with 'Many' and 'The number of' with 'The total'. If 'Many' makes sense, use a plural verb. If 'The total' makes sense, use a singular verb.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Error Spotting: The number of sophisticated cyber-attacks targeting critical infrastructure during the geopolitical conflict were significantly higher than the intelligence agencies had projected. (Identify the error)

RULE 43

Importance: 90/100

Pronouns: Relative Pronouns ('Who' vs. 'Whom')

'Who' is a subjective relative pronoun (functions as the subject of a clause), while 'whom' is an objective relative pronoun (functions as the object of a verb or preposition).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often place a subject and a verb immediately after the relative pronoun to confuse the candidate. For example, in 'The scholar who the committee appointed...', the presence of 'the committee' (subject) and 'appointed' (verb) often tricks candidates into choosing 'who' because it sounds natural, despite the pronoun being the object of the appointment.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, 'who' and 'whom' are relative pronouns used to refer to people, but they differ fundamentally in their grammatical function within a subordinate clause. 'Who' is a subjective (nominative) pronoun; it functions as the subject of the verb in the relative clause, meaning it is the entity performing the action. Conversely, 'whom' is an objective pronoun; it functions as the object of a verb or the object of a preposition, meaning it is the entity receiving the action. A definitive marker for 'whom' is its usage immediately following a preposition (e.g., 'to whom', 'by whom', 'with whom'), as prepositions always take objective case pronouns.

>> Employ 'who' when the pronoun serves as the subject performing the action of the verb within the relative clause.

>> Employ 'whom' when the pronoun acts as the object receiving the action of the verb.

>> Strictly use 'whom' when the pronoun is immediately preceded by a preposition (e.g., 'to whom', 'with whom', 'by whom').

>> Maintain prescriptive grammatical standards for competitive examinations (SBI PO, SSC CGL), disregarding colloquial trends where 'who' is used in place of 'whom'.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The environmentalist whom pioneered the reforestation initiative in the Western Ghats was honored by the UN.

OK CORRECT

The environmentalist who pioneered the reforestation initiative in the Western Ghats was honored by the UN.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The Ministry of Finance seldom has intervened in the autonomous functioning of the regulatory body.

OK CORRECT

The Ministry of Finance has seldom intervened in the autonomous functioning of the regulatory body.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The diplomatic envoy, for who the Ministry of External Affairs had designated a high-level security detail, arrived in the capital yesterday.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy, for whom the Ministry of External Affairs had designated a high-level security detail, arrived in the capital yesterday.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While 'who' is increasingly used as an object in spoken English, it remains a grammatical error in formal written English and standardized tests.

>> There are no structural exceptions in formal grammar for the objective use of 'whom' following a preposition.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Utilize the 'He/Him Substitution Test' for absolute clarity: isolate the relative clause and replace the pronoun with 'he' or 'him'. If 'he' (subjective) fits, use 'who'. If 'him' (objective) fits, use 'whom'. (e.g., 'The delegate [who/whom] the council praised' → 'The council praised him' → Use 'whom').

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead archaeologist who the government commissioned to supervise the excavation of the Indus Valley site has uncovered several rare artifacts.'

RULE 44

Importance: 90/100

Relative Pronouns: 'Which' vs. 'That'

'Which' is used for non-restrictive clauses (adds extra information, set off by commas) and for things/animals. 'That' is used for restrictive clauses (essential information, no commas) and can refer to people, things, or animals.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often pair limiting modifiers like 'the only' or 'the best' with 'which' to test if the candidate recognizes the mandatory shift to 'that'. Additionally, they may place 'that' inside commas to mislead students who identify the clause as non-restrictive but ignore the punctuation error.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, the distinction between 'which' and 'that' is determined by whether the relative clause is restrictive (defining) or non-restrictive (non-defining). A restrictive clause is essential to the identity of the noun it modifies; it limits the scope of the noun to a specific subset. If a restrictive clause is removed, the meaning of the sentence changes or becomes ambiguous. For such clauses, 'that' is used, and no commas are employed. A non-restrictive clause, however, provides supplementary or parenthetical information about a noun that is already clearly identified. This information is non-essential to the core meaning of the sentence. These clauses are introduced by 'which' and must be set off by commas. While 'which' refers strictly to things and animals, 'that' can refer to people, animals, or things, although 'who' remains the preferred choice for people in formal contexts.

>> Use 'that' for restrictive clauses which are essential to identify the noun; these clauses are integrated into the sentence and never preceded by a comma.

>> Use 'which' for non-restrictive clauses that provide supplementary information; these must be enclosed in commas as they are not essential to the sentence's primary meaning.

>> Mandatorily employ 'that' when the antecedent is preceded by limiting modifiers such as 'the only', 'the first', 'the last', 'all', 'any', 'every', or superlative adjectives (e.g., 'the most effective').

>> While 'which' refers strictly to inanimate objects or animals, 'that' is versatile; however, 'who' remains the gold standard for referring to people in formal examination contexts.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The ancient manuscript, that was discovered in the caves of Dunhuang, dates back to the 4th century.

OK CORRECT

The ancient manuscript, which was discovered in the caves of Dunhuang, dates back to the 4th century.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The Board of Directors has only authorized the expenditure for the research and development wing.

OK CORRECT

The Board of Directors has authorized the expenditure only for the research and development wing.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The only legislative framework which addresses the ethical implications of CRISPR technology remains fragmented across various jurisdictions.

OK CORRECT

The only legislative framework that addresses the ethical implications of CRISPR technology remains fragmented across various jurisdictions.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In British English, 'which' is frequently used for restrictive clauses.

>> However, for competitive exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL, which follow standard formal English (often aligned with American conventions for this rule), the strict distinction between 'that' (restrictive) and 'which' (non-restrictive) is the expected benchmark.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Use the 'Deletion Test': If you can remove the entire clause and the sentence still clearly identifies exactly which noun is being discussed, the clause is non-restrictive—use 'which' with commas. If removing the clause makes the noun ambiguous, it is restrictive—use 'that' without commas.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Great Barrier Reef, that suffers from extensive coral bleaching due to rising sea temperatures, is a critical biodiversity hotspot.'

RULE 45

Importance: 90/100

Pronouns: 'It's' vs. 'Its'

'It's' is a contraction of 'it is' or 'it has'. 'Its' is a possessive pronoun meaning 'belonging to it'.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Possessive Mimicry' Trap: Examiners often place 'its' in close proximity to a noun that correctly uses an apostrophe for possession (e.g., 'the government's mandate'). This tricks the candidate into instinctively applying the same apostrophe-for-possession logic to the pronoun 'its', which is a grammatical error.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, the distinction between 'it's' and 'its' is a frequent point of error in competitive examinations. 'It's' is a contraction, representing either 'it is' or 'it has'. The apostrophe here serves as a marker for the omitted letters (the 'i' in 'is' or the 'ha' in 'has'). Conversely, 'its' is a possessive determiner (similar to 'his', 'her', or 'their') used to indicate ownership or belonging to a neuter noun or an inanimate object. A fundamental rule in traditional grammar is that possessive pronouns and determiners never utilize apostrophes to show possession; therefore, 'its' is the correct form for possession.

- >> Use 'it's' exclusively as a contraction for the phrases 'it is' or 'it has'.
- >> Use 'its' as a possessive determiner to show that something belongs to an inanimate object, animal, organization, or abstract concept.
- >> Strictly avoid using an apostrophe to indicate possession for pronouns; possessive forms such as 'its', 'his', 'hers', and 'theirs' are inherently possessive and do not require an apostrophe.
- >> In high-stakes formal writing (such as legal briefs, diplomatic cables, or academic theses), avoid contractions like 'it's' entirely, opting for 'it is' or 'it has' to maintain a professional tone.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The city council revised it's zoning regulations last month.

OK CORRECT

The city council revised its zoning regulations last month.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

Although the government has implemented stringent fiscal policies, but the volatility in the stock market persists.

OK CORRECT

Although the government has implemented stringent fiscal policies, yet the volatility in the stock market persists.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The legislative assembly argued that the amendment's failure was inevitable because it's provisions contradicted the fundamental tenets of the constitution.

OK CORRECT

The legislative assembly argued that the amendment's failure was inevitable because its provisions contradicted the fundamental tenets of the constitution.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While 'it's' is most frequently a contraction for 'it is', it can also serve as a contraction for 'it has' (e.g., 'It's been a decade since the treaty was signed'), although this is rarely used in formal examination contexts.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Execute the 'Substitution Audit': Whenever you encounter 'it's' or 'its', mentally replace it with 'it is'. If the sentence remains logically and grammatically sound, 'it's' is correct. If the sentence becomes nonsensical, you must use the possessive 'its'.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The scientific community is concerned that the glacier's rapid melting indicates that it's structural integrity has been permanently compromised by rising global temperatures.'



RULE 46

Importance: 90/100

Prepositions: 'Between' vs. 'Among'

'Between' is used when referring to two distinct items or persons. 'Among' is used when referring to more than two, or when items are part of a group.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Numerical Fallacy': Candidates often assume that any number exceeding two automatically requires 'among'. In high-level competitive exams, if the entities are specifically named or distinct (e.g., three different countries or three specific ministers), 'between' is the grammatically precise choice, regardless of the count.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In traditional English grammar, 'between' is primarily employed when referring to two distinct persons, objects, or entities. However, a critical nuance for competitive exams is that 'between' is also used for more than two entities provided they are distinct, individual, and specifically named. Conversely, 'among' is utilized when referring to three or more entities that are not distinct but are viewed as a collective group, a mass, or an undefined number of people or things.

>> Utilize 'between' when referencing two distinct persons, objects, or entities.

>> Employ 'between' for three or more entities provided they are specifically named, identified as distinct individuals, or treated as separate units.

>> Use 'among' when referring to three or more entities that are perceived as a collective mass, an undefined group, or a non-distinct plurality.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The geopolitical tension escalated among the two neighboring states over the disputed maritime boundary.

OK CORRECT

The geopolitical tension escalated between the two neighboring states over the disputed maritime boundary.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The board of directors sought an unanimous decision to approve the merger of the two conglomerates.

OK CORRECT

The board of directors sought a unanimous decision to approve the merger of the two conglomerates.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The tripartite agreement was signed among the Ministry of Finance, the Reserve Bank, and the Securities and Exchange Board.

OK CORRECT

The tripartite agreement was signed between the Ministry of Finance, the Reserve Bank, and the Securities and Exchange Board.

EXCEPTIONS

>> There are no formal grammatical exceptions; however, 'among' is the only correct choice when the total number of entities is unknown or indeterminate, regardless of their potential distinctness.

PRO-TIP

Tip: When analyzing a sentence, isolate the noun phrase following the preposition. If the phrase denotes a collective entity or an unspecified group (e.g., 'among the populace', 'among the stakeholders'), use 'among'. If the phrase lists discrete identities or specific titles (e.g., 'between the Prime Minister, the President, and the Chief Justice'), use 'between'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: The responsibility for implementing the new environmental protocols was divided _____ the various municipal corporations across the metropolitan area. (Fill in the blank)



RULE 47

Importance: 90/100

Conjunctions: 'Unless' vs. 'If not'

'Unless' means 'if not'. Therefore, a negative word (like 'not') should not be used in the clause introduced by 'unless'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often place a negative word in the main clause (the result clause) to confuse the candidate into thinking the overall sentence needs another negative in the 'unless' clause. Additionally, they may use verbs with negative connotations (e.g., 'fail', 'refuse', 'deny') to mask the double negative structure.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The conjunction 'Unless' is a conditional word that inherently means 'if... not'. Because the negation is already embedded within the word 'Unless', the clause it introduces must remain in the affirmative form. Introducing another negative word (such as 'not', 'no', or 'never') into the 'unless-clause' results in a double negative, which is grammatically incorrect in standard English. When converting a sentence from 'if not' to 'unless', the negative particle 'not' is absorbed by 'unless', leaving the verb in its positive form.

- >> Isolate the dependent clause introduced by the conjunction 'unless'.
- >> Ensure the clause is devoid of negative markers such as 'not', 'no', 'never', 'neither', or 'nor'.
- >> When substituting 'if... not' with 'unless', the explicit negative particle must be removed to maintain the logical meaning.
- >> Distinguish between the 'unless-clause' (which must be affirmative) and the 'main clause' (which may remain negative to indicate the consequence).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Unless the administration does not implement stricter waste-management protocols, the landfill crisis will intensify.

OK CORRECT

Unless the administration implements stricter waste-management protocols, the landfill crisis will intensify.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Delegation from European Union expressed grave concern over volatility of global markets.

OK CORRECT

The delegation from the European Union expressed grave concern over the volatility of the global markets.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The constitutional amendment cannot be ratified unless the state legislatures do not provide a two-thirds majority in favor of the bill.

OK CORRECT

The constitutional amendment cannot be ratified unless the state legislatures provide a two-thirds majority in favor of the bill.

EXCEPTIONS

>> 'Unless' cannot be used in certain question formats where 'If'.

>> 'not' is required for natural phrasing (e.g., instead of 'Unless you finish the report, will the manager be angry?', use 'If you don't finish the report, will the manager be angry?').

PRO-TIP

Tip: In Error Spotting, treat 'Unless' as a 'Negative Trigger'. Once you spot it, scan exclusively until the next comma or the end of that specific clause. If you encounter any auxiliary verb paired with 'not' (don't, doesn't, didn't, won't), you have identified the grammatical error.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the part containing the error: 'The digital divide (A) / in rural hinterlands (B) / will persist unless (C) / the state government does not subsidize (D) / high-speed broadband infrastructure. (E) / No error'

RULE 48

Importance: 90/100

Verbs: Infinitives vs. Gerunds

Some verbs are followed by an infinitive (to + base verb), while others are followed by a gerund (-ing form). Certain verbs can take both, sometimes with a change in meaning.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Suggest' Fallacy: A frequent pitfall in SBI PO and SSC CGL exams is the use of 'suggest' followed by a to-infinitive (e.g., 'suggested to implement'). 'Suggest' is never followed by a to-infinitive; it must be followed by a gerund or a 'that' clause.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, the choice between using a gerund (the -ing form of a verb acting as a noun) and an infinitive (to + base form of the verb) is determined by the governing verb that precedes it. Verbs that denote a future intention, a decision, or a desire—such as 'decide', 'hope', 'agree', and 'refuse'—are typically followed by an infinitive. Conversely, verbs that describe an action already in progress, a general experience, or the avoidance of an act—such as 'avoid', 'enjoy', 'postpone', and 'deny'—require a gerund. A sophisticated layer of this rule involves 'dual-nature' verbs. Some verbs, like 'start' or 'begin', accept both forms with no change in meaning. However, others, such as 'stop', 'remember', and 'forget', undergo a semantic shift: a gerund usually refers to a past action or a habit, while an infinitive refers to a future obligation or a purpose.

>> Verbs denoting intention, resolution, or desire (e.g., decide, hope, agree, refuse, aim, plan) must be followed by a to-infinitive.

>> Verbs associated with avoidance, cessation, acknowledgment, or completion (e.g., avoid, enjoy, postpone, deny, finish, admit) must be followed by a gerund.

>> Versatile verbs such as 'start' and 'begin' can be followed by either a gerund or an infinitive without a significant change in meaning.

>> Semantic Shift Verbs: 'Stop', 'remember', and 'forget' utilize gerunds to refer to past actions or habits, and infinitives to denote future obligations, purposes, or intentions.

>> Causative verbs 'make' and 'let' are followed by a bare infinitive (the verb base without 'to').

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The environmental agency recommended to monitor the air quality indices on a daily basis.

OK CORRECT

The environmental agency recommended monitoring the air quality indices on a daily basis.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The prudence is a vital attribute for those aspiring to enter the Indian Administrative Service.

OK CORRECT

Prudence is a vital attribute for those aspiring to enter the Indian Administrative Service.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The legislative committee postponed to deliberate on the constitutional amendment until the subsequent session to ensure a thorough review.

OK CORRECT

The legislative committee postponed deliberating on the constitutional amendment until the subsequent session to ensure a thorough review.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain verbs like 'like', 'love', and 'hate' can take both forms.

>> However, 'prefer' exhibits a nuance: 'prefer doing' refers to a general preference, while 'would prefer to do' refers to a specific preference in a particular instance.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Distinguish between 'regret to inform' and 'regret informing'. Use the infinitive ('regret to') for formal, present-tense announcements of unfavorable news, and the gerund ('regret doing') to express remorse for a past action.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: The ethics committee stopped _____ (to evaluate / evaluating) the AI's algorithmic bias once the developer provided the comprehensive transparency report.



RULE 49

Importance: 88/100

Order of Adjectives (OSASCOMP)

When multiple adjectives describe a noun, they must follow a specific sequence: OSASCOMP (Opinion, Size, Age, Shape, Color, Origin, Material, Purpose).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often swap 'Origin' and 'Material' (e.g., 'Titanium Japanese alloy' instead of 'Japanese titanium alloy') or 'Age' and 'Shape' to create a sequence that sounds rhythmic but is grammatically flawed. Another subtle trap is placing a 'Purpose' adjective (which acts almost as part of the compound noun) before the 'Origin' or 'Color'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

It is grammatically incorrect to place multiple adjectives randomly before a noun. The standard order is: 1. Opinion (beautiful, ugly), 2. Size (big, small), 3. Age (old, new), 4. Shape (round, square), 5. Color (red, black), 6. Origin (Italian, Indian), 7. Material (wooden, silk), 8. Purpose (sleeping, dining).

- >> Opinion: Subjective judgments or evaluations (e.g., sophisticated, flawed, prestigious).
- >> Size: Physical dimensions or scale (e.g., immense, sprawling, minute).
- >> Age: Chronological status or era (e.g., antiquated, contemporary, prehistoric).
- >> Shape: Physical form or geometry (e.g., hexagonal, streamlined, oblong).
- >> Color: Hue, shade, or tone (e.g., iridescent, charcoal, crimson).
- >> Origin: Geographic, cultural, or linguistic source (e.g., Scandinavian, Vedic, indigenous).
- >> Material: The substance the object is composed of (e.g., graphene, obsidian, synthetic).
- >> Purpose: The primary function or intended use (e.g., pedagogical, surgical, residential).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The administrator requested a leather small black briefcase.

OK CORRECT

The administrator requested a small black leather briefcase.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The company's total assets was liquidated to settle the outstanding liabilities of the firm.

OK CORRECT

The company's total assets were liquidated to settle the outstanding liabilities of the firm.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The archaeological team discovered a Mesopotamian ancient magnificent clay tablet in the ruins.

OK CORRECT

The archaeological team discovered a magnificent ancient Mesopotamian clay tablet in the ruins.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When adjectives belong to the same category (coordinate adjectives), their order is interchangeable and they must be separated by commas or the conjunction 'and'.

>> For example, 'a long, grueling journey' where both 'long' and 'grueling' can be seen as opinions/observations.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Permanence Principle': The more intrinsic or permanent a characteristic is to the noun's identity, the closer it must be placed to that noun. Material and Purpose are the most intrinsic, while Opinion is the most subjective and transient, thus placing them furthest away.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The aerospace agency developed a revolutionary, cylindrical, American, new, carbon-fiber propulsion system.'



RULE 50

Importance: 86/100

Sentence Structure: Adjective and Adverb Clauses

An adjective clause modifies a noun and usually begins with a relative pronoun (who, which, that). An adverb clause modifies a verb, adjective, or adverb and begins with a subordinating conjunction (because, although, if).

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Proximity Error' trap: Examiners strategically place a relative clause after a secondary noun rather than the intended antecedent. This creates a logical fallacy where the clause describes the nearest noun (e.g., suggesting the 'governments' stipulated guidelines rather than the 'notification'), while maintaining a superficial grammatical flow to deceive the candidate.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Adjective clauses must be placed as close as possible to the noun they modify to avoid ambiguity. Adverb clauses answer questions like when, where, why, or under what conditions. If an adverb clause starts a sentence, it must be followed by a comma.

>> Adjective clauses must be positioned immediately after the noun or pronoun they modify to preclude syntactic ambiguity and misplaced modifiers.

>> Non-restrictive (non-defining) adjective clauses provide supplementary information and must be sequestered by commas; they cannot be introduced by the relative pronoun 'that'.

>> When a sentence commences with a subordinating adverb clause, a comma must be employed to separate it from the main independent clause.

>> Adverb clauses must maintain a logical and temporal alignment with the verb they modify to ensure the intended cause-effect or conditional relationship is coherent.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The botanist submitted the research paper to the journal that contained several critical taxonomical errors.

OK CORRECT

The botanist submitted the research paper, which contained several critical taxonomical errors, to the journal.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The shareholders's grievances were meticulously addressed during the annual general meeting.

OK CORRECT

The shareholders' grievances were meticulously addressed during the annual general meeting.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The Ministry of Home Affairs issued a notification to the state governments that stipulated the new guidelines for disaster management.

OK CORRECT

The Ministry of Home Affairs issued a notification, which stipulated the new guidelines for disaster management, to the state governments.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In restrictive adjective clauses, the relative pronoun (who, whom, which, that) may be omitted if it serves as the object of the clause (e.g., 'The evidence [that] the prosecutor presented was circumstantial').

PRO-TIP

Tip: Master the 'Restrictive vs. Non-restrictive' distinction: Use 'that' for essential information (no commas) and 'which' for non-essential, descriptive information (with commas). In SBI PO and SSC CGL exams, placing a comma immediately before 'that' is a classic error marker used to test a candidate's precision.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The aerospace engineer presented the prototype to the board of directors that featured an innovative propulsion system.'



RULE 51

Importance: 85/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: 'Many a/an'

The phrase 'many a/an' is always followed by a singular noun and takes a singular verb.

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner often inserts a 'distractor' plural noun within a prepositional phrase or a parenthetical clause immediately before the verb. This tricks the candidate into applying the 'proximity rule' (matching the verb to the nearest noun) rather than identifying the singular subject 'Many a...'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English and competitive examinations, the phrase 'many a' or 'many an' is used to refer to a large number of individuals or items, but it emphasizes them one by one rather than as a collective group. Despite the plural sense of the phrase, it is grammatically singular. Therefore, it must be followed by a singular countable noun and a singular verb. This construction is a common trap in Error Detection questions, as candidates often confuse it with the standard use of 'many', which requires plural nouns and verbs.

>> The grammatical structure must strictly follow: 'Many a/an' + Singular Countable Noun + Singular Verb.

>> While the semantic meaning implies a large number (plurality), the grammatical treatment is singular because it views the group as a series of individuals.

>> It is distinct from the construction 'Many' + Plural Noun + Plural Verb.

>> The singular verb requirement persists even if the sentence contains intervening plural nouns or complex modifiers.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Many a species of rainforest flora have vanished due to unchecked deforestation.

OK CORRECT

Many a species of rainforest flora has vanished due to unchecked deforestation.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The shareholders's resolution was passed unanimously during the annual general meeting to ensure corporate transparency.

OK CORRECT

The shareholders' resolution was passed unanimously during the annual general meeting to ensure corporate transparency.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Many a seasoned diplomat, tasked with navigating the volatile geopolitical landscape of the Cold War, were unable to prevent the escalation of regional conflicts.

OK CORRECT

Many a seasoned diplomat, tasked with navigating the volatile geopolitical landscape of the Cold War, was unable to prevent the escalation of regional conflicts.

EXCEPTIONS

>> There are no grammatical exceptions to the singular requirement of 'many a/an'; however, it is primarily used in formal or literary contexts and is rarely found in casual spoken English.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Whenever you encounter 'Many a/an', mentally replace it with 'Every single'. Since 'every' always mandates a singular verb, this substitution eliminates the confusion caused by the word 'many'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Many a tech startup, driven by the ambition to disrupt the global logistics market through generative AI, have failed to secure sustainable venture capital in the current fiscal climate.'

**RULE 52****Importance: 85/100****Subject-Verb Agreement: 'More than one'**

The phrase 'more than one' is always followed by a singular noun and takes a singular verb.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners leverage 'semantic plurality'—the logical understanding that 'more than one' means 'many'—to bait candidates into using a plural verb. They often contrast this with the 'more than one of the' structure in a single passage to test whether the candidate can distinguish between the two grammatical requirements.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In competitive English grammar, the phrase 'more than one' presents a paradox where the logical meaning is plural, but the grammatical construction is singular. According to traditional conventions (as seen in Wren & Martin), when 'more than one' modifies a noun, it must be followed by a singular countable noun and a singular verb. The grammatical focus is on the word 'one', which dictates the singularity of the subsequent noun and verb, despite the overall expression implying a quantity greater than one.

>> When 'more than one' acts as a determiner directly modifying a noun, the noun must be in the singular form and the corresponding verb must be singular.

>> When the construction 'More than one of the' is used, it must be followed by a plural noun and a plural verb, as the grammatical focus shifts to the plural group from which the selection is made.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

More than one solar panel have failed due to the extreme temperature fluctuations in the tundra.

OK CORRECT

More than one solar panel has failed due to the extreme temperature fluctuations in the tundra.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The geopolitical tensions in the Middle East have exacerbated the volatility of crude oil prices, several emerging economies are facing severe inflationary pressures.

OK CORRECT

The geopolitical tensions in the Middle East have exacerbated the volatility of crude oil prices; consequently, several emerging economies are facing severe inflationary pressures.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

More than one legislative clause have been contested in the Supreme Court on the grounds of violating the fundamental rights of the citizenry.

OK CORRECT

More than one legislative clause has been contested in the Supreme Court on the grounds of violating the fundamental rights of the citizenry.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When the phrase is structured as 'More than one of the [plural noun]', the verb is plural.

>> Example: 'More than one of the delegates were unavailable for the emergency session.'

PRO-TIP

Tip: Use the 'Of-Filter' for rapid elimination: If 'more than one' is followed immediately by a noun, it is singular. If 'more than one' is followed by 'of the', it is plural. This heuristic is highly effective for the Error Spotting and Sentence Improvement sections of SBI PO and SSC CGL.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'More than one geothermal vent were discovered during the deep-sea exploration of the Mid-Atlantic Ridge.'



RULE 53

Importance: 85/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Uncountable Nouns*Uncountable nouns (e.g., 'information', 'advice', 'furniture', 'news') always take a singular verb.*

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Proximity Trap': Examiners often insert a long prepositional phrase containing plural nouns (e.g., 'the details of the reports', 'the remnants of the ruins') immediately before the verb. This tricks the candidate into matching the verb with the nearest plural noun instead of the actual uncountable subject.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, uncountable nouns (also known as mass nouns) refer to substances, concepts, or masses that cannot be counted as individual units. According to traditional grammatical conventions, these nouns do not possess a plural form and are invariably treated as singular entities. Consequently, they must be paired with a singular verb to maintain subject-verb agreement. Common categories of uncountable nouns include abstract concepts (advice, information, knowledge), collective masses (furniture, luggage, equipment), and specific singular nouns that end in 's' (news, economics). A frequent error in competitive examinations is the tendency to treat these nouns as plural because of their perceived volume or their ending, but they strictly demand singular verb conjugation.

>> Purely uncountable nouns (e.g., information, luggage, equipment, furniture, advice) never take a plural form and always require a singular verb.

>> Academic disciplines or specialized fields of study that end in '-s' (e.g., Economics, Physics, Mathematics, Politics) are treated as singular entities.

>> When a quantifier is used to make an uncountable noun countable (e.g., 'pieces of', 'slabs of', 'units of'), the verb must agree with the quantifier, not the mass noun.

>> Contextual shift nouns (e.g., experience, time, paper, light) function as uncountable when referring to a general concept (singular verb) and as countable when referring to specific instances or types (plural verb).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The laboratory equipment procured for the atmospheric research project are highly sophisticated.

OK CORRECT

The laboratory equipment procured for the atmospheric research project is highly sophisticated.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The committee is divided in their opinions regarding the implementation of the new monetary policy.

OK CORRECT

The committee are divided in their opinions regarding the implementation of the new monetary policy.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The extensive evidence presented by the environmental commission regarding the degradation of coral reefs and the acidification of oceans have necessitated a revision of the global maritime treaty.

OK CORRECT

The extensive evidence presented by the environmental commission regarding the degradation of coral reefs and the acidification of oceans has necessitated a revision of the global maritime treaty.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain nouns like 'Statistics' or 'Politics' take a plural verb when they refer to specific data or a collection of personal beliefs rather than the field of study.

>> Example: 'The statistics regarding urban migration are staggering.'

PRO-TIP



Tip: To avoid errors, use the 'Isolation Technique': Mentally strip away all modifiers and prepositional phrases between the subject and the verb. If the remaining head noun is an uncountable mass noun, the verb must be singular, regardless of how many plural nouns precede it.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: The legislative baggage (A)/ associated with the proposed land reform (B)/ were considered too cumbersome (C)/ for the parliamentary committee to address (D).



RULE 54

Importance: 85/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Indefinite Pronouns ('All', 'Some', 'Most', 'Any', 'None')

When 'all', 'some', 'most', 'any', 'none' are used with an 'of' phrase, the verb agrees with the noun in that phrase (countable plural noun = plural verb; uncountable noun = singular verb).

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner often inserts a complex parenthetical phrase or a prepositional phrase containing plural nouns (e.g., 'objections raised by states') immediately before the verb. This tricks the candidate into matching the verb with the nearest plural noun rather than the actual object of the 'of' phrase (the uncountable noun 'legislation').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, the words 'all', 'some', 'most', 'any', and 'none' are categorized as indefinite pronouns. Unlike standard pronouns, they do not possess a fixed grammatical number (singular or plural). When these quantifiers are followed by a prepositional phrase starting with 'of', the number of the verb is determined by the noun that follows 'of' (the object of the preposition). If the noun in the 'of' phrase is an uncountable noun (mass noun), the verb must be singular. Conversely, if the noun in the 'of' phrase is a plural countable noun, the verb must be plural. This is a critical point of evaluation in competitive exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL, where examiners often place intervening phrases between the quantifier and the verb to confuse the candidate.

- >> Identify the indefinite pronoun (All, Some, Most, Any, None) acting as the subject of the sentence.
- >> Isolate the noun located immediately after the preposition 'of'.
- >> Determine whether this noun is 'countable plural' (e.g., citizens, documents, species) or 'uncountable/mass' (e.g., luggage, evidence, legislation, furniture).
- >> Assign a plural verb if the noun is countable and plural.
- >> Assign a singular verb if the noun is uncountable, regardless of the perceived quantity implied by the pronoun.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Most of the foliage in the tropical rainforest have been destroyed by illegal logging.

OK CORRECT

Most of the foliage in the tropical rainforest has been destroyed by illegal logging.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

There has been numerous contradictions in the testimonies provided by the witnesses during the cross-examination.

OK CORRECT

There have been numerous contradictions in the testimonies provided by the witnesses during the cross-examination.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

All of the legislation pertaining to maritime boundaries, notwithstanding the objections raised by the neighboring states, were passed by the parliament in a hurried session.

OK CORRECT

All of the legislation pertaining to maritime boundaries, notwithstanding the objections raised by the neighboring states, was passed by the parliament in a hurried session.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> While 'None' was traditionally treated as strictly singular ('not one'), in contemporary formal English and competitive exams, it typically follows the 'of' phrase rule: 'None of the candidates was' (singular) vs 'None of the candidates were' (plural), though the singular is often preferred in highly formal contexts.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Employ the 'Subtraction Technique': Mentally strike through all modifiers and intervening phrases between the noun following 'of' and the verb. If you are left with 'All of the legislation... were', the grammatical mismatch becomes immediately obvious.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Error Detection: 'Any of the evidence (A)/ presented by the medical board (B)/ were found to be (C)/ inconsistent with the autopsy report (D)/ No Error (E).'



RULE 55

Importance: 85/100

Present Continuous Tense: Usage and Constraints

The present continuous tense is used for actions happening at the moment of speaking, temporary actions, or definite future plans with a time expression.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Stative Mask': Examiners often use verbs like 'realize', 'understand', or 'consist' in complex sentences where the context suggests a continuing process. Candidates often mistake this perceived continuity for a reason to use the -ing form, forgetting that these verbs are inherently stative and must remain in the simple present.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Present Continuous Tense (formed as Subject + is/am/are + Present Participle/V1+ing) is utilized in three primary scenarios: First, to describe an action occurring precisely at the moment of utterance. Second, to denote a temporary situation or a prevailing trend that is in progress over a period of time, even if the action is not happening at the exact second of speaking. Third, to express a definite future arrangement or a planned event, typically accompanied by a specific time expression. In competitive examinations, the core challenge lies in distinguishing this tense from the Simple Present, which is reserved for universal truths, habits, and permanent states.

>> Utilize the structure 'Subject + is/am/are + V-ing' to denote actions happening precisely at the moment of utterance.

>> Employ this tense to describe temporary situations, shifting paradigms, or evolving global trends.

>> Apply the tense for definite future arrangements that have been pre-planned, typically accompanied by a specific time marker.

>> Strictly avoid the continuous form with stative verbs—those representing states of cognition, emotion, possession, or perception (e.g., 'perceive', 'understand', 'own', 'believe').

>> Do not use this tense to indicate a period of time; where 'since' or 'for' is used to denote duration, the Present Perfect Continuous must be substituted.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The research team is believing that the quantum algorithm provides a more efficient solution to the encryption problem.

OK CORRECT

The research team believes that the quantum algorithm provides a more efficient solution to the encryption problem.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Monetary Policy Committee is meeting bi-monthly to determine the benchmark repo rate to curb inflation.

OK CORRECT

The Monetary Policy Committee meets bi-monthly to determine the benchmark repo rate to curb inflation.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The coastal regions of the subcontinent are facing an unprecedented rise in sea levels for several decades due to accelerated glacial melting.

OK CORRECT

The coastal regions of the subcontinent have been facing an unprecedented rise in sea levels for several decades due to accelerated glacial melting.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain stative verbs can be used in the continuous form when they describe a dynamic process or a temporary behavior rather than a permanent state.

>> For example, 'I am thinking about the proposal' (process of consideration) is correct, whereas 'I am thinking he is honest' (belief/opinion) is incorrect.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Be alert for the adverb 'always' paired with the present continuous. While 'always' typically denotes a habit in the simple present, using it in the continuous form (e.g., 'The bureaucracy is always obstructing innovative reforms') expresses a persistent habit that evokes annoyance or criticism—a nuanced point frequently tested in high-level SBI PO and SSC CGL papers.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Ministry of External Affairs is knowing the geopolitical implications of the proposed bilateral treaty on regional stability.'



RULE 56

Importance: 85/100

Tenses: Present Perfect Continuous Usage

The present perfect continuous tense is used for actions that started in the past, have continued up to the present, and emphasize the duration of the action.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often blend the Present Continuous (is/am/are + V-ing) with time markers like 'since' or 'for' to lure candidates into overlooking the missing 'has/have been'. Additionally, they may use stative verbs in a continuous structure (e.g., 'The administration has been possessing the records since 1947') to test your knowledge of non-continuous verbs.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Present Perfect Continuous tense is employed to describe an action that commenced in the past and continues to persist in the present, with a specific emphasis on the duration of the activity. It is constructed using the auxiliary verbs 'has/have' + 'been' + the present participle (V1 + ing). A critical component of this tense is the application of time markers: 'since' is utilized for a specific point in time (e.g., since 2010, since Monday), whereas 'for' is utilized for a duration or period of time (e.g., for five years, for two decades). In competitive examinations, this tense is frequently tested against the Present Continuous to ensure the candidate recognizes that a time-duration marker necessitates the perfect aspect rather than the simple continuous aspect.

>> Structure: Subject + has/have + been + Present Participle (V1 + ing).

>> Use 'since' to specify a definitive starting point in time (e.g., since the 1991 economic reforms, since the inception of the project).

>> Use 'for' to specify a total duration or length of time (e.g., for three consecutive decades, for several fiscal quarters).

>> Stative verbs (verbs describing states, possession, or mental processes such as 'possess', 'realize', 'believe', 'understand') cannot be used in the continuous form; use the Present Perfect Simple instead.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The research team is analyzing the atmospheric carbon levels for three months.

OK CORRECT

The research team has been analyzing the atmospheric carbon levels for three months.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Monetary Policy Committee has revised the repo rate by twenty-five basis points during its last quarterly meeting to curb inflationary pressures.

OK CORRECT

The Monetary Policy Committee revised the repo rate by twenty-five basis points during its last quarterly meeting to curb inflationary pressures.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The Parliamentary Committee is examining the legislative loopholes in the land acquisition act since the last winter session.

OK CORRECT

The Parliamentary Committee has been examining the legislative loopholes in the land acquisition act since the last winter session.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain verbs like 'live', 'work', and 'study' can be used interchangeably in both the Present Perfect and Present Perfect Continuous tenses with minimal change in meaning when the duration is long-term (e.g., 'I have worked here for ten years' vs 'I have been working here for ten years').

PRO-TIP



Tip: In 'Error Spotting' sections, immediately flag any sentence where 'since' or 'for' appears alongside a verb that lacks the 'perfect' aspect (has/have + been). If the verb is merely in the continuous form, it is an automatic error in the context of duration.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The cybersecurity agency is monitoring the network traffic for anomalous patterns since the detection of the first breach last Tuesday.'



RULE 57

Importance: 85/100

Tenses: Sequence of Tenses (Universal Truths)

The tense in the subordinate clause does not change if it expresses a universal truth, a habitual fact, or a proverb, even if the main clause is in the past tense.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently use sophisticated reporting verbs such as 'stipulated', 'posited', 'contended', or 'asserted' in the past tense to lure candidates into applying the sequence of tenses rule, forcing an incorrect backshift of a scientific or logical fact.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

According to the standard sequence of tenses, a verb in a subordinate clause typically conforms to the tense of the verb in the principal clause. However, a critical exception arises when the subordinate clause expresses a universal truth, a scientific fact, a habitual action, or a proverb. In such instances, the verb in the subordinate clause remains in the Simple Present Tense, regardless of whether the principal clause is in the Past, Present, or Future tense. This is because these statements represent timeless realities that do not change based on the time of reporting.

>> Identify the structure of the complex sentence, distinguishing the principal (reporting) clause from the subordinate (reported) clause.

>> Analyze the content of the subordinate clause to determine if it states a timeless truth, a scientific law, a mathematical certainty, or a permanent geopolitical fact.

>> Maintain the verb of the subordinate clause in the Simple Present Tense if it describes a permanent reality.

>> Explicitly override the standard 'backshifting' rule (where present tense shifts to past tense) when the information conveyed is eternally true.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The astronomy lecturer explained that the Earth revolved around the Sun.

OK CORRECT

The astronomy lecturer explained that the Earth revolves around the Sun.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoys were negotiating the terms of the treaty for several months before the ceasefire was finally signed.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoys had been negotiating the terms of the treaty for several months before the ceasefire was finally signed.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The constitutional expert maintained during the symposium that the rule of law provided the essential foundation for an impartial judiciary.

OK CORRECT

The constitutional expert maintained during the symposium that the rule of law provides the essential foundation for an impartial judiciary.

EXCEPTIONS

>> If the 'truth' mentioned is no longer valid (e.g., a debunked scientific theory) or if the sentence refers to a specific historical occurrence rather than a general law, the past tense is used.

PRO-TIP

Tip: When you see a reporting verb in the past tense, isolate the subordinate clause and ask: 'Does this statement remain true regardless of the time of speaking?' If it is a constant law of nature, science, or logic, lock the verb in the Simple Present.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The climatologist argued that the increase in atmospheric carbon dioxide levels led to a gradual rise in global mean temperatures.'

RULE 58

Importance: 85/100

Pronouns: Reflexive Pronouns Usage

Reflexive pronouns (*myself, himself, herself, etc.*) are used when the subject and object of a verb are the same, or for emphasis. They should not be used as direct subjects or objects.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Formal Tone Fallacy': Examiners exploit the tendency of candidates to use 'myself' instead of 'I' or 'me' in compound structures, as it is mistakenly perceived as more sophisticated or deferential. Additionally, traps are set by pairing a singular subject with additive phrases (e.g., 'along with', 'as well as'), then using a plural reflexive pronoun like 'themselves' to mislead the candidate.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Reflexive pronouns (*myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself, ourselves, yourselves, themselves*) are employed in two primary capacities: 1. Reflexive Use: When the subject and the object of the verb are the same entity, the action 'reflects' back to the doer (e.g., The board members congratulated themselves). 2. Emphatic Use: When used immediately after a noun or pronoun to add emphasis to the subject (e.g., The Prime Minister himself addressed the assembly). A critical grammatical error frequently tested in competitive exams is the use of a reflexive pronoun as a subject or a standalone object. A reflexive pronoun cannot exist without a preceding noun or pronoun to which it refers.

>> Reflexive Function: Employ a reflexive pronoun when the subject and the direct object of the sentence are the same person or thing, indicating the action reflects back to the doer.

>> Emphatic/Intensive Function: Use a reflexive pronoun immediately after a noun or pronoun to add emphasis to the subject's role in the action (e.g., The President himself signed the treaty).

>> Subject Prohibition: A reflexive pronoun must never serve as the grammatical subject of a sentence or as part of a compound subject (e.g., 'Myself and the Director' is grammatically incorrect).

>> Obligatory Reflexives: Certain verbs—such as 'avail', 'absent', 'enjoy', 'reconcile', 'adapt', and 'resign'—require a reflexive pronoun when no other direct object is present to complete the sense of the verb.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

Myself and the curator will supervise the installation of the historical artifacts.

OK CORRECT

The curator and I will supervise the installation of the historical artifacts.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

If the administration had implemented the fiscal reforms last decade, the current inflation rate will be significantly lower.

OK CORRECT

If the administration had implemented the fiscal reforms last decade, the current inflation rate would be significantly lower.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The parliamentary subcommittee recommended that myself and the Ministry Secretary coordinate the implementation of the new agrarian reforms.

OK CORRECT

The parliamentary subcommittee recommended that the Ministry Secretary and I coordinate the implementation of the new agrarian reforms.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain verbs that usually require reflexive pronouns may dispense with them if a direct object is already present.

>> For instance, one can say 'He enjoyed himself at the gala' (reflexive) or 'He enjoyed the orchestral performance at the gala' (direct object).

PRO-TIP



Tip: Apply the 'Isolation Test' for compound subjects or objects: Temporarily remove the other person from the sentence. Since you would never say 'Myself will coordinate the report', you cannot say 'The Secretary and myself will coordinate the report'. Always prioritize the subjective pronoun 'I' in such structures.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead climatologist, along with her team of researchers, found themselves unable to reconcile the discrepancies in the glacial melt data.'

RULE 59

Importance: 85/100

Pronouns: After Prepositions and Conjunctions

Pronouns following prepositions (e.g., 'between', 'for', 'to') or certain conjunctions (e.g., 'but', 'except', 'than' when comparing objects) should be in the objective case.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Hypercorrection Trap': Examiners often pair a high-ranking title (e.g., 'the Chief Justice', 'the Ambassador') with a nominative pronoun (e.g., 'and I') to exploit a candidate's tendency to use 'I' to sound more formal or sophisticated in professional contexts.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

According to traditional English grammar, any pronoun that follows a preposition (such as 'between', 'for', 'with', 'to', 'against') must be in the objective case (me, us, him, her, them, whom). This rule extends to certain conjunctions that function as prepositions in specific contexts, most notably 'but' (meaning 'except') and 'except'. A frequent error in competitive exams occurs in compound objects; candidates often mistakenly use the nominative case (e.g., 'between you and I') under the false impression that it sounds more formal. However, since the pronoun is the object of the preposition, the objective case is mandatory regardless of whether it is alone or paired with another noun/pronoun.

>> Identify the preposition or the conjunction functioning as a preposition (e.g., 'between', 'against', 'for', 'except', 'without').

>> Ensure that any pronoun serving as the object of that preposition is in the objective case (me, us, him, her, them, whom).

>> In compound objects (e.g., 'between the director and me'), both the noun and the pronoun must strictly adhere to the objective case rule.

>> Differentiate whether 'than' and 'as' are acting as prepositions (requiring objective case) or introducing an elliptical clause (requiring nominative case).

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The responsibility for the reforestation project lies with the local community and she.

OK CORRECT

The responsibility for the reforestation project lies with the local community and her.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

It is high time the government implements stringent measures to curb the rising inflation.

OK CORRECT

It is high time the government implemented stringent measures to curb the rising inflation.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The constitutional amendment, though contentious, was debated extensively between the members of the parliamentary committee and he.

OK CORRECT

The constitutional amendment, though contentious, was debated extensively between the members of the parliamentary committee and him.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When 'than' or 'as' function as conjunctions introducing a clause where the verb is implied (elliptical clause), the nominative case is used.

>> Example: 'She is more proficient in diplomatic negotiations than he [is]'.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Apply the 'Isolation Technique': Temporarily remove the accompanying noun from the compound object to test the pronoun's case. You would never say 'The responsibility lies with he,' therefore you must say 'The responsibility lies with the community and him.'

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Spot the error in the following sentence: 'The ethical implications of generative AI and its impact on labor markets were discussed at length by the research panel and we.'

RULE 60

Importance: 85/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: Degrees of Comparison

Adjectives and adverbs have three degrees: positive (e.g., 'tall'), comparative (e.g., 'taller', 'more beautiful'), and superlative (e.g., 'tallest', 'most beautiful').

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Faulty Parallelism Trap': Examiners often compare a property of one noun to the noun itself. For example, 'The inflation rate of the US is higher than Germany.' Here, the rate is being compared to a country. The correct form must be 'higher than that of Germany' or 'higher than Germany's'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Degrees of comparison are used to describe the intensity of a quality or the extent of an action. There are three distinct levels: 1. Positive Degree: Used when no comparison is made, simply stating a quality (e.g., 'The candidate is diligent'). 2. Comparative Degree: Used to compare two entities. It is typically formed by adding '-er' to the adjective/adverb or by using 'more' before the word, followed by 'than' (e.g., 'The current fiscal policy is more stringent than the previous one'). 3. Superlative Degree: Used to compare three or more entities to denote the highest degree of a quality. It is formed by adding '-est' or using 'most' and is invariably preceded by the definite article 'the' (e.g., 'This is the most exhaustive report on the quarterly earnings'). A critical rule in competitive exams is the 'Parallelism of Comparison': one must compare like with like (e.g., comparing the 'salary of A' with the 'salary of B', not 'salary of A' with 'B').

>> Positive Degree: Utilized to describe a quality of a person or thing without making any comparison (e.g., 'The atmospheric pressure is stable').

>> Comparative Degree: Employed when comparing exactly two entities. It is formed by adding the suffix '-er' or using the modifier 'more', typically followed by 'than' (e.g., 'The current carbon sequestration method is more effective than the previous iteration').

>> Superlative Degree: Employed when comparing three or more entities to denote the highest degree of a quality. It is formed by adding the suffix '-est' or using 'most' and must be preceded by the definite article 'the' (e.g., 'The Great Barrier Reef is the largest coral reef system in the world').

>> Parallelism of Comparison: Comparison must be logically consistent, comparing similar attributes rather than an attribute to an entity (e.g., 'The legislative process in India is more complex than that of the UK', not 'more complex than the UK').

>> Latin Comparatives: Specific adjectives derived from Latin—such as 'Superior', 'Inferior', 'Senior', 'Junior', 'Prior', and 'Prefer'—are followed by the preposition 'to' instead of 'than'.

>> Avoidance of Double Comparatives: Combining 'more' or 'most' with an adjective that already possesses an '-er' or '-est' ending is grammatically redundant and incorrect.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The updated irrigation system is more efficienter than the traditional method.

OK CORRECT

The updated irrigation system is more efficient than the traditional method.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The novice investor speaks with such audacity as if he is a seasoned veteran of the stock market.

OK CORRECT

The novice investor speaks with such audacity as if he were a seasoned veteran of the stock market.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

Of the two geopolitical strategies proposed by the council, the latter is clearly the most viable option for long-term stability.

OK CORRECT

Of the two geopolitical strategies proposed by the council, the latter is clearly the more viable option for long-term stability.

**EXCEPTIONS**

>> Some adjectives possess irregular forms that do not follow standard suffix rules (e.g., 'good' becomes 'better' and 'best'; 'bad' becomes 'worse' and 'worst').

>> Additionally, some adjectives can accept both '-er' and 'more' (e.g., 'cleverer' or 'more clever'), though formal usage usually prefers one based on context.

PRO-TIP

Tip: When comparing two different qualities of the same individual or object, always use 'more + positive degree' regardless of the length of the adjective. For example, 'The diplomat was more prudent than tactful' is correct, whereas 'prudenter' would be an error.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The administrative framework of the newly autonomous region is considered superior than the previous centralized model.'

RULE 61

Importance: 85/100

Placement of Adverbs (Focus on Adverbs of Frequency and Limiting Adverbs)

Adverbs should generally be placed close to the word they modify to avoid ambiguity. Adverbs of frequency typically come before the main verb but after 'be' verbs.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently employ the 'misplaced modifier' trap by positioning limiting adverbs like 'only' or 'just' before the verb rather than the noun they are meant to restrict. This creates a subtle semantic shift that candidates often overlook, assuming the sentence is grammatically correct when it is logically flawed.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The placement of an adverb is critical to the precision of a sentence; a misplaced adverb can create ambiguity or fundamentally alter the intended meaning. The general principle is that an adverb should be positioned as close as possible to the word it modifies. Specifically, Adverbs of Frequency (e.g., always, seldom, rarely, often, never) follow a strict positional hierarchy in formal English: 1. They are placed immediately before the main verb (e.g., 'He seldom fails'). 2. They are placed after the verb 'to be' (am, is, are, was, were) (e.g., 'She is often late'). 3. In sentences containing auxiliary verbs, the adverb is positioned between the auxiliary verb and the main verb (e.g., 'The project has frequently been delayed').

>> Adverbs of frequency (e.g., always, seldom, rarely, often, never) are placed immediately before the main verb in simple tenses.

>> Adverbs of frequency are positioned after the verb 'to be' (am, is, are, was, were) when it acts as the main verb.

>> In sentences with auxiliary or modal verbs, the adverb of frequency is placed between the auxiliary verb and the main verb.

>> Limiting adverbs (e.g., 'only', 'almost', 'just', 'merely') must be placed immediately before the specific word or phrase they modify to ensure the intended meaning is logically sound.

>> Adverbs of manner typically follow the main verb or the direct object, while adverbs of time and place are generally situated at the end of the clause.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The automated system generates occasionally errors during peak data transmission.

OK CORRECT

The automated system occasionally generates errors during peak data transmission.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

One must be mindful of his conduct when representing the organization at an international forum.

OK CORRECT

One must be mindful of one's conduct when representing the organization at an international forum.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The parliamentary committee has been scrutinized because it seldom has acknowledged the socio-economic disparities in the border regions.

OK CORRECT

The parliamentary committee has been scrutinized because it has seldom acknowledged the socio-economic disparities in the border regions.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain adverbs of frequency, such as 'sometimes', 'usually', and 'often', exhibit greater flexibility and can be placed at the beginning or the end of a sentence for rhetorical emphasis without violating grammatical norms (e.g., 'Sometimes, the administration ignores the established protocol').

PRO-TIP



Tip: In high-level exams like SBI PO, always perform a 'Logic Check' for the word 'only'. Identify exactly which word is being limited. If the adverb 'only' is placed before the verb 'approved' (e.g., 'The Minister only approved the bill'), it implies the Minister did nothing else but approve it. If it is placed before the object (e.g., 'The Minister approved only the bill'), it implies no other bills were approved. Precision in placement is the key to scoring here.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the segment that contains a grammatical error: 'The legislative council (A) / argued that the amendment (B) / only should be adopted (C) / after a comprehensive review. (D) / No Error (E)'



RULE 62

Importance: 85/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Only' Placement

The word 'only' should be placed immediately before the word or phrase it modifies to ensure clarity and avoid misinterpretation.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Auditory Illusion' trap. Examiners create sentences that mirror natural spoken English, where 'only' is often misplaced before the verb. While these sound acceptable to the ear, they are logically incorrect in formal writing because they restrict the action rather than the intended object or condition.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, 'only' functions as a limiting modifier. To ensure semantic precision and avoid ambiguity, it must be placed immediately before the specific word, phrase, or clause it is intended to modify. A misplaced 'only' often inadvertently modifies the verb rather than the intended noun or adjective, which fundamentally alters the logical meaning of the sentence. In high-stakes competitive examinations such as SBI PO and SSC CGL, this is categorized under 'Misplaced Modifiers.' The examiner tests whether the candidate can distinguish between the action being limited and the object or condition being limited.

- >> Pinpoint the exact element—be it a noun, adjective, or qualifying phrase—that requires restriction.
- >> Position 'only' immediately preceding the target element to ensure the limitation is unambiguous.
- >> Avoid the colloquial habit of placing 'only' before the verb if the restriction is meant for the object, a timeframe, or a conditional clause.
- >> Perform a semantic check to ensure 'only' is not inadvertently modifying the action (the verb), which would imply that the subject performed no other action except the one mentioned.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The research team only analyzed the soil samples from the Arctic region.

OK CORRECT

The research team analyzed only the soil samples from the Arctic region.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The architectural design of the newly inaugurated parliament building is more unique than that of the previous structure.

OK CORRECT

The architectural design of the newly inaugurated parliament building is unique.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The parliamentary committee only voted to implement the austerity measures after reviewing the comprehensive fiscal deficit report.

OK CORRECT

The parliamentary committee voted to implement the austerity measures only after reviewing the comprehensive fiscal deficit report.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When 'only' serves as an adjective meaning 'sole' or 'single' (e.g., 'He was the only survivor of the shipwreck'), its position is fixed before the noun it modifies and does not follow the rules of adverbial placement.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Exclusivity Test': Replace 'only' with 'solely' or 'exclusively'. If the sentence sounds logically flawed or changes the intended meaning, move the modifier closer to the word it is meant to limit. If you intend to limit the 'when', 'how', or 'what', 'only' must stay away from the verb.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The legislative body only allowed the deployment of autonomous drones once the safety protocols were ratified by the international ethics committee.'

RULE 63

Importance: 85/100

Conjunctions: 'Though/Although...yet'

When 'though' or 'although' introduce a concessive clause, the main clause can be introduced by 'yet' (optional but preferred in formal English). Avoid using 'but' with 'though/although'.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Distraction Gap': Examiners often insert a lengthy, complex subordinating clause filled with modifiers. By the time the candidate reaches the main clause, the initial 'Although' is mentally discarded, making the subsequent 'but' seem necessary to signal the contrast, thus leading the candidate into a redundancy trap.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, 'Though' and 'Although' are subordinating conjunctions used to introduce a concessive clause—a clause that acknowledges a fact but introduces a contrasting idea in the main clause. According to traditional grammatical conventions (as seen in Wren & Martin), the main clause following a 'though' or 'although' clause can be introduced by the conjunction 'yet'. While 'yet' is optional and can be replaced by a simple comma in modern usage, it remains the preferred formal correlate in competitive examinations. The most critical error to avoid is the use of 'but' in the main clause. Since 'though/although' already establishes the contrast, adding 'but' (a coordinating conjunction) creates a redundant and grammatically incorrect structure known as a double conjunction error.

- >> Initiate the dependent (concessive) clause using 'Although' or 'Though' to introduce a contrasting fact.
- >> Connect the main clause using either a comma (preferred in contemporary professional English) or the conjunction 'yet' (preferred in formal or traditional contexts).
- >> Strictly prohibit the use of 'but' as a correlate to 'Although' or 'Though', as this creates a redundant double-conjunction error.
- >> Ensure that if 'yet' is used, it is placed at the start of the main clause to logically transition from the concession to the result.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

Although the new environmental legislation aims to curb plastic pollution, but it lacks a stringent enforcement mechanism.

OK CORRECT

Although the new environmental legislation aims to curb plastic pollution, it lacks a stringent enforcement mechanism.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

A little evidence the prosecutor presented was insufficient to secure a conviction in the high-profile trial.

OK CORRECT

The little evidence the prosecutor presented was insufficient to secure a conviction in the high-profile trial.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

Although the Magna Carta was intended to limit the arbitrary power of the monarchy and establish the rule of law, but its immediate impact was negligible due to the King's refusal to abide by its terms.

OK CORRECT

Although the Magna Carta was intended to limit the arbitrary power of the monarchy and establish the rule of law, yet its immediate impact was negligible due to the King's refusal to abide by its terms.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> While 'yet' is a formal correlate, it is entirely optional.
- >> Additionally, 'though' can function as an adverb at the end of a sentence to indicate contrast (e.g., 'The evidence was circumstantial; the jury convicted him, though'), in which case it does not require a correlate.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Apply the 'Binary Search' Method: The moment you spot 'Although' or 'Though' at the commencement of a sentence, immediately scan the midpoint for 'but'. In SBI PO and SSC CGL exams, 'Although... but' is one of the most frequently tested error patterns; if you find 'but', it is almost certainly the error point.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Although the integration of generative AI in healthcare promises unprecedented diagnostic accuracy, but the ethical concerns regarding data privacy and algorithmic bias remain largely unresolved.'



RULE 64

Importance: 85/100

Indefinite Articles: Usage of 'A' and 'An'

'A' is used before singular countable nouns starting with a consonant sound. 'An' is used before singular countable nouns starting with a vowel sound. They refer to non-specific items.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently use words like 'unanimous', 'university', or 'one-time' to trick candidates into using 'an' because they start with a vowel letter, or abbreviations like 'FIR' or 'MBA' to trick them into using 'a' because they start with a consonant letter.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Indefinite articles ('a' and 'an') are employed before singular countable nouns to denote a non-specific entity or a member of a general class. The selection between 'a' and 'an' is governed strictly by the phonetic sound of the succeeding word, not its orthographic spelling. 'A' is used before words beginning with a consonant sound, whereas 'an' is used before words beginning with a vowel sound. In high-level competitive examinations, the distinction rests on the pronunciation of the initial sound, particularly when dealing with silent letters, semi-vowels, or abbreviations.

- >> Use 'a' before words that begin with a consonant sound (e.g., a bank, a corporate strategy).
- >> Use 'an' before words that begin with a vowel sound (e.g., an asset, an audit).
- >> Use 'an' before words starting with a silent 'h' where the first sound is a vowel (e.g., an hour, an honest appraisal).
- >> Use 'a' before words starting with vowel letters that produce a consonant 'y' sound (e.g., a university, a unanimous vote, a European union).
- >> Use 'an' before abbreviations that begin with a vowel sound when spoken (e.g., an MBA, an FIR, an NGO), and 'a' for those starting with a consonant sound (e.g., a PhD, a CEO).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The intern submitted an report to a office manager.

OK CORRECT

The intern submitted a report to an office manager.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

A few resources available to the refugees were insufficient to meet their basic needs.

OK CORRECT

The few resources available to the refugees were insufficient to meet their basic needs.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The board of directors sought an unanimous decision to approve the merger of the two conglomerates.

OK CORRECT

The board of directors sought a unanimous decision to approve the merger of the two conglomerates.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Always pronounce the word aloud in your head. If the first sound you utter is a vowel sound, use 'an'. If it is a consonant sound (including the 'y' sound in 'unit'), use 'a'. Ignore the written letter entirely.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The legal counsel advised the CEO that filing an FIR would be a essential step in the litigation process.'



RULE 65

Importance: 85/100

Articles: Definite Article ('The') Usage (Specific)

'The' is used to refer to a specific noun that has already been mentioned, is unique, or is understood from the context.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often omit 'the' in complex sentences involving 'Noun + of + Noun' structures or before nouns modified by restrictive relative clauses, banking on the candidate's tendency to overlook specificity in long, academic phrasings.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The definite article 'The' is employed to denote a particular person, place, or thing, distinguishing it from others of the same class. In competitive examinations, its usage is categorized into four primary applications: 1. Subsequent Mention: When a noun is introduced for the first time using 'a' or 'an', all subsequent references to that same noun must use 'the'. 2. Uniqueness: It precedes nouns that are unique in nature or existence (e.g., The Sun, The Constitution, The Judiciary). 3. Contextual Specification: It is used when the noun is limited or defined by a following qualifying phrase or relative clause (e.g., The man who is standing there). 4. Superlatives and Ordinals: It is mandatory before superlative adjectives (the most proficient) and ordinal numbers (the first instance).

>> Subsequent Mention: Employ 'the' when referring to a noun that has already been introduced in the discourse using an indefinite article ('a' or 'an').

>> Universal Uniqueness: Use 'the' for nouns that are unique by nature, existence, or authority (e.g., The Stratosphere, The Judiciary, The Vatican).

>> Contextual Specification: Use 'the' when a noun is restricted or defined by a following qualifying phrase, prepositional phrase, or relative clause (e.g., The treaty signed in 1945).

>> Superlatives and Ordinals: Mandatory use of 'the' before superlative adjectives (the most sophisticated) and ordinal numbers (the third iteration).

>> Geographic and Political Entities: Use 'the' with names of oceans, rivers, mountain ranges, and countries that are unions, republics, or plural (e.g., The Pacific Ocean, The Russian Federation, The Philippines).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Atmosphere consists primarily of nitrogen and oxygen.

OK CORRECT

The atmosphere consists primarily of nitrogen and oxygen.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy agreed with the proposed ceasefire terms to prevent further escalation of the conflict.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy agreed to the proposed ceasefire terms to prevent further escalation of the conflict.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Magna Carta, which limited power of English monarchy, laid foundation for modern constitutional law.

OK CORRECT

The Magna Carta, which limited the power of the English monarchy, laid the foundation for modern constitutional law.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Do not use 'the' with most proper names of countries (e.g., India, Canada), cities, continents, or abstract nouns used in a general sense (e.g., 'Wisdom is better than strength').

PRO-TIP



Tip: Distinguish between general and specific plurals. 'Computers are essential' (General/Zero Article) vs. 'The computers in this laboratory are essential' (Specific/Definite Article). When a plural noun is qualified by a phrase, 'the' is almost always required.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Integration of artificial intelligence into healthcare system necessitates stringent regulatory framework to prevent data breach.'

RULE 66

Importance: 85/100

Articles: Omission of Articles (General Sense)

Articles are generally omitted before plural countable nouns, uncountable nouns, abstract nouns, and material nouns when they are used in a general sense.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Pseudo-Formality Trap': Examiners frequently insert 'the' before abstract nouns (e.g., 'the justice', 'the patience', 'the integrity') to make a sentence sound more authoritative or sophisticated, tricking candidates into accepting a grammatically incorrect particularization of a general concept.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, the 'Zero Article' is employed when nouns are used in a generic or general sense to represent a whole class, a universal quality, or a substance. Articles are strictly omitted in the following scenarios: 1. Plural Countable Nouns: When referring to a class in general (e.g., 'Economists argue...' rather than 'The economists argue...'). 2. Uncountable Nouns: When discussing a substance or concept in its entirety (e.g., 'Information is power'). 3. Abstract Nouns: When denoting a quality or state (e.g., 'Wisdom is better than strength'). 4. Material Nouns: When referring to the substance itself (e.g., 'Copper is a good conductor'). The moment these nouns are restricted or specified, the omission rule no longer applies.

- >> Omit articles before plural countable nouns when referring to a general class, category, or group.
- >> Omit articles before uncountable or material nouns when discussing a substance or mass in a universal or general context.
- >> Omit articles before abstract nouns when they denote a general quality, state, or concept without specific limitation.
- >> Use the definite article 'the' only when the noun is particularized, restricted, or specified by a subsequent modifying phrase, adjective, or relative clause.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The water is essential for the survival of all biological species.

OK CORRECT

Water is essential for the survival of all biological species.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The administration tightened security protocols lest any unauthorized personnel should not gain access to the classified archives.

OK CORRECT

The administration tightened security protocols lest any unauthorized personnel should gain access to the classified archives.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The cognitive dissonance experienced by the populace often leads to the widespread social unrest during political transitions.

OK CORRECT

Cognitive dissonance experienced by the populace often leads to widespread social unrest during political transitions.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> The article 'the' becomes mandatory when an abstract or material noun is modified by a phrase that particularizes it.
- >> For instance, while 'Wisdom is rare' (general) is correct, 'The wisdom of the ancient philosophers' (particular) requires 'the' because it refers to a specific subset of wisdom.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Apply the 'Qualifier Test': If the noun is followed by a qualifying 'of' phrase or a restrictive relative clause (e.g., 'The courage that he exhibited during the crisis'), 'the' is necessary. If the noun represents a standalone abstract concept (e.g., 'Courage is contagious'), omit the article entirely.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: (A) The artificial intelligence / (B) is fundamentally / (C) reshaping the global / (D) landscape of labor markets. (E) No Error



RULE 67

Importance: 85/100

Nouns Always Plural (Pluralia Tantum)

Some nouns are always plural and take a plural verb (e.g., 'scissors', 'trousers', 'goods', 'assets', 'earnings', 'thanks', 'remains', 'riches').

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Intervening Clause Trap': Examiners frequently insert long, complex modifiers or prepositional phrases between the plural subject (e.g., 'proceeds' or 'remains') and the verb. This is designed to trick the candidate into agreeing the verb with a singular noun located closer to the verb within the modifier.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, certain nouns are categorized as 'pluralia tantum,' meaning they exist only in the plural form and do not have a singular counterpart. These nouns necessarily govern a plural verb to maintain subject-verb agreement. This category typically includes: 1) Instruments or garments consisting of two symmetrical parts (e.g., scissors, pliers, trousers, spectacles, pajamas), 2) Commercial or financial terms (e.g., goods, assets, earnings, proceeds, riches), and 3) Specific abstract or physical remnants (e.g., thanks, remains, annals). It is a common error in competitive exams to treat these nouns as singular because they may represent a single conceptual entity, but grammatically, they must be treated as plural.

>> Nouns designating tools or garments consisting of two symmetrical parts (e.g., scissors, pliers, trousers, binoculars) always take a plural verb.

>> Specific commercial and financial terms (e.g., proceeds, earnings, assets, goods) are inherently plural, regardless of the total amount or quantity they represent.

>> Certain nouns referring to historical records, biological remnants, or expressions of gratitude (e.g., annals, remains, thanks) must be treated as plural.

>> If these nouns are preceded by the quantifier 'a pair of', the grammatical subject shifts to 'pair' (singular), necessitating a singular verb.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The high-precision calipers required for the aerospace component's measurement was unavailable in the laboratory.

OK CORRECT

The high-precision calipers required for the aerospace component's measurement were unavailable in the laboratory.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Proficiency in the English is indispensable for securing a high rank in the SSC CGL examination.

OK CORRECT

Proficiency in English is indispensable for securing a high rank in the SSC CGL examination.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The annals of the ancient Mesopotamian civilization, which provide a comprehensive account of the earliest urban settlements and legal codes, offers profound insights into the origins of governance.

OK CORRECT

The annals of the ancient Mesopotamian civilization, which provide a comprehensive account of the earliest urban settlements and legal codes, offer profound insights into the origins of governance.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When preceded by the phrase 'a pair of', the noun becomes part of a prepositional phrase and the headword 'pair' determines the verb agreement.

>> Example: 'A pair of binoculars is essential for birdwatching' vs 'The binoculars are essential for birdwatching'.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Be particularly vigilant with 'earnings' and 'proceeds'. Candidates often mistake these for uncountable singular nouns because they refer to a sum of money. Regardless of the amount, these words always demand a plural verb.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The remnants of the coral reef, severely degraded by ocean acidification and rising sea temperatures, remains the only evidence of the region's former biodiversity.'

**RULE 68****Importance: 85/100****Nouns: Possessive Case**

The possessive case is formed by adding 's to singular nouns and irregular plural nouns, and by adding only an apostrophe (') to plural nouns ending in 's'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently use irregular plurals—such as 'criteria', 'phenomena', or 'people'—and omit the 's' (using only an apostrophe), or they use regular plurals like 'shareholders' and add 's after the apostrophe to test the candidate's knowledge of redundant sibilance.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The possessive case (or genitive case) is employed to denote ownership, origin, or a close relationship between two nouns. The formation follows three primary patterns: 1. For singular nouns and irregular plural nouns (those that do not end in 's'), the possessive is formed by adding an apostrophe followed by an 's' ('s). 2. For regular plural nouns ending in 's', only an apostrophe (') is appended to the end of the word. 3. For non-living things, the possessive 's is generally avoided in formal English; instead, the 'of' construction is utilized (e.g., 'the leg of the table' rather than 'the table's leg').

- >> Append 's to singular nouns and irregular plural nouns (e.g., women's, children's, people's) to indicate possession.
- >> Append only an apostrophe (') to regular plural nouns that already end in 's' (e.g., participants', citizens').
- >> Prefer the 'of' construction for inanimate objects in formal or administrative writing to avoid anthropomorphism (e.g., use 'the Treaty of Versailles' instead of 'Versailles's Treaty').
- >> In instances of joint possession (two entities owning one single item), attach the possessive 's only to the final noun.
- >> In instances of separate possession (two entities owning distinct items), attach the possessive 's to each noun independently.
- >> For compound nouns or hyphenated titles, place the apostrophe and 's' at the end of the final word of the compound.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The dynasty's' influence extended across the entire Asian continent for three centuries.

OK CORRECT

The dynasty's influence extended across the entire Asian continent for three centuries.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The delinquent youth was remanded to the prison pending the final verdict of the High Court.

OK CORRECT

The delinquent youth was remanded to prison pending the final verdict of the High Court.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislators's failure to reach a consensus on the climate bill led to a parliamentary deadlock.

OK CORRECT

The legislators' failure to reach a consensus on the climate bill led to a parliamentary deadlock.

EXCEPTIONS

>> For classical, biblical, or historical names ending in -s (e.g., Socrates, Achilles, Jesus), both the 's and the lone apostrophe are acceptable, though the lone apostrophe (e.g., Socrates') is often preferred in traditional academic contexts.

PRO-TIP



Tip: In high-stakes formal writing (SBI PO/SSC CGL), avoid the possessive 's for inanimate objects. Instead of 'the company's policy', use 'the policy of the company'. This shift in construction elevates the formality of the prose and eliminates ambiguity.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Prime Minister's's address to the United Nations emphasized the need for global cooperation in combating pandemic-related economic instability.'



RULE 69

Importance: 85/100

Sentence Structure: Run-on Sentences and Comma Splices

A run-on sentence incorrectly joins two or more independent clauses without proper punctuation or conjunction. A comma splice incorrectly joins two independent clauses with only a comma.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently insert conjunctive adverbs such as 'furthermore', 'nevertheless', or 'accordingly' preceded only by a comma. Candidates often mistake these for coordinating conjunctions, failing to realize that these adverbs require a semicolon to avoid a comma splice.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

An independent clause is a group of words containing a subject and a predicate that expresses a complete thought. A run-on sentence (specifically a 'fused sentence') occurs when two or more independent clauses are joined without any punctuation or coordinating conjunction. A comma splice is a more subtle error where two independent clauses are joined using only a comma, which is grammatically insufficient to link two complete thoughts. To rectify these errors, one must employ one of four methods: 1) Separate the clauses into two distinct sentences using a full stop; 2) Use a semicolon to indicate a close logical relationship; 3) Use a comma followed by a coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS: For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So); or 4) Convert one independent clause into a dependent clause using a subordinating conjunction (e.g., although, because, since).

>> Utilize a full stop (period) to separate independent clauses into two distinct, autonomous sentences.

>> Employ a semicolon to link two independent clauses that share a close logical connection without needing a conjunction.

>> Combine independent clauses using a comma followed by a coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS: For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So).

>> Convert one of the independent clauses into a dependent clause by introducing a subordinating conjunction (e.g., Although, Because, While, Since).

>> When using conjunctive adverbs (e.g., However, Therefore, Moreover, Consequently), place a semicolon before the adverb and a comma immediately after it.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The ozone layer is showing signs of recovery, atmospheric scientists have observed a significant reduction in ozone-depleting substances.

OK CORRECT

The ozone layer is showing signs of recovery; atmospheric scientists have observed a significant reduction in ozone-depleting substances.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The research committee meticulously analyzed the various phenomena associated with the sudden collapse of the financial bubble.

OK CORRECT

The research committee meticulously analyzed the various phenomena associated with the sudden collapse of the financial bubble.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy presented the revised treaty to the council, consequently, the long-standing border dispute was resolved through bilateral negotiations.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy presented the revised treaty to the council; consequently, the long-standing border dispute was resolved through bilateral negotiations.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In very informal writing or specific literary styles, short independent clauses may be joined by commas for rhythmic effect.

>> However, in formal examinations like SBI PO or SSC CGL, such constructions are strictly classified as errors.

**PRO-TIP**

Tip: To identify a comma splice instantly, isolate the text before and after the comma. If both segments possess their own subject and finite verb and can stand alone as complete sentences, a comma alone is insufficient. Pay extreme attention to long, complex sentences where the subject of the second clause is obscured by modifiers.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The excavation at Harappa revealed a sophisticated urban planning system, it underscores the advanced architectural knowledge of the Indus Valley Civilization.'



RULE 70

Importance: 85/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Much' vs. 'Many'

'Much' is used with uncountable nouns (e.g., 'much time', 'much money'). 'Many' is used with countable nouns (e.g., 'many friends', 'many ideas').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often utilize 'pseudo-countable' nouns—words like 'evidence', 'luggage', 'knowledge', or 'machinery'—which conceptually represent multiple items but are grammatically singular/uncountable. They will pair these with 'many' to trick candidates into relying on logical quantity rather than grammatical category.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The distinction between 'Much' and 'Many' is predicated on the countability of the noun they modify. 'Many' is used exclusively with plural countable nouns—entities that can be quantified as individual units (e.g., candidates, discrepancies, obligations). 'Much' is employed with uncountable (mass) nouns—entities that are perceived as an indivisible whole or cannot be counted numerically (e.g., patience, evidence, legislation, wealth). In formal academic and competitive English, 'much' and 'many' are most frequently utilized in negative constructions and interrogative sentences. In affirmative sentences, while 'many' remains standard, 'much' is often replaced by 'a great deal of' or 'a large amount of' to maintain formal tone, unless it is functioning as an adverb to modify a comparative adjective (e.g., 'much more prudent').

- >> Employ 'many' exclusively with plural countable nouns—entities that can be enumerated as discrete units (e.g., constituents, anomalies, protocols).
- >> Employ 'much' with uncountable (mass) nouns—entities viewed as an indivisible whole or abstract concepts that cannot be quantified numerically (e.g., legislation, momentum, resilience, infrastructure).
- >> In formal affirmative assertions, 'much' is frequently substituted with phrases like 'a great deal of' or 'a significant amount of' to enhance the professional register.
- >> Use 'much' as an adverb to modify comparative adjectives to indicate a higher degree of difference (e.g., 'much more sophisticated' or 'much more volatile').
- >> Identify nouns that may appear countable in meaning but are grammatically uncountable (e.g., 'information', 'equipment', 'advice', 'software'); these must always be paired with 'much' or its equivalents.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Much artifacts were recovered from the ancient ruins during the archaeological survey.

OK CORRECT

Many artifacts were recovered from the ancient ruins during the archaeological survey.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Chief Executive Officer, along with the board of directors and the legal consultants, have signed the merger agreement.

OK CORRECT

The Chief Executive Officer, along with the board of directors and the legal consultants, has signed the merger agreement.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Despite the implementation of stringent carbon credits, there is still many pollution emanating from the industrial corridor.

OK CORRECT

Despite the implementation of stringent carbon credits, there is still much pollution emanating from the industrial corridor.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> The construction 'many a [singular noun]' is a formal stylistic choice that takes a singular verb despite the meaning being plural (e.g., 'Many a politician has succumbed to the allure of power').
- >> In this specific case, 'many' is followed by a singular countable noun.

**PRO-TIP**

Tip: Apply the 'Number Test': Try placing a specific number (e.g., 'three' or 'ten') directly before the noun. If the phrase sounds ungrammatical (e.g., 'three evidences' or 'ten softwares'), the noun is uncountable and 'many' must be rejected in favor of 'much'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Spot the error: 'The cybersecurity firm discovered that many evidence of a systemic data breach had been meticulously erased by the sophisticated malware.'



RULE 71

Importance: 85/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Good' vs. 'Well'

'Good' is an adjective. 'Well' is usually an adverb, but can be an adjective meaning 'in good health'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often use linking verbs like 'feel' or 'look' to confuse candidates. They may insert a long prepositional phrase between the verb and the modifier, tempting the candidate to use 'good' (the adjective) when the context actually refers to physical health, or conversely, using 'well' (the adverb) to describe a general state of quality.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, 'good' is an adjective used to modify nouns or pronouns, describing a quality, characteristic, or state. Conversely, 'well' primarily functions as an adverb, modifying verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs to describe the manner in which an action is performed. A critical distinction arises with linking verbs (e.g., be, seem, feel, look, smell, sound); these verbs are followed by adjectives (predicative adjectives) to describe the subject. Therefore, 'good' is used after a linking verb to describe a general quality or emotion, whereas 'well' is used as an adjective specifically when referring to physical health or wellness.

- >> Use 'good' as an adjective to qualify a noun or pronoun, describing an inherent characteristic or quality.
- >> Use 'well' as an adverb to describe the manner in which an action is performed (modifying a verb).
- >> Use 'well' to modify adjectives or other adverbs to indicate degree or intensity.
- >> When following linking verbs (such as be, seem, feel, look, sound), use 'good' to describe the subject's general quality or emotional state.
- >> Use 'well' after linking verbs exclusively when the context refers to physical health or recovery from illness.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The satellite transmitted the data good despite the atmospheric interference.

OK CORRECT

The satellite transmitted the data well despite the atmospheric interference.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The board of directors approved, after considering the long-term implications of the merger and the current market volatility, the proposed acquisition of the subsidiary.

OK CORRECT

After considering the long-term implications of the merger and the current market volatility, the board of directors approved the proposed acquisition of the subsidiary.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy, tasked with mitigating the escalating border dispute, negotiated the ceasefire terms remarkably good, thereby ensuring regional stability.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy, tasked with mitigating the escalating border dispute, negotiated the ceasefire terms remarkably well, thereby ensuring regional stability.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> While 'well' is typically an adverb, it functions as an adjective when describing health (e.g., 'The patient is well').
- >> Additionally, 'well' is used in compound adjectives to modify other adjectives (e.g., 'a well-informed citizen' or 'a well-documented historical event').

PRO-TIP

Tip: To determine which word to use, identify if the word modifies a 'thing' (noun) or an 'action' (verb). If the verb is a linking verb (acting like an equals sign), ask if you are describing 'health' or 'quality'. If it's quality, use 'good'; if it's health, use 'well'.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Error Spotting: The environmental agency noted that the municipal corporation managed the waste segregation drive good, leading to a 30% reduction in landfill volume. (Identify and correct the error)



RULE 72

Importance: 85/100

Prepositions: 'In' vs. 'Into'*'In' indicates a position or location. 'Into' indicates movement or entry from outside to inside.*

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently test the distinction between physical and abstract entry. They may present a sentence like 'The representative entered into the conference hall,' which is incorrect because the hall is a physical space. Conversely, 'The nations entered the trade agreement' is incorrect because a trade agreement is an abstract concept requiring 'into'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The preposition 'In' is employed to denote a static position, location, or state of being within a defined space, container, or boundary. It emphasizes the point of residence or existence (e.g., being inside a room or a city). Conversely, 'Into' is a preposition of motion and direction. It is used specifically to describe the transition or movement of an object or person from an exterior position to an interior one. While 'in' describes the state of being enclosed, 'into' describes the action of entering that enclosure.

>> Use 'In' to describe a state of being enclosed, a fixed position, or a condition of residence within a defined area.

>> Use 'Into' to indicate directional movement, motion from the outside to the inside, or a transformation from one state to another.

>> Do not use 'into' following the verb 'enter' when it refers to a physical space (e.g., 'entered the building').

>> Use the phrase 'enter into' exclusively for abstract concepts, such as agreements, contracts, alliances, or formal discussions.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The lab technician poured the reagent in the beaker carefully.

OK CORRECT

The lab technician poured the reagent into the beaker carefully.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The presiding officer made the witness to recount the events of the night in exhaustive detail.

OK CORRECT

The presiding officer made the witness recount the events of the night in exhaustive detail.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Following the ceasefire agreement, the peacekeeping forces marched in the disputed territory to ensure the safe return of refugees.

OK CORRECT

Following the ceasefire agreement, the peacekeeping forces marched into the disputed territory to ensure the safe return of refugees.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain phrasal verbs use 'in' or 'into' regardless of physical motion.

>> For instance, 'run into' can mean to meet someone unexpectedly, and 'hand in' refers to submitting a document.

>> Additionally, 'enter into' is a mandatory idiomatic construction for non-physical entries, such as 'entering into a treaty'.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Motion-State Test'. If the verb describes a change in position or a transition from Point A to Point B (e.g., plunge, dive, insert, transform), 'into' is the correct preposition. If the verb describes a stable condition or existence within a boundary (e.g., dwell, reside, remain, exist), use 'in'.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: The sudden surge in volatility caused the investor's portfolio to plunge ____ a deep deficit within a matter of hours. (Fill in the blank with 'in' or 'into')



RULE 73

Importance: 85/100

Prepositions: 'At' vs. 'In' (Place)

'At' is used for specific points, addresses, or smaller places. 'In' is used for larger areas, cities, countries, or enclosed spaces.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently exploit 'functional locations'. They may use a physically large building (like a university or a museum) and use 'in' to trick the candidate, when the context implies the institution as a point of activity (requiring 'at'). They also often swap the prepositions when a city and a specific venue are mentioned in the same sentence.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The distinction between 'at' and 'in' regarding location is primarily based on the perceived dimension and specificity of the place. 'At' is employed to denote a specific point, a precise address, or a functional location where a particular activity occurs (e.g., at the reception, at the crossroads). It treats the location as a 'point' on a map. Conversely, 'In' is utilized for enclosed spaces, three-dimensional areas, or larger geographical entities such as cities, states, and countries. It treats the location as a 'container' or a bounded area. A critical nuance arises when a place is viewed as a point of arrival or a meeting spot ('at the station') versus when the emphasis is on being physically inside the structure ('in the station').

>> Use 'at' for precise addresses, specific coordinates, or functional locations where a particular activity occurs (e.g., at the summit, at the crossroads, at the headquarters).

>> Use 'in' for enclosed three-dimensional spaces, bounded areas, or larger geographical entities such as cities, states, countries, and continents (e.g., in the archive, in Geneva, in Asia).

>> Use 'at' when the location is viewed as a destination or a point of arrival; use 'in' when the emphasis is on the physical presence within the interior of a structure.

>> Use 'at' for specific numbered addresses (e.g., at 1600 Pennsylvania Avenue), but use 'in' for the street or neighborhood name alone (e.g., in Pennsylvania Avenue).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The ambassador is currently at London in the embassy.

OK CORRECT

The ambassador is currently in London at the embassy.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The regulatory authority made the corporation to disclose its undisclosed financial liabilities during the audit.

OK CORRECT

The regulatory authority made the corporation disclose its undisclosed financial liabilities during the audit.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The environmentalists are currently at the Serengeti Plains, conducting a census in the precise junction of the migratory route.

OK CORRECT

The environmentalists are currently in the Serengeti Plains, conducting a census at the precise junction of the migratory route.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain idiomatic expressions bypass these rules, such as 'at home' or 'at sea'.

>> Furthermore, a semantic shift occurs in specific contexts: 'in the hospital' typically denotes being admitted as a patient, whereas 'at the hospital' suggests visiting or working there.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Apply the 'GPS Test': If the location can be represented as a single, dimensionless coordinate on a map, use 'at'. If the location requires a perimeter or a shaded region to be defined, use 'in'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The technological symposium was organized at Tokyo, and the keynote speaker arrived in the main auditorium at noon.' (A) at Tokyo (B) and the keynote (C) in the main auditorium (D) No error

RULE 74

Importance: 85/100

Prepositions: 'At' vs. 'In' (Time)

'At' is used for specific times (e.g., 'at 3 o'clock'). 'In' is used for months, years, seasons, or periods of the day (e.g., 'in July', 'in the morning').

EXAMINER TRAP: Candidates often confuse 'in the morning/afternoon/evening' with 'at noon/midnight'. Examiners will intentionally place 'in' before 'noon' or 'at' before 'the afternoon' to test this distinction.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, 'at' and 'in' serve as temporal prepositions but differ fundamentally in the degree of specificity they denote. 'At' is employed for precise, pinpoint moments in time—such as clock times (at 5 PM), specific points in the day (at noon, at midnight, at sunset), or festive periods (at Christmas). Conversely, 'in' is utilized for extended periods of time, encompassing months (in January), years (in 1947), seasons (in winter), decades, centuries, or general parts of the day (in the morning, in the afternoon). The fundamental distinction lies in the transition from a 'point' (at) to a 'period' (in).

- >> Use 'at' for specific clock times (e.g., at 14:30 hours, at 6:00 PM).
- >> Use 'at' for precise, singular points in the day (e.g., at noon, at midnight, at sunset, at dawn).
- >> Use 'in' for longer durations including months, years, decades, and centuries (e.g., in August, in 1947, in the 1980s, in the 18th century).
- >> Use 'in' for seasons (e.g., in winter, in the monsoon).
- >> Use 'in' for general periods of the day (e.g., in the morning, in the afternoon, in the evening).
- >> Apply 'at night' for a general time of day, but use 'in the night' when referring to a specific moment within a particular night.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The satellite's telemetry data is scheduled for synchronization in 04:00 UTC.

OK CORRECT

The satellite's telemetry data is scheduled for synchronization at 04:00 UTC.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

Three-quarters of the candidates has failed to meet the stringent eligibility criteria set by the commission.

OK CORRECT

Three-quarters of the candidates have failed to meet the stringent eligibility criteria set by the commission.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The geopolitical tensions that escalated at the 19th century finally culminated in a peace treaty signed in midnight on the eve of the ceasefire.

OK CORRECT

The geopolitical tensions that escalated in the 19th century finally culminated in a peace treaty signed at midnight on the eve of the ceasefire.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> While 'at night' is the standard phrase for the general period of darkness, 'in the night' is used when the night is modified by a description (e.g., 'in the dead of night').
- >> Furthermore, 'at the end' refers to a specific point (at the end of the movie), whereas 'in the end' means 'eventually' or 'finally'.

PRO-TIP

Tip: To avoid errors, categorize the time marker: if it is a 'point' on a timeline (a dot), use 'at'; if it is a 'container' or a 'block' of time (a segment), use 'in'. This logical division prevents confusion between specific moments and general durations.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error: The Ministry of Environment (A) / intends to implement the new carbon credits policy (B) / at the autumn of 2025 (C) / to mitigate industrial emissions (D) / No error (E).



RULE 75

Importance: 85/100

Prepositions: 'By' vs. 'With' (Agent vs. Instrument)

'By' is used to indicate the agent or doer of an action (e.g., 'written by him'). 'With' is used to indicate the instrument or tool used (e.g., 'cut with a knife').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often use nouns that imply autonomy or intelligence, such as 'AI-driven algorithm', 'automated system', or 'precision software'. These are designed to mislead the candidate into treating the instrument as an agent, prompting the incorrect use of 'by' instead of 'with'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, specifically within passive constructions, a critical distinction is made between the agent of an action and the instrument used to execute that action. 'By' is employed to denote the agent—the person, entity, or force that is the primary doer of the action (e.g., 'The law was passed by the legislature'). In contrast, 'With' is used to specify the instrument, tool, or material employed by the agent to achieve the result (e.g., 'The law was written with a fountain pen'). A common pitfall in competitive examinations is the erroneous use of 'by' to describe the tool used, which incorrectly attributes agency to an inanimate object.

- >> Employ 'by' to identify the agent: the sentient being, legal entity, or governing body that possesses the volition or authority to initiate the action.
- >> Employ 'with' to identify the instrument: the physical object, specialized tool, or technological medium utilized by the agent to achieve the objective.
- >> In passive constructions, 'by' answers the question 'Who did it?' while 'with' answers the question 'What was used to do it?'
- >> Maintain this distinction regardless of the complexity of the sentence or the proximity of the instrument to the verb.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The geological strata were analyzed by a high-resolution electron microscope.

OK CORRECT

The geological strata were analyzed with a high-resolution electron microscope.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Fifty thousand rupees are a staggering amount to pay for a basic insurance premium.

OK CORRECT

Fifty thousand rupees is a staggering amount to pay for a basic insurance premium.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The historic accord was negotiated by the diplomatic envoys and formally authenticated by a ceremonial seal.

OK CORRECT

The historic accord was negotiated by the diplomatic envoys and formally authenticated with a ceremonial seal.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When referring to a 'method' or 'mode' of transport/communication rather than a physical tool, 'by' is used (e.g., 'The decree was disseminated by email' or 'The delegates arrived by rail'), even though the medium acts as the means.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Perform the 'Sentience Test': Determine if the noun following the preposition has independent will or legal agency. If the noun is an inanimate object manipulated by someone else, 'with' is the grammatically precise choice. If the noun is the decision-maker, 'by' is required.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The urban planning commission redesigned the metropolitan transit map by a sophisticated geospatial modeling tool to mitigate traffic congestion.'



RULE 76

Importance: 85/100

Conjunctions: 'So...that' vs. 'Such...that'

'So...that' is used with adjectives or adverbs to express cause and effect. 'Such...that' is used with nouns (often preceded by 'a/an') to express cause and effect.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Quantifier Interference' Trap: Examiners often place a noun phrase immediately after the blank to lure candidates into choosing 'such'. However, if the noun is preceded by 'many', 'few', 'much', or 'little', the rule for 'such' is overridden, and 'so' must be used. Failure to spot these quantifiers is a common source of error in high-level exams.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Both 'so...that' and 'such...that' are used to express a cause-and-effect relationship, where the first part of the sentence describes a quality or characteristic and the second part describes the resulting consequence. The distinction lies entirely in the part of speech being modified. 'So' is an intensifier used exclusively with adjectives or adverbs (e.g., so exhausted, so rapidly). The structure is: So + Adjective/Adverb + that + Result Clause. Conversely, 'Such' is used to modify a noun or a noun phrase, often accompanied by an adjective (e.g., such a disaster, such an intricate problem). The structure is: Such + (a/an) + (Adjective) + Noun + that + Result Clause. In competitive examinations, the error usually occurs when 'so' is used before a noun phrase or 'such' is used before a standalone adjective.

>> Employ 'so...that' when the intensifier modifies an adjective or an adverb. Structure: So + Adjective/Adverb + that + Result Clause.

>> Employ 'such...that' when the intensifier modifies a noun or a noun phrase, regardless of whether an adjective is present. Structure: Such + (a/an) + (Adjective) + Noun + that + Result Clause.

>> Distinguish based on the target of the intensification: 'so' emphasizes the degree of a quality, while 'such' emphasizes the nature or category of the entity.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The atmospheric pressure in the region was such high that the weather station's sensors malfunctioned.

OK CORRECT

The atmospheric pressure in the region was so high that the weather station's sensors malfunctioned.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy negotiated the terms of the ceasefire when the sudden outbreak of hostilities rendered the talks futile.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy was negotiating the terms of the ceasefire when the sudden outbreak of hostilities rendered the talks futile.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic impasse between the two nations was so a complex dilemma that it required the mediation of the United Nations.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic impasse between the two nations was such a complex dilemma that it required the mediation of the United Nations.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The word 'so' is used instead of 'such' when the noun is preceded by the quantifiers 'many', 'few', 'much', or 'little'.

>> Example: 'The newly implemented security protocol introduced so many vulnerabilities that the entire network remained susceptible to cyber-attacks.'

PRO-TIP



Tip: Use the 'Article Trigger' technique: In most cases, if the blank is immediately followed by an indefinite article ('a' or 'an'), 'such' is the correct choice. Conversely, if the blank is followed directly by an adjective without an article, or by a quantifier, 'so' is the correct choice.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: The archaeological discovery in the Indus Valley was ____ a profound revelation that it forced historians to rewrite the timeline of urban civilization. (Fill in the blank with 'so' or 'such')

RULE 77

Importance: 85/100

Verbs: Lie vs. Lay

'Lie' (intransitive) means to recline or rest (lie, lay, lain). 'Lay' (transitive) means to place something down (lay, laid, laid).

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Morphological Mirror': Examiners exploit the fact that 'lay' serves as both the present tense of the transitive verb (to place) and the past tense of the intransitive verb (to recline). They often insert a past-tense marker in the sentence to trick the candidate into using 'laid' (the past of 'lay') instead of 'lay' (the past of 'lie').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Lie/Lay confusion is one of the trickiest verb questions in competitive exams. The KEY rule is TRANSITIVITY: LIE does not need an object ('I lie down'). LAY always needs an object — something is being placed ('I lay the book on the table'). The biggest trap: the Past tense of LIE is LAY — making students think they should write LAY everywhere. Always ask: Is there an object? If yes, use LAY/LAID. If no, use LIE/LAY/LAIN.

- >> Identify Transitivity: The primary distinction is the presence of a direct object. 'Lay' requires an object to receive the action (Transitive), whereas 'Lie' describes the subject's own state or position (Intransitive).
- >> Conjugation of 'Lie' (Recline): When the subject is resting or reclining, follow the sequence: Lie (Present) → Lay (Past) → Lain (Past Participle) → Lying (Present Participle).
- >> Conjugation of 'Lay' (Place): When the subject is placing an object, follow the sequence: Lay (Present) → Laid (Past) → Laid (Past Participle) → Laying (Present Participle).
- >> Temporal Verification: Carefully analyze the sentence tense. Because the past tense of 'lie' is 'lay', it is frequently confused with the present tense of the transitive verb 'lay'.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The clerk was instructed to lie the confidential dossiers on the magistrate's desk.

OK CORRECT

The clerk was instructed to lay the confidential dossiers on the magistrate's desk.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The diplomat addressed the foreign delegation friendly to ease the geopolitical tension.

OK CORRECT

The diplomat addressed the foreign delegation in a friendly manner to ease the geopolitical tension.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

Due to the catastrophic seismic activity, the sediment layers had laid undisturbed for millennia before the tectonic shift.

OK CORRECT

Due to the catastrophic seismic activity, the sediment layers had lain undisturbed for millennia before the tectonic shift.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The verb 'Lie' also functions as a regular verb meaning 'to tell a falsehood.' In this specific context, it follows a regular conjugation pattern: Lie → Lied → Lied.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Utilize the 'Substitution Method': Attempt to replace the verb with 'put' or 'place'. If the sentence remains grammatically logical, 'Lay' (or its forms) is correct. If the sentence requires 'recline' or 'rest', 'Lie' (or its forms) must be used.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: The ancient treaty, which redefined the borders of the two warring empires, had _____ forgotten in the royal archives for centuries. (Fill in the blank: lain / laid)

RULE 78

Importance: 85/100

Verbs: Rise vs. Raise

'Rise' (intransitive) means to go up (rise, rose, risen). 'Raise' (transitive) means to lift something up or to increase (raise, raised, raised).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often insert long, complex qualifying phrases (adverbial clauses) between the verb and its object to hide the transitive relationship, leading candidates to mistake 'raise' for 'rise'. They may also use 'risen' (past participle of rise) in a passive construction where 'raised' (past participle of raise) is grammatically required.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

RISE and RAISE are confusable because both mean 'going up' in a general sense. The key difference is who or what causes the upward movement. RISE = self-movement (no one is causing it — the sun, prices, temperature rise on their own). RAISE = someone causes the movement (a person raises a hand, raises a question, raises prices). If there is a doer causing the upward action, use RAISE. If it happens by itself, use RISE.

- >> Use 'Rise' when the subject performs the action of moving upward or increasing autonomously without an external agent acting upon it.
- >> Because 'Rise' is an intransitive verb, it never takes a direct object (you cannot 'rise' something).
- >> Use 'Raise' when an agent (the subject) deliberately lifts, increases, or elevates a separate entity (the object).
- >> Because 'Raise' is a transitive verb, it must be followed by a direct object that receives the action.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The global sea levels raised significantly over the last decade due to glacial melting.

OK CORRECT

The global sea levels rose significantly over the last decade due to glacial melting.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

A many seasoned diplomat has struggled to navigate the complexities of this geopolitical crisis.

OK CORRECT

Many a seasoned diplomat has struggled to navigate the complexities of this geopolitical crisis.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

To counteract the systemic inefficiency, the administration decided to rise the eligibility criteria for the civil services examination.

OK CORRECT

To counteract the systemic inefficiency, the administration decided to raise the eligibility criteria for the civil services examination.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> The verb 'raise' is used transitively not only for physical lifting but also for nurturing or breeding (e.g., 'The sanctuary raised several endangered species back to health').
- >> 'Rise' appears in fixed idiomatic expressions such as 'rise to the occasion' or 'rise from the ashes,' where the focus is on overcoming adversity rather than simple vertical movement.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Object Test': Ask 'What is being lifted/increased?'. If the answer is a noun that follows the verb, use 'Raise'. If the subject itself is the thing increasing and there is no object following the verb, use 'Rise'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The sudden surge in cosmic radiation levels caused the sensor's thermal output to raise beyond the permissible safety threshold.'



RULE 79

Importance: 85/100

Determiners: 'This/That' vs 'These/Those'

Demonstrative determiners must agree in number with the noun they modify. 'This/That' are singular; 'These/Those' are plural.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Kind/Sort/Type' Discord: Examiners frequently create a mismatch by pairing a plural determiner (these/those) with a singular head noun (kind/sort/type), followed by a plural noun (e.g., 'those type of regulations'). The grammatical error is the lack of agreement between 'those' (plural) and 'type' (singular).

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

'This' and 'These' refer to objects close to the speaker, while 'That' and 'Those' refer to objects farther away. The most common error occurs when singular determiners are incorrectly paired with plural nouns, especially with words like 'kind', 'sort', or 'type'.

- >> Use 'This' (singular, near) and 'That' (singular, far) exclusively with singular countable nouns or uncountable nouns.
- >> Use 'These' (plural, near) and 'Those' (plural, far) exclusively with plural countable nouns.
- >> Ensure strict numerical agreement between the demonstrative determiner and the head noun it modifies to avoid subject-determiner discord.
- >> In constructions involving 'kind', 'sort', or 'type', the determiner must agree in number with these specific words (the head nouns) rather than the noun that follows the preposition 'of'.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

These legislative measure is essential for the mitigation of urban pollution.

OK CORRECT

This legislative measure is essential for the mitigation of urban pollution.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Reserve Bank of India which is the central banking institution of the country has maintained the repo rate to curb inflation.

OK CORRECT

The Reserve Bank of India, which is the central banking institution of the country, has maintained the repo rate to curb inflation.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The geopolitical analysts suggested that those sort of territorial disputes often stem from antiquated colonial boundaries.

OK CORRECT

The geopolitical analysts suggested that those sorts of territorial disputes often stem from antiquated colonial boundaries.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When referring to multiple distinct categories or varieties, the determiner, the word 'kind/sort/type', and the accompanying noun should all be pluralized to maintain grammatical harmony (e.g., 'these types of ecosystems' instead of 'this type of ecosystems').

PRO-TIP

Tip: To identify the error quickly, isolate the noun immediately following the determiner. If the head noun is 'kind', 'sort', or 'type', temporarily ignore the noun following 'of' and verify if the determiner matches the head noun's plurality.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: The lead researcher emphasized that (this / these) sort of genetic mutation occurs rarely in nature but can be induced in controlled laboratory settings.



RULE 80

Importance: 82/100

Sentence Structure: Imperative and Exclamatory Sentences

Imperative sentences give commands or requests and have an implied subject 'you'. Exclamatory sentences express strong emotion and often begin with 'What' or 'How'.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Interrogative Mirror' trap: Examiners frequently swap the subject and the auxiliary verb (e.g., 'How agile is the new AI framework!') to trick candidates into accepting a question structure as an exclamatory sentence simply because it ends with an exclamation mark.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In imperative sentences, the subject 'you' is understood and omitted (e.g., 'Close the door'). Exclamatory sentences follow the structure: 'What + a/an + (adjective) + singular countable noun!' or 'How + adjective/adverb + subject + verb!'.

- >> In imperative sentences, the subject 'you' is understood and omitted to create a direct command, request, or formal instruction.
- >> Exclamatory sentences starting with 'What' follow the structure: What + (a/an) + (adjective) + noun + subject + verb!
- >> Exclamatory sentences starting with 'How' follow the structure: How + adjective/adverb + subject + verb!
- >> Exclamatory sentences must strictly adhere to declarative word order (Subject + Verb); inverting them into interrogative order (Verb + Subject) is a grammatical error.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

How severe is the impact of glacial melting!

OK CORRECT

How severe the impact of glacial melting is!

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Although the Monetary Policy Committee decided to maintain the status quo on repo rates to curb inflationary pressures.

OK CORRECT

Although the Monetary Policy Committee decided to maintain the status quo on repo rates to curb inflationary pressures, the equity markets remained volatile.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

What a comprehensive set of reforms has the legislative assembly proposed to curb systemic corruption!

OK CORRECT

What a comprehensive set of reforms the legislative assembly has proposed to curb systemic corruption!

EXCEPTIONS

>> When 'What' is used with an uncountable noun or a plural noun in an exclamatory sentence, the indefinite article 'a/an' must be omitted (e.g., 'What profound insights the archaeological findings provided!').

PRO-TIP

Tip: Use the 'Declarative Conversion Test': mentally rewrite the sentence as a standard statement. If the sentence reads 'The impact is severe,' the exclamatory version must be 'How severe the impact is!' If the structure resembles a question ('Is the impact severe?'), it is incorrect as an exclamation.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: What (a / -) disruptive potential the emergence of quantum computing possesses!

RULE 81

Importance: 80/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Collective Nouns

Collective nouns (e.g., 'team', 'committee', 'family') take a singular verb when acting as a single unit, but a plural verb when their individual members are acting separately.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often place long, complex prepositional phrases or appositives between the collective noun and the verb to obscure the subject. They frequently use 'trigger words' such as 'divided', 'split', 'differ', or 'disagree' to signal a plural requirement, betting that the candidate will instinctively apply the singular rule for collective nouns.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Collective nouns refer to a group of individuals acting as a whole (e.g., committee, jury, board, audience, fleet). The verb agreement is determined by the 'notional concord'—the intended meaning of the sentence. When the collective noun represents the group acting as a single, cohesive unit, it is treated as singular and takes a singular verb. Conversely, when the sentence emphasizes the individual members of the group acting independently, disagreeing, or performing separate actions, the noun is treated as plural and takes a plural verb.

- >> Identify if the collective noun (e.g., jury, board, committee, staff, fleet) is functioning as a unified whole or as a collection of individuals.
- >> Assign a singular verb when the group performs an action in unison or represents a single legal/administrative entity.
- >> Assign a plural verb when the sentence highlights internal conflict, individual differences, or members acting independently within the group.
- >> Ensure notional concord: the verb must align with the intended meaning (the 'notion') of the subject rather than its grammatical form alone.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The environmental task force have concluded its assessment of the protected wetlands.

OK CORRECT

The environmental task force has concluded its assessment of the protected wetlands.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The United Arab Emirates have consistently emerged as a global hub for trade and innovation.

OK CORRECT

The United Arab Emirates has consistently emerged as a global hub for trade and innovation.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The diplomatic delegation, despite having reached a preliminary consensus on the treaty, is currently disagreeing on the specific terminology of the final clause.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic delegation, despite having reached a preliminary consensus on the treaty, are currently disagreeing on the specific terminology of the final clause.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain nouns that are conceptually collective but grammatically treated as plural in all contexts—such as 'Police', 'Cattle', 'Poultry', and 'Gentry'—must always take a plural verb regardless of the action performed.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Perform the 'Pronoun Alignment Test'. If the sentence uses 'their' instead of 'its', the author is treating the collective noun as plural. Additionally, if you can mentally insert the phrase 'the members of' before the collective noun without changing the meaning, a plural verb is almost certainly required.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: The research consortium (is/are) presenting their findings on the exoplanet's atmospheric composition at the international symposium.



RULE 82

Importance: 80/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Inverted Sentences ('There is/are')

In sentences beginning with 'there is/are' or 'here is/are', the verb agrees with the actual subject that follows it.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently insert long, complex prepositional phrases or modifiers between the verb and the real subject. Furthermore, they often use the phrase 'a number of' (which requires a plural verb) versus 'the number of' (which requires a singular verb) immediately following the verb to confuse the candidate.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In standard English syntax, the subject typically precedes the verb. However, in sentences beginning with the introductory words 'There' or 'Here', the word 'There' serves as a dummy subject (expletive) and carries no grammatical weight regarding number. The actual grammatical subject of the sentence follows the verb. Consequently, the verb must agree in number and person with the subsequent noun or pronoun. If the real subject is singular or uncountable, a singular verb is employed; if the real subject is plural, a plural verb is mandatory.

>> In inverted sentence structures starting with 'There' or 'Here', these words serve as expletives (dummy subjects) and possess no grammatical number of their own.

>> The true grammatical subject is located after the verb; therefore, the verb must be determined by the noun or pronoun that follows it.

>> Use a singular verb if the subsequent subject is singular or an uncountable noun (e.g., evidence, legislation, furniture).

>> Use a plural verb if the subsequent subject is plural or consists of multiple items joined by 'and'.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

There is several options available for urban waste management in the metropolitan area.

OK CORRECT

There are several options available for urban waste management in the metropolitan area.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The disenfranchised is increasingly demanding systemic reforms to ensure equitable representation in the legislative assembly.

OK CORRECT

The disenfranchised are increasingly demanding systemic reforms to ensure equitable representation in the legislative assembly.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

There has been various legislative amendments proposed to strengthen the autonomy of the judiciary and ensure a fair trial.

OK CORRECT

There have been various legislative amendments proposed to strengthen the autonomy of the judiciary and ensure a fair trial.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When the subject follows 'there' as a compound subject joined by 'and', a plural verb is required.

>> However, if the subject is an uncountable noun (e.g., 'information', 'evidence', 'equipment'), the verb must remain singular, regardless of the perceived scale of the quantity.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Employ the 'Strip-and-Identify' method: Mentally eliminate the introductory 'There/Here' and any intervening adjectives or prepositional phrases. Once you isolate the 'head noun' that follows the verb, the correct agreement becomes immediately apparent.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error: 'There is (A) a wide range of discrepancies (B) between the two reports (C) submitted by the auditing firm (D) regarding the project's expenditure. (E) No Error.'



RULE 83

Importance: 80/100

Tenses: Simple Present Usage

The simple present tense is used for habitual actions, universal truths, facts, and scheduled future events.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently substitute the Simple Present with the Present Continuous (is/are + -ing) when describing universal truths, permanent states, or fixed schedules to mislead the candidate into treating a permanent fact as a temporary ongoing action.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Simple Present Tense is employed to denote actions that are habitual, permanent, or universally true. In the context of competitive examinations, its usage is categorized into four primary domains: 1. Habitual Actions: Actions performed regularly or routinely, often signaled by adverbs of frequency such as 'seldom', 'often', or 'usually'. 2. Universal Truths and Scientific Facts: Statements that remain constant regardless of time and are accepted as objective reality. 3. Fixed Future Arrangements: Events governed by a formal timetable, official schedule, or calendar, where the present tense conveys a sense of certainty. 4. General Truths and Permanent States: Conditions that are generally accepted as true or enduring characteristics of a subject.

>> Habitual Actions: Use for actions performed regularly or routinely, often signaled by adverbs of frequency such as 'seldom', 'often', or 'usually'.

>> Universal Truths and Scientific Facts: Apply to statements that remain constant regardless of time and are accepted as objective reality.

>> Fixed Future Arrangements: Employ for events governed by a formal timetable, official schedule, or calendar, where the tense conveys certainty.

>> General Truths and Permanent States: Use to describe conditions generally accepted as true or the enduring characteristics of a subject.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Water is boiling at 100 degrees Celsius under standard atmospheric pressure.

OK CORRECT

Water boils at 100 degrees Celsius under standard atmospheric pressure.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The bespoke trousers, tailored specifically for the diplomatic envoy, is crafted from the finest Italian wool.

OK CORRECT

The bespoke trousers, tailored specifically for the diplomatic envoy, are crafted from the finest Italian wool.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The Constitution of India is providing for a parliamentary system of government to ensure executive accountability to the legislature.

OK CORRECT

The Constitution of India provides for a parliamentary system of government to ensure executive accountability to the legislature.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Stative Verbs (e.g., believe, know, understand, possess, love, hate) are used in the Simple Present even when referring to a current state, as they describe a state of being rather than a physical action and thus typically avoid the continuous (-ing) form.

PRO-TIP

Tip: The most critical intersection in competitive exams is between Simple Present and Subject-Verb Agreement (SVA). Always verify if the subject is third-person singular (He, She, It, or a Singular Noun); if so, the verb must append -s or -es. Be particularly vigilant with collective nouns and indefinite pronouns like 'each', 'everyone', and 'neither', which strictly require the singular verb form.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The updated firmware for the satellite array update automatically every quarter to optimize signal transmission.'



RULE 84

Importance: 80/100

Tenses: Simple Past Usage

The simple past tense is used for actions completed at a specific point in the past, often indicated by time expressions like 'yesterday', 'last week', 'ago'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently pair a specific past time marker (e.g., 'two decades ago', 'in 1947') with the Present Perfect tense ('has/have + V3'). This creates a grammatical contradiction because the Present Perfect is used for unspecified time, while the marker demands the Simple Past.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Simple Past Tense (or Preterite) is utilized to describe an action that was completed at a specific, definite time in the past. The primary characteristic of this tense is that the action is entirely severed from the present. In competitive examinations, the Simple Past is distinguished from the Present Perfect by the presence of specific temporal markers (time adverbs) such as 'yesterday', 'last week', 'ago', 'in 1998', or 'during the previous tenure'. The affirmative form uses the second form of the verb (V2), while negative and interrogative forms utilize the auxiliary 'did' followed by the base form of the verb (V1).

- >> Utilize the Simple Past to describe an action that was completed at a specific, definite time in the past.
- >> Ensure the action is entirely severed from the present; it has no direct continuing effect or connection to the current moment.
- >> Identify specific temporal markers (time adverbs) such as 'yesterday', 'last week', 'ago', 'in [specific year]', or 'during the previous administration' to trigger this tense.
- >> Use the second form of the verb (V2) for affirmative statements.
- >> Employ the auxiliary 'did' followed by the base form of the verb (V1) for negative and interrogative constructions.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The civilization flourished along the Indus Valley and has declined around 1900 BCE.

OK CORRECT

The civilization flourished along the Indus Valley and declined around 1900 BCE.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Chief Executive Officer would rather the shareholders approve the acquisition strategy immediately to prevent a market slump.

OK CORRECT

The Chief Executive Officer would rather the shareholders approved the acquisition strategy immediately to prevent a market slump.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The Ministry of External Affairs has implemented the new diplomatic protocol during the previous fiscal year to streamline international collaborations.

OK CORRECT

The Ministry of External Affairs implemented the new diplomatic protocol during the previous fiscal year to streamline international collaborations.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> The Simple Past may be used to describe a past habit or a repeated action that no longer occurs (e.g., 'The diplomat visited the consulate every Friday during his posting').
- >> It is also used in the 'Subjunctive Mood' to express hypothetical or unreal present situations, such as in the second conditional (e.g., 'If he were the Prime Minister, he would reform the tax code').

PRO-TIP



Tip: When deciding between Simple Past and Present Perfect, ask: 'Does the sentence answer WHEN the action happened?' If there is a specific time reference, the Simple Past is mandatory. If the time is vague or the focus is on the current result of a past action, use the Present Perfect.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Detect the error: 'The global semiconductor industry has encountered a severe supply chain disruption during the 2021 pandemic peak, leading to widespread production delays.'



RULE 85

Importance: 80/100

Tenses: Past Perfect Continuous Usage

The past perfect continuous tense is used for an action that was ongoing for a duration before another action in the past.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most frequent trap is the substitution of the Past Continuous ('was/were + V-ing') for the Past Perfect Continuous when a duration marker (for/since) is present. While Past Continuous describes an action in progress at a specific moment, it cannot logically express the duration of an action leading up to another past event.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Past Perfect Continuous tense is employed to describe an action that commenced in the past and continued over a specific duration up until another point or action in the past. It emphasizes the continuity and the time elapsed before the second event occurred. The grammatical structure is: Subject + had + been + Present Participle (Verb+ing). Unlike the Past Continuous, which merely describes an action in progress at a specific moment, the Past Perfect Continuous explicitly links the duration of an activity to a subsequent past event, often utilizing markers such as 'for' (duration) or 'since' (point of origin).

- >> Used to describe an action that commenced in the past and continued uninterrupted up until another specific point or event in the past.
- >> Primary emphasis is placed on the duration or the persistence of the activity leading up to the second event.
- >> The grammatical construction is: Subject + had + been + Present Participle (Verb+ing).
- >> Typically requires a duration marker such as 'for' (to denote a period of time) or 'since' (to denote a specific starting point).
- >> The subsequent event that interrupts or follows the continuous action is almost always expressed in the Simple Past tense.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The municipal corporation has been renovating the sewage system for six months before the monsoon rains caused a flood.

OK CORRECT

The municipal corporation had been renovating the sewage system for six months before the monsoon rains caused a flood.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The conglomerate, who's strategic acquisitions have dominated the emerging markets, is now under scrutiny by the antitrust commission.

OK CORRECT

The conglomerate, whose strategic acquisitions have dominated the emerging markets, is now under scrutiny by the antitrust commission.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The research consortium was analyzing the atmospheric data since the previous fiscal year before they discovered the anomaly in the ozone layer.

OK CORRECT

The research consortium had been analyzing the atmospheric data since the previous fiscal year before they discovered the anomaly in the ozone layer.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Stative verbs (non-continuous verbs) such as 'know', 'believe', 'understand', 'possess', 'belong', and 'seem' cannot be used in the continuous form.
- >> In these instances, the Past Perfect tense must be utilized.
- >> For example, instead of 'had been knowing the truth', use 'had known the truth'.

PRO-TIP



Tip: In high-stakes exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL, employ the 'Duration-Cutoff' filter. If the sentence contains a specific duration (e.g., 'for three decades') and a past cutoff event (e.g., 'until the law changed'), you must use 'had been + V-ing'. If the duration marker is missing, Past Continuous may be acceptable; if the duration is present, it is mandatory.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Error Detection: The colonial administration (A) had been implementing (B) stringent land reforms for decades (C) until the indigenous population revolted (D). No Error (E).



RULE 86

Importance: 80/100

Tenses: Mixed Conditionals

Mixed conditionals combine elements of Type 2 and Type 3, often linking a past condition to a present result or a present condition to a past result.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently swap the result clauses of Type 3 and Mixed Conditionals. They may use 'would have + V3' in a sentence containing the word 'now', or 'would + V1' in a sentence referring to a specific past date, hoping the candidate will rely on the rhythm of standard conditionals rather than the temporal markers.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Mixed Conditionals are advanced structures used when the time reference in the 'if-clause' (condition) is different from the time reference in the 'main clause' (result). Unlike standard conditionals (Type 0-3), mixed conditionals bridge the gap between the past and the present. There are two primary configurations: 1. Past Condition $\rightarrow$ Present Result: Used when a hypothetical action in the past has a continuing effect on the present. Structure: [If + Past Perfect], [would + Base Verb]. Example: If he had taken the promotion, he would be the CEO now. 2. Present/Permanent Condition $\rightarrow$ Past Result: Used when a general, permanent state or characteristic influenced a specific event in the past. Structure: [If + Simple Past/Subjunctive 'were'], [would have + Past Participle]. Example: If she were more disciplined, she would have completed the project on time last month.

>> Past Condition $\rightarrow$ Present Result: Used when a hypothetical action in the past has a continuing effect on the present. Structure: [If + Past Perfect], [would + Base Verb].

>> Present/Permanent Condition $\rightarrow$ Past Result: Used when a general, permanent state or characteristic influenced a specific event in the past. Structure: [If + Simple Past/Subjunctive 'were'], [would have + Past Participle].

>> Time Marker Identification: Always look for markers like 'now', 'currently', or 'at present' in the result clause to determine if a Mixed Conditional (instead of a standard Type 3) is required.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

If the software engineer had patched the security flaw yesterday, the server will be stable now.

OK CORRECT

If the software engineer had patched the security flaw yesterday, the server would be stable now.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Let he assume the responsibility of coordinating the inter-departmental audit to ensure complete transparency.

OK CORRECT

Let him assume the responsibility of coordinating the inter-departmental audit to ensure complete transparency.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

If the diplomatic envoy were more skilled in cross-cultural communication, the negotiations in Geneva last month would be more successful.

OK CORRECT

If the diplomatic envoy were more skilled in cross-cultural communication, the negotiations in Geneva last month would have been more successful.

EXCEPTIONS

>> When using the verb 'to be' in a present hypothetical condition (Mixed Type 2), 'were' is used for all subjects (I, he, she, it) regardless of number, adhering to the subjunctive mood (e.g., 'If he were more competent...').

PRO-TIP



Tip: When solving error detection questions, first isolate the 'If-clause' and the 'Main-clause'. If the time references for each are different (e.g., 'had' for past and 'now' for present), you are dealing with a Mixed Conditional. A standard Type 3 conditional must have both condition and result in the past; any shift to the present requires a change in the auxiliary verb of the result clause.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Error Detection: If the global community had acted decisively (A) / on carbon emissions during the 1990s, (B) / the current rate of glacial melt (C) / would have been significantly slower. (D) / No Error (E)

RULE 87

Importance: 80/100

Tenses: 'It is time/high time'

The phrases 'it is time' or 'it is high time' are followed by a subject and a verb in the simple past tense, indicating that an action should have been done or should start now.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners exploit the logical disconnect between the meaning (present urgency) and the required grammar (past tense). They often use the Simple Present or Present Perfect to make the sentence sound 'logically' correct to the candidate, hoping they will overlook the specific grammatical mandate of the subjunctive past.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The expressions 'It is time' or 'It is high time' are used to indicate that a particular action is overdue and should have been completed already. According to traditional English grammar and competitive exam standards, when these phrases are followed by a subject and a verb (a subordinate clause), the verb must be in the Simple Past tense. This is a subjunctive usage where the past tense does not refer to a past time, but rather to a present urgency or a hypothetical situation that has not yet occurred. The addition of the word 'high' serves to further intensify the sense of urgency.

>> When 'It is time' or 'It is high time' is followed by a subject (a subordinate clause), the verb must be in the Simple Past tense (V2).

>> The use of the Simple Past in this context is subjunctive; it does not refer to a completed action in the past, but to an action that is overdue in the present.

>> The addition of 'high' serves as an intensifier, emphasizing that the action is significantly overdue.

>> The structure is strictly: [It is (high) time] + [Subject] + [Simple Past Verb].

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

It is time the city council approves the new zoning laws to prevent urban sprawl.

OK CORRECT

It is time the city council approved the new zoning laws to prevent urban sprawl.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The venerable statesman died from a prolonged bout of pneumonia after weeks of hospitalization.

OK CORRECT

The venerable statesman died of a prolonged bout of pneumonia after weeks of hospitalization.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

It is high time the global community adopts a unified framework to regulate the ethical deployment of Artificial Intelligence and mitigate systemic bias.

OK CORRECT

It is high time the global community adopted a unified framework to regulate the ethical deployment of Artificial Intelligence and mitigate systemic bias.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The Simple Past rule applies only when a subject follows the phrase.

>> If the phrase is followed directly by an infinitive, the base form is used (e.g., 'It is time to overhaul the tax system').

>> Additionally, the structure 'It is time for + object + to-infinitive' is grammatically correct (e.g., 'It is time for the judiciary to intervene in the matter').

PRO-TIP



Tip: In high-pressure exams like SBI PO or SSC CGL, treat 'It is high time' as a trigger word. As soon as you identify this phrase followed by a subject, instinctively scan for the V2 (Simple Past) form. If you encounter V1 (Present) or 'should have' (Modal), it is almost certainly the error point.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error: It is high time (A) / that the industrial sectors (B) / transition to renewable energy (C) / to mitigate ecological collapse. (D) / No Error (E)



RULE 88

Importance: 80/100

Tenses/Conjunctions: 'As if' / 'As though' (Unreal Comparison)

When 'as if' or 'as though' introduce a hypothetical or unreal situation, they are followed by the past subjunctive (past tense for present unreality) or past perfect tense (for past unreality). They are never followed by the present tense.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently use 'was' instead of 'were' for singular subjects to trick candidates into following colloquial speech rather than formal subjunctive grammar. Additionally, they may use the Present Perfect ('has been') in the subordinate clause to test if the candidate can identify a past unreal situation that requires the Past Perfect ('had been').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The conjunctions 'as if' and 'as though' are used to describe a situation that is contrary to fact, hypothetical, or unreal. In competitive examinations, this follows the logic of the subjunctive mood. The tense of the subordinate clause depends on the timing of the unreality relative to the main clause: 1. Present Unreality: If the main verb is in the present tense and the situation is hypothetical, the subordinate clause must be in the Simple Past. Crucially, the verb 'to be' always takes the form 'were', regardless of whether the subject is singular or plural. 2. Past Unreality: If the main verb is in the past tense and the situation was hypothetical at that time, the subordinate clause must be in the Past Perfect tense to indicate a further shift back in time. As a Conjunction: The conjunctions 'as if' and 'as though' are used to introduce a clause that describes a situation that is contrary to fact or hypothetical. In formal English and competitive examinations, this requires the use of the Subjunctive Mood to indicate unreality. 1. Present Unreality: When the hypothetical situation refers to the present or future, the Simple Past tense is used. Specifically, the verb '

>> Use the Simple Past tense in the subordinate clause to describe a hypothetical or unreal situation that is simultaneous with a present-tense main verb.

>> In the subjunctive mood, the verb 'to be' must always take the form 'were', regardless of whether the subject is singular or plural (e.g., 'he were', 'it were').

>> Use the Past Perfect tense ('had' + past participle) in the subordinate clause when the hypothetical situation occurred prior to the time indicated by the main verb, typically when the main verb is in the past tense.

>> Avoid using the present indicative or present perfect tense when the context explicitly indicates that the situation is contrary to fact.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The outdated software behaves as if it is haunted by a legacy bug.

OK CORRECT

The outdated software behaves as if it were haunted by a legacy bug.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy met with several commander-in-chiefs to coordinate the joint military exercise.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy met with several commanders-in-chief to coordinate the joint military exercise.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The magistrate deliberates on the high-profile case as if the law was a flexible suggestion rather than a rigid statute.

OK CORRECT

The magistrate deliberates on the high-profile case as if the law were a flexible suggestion rather than a rigid statute.

EXCEPTIONS



>> If the situation described is not hypothetical but is perceived as a likely reality or a probable fact, the indicative mood (standard tense) is used.

>> Example: 'The clouds are darkening; it looks as if it is going to rain.' (Here, rain is a probable reality, not a counter-factual hypothesis).

PRO-TIP

Tip: To quickly identify if the subjunctive is needed, look for contradictory markers in the sentence (e.g., 'despite being...', 'although he is not...'). If the sentence implies 'but it is actually NOT the case', you must use 'were' or 'had been'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The artificial intelligence system processes information as though it has a consciousness similar to that of a human being.'



RULE 89

Importance: 80/100

Pronouns: 'One' as a Pronoun

When 'one' is used as a pronoun meaning 'a person', its possessive form is 'one's' and its reflexive form is 'oneself'.

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner often constructs complex, multi-clause sentences, placing the incorrect pronoun ('his', 'her', or 'their') at the end of the sentence to distract the candidate from the initial subject 'one'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English, when 'one' is used as an indefinite pronoun to refer to people in general (meaning 'any person'), it creates a requirement for grammatical consistency throughout the sentence. This is known as maintaining the pronoun antecedent. If a sentence begins with 'one', all subsequent pronouns referring back to that subject must remain in the 'one' family. Specifically, the possessive form must be 'one's' and the reflexive form must be 'oneself'. A frequent error in competitive examinations is the 'pronoun shift,' where a writer starts with 'one' but switches to 'he', 'she', 'his', or 'their' later in the sentence. Such shifts are considered grammatically incorrect in formal, standard English.

- >> Use 'one' as an indefinite pronoun to refer to people in general or any arbitrary person.
- >> Maintain strict grammatical consistency (pronoun-antecedent agreement) throughout the entire sentence.
- >> If the subject is 'one', the possessive form must be 'one's' (e.g., one's integrity).
- >> If the subject is 'one', the reflexive form must be 'oneself' (e.g., one must challenge oneself).
- >> Avoid 'pronoun shift,' which occurs when a sentence starts with 'one' but switches to 'he', 'she', 'they', 'his', 'her', or 'their' later in the discourse.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

One must always be mindful of his civic duties to ensure the smooth functioning of a democracy.

OK CORRECT

One must always be mindful of one's civic duties to ensure the smooth functioning of a democracy.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The government has implemented a five-years strategic plan to bolster the nation's fiscal reserves.

OK CORRECT

The government has implemented a five-year strategic plan to bolster the nation's fiscal reserves.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

While analyzing the impact of carbon emissions on glacial melting, one must ensure that his data is validated through peer-reviewed sources to avoid skewed conclusions.

OK CORRECT

While analyzing the impact of carbon emissions on glacial melting, one must ensure that one's data is validated through peer-reviewed sources to avoid skewed conclusions.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> In colloquial or informal discourse, 'one' is frequently replaced by 'you' to avoid an overly stiff or archaic tone.
- >> However, for standardized competitive examinations like SBI PO and SSC CGL, strict adherence to formal pronoun consistency is mandatory.

PRO-TIP

Tip: In 'Error Detection' or 'Sentence Improvement' questions, immediately scan for the word 'one' acting as the subject. Once identified, track every subsequent pronoun in the sentence; any shift to the third person (he/she/they) is an automatic error.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'To truly comprehend the intricacies of the Magna Carta, one must immerse himself in the socio-political climate of 13th-century England.'

RULE 90

Importance: 80/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: Absolute Adjectives

Absolute adjectives (e.g., 'unique', 'perfect', 'complete', 'universal', 'eternal', 'impossible') describe qualities that cannot be graded or compared; they should not be used with comparatives or superlatives.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often embed absolute adjectives within long, sophisticated sentences using words like 'more' or 'most' to create a false sense of formality or emphasis, tricking candidates into overlooking the logical impossibility of grading an absolute quality.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Absolute adjectives, also known as non-gradable adjectives, describe qualities that are total, complete, or definitive. By definition, these adjectives represent a state that cannot be increased, decreased, or compared because they already denote the utmost limit of a quality. For instance, if something is 'unique,' it is the only one of its kind; it cannot be 'more unique' or 'most unique.' Similarly, 'perfect' implies a state of flawlessness, making 'more perfect' a logical contradiction. In competitive examinations like SBI PO and SSC CGL, the use of modifiers such as 'more,' 'most,' 'very,' 'quite,' or 'too' with absolute adjectives is treated as a grammatical error.

- >> Absolute adjectives (non-gradable adjectives) represent an ultimate or binary state that cannot be increased or decreased in intensity.
- >> Because they denote a definitive limit, they cannot be used with comparative modifiers such as 'more', 'less', or suffixes like '-er'.
- >> Similarly, they cannot be used with superlative modifiers such as 'most', 'least', or suffixes like '-est'.
- >> Intensifiers such as 'very', 'quite', 'too', or 'rather' are grammatically incorrect when paired with absolute adjectives in formal written English.
- >> In competitive examinations (SSC CGL, SBI PO), any attempt to grade a non-gradable adjective is flagged as a logical and grammatical error.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The new encryption protocol offers a more unique method of securing sensitive data.

OK CORRECT

The new encryption protocol offers a unique method of securing sensitive data.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

Statistics are a rigorous branch of mathematics that requires a deep understanding of probability.

OK CORRECT

Statistics is a rigorous branch of mathematics that requires a deep understanding of probability.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The treaty aimed to establish a more universal standard for carbon emission credits across all participating nations to mitigate global warming.

OK CORRECT

The treaty aimed to establish a universal standard for carbon emission credits across all participating nations to mitigate global warming.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While colloquial English and some historical documents (e.g., the US Constitution's 'a more perfect Union') use modifiers for rhetorical emphasis, such usage is strictly considered an error in standardized grammar tests.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Develop a 'Red Flag List' of absolute adjectives: Unique, Perfect, Complete, Universal, Eternal, Impossible, Infinite, Dead, Square, and Absolute. Whenever you encounter these in a sentence, immediately check for any preceding modifiers like 'very', 'more', or 'most'.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The judicial review of the proposed legislation was deemed to be the most complete evaluation of the bill's constitutionality to date.'

RULE 91

Importance: 80/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Little/A little/The little'

'Little' means 'hardly any' (negative). 'A little' means 'some' (positive). 'The little' means 'all that is available'. These are used with uncountable nouns.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often create a conflict between the quantifier and the outcome of the sentence. They may use 'a little' (positive) in a sentence where the result is failure (e.g., 'was unable to'), or conversely, use 'little' (negative) where the result is success (e.g., 'sufficient to'). Another common trap is substituting these with countable nouns like 'personnel' or 'resources' to test your knowledge of noun types.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

This is a 3-way choice and the key is the TONE of the sentence, not the quantity. Ask yourself: Is the sentence saying something negative (failure, not enough)? → 'Little'. Is it positive (some, at least something)? → 'A little'. Is it saying 'all that existed'? → 'The little'. Remember: all three are ONLY used with UNCOUNTABLE nouns (water, patience, information, money). For countable nouns, use: Few / A few / The few.

>> Use 'Little' when the connotation is negative, implying a scarcity that leads to an insufficient result (synonymous with 'hardly any').

>> Use 'A little' when the connotation is positive, implying that although the quantity is small, it is enough to be useful (synonymous with 'some').

>> Use 'The little' to refer to a specific, limited quantity, meaning 'the entirety of the small amount available' (often followed by a qualifying clause).

>> Strictly apply these quantifiers only to uncountable nouns (e.g., patience, information, wealth, progress) and never to countable nouns.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The local municipality has little funding for the waste management project, so it managed to install ten new recycling bins.

OK CORRECT

The local municipality has a little funding for the waste management project, so it managed to install ten new recycling bins.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

I, you, and he shall collaborate on the strategic framework for the upcoming quarterly audit.

OK CORRECT

You, he, and I shall collaborate on the strategic framework for the upcoming quarterly audit.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

A little autonomy the provincial government exercised over the healthcare sector was revoked following the constitutional crisis.

OK CORRECT

The little autonomy the provincial government exercised over the healthcare sector was revoked following the constitutional crisis.

EXCEPTIONS

>> These terms must never be used with countable nouns; for countable nouns, the counterparts 'Few', 'A few', and 'The few' must be employed.

PRO-TIP

Tip: To identify the correct choice in Error Spotting, isolate the 'result clause.' If the sentence implies insufficiency or failure (e.g., 'failed to,' 'could not,' 'insufficient'), the correct choice is 'Little'. If the sentence implies a possibility or a modest success (e.g., 'managed to,' 'enough to'), use 'A little'. 'The little' is typically signaled by a restricting relative clause (e.g., 'The little progress [that] was made...').

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error: 'Despite having (A) a little expertise (B) in quantum computing, the researcher (C) was unable to resolve (D) the anomalies in the simulation.'



RULE 92

Importance: 80/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Few/A few/The few'

'Few' means 'hardly any' (negative). 'A few' means 'some' (positive). 'The few' means 'all that are available'. These are used with countable nouns.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently swap 'few' with 'a few' in sentences where the sentiment is subtly negative. They may also use 'little' with a plural countable noun to test the candidate's ability to distinguish between countable and uncountable quantifiers.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Identical logic to Little/A little/The little — but ONLY for countable nouns (things you can count individually: books, students, employees, mistakes). The tone/context of the sentence tells you which one to pick. Negative/failure context → Few. Positive/hopeful context → A few. Specific limited group → The few. Memory trick: 'A' in 'A few' = Affirmative (positive). No 'A' = Negative.

>> Use these quantifiers exclusively with plural countable nouns (e.g., legislators, satellites, amendments, discrepancies).

>> Use 'Few' to convey a negative connotation, implying scarcity, insufficiency, or a disappointing lack.

>> Use 'A few' to convey a positive connotation, implying that while the number is small, it is nonetheless present or sufficient.

>> Use 'The few' to refer to a specific, limited group, often followed by a qualifying phrase or relative clause (e.g., 'the few who survived').

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The council had few members attending the emergency session, which is why the quorum was easily reached.

OK CORRECT

The council had a few members attending the emergency session, which is why the quorum was easily reached.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The news regarding the sudden fluctuation in the global stock market have caused widespread panic among retail investors.

OK CORRECT

The news regarding the sudden fluctuation in the global stock market has caused widespread panic among retail investors.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The research paper was widely criticized in the scientific community because a few peer reviewers had meticulously scrutinized the methodology, leading to several overlooked errors.

OK CORRECT

The research paper was widely criticized in the scientific community because few peer reviewers had meticulously scrutinized the methodology, leading to several overlooked errors.

EXCEPTIONS

>> These quantifiers must never be used with uncountable nouns (e.g., patience, luggage, information); for uncountable nouns, the counterparts 'little', 'a little', and 'the little' must be used.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Determine the 'emotional valence' of the sentence. If the context suggests disappointment, failure, or an inadequate amount (e.g., 'insufficient', 'hardly', 'unfortunately'), use 'few'. If the context suggests possibility, satisfaction, or the existence of a small amount (e.g., 'at least', 'managed to'), use 'a few'. If the noun is specified by a restrictive clause (e.g., 'that were available'), 'the few' is the required choice.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'While the archaeological excavation yielded numerous shards of pottery, a few artifacts of significant historical value were recovered, leaving the lead historians profoundly dissatisfied with the results.'

**RULE 93****Importance: 80/100****Prepositions: 'Agree with/to/on'***'Agree with' is used for people, 'agree to' for a proposal or suggestion, and 'agree on' for a point or issue.*

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently swap 'agree to' and 'agree on'. Remember: 'agree to' implies consent to a suggested action or contract (acceptance), whereas 'agree on' implies a shared decision reached after discussion (consensus). Another common trap is using 'agree to' when referring to a person's opinion.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The verb 'agree' is followed by different prepositions depending on the object of the agreement. 1. 'Agree with' is used when the agreement is with a person, their opinion, or a specific statement. It is also used when something is compatible or suits a person (e.g., health or climate). 2. 'Agree to' is used when one gives consent to a proposal, a suggestion, a set of terms, or a request. 3. 'Agree on' (or 'upon') is used when two or more parties reach a mutual consensus or a collective decision regarding a specific point, date, price, or issue.

- >> Use 'agree with' when expressing concurrence with a person, their specific perspective, or a stated opinion.
- >> Use 'agree to' when granting formal consent, acceptance, or submission to a proposal, a plan, a set of terms, or a request.
- >> Use 'agree on' (or 'upon') when two or more parties reach a mutual consensus or a collective decision regarding a specific point, date, price, or issue of contention.
- >> Use 'agree with' in a physiological context to indicate that something, such as food, climate, or medicine, is suitable or tolerable for a person's health.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The lead researcher agreed to the colleague's hypothesis regarding carbon sequestration.

OK CORRECT

The lead researcher agreed with the colleague's hypothesis regarding carbon sequestration.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

You, he, and I are responsible for the discrepancy in the quarterly financial audit.

OK CORRECT

I, you, and he are responsible for the discrepancy in the quarterly financial audit.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

After hours of deliberation, the legislative committee finally agreed to the specific date for the upcoming referendum.

OK CORRECT

After hours of deliberation, the legislative committee finally agreed on the specific date for the upcoming referendum.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The phrase 'agree with' is employed in a non-consensual, physiological sense to mean 'to be healthy for' or 'to suit' (e.g., 'The arid climate of the Rajasthan desert did not agree with the foreign delegates').

PRO-TIP

Tip: Analyze the object of the verb 'agree': Person/Opinion $\rightarrow$ 'with'; Proposal/Terms/Request $\rightarrow$ 'to'; Mutual Consensus/Specific Detail $\rightarrow$ 'on'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: The governing council reluctantly agreed ____ the stringent austerity measures imposed by the International Monetary Fund to stabilize the national economy. (Fill in the blank)

**RULE 94****Importance: 80/100****Conjunctions: 'Lest...should'**

The conjunction 'lest' (meaning 'for fear that') is always followed by 'should' and a bare infinitive, expressing a negative purpose or warning.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently introduce a 'not' after 'should' to create a double negative, or they substitute 'should' with other modal verbs such as 'might', 'may', 'would', or 'will' to test whether the candidate recognizes the fixed nature of this pairing.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The conjunction 'lest' is a formal subordinating conjunction meaning 'for fear that' or 'to avoid the risk of.' In the context of competitive English grammar, it follows a rigid structural pattern: it must be followed by the auxiliary verb 'should' and the base form of the main verb. A critical aspect of 'lest' is its inherent negative meaning; it already implies that the speaker wants to prevent a specific undesirable outcome. Consequently, the use of 'not' within the 'lest' clause creates a redundant double negative and is strictly prohibited. While the subjunctive mood (omitting 'should') is occasionally found in classical literature, for SBI PO and SSC CGL examinations, the 'lest...should' construction is the mandatory standard for correctness.

>> The conjunction 'lest' serves as a formal subordinating conjunction meaning 'for fear that' or 'to avoid the risk of'.

>> It must be followed by the auxiliary verb 'should' and the base form (bare infinitive) of the main verb.

>> Because 'lest' inherently carries a negative implication, the use of 'not' within the clause is grammatically redundant and strictly prohibited.

>> In the context of competitive examinations (SBI PO, SSC CGL), the 'lest...should' construction is the mandatory standard for correctness.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The environmentalists monitored the rainforest's perimeter closely lest the illegal loggers might penetrate the sanctuary.

OK CORRECT

The environmentalists monitored the rainforest's perimeter closely lest the illegal loggers should penetrate the sanctuary.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Ministry of Finance has proposed a comprehensive, long term strategy to mitigate the risks associated with fiscal deficits.

OK CORRECT

The Ministry of Finance has proposed a comprehensive, long-term strategy to mitigate the risks associated with fiscal deficits.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislative body amended the constitutional clause with extreme precision lest the provision should not be exploited as a loophole by opportunistic litigators.

OK CORRECT

The legislative body amended the constitutional clause with extreme precision lest the provision should be exploited as a loophole by opportunistic litigators.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In highly formal or archaic literary contexts, the subjunctive mood may be employed (e.g., 'Lest he forget'), omitting the word 'should'.

>> However, for the purpose of competitive examinations, 'should' is considered the only correct auxiliary.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Whenever you encounter 'lest' in an Error Detection question, immediately execute a two-step check: first, verify that 'should' is present; second, ensure that no negative particle (like 'not') exists in the subsequent clause.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Error Detection: The cybersecurity firm implemented a multi-layered encryption protocol (A) / lest the sensitive data (B) / could be intercepted (C) / by malicious actors during transit (D).

**RULE 95****Importance: 80/100****Articles: Omission of Articles (Proper Nouns/Meals/Languages)**

Articles are usually omitted before proper nouns, names of meals (breakfast, lunch), languages, diseases, and sports.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently exploit the distinction between a language and a nationality. While 'French' (the language) takes no article, 'the French' refers to the people of France. Furthermore, they may blend proper nouns that require 'the' (e.g., 'The Netherlands', 'The UK') with those that do not (e.g., 'Switzerland', 'Japan') to test the candidate's precision.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The 'Zero Article' occurs when a noun is used without any preceding article (a, an, or the). This omission is mandatory in several specific contexts: 1. Proper Nouns: Names of people, cities, and most countries (e.g., New Delhi, Japan) do not take articles. 2. Languages: Names of languages (e.g., Hindi, French) are used without articles when referring to the language itself. 3. Meals: General references to breakfast, lunch, and dinner are treated as uncountable and omit articles. 4. Sports and Games: Names of sports (e.g., Cricket, Tennis) are never preceded by articles. 5. Diseases: Most diseases (e.g., Cancer, Tuberculosis) are used without articles, though there are specific exceptions.

>> Proper nouns, including names of individuals, most cities, and the majority of sovereign states, do not require preceding articles.

>> Names of languages are used without articles when they refer to the language itself rather than the people of that nation.

>> General references to daily meals (breakfast, lunch, dinner) are treated as uncountable and omit articles.

>> Names of sports and athletic games are never preceded by articles.

>> Most diseases and medical conditions are used without articles, with a few traditional exceptions.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The Python is widely utilized for developing sophisticated machine learning algorithms.

OK CORRECT

Python is widely utilized for developing sophisticated machine learning algorithms.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The monetary policy committee has maintained the status quo on interest rates; consequently, the market expects a period of relative stability in bond yields.

OK CORRECT

The monetary policy committee has maintained the status quo on interest rates; consequently, the market expects a period of relative stability in bond yields.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Despite his mastery over the Mandarin, the diplomat struggled to navigate the bureaucratic hurdles in the China.

OK CORRECT

Despite his mastery over Mandarin, the diplomat struggled to navigate the bureaucratic hurdles in China.

EXCEPTIONS

>> 1.

>> Proper Nouns as Common Nouns: When a name is used to represent a specific quality or archetype (e.g., 'He is the Newton of our era').

>> 2.

>> Language + 'Language': The definite article is required if the word 'language' follows the name (e.g., 'The English language is global').



>> 3.

>> Modified Meals: An article is used if the meal is described by an adjective (e.g., 'A lavish breakfast was served to the guests').

>> 4.

>> Specific Diseases: Certain conditions like 'the flu', 'the mumps', or 'the measles' traditionally take the definite article.

PRO-TIP

Tip: When scanning a sentence, isolate the noun. If it is a language, sport, or meal, immediately check for a preceding article. Unless there is a modifying adjective (e.g., 'a hearty lunch') or the noun is followed by the word 'language', the article is almost certainly superfluous and constitutes an error.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The legislative assembly debated whether the proficiency in the Arabic would be an asset for the diplomatic corps in the Middle East.'



RULE 96

Importance: 80/100

Articles: Omission of Articles (Institutions)

Articles are omitted before 'school', 'college', 'hospital', 'church', 'prison', 'bed', 'market' when they are visited for their primary purpose.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently use high-status subjects (e.g., diplomats, ministers, or scientists) and complex sentence structures to make the inclusion of 'the' sound naturally correct to the ear, misleading candidates into ignoring the primary purpose of the visit.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, the definite article 'the' is omitted before nouns denoting institutions—specifically school, college, hospital, church, prison, bed, and market—when these locations are visited for their primary, intended purpose. This omission signifies that the focus is on the activity or function of the institution rather than the physical building. For example, if a person enters a hospital as a patient for medical treatment, the article is omitted. Conversely, if a person visits the hospital as a visitor or for a purpose unrelated to treatment, the definite article 'the' is required to specify the building as a physical entity.

>> Omit the definite article 'the' before nouns denoting institutions (such as school, college, hospital, church, prison, bed, and market) when the location is visited for its primary, intended purpose.

>> The omission of the article signifies that the focus is on the activity, function, or status associated with the institution rather than the physical architecture of the building.

>> Restore the definite article 'the' when the institution is referred to as a specific physical entity or when the visit is for a secondary purpose unrelated to the institution's core function.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The scholar returned to the college to complete his doctoral research.

OK CORRECT

The scholar returned to college to complete his doctoral research.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The objective for the current fiscal year is: maintaining the inflation target within the tolerance band of 2% to 6%.

OK CORRECT

The Monetary Policy Committee has outlined a clear objective for the current fiscal year: maintaining the inflation target within the tolerance band of 2% to 6%.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Following the treason trial, the disgraced official was escorted to the prison to serve a twenty-year sentence.

OK CORRECT

Following the treason trial, the disgraced official was escorted to prison to serve a twenty-year sentence.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The article 'the' must be used when the institution is referred to as a specific building or when the visit is for a secondary purpose (e.g., 'The civil engineer visited the prison to inspect the structural integrity of the east wing').

PRO-TIP

Tip: To determine the correct usage, analyze the subject's role: if the person is a 'student' at school, a 'patient' at hospital, or a 'convict' at prison, the zero article is mandatory. If the subject is a 'visitor', 'parent', or 'consultant', 'the' must be used.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The environmental activist spent six months in the prison for protesting against the illegal dredging of the riverbed.' (A) The environmental activist (B) spent six months (C)



in the prison (D) No error



RULE 97

Importance: 80/100

Nouns: Irregular Plurals

Many nouns have irregular plural forms (e.g., 'man/men', 'child/children', 'foot/feet', 'datum/data', 'crisis/crises').

Memorizing these is crucial.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often use Latin/Greek plurals like 'criteria', 'phenomena', or 'analyses' as the subject and pair them with a singular verb (e.g., 'The criteria is...'). Because these words do not end in '-s', students often mistake them for singular nouns.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

While most English nouns form their plurals by adding '-s' or '-es', irregular plurals deviate from this standard pattern. These irregularities generally fall into four categories: 1. Vowel Mutation (e.g., foot → feet, goose → geese, man → men), where the internal vowel changes. 2. En-suffixation (e.g., child → children, ox → oxen). 3. Foreign Plurals, predominantly derived from Latin and Greek, which are high-frequency targets in competitive exams. This includes nouns ending in '-um' changing to '-a' (datum → data, bacterium → bacteria), '-on' changing to '-a' (criterion → criteria, phenomenon → phenomena), and '-is' changing to '-es' (crisis → crises, analysis → analyses). 4. Zero Plurals, where the singular and plural forms are identical. Mastery of these forms is essential for ensuring Subject-Verb Agreement, as using a singular noun with a plural verb (or vice versa) is a common error tested in Error Detection sections.

>> Vowel Mutation: Some nouns change their internal vowel to indicate plurality (e.g., foot → feet, goose → geese, man → men).

>> En-suffixation: A small group of nouns form plurals by adding '-en' (e.g., child → children, ox → oxen).

>> Latin and Greek Plurals: High-frequency exam targets including: nouns ending in '-um' changing to '-a' (datum → data, bacterium → bacteria), '-on' changing to '-a' (criterion → criteria, phenomenon → phenomena), and '-is' changing to '-es' (crisis → crises, analysis → analyses).

>> Zero Plurals: Certain nouns maintain the same form for both singular and plural instances (e.g., species, aircraft, sheep, series).

>> Subject-Verb Agreement (SVA): The primary application in exams is ensuring that these irregular plural nouns are paired with plural verbs, avoiding the common mistake of treating them as singular.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The government has established a new criterion for the allocation of urban development grants.

OK CORRECT

The government has established new criteria for the allocation of urban development grants.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The fiscal trajectory of the emerging economy-despite the optimistic projections provided by the World Bank-remains precarious due to systemic inflationary pressures.

OK CORRECT

The fiscal trajectory of the emerging economy—despite the optimistic projections provided by the World Bank—remains precarious due to systemic inflationary pressures.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The atmospheric phenomenons witnessed during the solar eclipse provided the researchers with unprecedented data.

OK CORRECT

The atmospheric phenomena witnessed during the solar eclipse provided the researchers with unprecedented data.

EXCEPTIONS



>> Nouns with identical singular and plural forms—such as 'species', 'series', 'aircraft', and 'deer'—do not take any suffix to indicate plurality.

>> For example, 'A rare species of orchid' and 'Several rare species of orchids' are both correct.

PRO-TIP

Tip: In high-stakes exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL, adhere to formal prescriptive grammar: treat 'data' as the plural of 'datum' and 'media' as the plural of 'medium'. While colloquial English accepts 'the data is', the exam boards typically require 'the data are'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The geopolitical analyses of the conflict conducted by the think-tank was found to be superficial and lacking in empirical evidence.'



RULE 98

Importance: 80/100

Sentence Structure: Subject-Verb Separation

Avoid placing unnecessary words or phrases between the subject and its verb, as this can make the sentence difficult to read and understand.

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner frequently inserts a plural noun or a complex list of entities immediately before the verb. This is designed to tempt the candidate into applying the 'Rule of Proximity', choosing a plural verb because the nearest noun is plural, while the actual primary subject remains singular.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In standard English syntax, the subject and its corresponding verb should ideally be placed close to one another to ensure clarity and logical flow. In competitive examinations, this rule is frequently tested through 'Intervening Phrases'—words or clauses placed between the subject and the verb to distract the candidate. These phrases often include expressions such as 'along with', 'as well as', 'together with', 'including', 'accompanied by', or relative clauses. The critical grammatical principle here is that these intervening phrases do not change the number of the subject. Whether the phrase contains a plural or singular noun, the verb must strictly agree with the primary subject of the sentence, not the noun closest to the verb.

>> The subject and its corresponding verb should ideally be placed in close proximity to ensure logical flow and syntactic clarity.

>> Intervening phrases—such as those beginning with 'along with', 'as well as', 'together with', 'including', 'accompanied by', or 'coupled with'—do not alter the grammatical number of the primary subject.

>> The verb must strictly agree with the primary subject, regardless of whether the nouns within the intervening phrase are singular or plural.

>> Relative clauses acting as modifiers between the subject and verb should be isolated to prevent 'proximity error' where the verb mistakenly agrees with the nearest noun.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The lead investigator, as well as his assistants, are reviewing the forensic evidence.

OK CORRECT

The lead investigator, as well as his assistants, is reviewing the forensic evidence.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

She works hard, does she?

OK CORRECT

She works hard, doesn't she?

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The discovery of rare minerals in the asteroid belt, including traces of platinum and palladium, have sparked a global race for space mining rights.

OK CORRECT

The discovery of rare minerals in the asteroid belt, including traces of platinum and palladium, has sparked a global race for space mining rights.

EXCEPTIONS

>> If the subject is joined by the coordinating conjunction 'and', it creates a compound subject, which necessitates a plural verb, regardless of the proximity of other intervening phrases.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Utilize the 'Bracketing Technique': mentally place brackets around the intervening phrase (e.g., [along with...], [including...]) and ignore it entirely. This allows you to isolate the true subject and verify its agreement with the verb instantaneously without being distracted by modifiers.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The adjudication of the territorial dispute, accompanied by numerous appeals from the affected provinces, were delayed due to the lack of a quorum in the Supreme Court.'

RULE 99

Importance: 80/100

Sentence Structure: Verb-Object Separation

Avoid placing unnecessary words or phrases between a verb and its direct object, as this can obscure the relationship between them.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often use sophisticated, multi-word modifiers starting with 'notwithstanding,' 'in light of,' or 'despite' immediately after a transitive verb. This creates an illusion of 'academic' or 'complex' writing, while actually violating the structural integrity of the SVO pattern.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In standard English syntax, the fundamental word order is Subject-Verb-Object (SVO). A transitive verb requires a direct object to complete its meaning. For maximum clarity and syntactic cohesion, the direct object should immediately follow the verb. When lengthy adverbial phrases, prepositional modifiers, or parenthetical expressions are inserted between the verb and its object, it creates 'structural distance.' This separation obscures the relationship between the action and the recipient of that action, often leading to awkward phrasing or ambiguity, which is a frequent target in high-level competitive exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL.

- >> Adhere to the standard Subject-Verb-Object (SVO) sequence to maintain syntactic clarity and cohesion.
- >> Ensure that transitive verbs are immediately followed by their direct objects to avoid creating 'structural distance.'
- >> Avoid inserting lengthy adverbial phrases, prepositional modifiers, or parenthetical expressions between the action (verb) and the recipient (object).
- >> Identify and relocate interrupting phrases to the beginning or the end of the sentence to restore the natural flow of the English language.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The administrator denied, without any hesitation, the request for an extension.

OK CORRECT

The administrator denied the request for an extension without any hesitation.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

She bought a wooden old beautiful small round Italian table.

OK CORRECT

She bought a beautiful small old round wooden Italian table.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The environmental agency mandated, following the discovery of toxic runoff in the local watershed and subsequent public outcry, the immediate cessation of industrial discharge.

OK CORRECT

Following the discovery of toxic runoff in the local watershed and subsequent public outcry, the environmental agency mandated the immediate cessation of industrial discharge.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Short, single-word adverbs (e.g., 'The scientist carefully measured the sample') or essential qualifying phrases that cannot be moved without altering the semantic meaning are permissible.

PRO-TIP

Tip: In 'Error Spotting' or 'Sentence Improvement' sections, locate the main transitive verb and check for its direct object. If you find a comma-delimited phrase wedged between them, the sentence is likely structurally flawed. Move the modifier to the front of the sentence to verify the correction.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The archaeological team uncovered, during the excavation of the third stratum in the Indus Valley site, several ivory ornaments and prehistoric clay seals.'

**RULE 100****Importance: 80/100****Verbs: Bare Infinitives**

Bare infinitives (verb without 'to') are used after modal verbs, verbs of perception (see, hear, feel) when followed by an object, and after 'let', 'make', 'have' (causative).

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Passive Voice Shift' is the most common trap. Examiners will often use 'make' in a passive construction (e.g., 'was made', 'were made') and omit the 'to' to see if the candidate blindly applies the active voice rule. Remember: Active Make = Bare Infinitive; Passive Make = Full Infinitive.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

An infinitive is typically the base form of a verb preceded by the particle 'to'. However, a 'Bare Infinitive' is the base form of the verb used without 'to'. In competitive examinations, this rule is tested across four primary linguistic environments: 1. Following Modal Auxiliaries (can, could, may, might, shall, should, will, would, must), where the use of 'to' is grammatically incorrect. 2. After Verbs of Perception (see, hear, feel, watch, notice) when they are followed by a direct object to indicate a completed action. 3. After Causative Verbs such as 'let', 'make', and 'have' when used in the active voice. 4. After specific idiomatic expressions such as 'had better', 'would rather', and 'would prefer'. Mastery of this concept is essential for Error Detection and Sentence Improvement sections.

>> Use a bare infinitive immediately following modal auxiliaries such as can, could, may, might, shall, should, will, would, and must.

>> Employ a bare infinitive after verbs of perception (e.g., see, hear, feel, watch, notice) when they are followed by a direct object to denote a completed action.

>> Use a bare infinitive after causative verbs 'let', 'make', and 'have' when the sentence is constructed in the active voice.

>> Apply the bare infinitive after specific idiomatic expressions such as 'had better', 'would rather', and occasionally 'would prefer' depending on the construction.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The administrative officer had better to notify the department about the revised deadlines.

OK CORRECT

The administrative officer had better notify the department about the revised deadlines.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

I wish I was rich enough to buy that house.

OK CORRECT

I wish I were rich enough to buy that house.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislative assembly made the ministry to overhaul the urban planning laws to mitigate the effects of unplanned sprawl.

OK CORRECT

The legislative assembly made the ministry overhaul the urban planning laws to mitigate the effects of unplanned sprawl.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The most critical exception occurs in the passive voice: while 'make' takes a bare infinitive in the active voice, it must be followed by a full infinitive (with 'to') in the passive voice (e.g., 'The ministry was made to overhaul the laws').

>> Additionally, the verb 'help' is unique as it can be followed by either a bare or a full infinitive without altering the meaning.

PRO-TIP



Tip: When you spot 'would rather' or 'had better' in an Error Detection question, immediately check the following verb. If you see 'to', it is almost certainly the error. These expressions act as modal-like triggers that demand the base form of the verb.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'Given the sensitivity of the geopolitical climate, the diplomatic envoy would rather to defer the bilateral talks until the ceasefire is ratified.'

**RULE 101****Importance: 80/100****Verbs: Causative Verbs ('Make', 'Have', 'Get')**

Causative verbs indicate that one person causes another person to do something. 'Make' and 'have' are followed by a bare infinitive, while 'get' is followed by a to-infinitive.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently embed the causative verb within a long, complex sentence and insert 'to' after 'make' or 'let' to mimic the structure of 'get'. Additionally, they may use the passive 'make' construction to test if the candidate knows that the 'to' is required only in the passive form.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Causative verbs describe situations where one person CAUSES another person to do something. The three main ones tested in SBI PO and SSC CGL are MAKE, HAVE, and GET. The key difference is the TONE (forced, neutral, persuaded) and the VERB FORM that follows. Critical rule: After MAKE and LET, always use Bare Infinitive (no 'to'). After GET, always use To-Infinitive (with 'to'). HAVE uses Bare Infinitive for active sense, but Past Participle (V3) for passive sense.

- >> Causative verbs are used when the subject does not perform the action themselves but causes someone else to perform it.
- >> The verb 'MAKE' (implying force or compulsion) and 'LET' (implying permission) must be followed by the Bare Infinitive (V1 without 'to').
- >> The verb 'GET' (implying persuasion or conviction) must be followed by a To-Infinitive (to + V1) when the agent of the action is mentioned.
- >> The verb 'HAVE' (implying a professional arrangement or request) uses a Bare Infinitive in the active voice.
- >> In the passive sense (where the focus is on the action completed rather than the agent), both 'HAVE' and 'GET' are followed by the Past Participle (V3).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The environmental agency made the factory to install scrubbers to reduce carbon emissions.

OK CORRECT

The environmental agency made the factory install scrubbers to reduce carbon emissions.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Not only he studied hard, but also he scored the highest marks.

OK CORRECT

Not only did he study hard, but he also scored the highest marks.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislative committee had the ministry to draft a comprehensive bill on data privacy before the winter session concluded.

OK CORRECT

The legislative committee had the ministry draft a comprehensive bill on data privacy before the winter session concluded.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> A critical exception occurs when 'Make' is used in the passive voice.
- >> In passive constructions, the bare infinitive reverts to a to-infinitive.
- >> For example: 'The witness was made to testify under oath' is correct, whereas in active voice, 'The prosecutor made the witness testify' is correct.

PRO-TIP



Tip: When identifying the error, first determine if the sentence is active or passive. If active, check the specific causative verb: MAKE/HAVE $\rightarrow$ No 'to'; GET $\rightarrow$ Must have 'to'. If the sentence describes a service performed (e.g., 'I had my passport renewed'), ensure the verb is in the V3 form regardless of whether 'have' or 'get' is used.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The tech consortium managed to get the regulatory body waive the licensing fees for emerging AI startups to foster innovation.'



RULE 102

Importance: 80/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Hard' vs. 'Hardly'

'Hard' can be an adjective (difficult) or an adverb (with great effort). 'Hardly' is an adverb meaning 'scarcely' or 'barely' and has a negative connotation.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often place 'hardly' in a sentence that describes a high-pressure or high-effort scenario (e.g., academic rigor or military training). This tricks candidates into treating 'hardly' as the adverbial form of 'hard' (meaning vigorously), when it actually reverses the meaning to 'scarcely'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In standard English grammar, 'hard' and 'hardly' are not interchangeable, despite 'hardly' appearing to be the adverbial form of 'hard'. 'Hard' functions as both an adjective (meaning difficult, solid, or rigorous) and an adverb (meaning with great effort, intensity, or energy). For example, in 'a hard task,' it is an adjective; in 'he worked hard,' it is an adverb. In contrast, 'hardly' is an adverb of degree that means 'scarcely,' 'barely,' or 'almost not.' It possesses a negative connotation and is used to indicate that something is only just true or almost non-existent. A common error in competitive examinations is using 'hardly' to describe intense effort, which fundamentally alters the meaning of the sentence to its opposite.

>> Use 'hard' as an adjective when describing something that is difficult, solid, or rigorous (e.g., a hard-fought battle).

>> Use 'hard' as an adverb when an action is performed with significant effort, intensity, or energy (e.g., to work hard).

>> Use 'hardly' as an adverb of degree to convey the meaning of 'scarcely,' 'barely,' or 'almost not'.

>> Note that 'hardly' possesses an inherent negative meaning; it indicates that something is only just true or nearly non-existent.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The environmental activists fought hardly to prevent the deforestation of the ancient rainforest.

OK CORRECT

The environmental activists fought hard to prevent the deforestation of the ancient rainforest.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

It might rains today, so you must to carry an umbrella.

OK CORRECT

It might rain today, so you must carry an umbrella.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

To ensure the transparency of the electoral process, the Election Commission worked hardly to implement the new biometric verification system across rural constituencies.

OK CORRECT

To ensure the transparency of the electoral process, the Election Commission worked hard to implement the new biometric verification system across rural constituencies.

EXCEPTIONS

>> There are no grammatical exceptions to the meaning, but 'hardly' is frequently paired with 'any' or 'ever' to reinforce its negative sense (e.g., 'there was hardly any evidence' or 'the diplomat hardly ever concedes a point').

PRO-TIP

Tip: Because 'hardly' is inherently negative, avoid pairing it with other negative words such as 'not', 'never', or 'no' within the same clause. Using them together creates a 'Double Negative' error, a favorite trap in the Error Detection sections of SBI PO and SSC CGL exams.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The oncology team studied hardly for months to synthesize the compound, yet the patient could hardly tolerate the side effects of the chemotherapy.'



RULE 103

Importance: 80/100

Prepositions: 'Beside' vs. 'Besides'*'Beside' means 'next to'. 'Besides' means 'in addition to' or 'apart from'.*

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often place 'beside' at the beginning of a long, complex sentence to mimic a transitional phrase. Candidates often overlook the missing 's', mistakenly using the spatial preposition instead of the additive one.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The distinction between 'beside' and 'besides' is a frequent point of testing in competitive examinations. 'Beside' is a preposition of place, meaning 'at the side of' or 'next to'. It refers strictly to physical proximity or spatial positioning. In contrast, 'besides' functions as both a preposition and an adverb, meaning 'in addition to', 'as well as', or 'apart from'. While 'beside' describes where something is located, 'besides' describes the addition or exclusion of information, people, or things.

>> Use 'beside' strictly as a preposition of place to indicate physical proximity or spatial positioning (synonym: 'next to' or 'at the side of').

>> Use 'besides' as a preposition or adverb to indicate addition, inclusion, or exclusion (synonym: 'in addition to', 'furthermore', or 'apart from').

>> Identify whether the context requires a geographical/spatial reference ('beside') or a cumulative/supplementary reference ('besides').

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The diplomat stood besides the ambassador during the joint press conference.

OK CORRECT

The diplomat stood beside the ambassador during the joint press conference.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

What beautiful painting it is!

OK CORRECT

What a beautiful painting it is!

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Beside the inherent risks of the geopolitical climate, the treaty failed to address the core territorial disputes between the two nations.

OK CORRECT

Besides the inherent risks of the geopolitical climate, the treaty failed to address the core territorial disputes between the two nations.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The word 'beside' is used in the idiomatic expression 'beside oneself' (e.g., 'The witness was beside herself with grief'), which denotes being overcome by a strong emotion rather than physical location.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Substitution Test': Replace the word with 'next to'. If the sentence remains logically sound and spatially accurate, use 'beside'. If the sentence requires 'also' or 'furthermore' to make sense, use 'besides'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Fill in the blank: '_____ the ability to process vast datasets in seconds, the new AI architecture demonstrates an unprecedented capacity for nuanced linguistic reasoning.'



RULE 104

Importance: 80/100

Prepositions: 'During' vs. 'While'

'During' is a preposition and is followed by a noun or noun phrase. 'While' is a conjunction and is followed by a clause (subject + verb).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often insert a long, complex noun phrase containing modifiers (e.g., 'the prolonged and exhaustive deliberation of the legislative committee') immediately after 'while'. This creates the illusion of a clause, tricking the candidate into overlooking the absence of a finite verb.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In high-level competitive English, the distinction between 'during' and 'while' is based on their grammatical category. 'During' is a preposition used to indicate that an event happens within a specific period of time. As a preposition, it must be followed by a noun or a noun phrase (e.g., during the conference). It describes 'when' something happened. 'While' is a conjunction used to indicate that two actions are occurring simultaneously. As a conjunction, it must be followed by a clause, which consists of a subject and a finite verb (e.g., while the committee was meeting). It emphasizes the duration of an action.

- >> Use 'during' as a preposition to indicate that an event occurs within a specific time frame; it must be followed by a noun or a noun phrase.
- >> Use 'while' as a conjunction to indicate that two actions are happening simultaneously; it must be followed by a clause containing a subject and a finite verb.
- >> Distinguish 'during' as the answer to the question 'When?' regarding a period of time.
- >> Distinguish 'while' as a marker of duration or concurrency between two activities.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The board of directors remained silent while the presentation of the quarterly fiscal report.

OK CORRECT

The board of directors remained silent during the presentation of the quarterly fiscal report.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

I returned the book to the library that I borrowed from you.

OK CORRECT

The book that I borrowed from you is fascinating.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

While the rigorous implementation of the new environmental protocols, the agency encountered unforeseen logistical hurdles that delayed the project by three months.

OK CORRECT

During the rigorous implementation of the new environmental protocols, the agency encountered unforeseen logistical hurdles that delayed the project by three months.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> A common variation occurs when 'while' is followed by a present participle (e.g., 'While implementing the protocol...').
- >> This is a reduced adverbial clause where the subject and the verb 'to be' are omitted; however, it still functions as a conjunction and cannot be replaced by 'during'.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Verb Search' technique: Immediately scan the words following the trigger word. If there is no finite verb (a verb that agrees with a subject), 'while' is grammatically incorrect. If you see a verb or a verb-ing form (functioning as a reduced clause), 'during' is the error.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The diplomat refused to concede any territory while the strategic negotiations between the two sovereign nations.'



RULE 105

Importance: 75/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Fractions/Percentages*When a fraction or percentage is used as a subject, the verb agrees with the noun in the 'of' phrase that follows it.*

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often insert complex prepositional phrases or parenthetical modifiers between the noun in the 'of' phrase and the verb (e.g., 'Two-thirds of the population, including the dissenting minority, is/are...'). This is designed to make the candidate lose sight of the actual noun determining the verb's number.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, fractions (e.g., one-third, three-fourths) and percentages (e.g., 20%, 75%) function as quantifiers rather than fixed subjects. Because they represent a portion of a whole, they do not possess an inherent number (singular or plural). Therefore, the number of the verb is determined by the noun that follows the preposition 'of'. If the noun in the 'of' phrase is singular or uncountable, the verb must be singular. If the noun in the 'of' phrase is plural, the verb must be plural.

>> Fractions (e.g., one-half, two-thirds) and percentages (e.g., 10%, 80%) function as quantifiers rather than fixed subjects.

>> The number of the verb is determined entirely by the noun that follows the preposition 'of'.

>> If the noun in the 'of' phrase is singular or uncountable, a singular verb must be used.

>> If the noun in the 'of' phrase is plural, a plural verb must be used.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

One-quarter of the ozone layer are depleted due to chemical emissions.

OK CORRECT

One-quarter of the ozone layer is depleted due to chemical emissions.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Ministry of Finance has been implementing stringent austerity measures for the onset of the global recession.

OK CORRECT

The Ministry of Finance has been implementing stringent austerity measures since the onset of the global recession.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Sixty percent of the legislative amendments proposed by the committee has been rejected by the upper house.

OK CORRECT

Sixty percent of the legislative amendments proposed by the committee have been rejected by the upper house.

EXCEPTIONS

>> If the fraction or percentage refers to a singular collective entity or an uncountable mass noun (e.g., 'Fifty percent of the urban population is migrating'), the verb remains singular regardless of the numerical value of the percentage.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Be exceptionally cautious with 'uncountable' nouns that appear plural or conceptually large, such as 'evidence', 'legislation', 'machinery', or 'information'. Even if the percentage is 99%, if the noun is uncountable, the verb must be singular.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Forty-five percent of the specialized laboratory equipment ____ (was/were) damaged during the seismic event.



RULE 106

Importance: 75/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Distances, Periods, Sums (as a unit)*When distances, periods of time, or sums of money are considered as a single unit, they take a singular verb.*

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner will place a plural noun ending in '-s' immediately before the verb to trigger a reflexive use of a plural verb. They often pair this with a singular complement (e.g., 'a long time' or 'a vast sum') to create a cognitive conflict for the candidate.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, nouns denoting measurements of distance, intervals of time, or sums of money typically appear in the plural form (e.g., miles, years, rupees). However, when these quantities are perceived as a single collective unit, a total amount, or a specific measurement, they are treated as singular subjects and must be followed by a singular verb. The grammatical focus shifts from the individual units to the aggregate total as a single conceptual entity.

>> Nouns denoting measurements of distance, intervals of time, or sums of money typically appear in the plural form (e.g., miles, years, rupees).

>> When these quantities are perceived as a single collective unit, a total amount, or a specific measurement, they are treated as singular subjects.

>> The grammatical focus shifts from the individual units to the aggregate total, necessitating a singular verb to maintain agreement with the conceptual entity.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Two hundred miles are a considerable distance to traverse across the tundra.

OK CORRECT

Two hundred miles is a considerable distance to traverse across the tundra.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

It was her who spearheaded the diplomatic negotiations between the two sovereign nations.

OK CORRECT

It was she who spearheaded the diplomatic negotiations between the two sovereign nations.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Ten billion dollars are a staggering allocation for the national infrastructure project, given the current fiscal deficit.

OK CORRECT

Ten billion dollars is a staggering allocation for the national infrastructure project, given the current fiscal deficit.

EXCEPTIONS

>> If the units are referred to as individual items rather than a collective sum, a plural verb is used.

>> For example, 'Ten five-rupee notes were scattered on the floor' (here, the focus is on the individual physical notes, not the total sum of 50 rupees).

PRO-TIP

Tip: Always look for the complement of the sentence. If the predicate nominative is a singular noun phrase (such as 'a significant duration' or 'a substantial amount'), it is a definitive signal that the subject is being treated as a single unit, requiring a singular verb.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Error Detection: Six light-years (A) / are an immense distance (B) / for a space probe (C) / to travel in a single decade. (D) / No Error (E)

**RULE 107****Importance: 75/100****Tenses: Past Continuous Usage**

The past continuous tense is used for actions that were ongoing at a specific time in the past, often interrupted by another past action.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often create traps by placing both the background action and the interrupting event in the Past Continuous, or by swapping them so that the sudden event is continuous and the background action is simple. Always ensure the interrupting event is in the Simple Past.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The Past Continuous Tense is employed to describe an action that was in progress at a specific point in the past or over a duration of time. In competitive examinations, this tense is most frequently tested in the context of 'interrupted actions,' where a longer background action (Past Continuous) is interrupted by a shorter, sudden event (Simple Past). The structural formula is: Subject + was/were + present participle (verb + ing). It is essential to maintain the temporal distinction between the ongoing state and the interrupting event to ensure grammatical precision.

- >> Utilize the Past Continuous to describe an action that was in progress at a specific point or over a duration in the past.
- >> Apply this tense for 'interrupted actions,' where a longer background action (Past Continuous) is interrupted by a shorter, sudden event (Simple Past).
- >> Follow the structural formula: Subject + was/were + present participle (verb + ing).
- >> Maintain a clear temporal distinction between the continuous background state and the sudden interrupting event to ensure grammatical precision.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The committee discussed the budget proposal when the chairperson entered the room.

OK CORRECT

The committee was discussing the budget proposal when the chairperson entered the room.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The auditor noted that less discrepancies were found in the financial statements of the current fiscal year compared to the previous one.

OK CORRECT

The auditor noted that fewer discrepancies were found in the financial statements of the current fiscal year compared to the previous one.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

While the archaeologists were excavating the ancient ruins, a sudden torrential rain was flooding the site.

OK CORRECT

While the archaeologists were excavating the ancient ruins, a sudden torrential rain flooded the site.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Stative verbs—verbs that describe a state, emotion, or possession rather than a physical action (e.g., 'know', 'believe', 'understand', 'possess', 'seem')—are generally not used in the continuous form.
- >> For instance, 'The administration was possessing the necessary documents' is incorrect; 'The administration possessed the necessary documents' is the correct form.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Distinguish between 'While' and 'When': 'While' typically introduces the longer, ongoing action and is followed by the Past Continuous (e.g., 'While the economy was stagnating...'), whereas 'When' typically introduces the sudden interruption and is followed by the Simple Past (e.g., '...when the crisis hit').

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The legislative body was debating the controversial amendment when the Speaker is calling for a vote of confidence.'

**RULE 108****Importance: 75/100****Adjectives & Adverbs: Adjectives ending in '-ly'**

Some words ending in '-ly' are adjectives, not adverbs (e.g., 'friendly', 'lovely', 'lonely', 'costly', 'lively'). To form an adverb, use a phrase like 'in a friendly manner'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often place noun-derived '-ly' words (like 'costly' or 'friendly') immediately after a verb or at the end of a sentence to mimic the position of an adverb. Candidates often mistake these for standard adverbs because of the '-ly' suffix, overlooking that they are actually adjectives requiring a periphrastic construction (e.g., 'in a... way').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In standard English grammar, the suffix '-ly' is most commonly associated with the formation of adverbs from adjectives (e.g., 'slow' becomes 'slowly'). However, a specific class of adjectives is formed by adding '-ly' to a noun. Words such as 'friendly', 'costly', 'lovely', 'lonely', 'lively', and 'silly' are adjectives, not adverbs. Consequently, they cannot be used to modify verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs directly. To express the same meaning adverbially, one must use a periphrastic construction, typically employing the phrase 'in a ... manner' or 'in a ... way'.

>> Standard adverbs are typically formed by adding the suffix '-ly' to an adjective (e.g., 'Quick' → 'Quickly').

>> A specific group of adjectives is formed by adding '-ly' to a noun (e.g., 'Friend' → 'Friendly', 'Cost' → 'Costly', 'Life' → 'Lively').

>> Because these words are adjectives, they can only modify nouns or pronouns; they cannot modify verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs.

>> To use these specific adjectives to modify a verb, you must employ a prepositional phrase such as 'in a [adjective] manner' or 'in a [adjective] way'.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The government official spoke friendly to the protesters.

OK CORRECT

The government official has a very friendly demeanor.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The legal counsel provided comprehensive advices regarding the implications of the merger.

OK CORRECT

The legal counsel provided comprehensive advice regarding the implications of the merger.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The parliamentary committee debated the proposed environmental regulations lively, leading to a deadlock in the session.

OK CORRECT

The parliamentary committee debated the proposed environmental regulations in a lively manner, leading to a deadlock in the session.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The word 'early' is a prominent exception; it functions as both an adjective (e.g., 'the early bird') and an adverb (e.g., 'he arrived early') without requiring a phrase.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Root Word Test': Identify the base word before the '-ly'. If the root is a noun (Friend, Cost, Love, Life), the word is an adjective. If the root is an adjective (Happy, Quick, Careful), the word is an adverb. This distinction is crucial for 'Error Spotting' and 'Sentence Improvement' sections in SBI PO and SSC CGL.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'While the geopolitical climate remained volatile, the two heads of state interacted friendly during the summit to prevent an escalation of the conflict.'



RULE 109

Importance: 75/100

Articles: 'A/An' with 'Many', 'Rather', 'Quite', 'Such'

The indefinite article 'a/an' is placed after 'many', 'rather', 'quite', and 'such' when followed by a singular countable noun (e.g., 'many a man', 'rather a good idea').

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Plurality Instinct' trap: Examiners often pair 'many a' with a plural noun and a plural verb (e.g., 'Many a citizens have...'). Because the word 'many' conceptually implies a plural quantity, students often overlook the strict grammatical requirement that 'many a' must take a singular noun and a singular verb.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In standard English grammar, the indefinite article 'a' or 'an' typically precedes the adjective. However, a specific syntactical exception occurs with the words 'many', 'rather', 'quite', and 'such'. When these words modify a singular countable noun, the indefinite article is placed AFTER them. The most critical application is 'many a', which is a formal expression meaning 'many' but grammatically requires a singular noun and a singular verb. Similarly, 'rather', 'quite', and 'such' function as pre-determiners, necessitating the sequence: [Pre-determiner] + [Article] + [Adjective] + [Singular Noun].

>> When the words 'many', 'rather', 'quite', or 'such' modify a singular countable noun, the indefinite article ('a' or 'an') must be positioned after these pre-determiners.

>> The construction 'Many a' is a formal literary device used to emphasize individual instances within a large group; it must be followed by a singular noun and a singular verb.

>> For 'rather', 'quite', and 'such', the grammatical sequence must strictly be: [Pre-determiner] + [Article] + [Adjective] + [Singular Noun].

>> Ensure that the subject-verb agreement aligns with the singular nature of the noun following 'many a', regardless of the implied plural meaning.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

A quite complex experiment was conducted in the laboratory.

OK CORRECT

Quite a complex experiment was conducted in the laboratory.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

A number of delegates from the international summit has voiced their concerns regarding the climate treaty.

OK CORRECT

A number of delegates from the international summit have voiced their concerns regarding the climate treaty.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Many a legislative amendment have been proposed to curb the influence of lobbying in the parliamentary process.

OK CORRECT

Many a legislative amendment has been proposed to curb the influence of lobbying in the parliamentary process.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The indefinite article is omitted if 'rather' or 'quite' modify an adjective that is not followed by a noun (e.g., 'The judicial ruling was quite ambiguous' is correct; 'The judicial ruling was quite an ambiguous' is incorrect).

>> Additionally, when 'many' is used in its standard sense without 'a', plural nouns and verbs are required (e.g., 'Many amendments were proposed').

PRO-TIP



Tip: In competitive exams, immediately isolate the phrase 'Many a'. If you see 'Many a' followed by a plural noun or a plural verb, it is an automatic error. For 'rather' and 'quite', remember that the article is a 'satellite' that follows the pre-determiner, not one that precedes it.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Many a historian have contested the validity of the primary sources used to document the colonial administration's impact on indigenous populations.'

RULE 110

Importance: 75/100

Punctuation: Comma Usage

This rule covers the various uses of commas to separate items in lists, join independent clauses, set off introductory elements, and delineate non-restrictive clauses for clarity.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Comma Splice' is a frequent trap where two independent clauses are joined by only a comma without a coordinating conjunction. Examiners also frequently omit the closing comma after a non-essential appositive, hoping the candidate will miss the lack of symmetry in the punctuation.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The comma is a punctuation mark used to indicate a brief pause within a sentence, ensuring clarity and preventing ambiguity. In competitive examinations, comma usage is tested across five primary dimensions: 1. Separating Items in a Series: Used to separate three or more items in a list (e.g., A, B, and C). 2. Joining Independent Clauses: A comma must precede a coordinating conjunction (For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So) when joining two complete sentences. 3. Introductory Elements: Used after introductory phrases, dependent clauses, or transitional adverbs (e.g., 'However,', 'Despite the crisis,') to signal the start of the main clause. 4. Non-Restrictive (Non-Essential) Clauses: Used to set off appositives or relative clauses that provide extra information but are not essential to the identity of the noun they modify. 5. Parenthetical Expressions: Used to isolate interjections or side-remarks that interrupt the flow of the sentence.

- >> Use commas to separate three or more items, phrases, or clauses in a series (the Oxford comma is typically preferred in formal examinations).
- >> Place a comma before a coordinating conjunction (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) when it connects two independent clauses to avoid run-on sentences.
- >> Insert a comma after introductory elements, such as dependent clauses, long prepositional phrases, or transitional adverbs, to signal the start of the main clause.
- >> Enclose non-restrictive (non-essential) clauses or appositives with commas, as they provide supplementary information that is not critical to the identity of the noun.
- >> Use commas to isolate parenthetical expressions, interjections, or abrupt shifts in thought that interrupt the natural flow of the sentence.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The Magna Carta signed in 1215 limited the absolute power of the English monarchy.

OK CORRECT

The Magna Carta, signed in 1215, limited the absolute power of the English monarchy.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The diplomat who the Ministry of External Affairs appointed as the ambassador possesses extensive experience in multilateral negotiations.

OK CORRECT

The diplomat whom the Ministry of External Affairs appointed as the ambassador possesses extensive experience in multilateral negotiations.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

While the integration of quantum computing promises a paradigm shift in data encryption experts warn that current cybersecurity protocols will become obsolete almost overnight.

OK CORRECT

While the integration of quantum computing promises a paradigm shift in data encryption, experts warn that current cybersecurity protocols will become obsolete almost overnight.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Restrictive clauses—those essential to identifying the noun they modify—must NOT be set off by commas.



>> For example, in the sentence 'The diplomat who negotiated the peace treaty was awarded a medal,' the clause 'who negotiated the peace treaty' is essential to specify which diplomat is being discussed; thus, no commas are used.

PRO-TIP

Tip: To distinguish between restrictive and non-restrictive clauses, apply the 'Removal Test': if you can remove the clause without changing the fundamental meaning or identity of the subject, it is non-restrictive and requires commas. If the sentence becomes vague or loses its specific meaning, it is restrictive and must remain without commas.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The administration has implemented stringent emission norms to combat urban smog, consequently, the manufacturing sector is facing a sudden spike in operational costs.'

**RULE 111****Importance: 75/100****Sentence Structure: Sentence Fragments**

A sentence fragment is an incomplete sentence that lacks a subject, a verb, or fails to express a complete thought, often appearing as a dependent clause standing alone.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often employ 'The Illusion of Length.' By adding multiple prepositional phrases, complex modifiers, and sophisticated vocabulary to a subordinate clause, they make the fragment appear like a complete, weighty sentence, tricking the candidate into overlooking the absence of a main independent clause.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

A grammatically complete sentence must satisfy three criteria: it must contain a subject, a finite verb, and express a complete thought (an independent clause). A sentence fragment is a group of words that is punctuated as a sentence but fails to meet these criteria. In high-level competitive exams, fragments most commonly manifest as 'Dependent Clause Fragments.' This occurs when a subordinate clause—introduced by subordinating conjunctions such as 'Although,' 'Because,' 'Since,' 'While,' or 'Whereas'—is detached from the main clause and presented as a standalone sentence. Because a dependent clause cannot stand alone, it remains a fragment until it is attached to an independent clause.

>> A grammatically complete sentence must satisfy three core criteria: it must contain a subject, a finite verb, and express a complete thought (forming an independent clause).

>> A sentence fragment occurs when a group of words is punctuated as a sentence but fails to meet one or more of the above criteria.

>> The most common error in competitive exams is the 'Dependent Clause Fragment,' where a subordinate clause—introduced by conjunctions like 'Although,' 'Because,' 'Since,' 'While,' or 'Whereas'—is detached from the main clause.

>> A dependent clause cannot stand alone as a sentence because it leaves the reader expecting further information to complete the thought.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Despite the sudden surge in global temperatures and erratic rainfall patterns.

OK CORRECT

Despite the sudden surge in global temperatures and erratic rainfall patterns, the region's agricultural output remained stable.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The strategic initiative which was implemented by the board of directors has yielded an unprecedented increase in quarterly dividends.

OK CORRECT

The strategic initiative that was implemented by the board of directors has yielded an unprecedented increase in quarterly dividends.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

While the judiciary has consistently upheld the fundamental rights of citizens against arbitrary state action through various landmark judgments over the last decade.

OK CORRECT

While the judiciary has consistently upheld the fundamental rights of citizens against arbitrary state action through various landmark judgments over the last decade, the actual implementation of these rulings at the grassroots level remains sluggish.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Elliptical constructions, where the subject or verb is omitted because it is implied by the context, are permissible in informal dialogue or literary prose; however, these are strictly categorized as errors in formal examinations like SBI PO or SSC CGL.

**PRO-TIP**

Tip: Whenever a sentence begins with a subordinating conjunction (e.g., 'Provided that', 'Whereas', 'Inasmuch as'), scan the sentence for a comma followed by a subject-verb pair. If the sentence ends with a full stop before an independent clause is introduced, you have identified a fragment.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the segment containing the error: (A) The municipal corporation has initiated a comprehensive waste management project / (B) to mitigate the growing landfill crisis in the metropolis / (C) Since the objective is to achieve a zero-waste city / (D) by the end of the current fiscal year. / (E) No Error



RULE 112

Importance: 75/100

Pronouns: 'Each other' vs. 'One another'

'Each other' is used when referring to two people or things, while 'one another' is used when referring to more than two.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often embed the reciprocal pronoun within complex sentences containing multiple nouns to distract the candidate. They may use a collective noun (e.g., 'The committee', 'The panel') which implies more than two people, but then incorrectly pair it with 'each other' to test your ability to identify the plural nature of the subject.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Reciprocal pronouns are employed to indicate that two or more subjects are performing the same action toward one another. According to traditional English grammar conventions (as established by Wren & Martin), a strict distinction is maintained based on number: 'each other' is used exclusively when referring to two persons or things (dual number), whereas 'one another' is used when referring to more than two persons or things (plural number). In high-stakes competitive exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL, this distinction is frequently tested in Error Spotting and Sentence Improvement sections to evaluate the candidate's precision in pronoun usage.

>> Reciprocal pronouns are employed to indicate that two or more subjects are performing the same action toward one another.

>> Use 'each other' exclusively when the action is mutual between exactly two persons or entities (Dual Number).

>> Use 'one another' when the action is mutual among three or more persons or entities (Plural Number).

>> In high-stakes competitive exams, strict adherence to this numerical distinction is required, regardless of contemporary colloquial usage.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The two signatory nations of the climate accord disagreed with one another regarding the carbon emission deadlines.

OK CORRECT

The two signatory nations of the climate accord disagreed with each other regarding the carbon emission deadlines.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The central bank maintained its stance on interest rates despite the mounting inflationary pressures.

OK CORRECT

The central bank maintained its stance on interest rates despite the mounting inflationary pressures.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Throughout the Cold War, the various member states of the Warsaw Pact relied upon each other for ideological and military support.

OK CORRECT

Throughout the Cold War, the various member states of the Warsaw Pact relied upon one another for ideological and military support.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While contemporary colloquial English often treats these as interchangeable, competitive examinations strictly adhere to the traditional dual vs.

>> plural distinction.

>> No structural exceptions exist within the framework of formal grammar.

PRO-TIP



Tip: To ensure accuracy, immediately identify the quantifier. If you see 'both', 'two', 'a pair', or 'the duo', use 'each other'. If you encounter 'several', 'many', 'diverse', or a specific number greater than two, use 'one another'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: The diverse architectural frameworks of the competing Large Language Models were analyzed by the researchers to determine how they optimize weights relative to _____ to enhance inference speed. (Fill in the blank: each other / one another)



RULE 113

Importance: 75/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Further' vs. 'Farther'

'Farther' refers to physical distance. 'Further' refers to additional or abstract extent, meaning 'more' or 'to a greater degree'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often use words associated with 'movement'—such as 'proceeding', 'advancing', or 'progressing'—in an abstract sense (e.g., 'proceeding with an investigation'). This tempts students to use 'farther' because they associate movement with physical distance, whereas these contexts actually require 'further'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Both 'farther' and 'further' serve as comparative forms of the adjective/adverb 'far'. However, in formal English and standard competitive examinations, a strict distinction is maintained based on the nature of the distance being described. 'Farther' is used exclusively to denote physical, linear, or measurable distance (e.g., distance in kilometers or miles). Conversely, 'Further' is employed to describe abstract distance, degree, time, or to signify 'additional' or 'more'. While 'further' is occasionally used for physical distance in colloquial speech, the rigorous standards of SBI PO and SSC CGL mandate the use of 'farther' for spatial distance and 'further' for metaphorical or additive extensions.

>> Use 'farther' exclusively to denote physical, linear, or measurable spatial distance (e.g., distance measured in kilometers, miles, or light-years).

>> Use 'further' to describe abstract distance, a higher degree of intensity, or to signify 'additional' or 'more'.

>> In formal academic and competitive examination contexts, these two terms are not interchangeable; the distinction between tangible distance and metaphorical extension must be strictly maintained.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The migratory patterns of the Arctic tern extend further than those of any other bird species.

OK CORRECT

The migratory patterns of the Arctic tern extend farther than those of any other bird species.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The strategic alliance was forged among India, Japan, and Australia to maintain a free and open Indo-Pacific.

OK CORRECT

The strategic alliance was forged between India, Japan, and Australia to maintain a free and open Indo-Pacific.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy sought to push the negotiations farther to ensure a comprehensive peace treaty was ratified by all sovereign states.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy sought to push the negotiations further to ensure a comprehensive peace treaty was ratified by all sovereign states.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While contemporary informal English frequently uses 'further' as a universal substitute for both meanings, such usage is penalized in competitive examinations like SBI PO and SSC CGL.

>> There are no other standard exceptions.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Substitution Test': If the word can be replaced by 'additional' or 'more' without altering the meaning, 'further' is the correct choice. If the distance can be measured by a physical instrument like a GPS, odometer, or ruler, 'farther' is mandatory.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: The scientific community believes that the deep-space probe must travel _____ into the Oort Cloud to retrieve viable interstellar data.

RULE 114

Importance: 75/100

Verbs: Sit vs. Set

'Sit' (intransitive) means to take a seat (sit, sat, sat). 'Set' (transitive) means to place something (set, set, set).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently exploit the fact that 'set' remains the same in present and past forms, attempting to lure candidates into using it to describe a person's posture in the past tense (where 'sat' is required). They may also use complex sentence structures where the direct object of 'set' is placed far from the verb to confuse the reader into thinking the verb is intransitive.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The distinction between 'Sit' and 'Set' is fundamentally rooted in the grammatical concept of transitivity. 'Sit' is an intransitive verb, meaning it does not require a direct object to complete its meaning; it describes the action of the subject placing themselves in a seated position or remaining in a seated posture. Its principal parts are sit (present), sat (past), and sat (past participle). In contrast, 'Set' is a transitive verb, which necessitates a direct object. It means to place, put, or position something in a specific location. Its principal parts are set (present), set (past), and set (past participle). In high-level competitive exams, errors frequently arise in the past tense, where 'sat' is erroneously used to describe placing an object, or 'set' is used to describe the subject's posture.

- >> 'Sit' is an intransitive verb, meaning it does not require a direct object to complete its meaning.
- >> Use 'Sit' to describe the action of a subject placing themselves in a seated position or remaining in a seated posture.
- >> The principal parts of 'Sit' are: sit (present), sat (past), and sat (past participle).
- >> 'Set' is a transitive verb, which necessitates a direct object (the thing being placed).
- >> Use 'Set' when the action involves placing, putting, or positioning an object in a specific location.
- >> The principal parts of 'Set' are: set (present), set (past), and set (past participle).

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The historian set in the archives for hours, researching the dynasty.

OK CORRECT

The historian sat in the archives for hours, researching the dynasty.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

Unless the administration does not adopt a more transparent approach, the public outcry will persist.

OK CORRECT

Unless the administration adopts a more transparent approach, the public outcry will persist.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

After the heated debate on climate policy, the delegates set in silence, contemplating the implications of the proposed accord.

OK CORRECT

After the heated debate on climate policy, the delegates sat in silence, contemplating the implications of the proposed accord.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The verb 'set' can function intransitively in specific idiomatic or natural contexts, most notably regarding celestial bodies (e.g., 'The sun sets in the west'), where it denotes sinking or descending rather than the act of placing an object.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Object Test': Ask 'Set what?'. If the sentence provides a logical direct object (e.g., 'Set the documents on the table' → documents), use 'Set'. If the action describes the subject's own position and no external object is being manipulated, use 'Sit'. Remember: You sit yourself, but you set an object.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error: The specialized sensor (A) / set on the seabed (B) / for three months (C) / monitoring seismic activity (D) / No Error (E).



RULE 115

Importance: 70/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Titles/Phrases as Subjects

Titles of books, names of countries, or phrases acting as a single concept, even if plural in form, take a singular verb.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often insert long appositive phrases or prepositional modifiers containing plural nouns between the singular title/entity and the verb to mislead the candidate into choosing a plural verb based on proximity.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

According to traditional grammatical conventions, when a subject consists of the title of a book, a movie, a musical composition, or the name of a country/organization, it is treated as a singular entity. This holds true even if the title contains a plural noun. Similarly, when two nouns are joined by 'and' but represent a single combined concept, a single idea, or a collective unit (e.g., 'Slow and steady', 'Bread and butter' when referring to livelihood), the subject is regarded as singular and must be followed by a singular verb. The governing principle is that the conceptual unity of the subject outweighs its morphological plurality.

- >> Titles of literary works, movies, musical compositions, or artworks are treated as singular entities, regardless of any plural nouns present within the title.
- >> Proper nouns representing countries, states, or international organizations (e.g., The United Arab Emirates, The Philippines) require a singular verb.
- >> When two nouns are joined by 'and' but represent a single combined concept, a specific dish, or a collective livelihood, the subject is regarded as singular.
- >> The grammatical priority is given to the conceptual unity of the subject rather than its morphological plural form.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The Wealth of Nations are considered a foundational text in classical economics.

OK CORRECT

The Wealth of Nations is considered a foundational text in classical economics.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy avoided to comment on the escalating tensions between the two sovereign nations to maintain neutrality.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy avoided commenting on the escalating tensions between the two sovereign nations to maintain neutrality.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The United Nations Environmental Programme, despite facing significant bureaucratic hurdles and fluctuating funding, have struggled to implement the global biodiversity treaty effectively.

OK CORRECT

The United Nations Environmental Programme, despite facing significant bureaucratic hurdles and fluctuating funding, has struggled to implement the global biodiversity treaty effectively.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> If the nouns joined by 'and' are intended to be viewed as separate, distinct entities rather than a single combined concept, a plural verb must be used.
- >> For example, 'Bread and butter are sold separately in the organic section' treats the items as individual commodities rather than a single meal or livelihood.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Whenever you encounter a subject starting with 'The' followed by a plural-sounding name (e.g., The Canterbury Tales, The United States), ignore the plural suffix and identify the 'Conceptual Unit'. If it represents one single entity, one book, or one nation, always opt for the singular verb.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The United States of America (A)/ have consistently advocated (B)/ for a multilateral approach (C)/ to global security (D)/ No Error (E).'



RULE 116

Importance: 70/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: 'The + Adjective' for a Class

When 'the' is used with an adjective to refer to a whole class of people (e.g., 'the rich', 'the poor'), it takes a plural verb.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently insert a singular noun within a prepositional phrase or a modifying clause—such as 'the government', 'the administration', or 'the committee'—immediately before the verb. This lures the candidate into a 'proximity error,' where they mistakenly match the verb to the nearest singular noun instead of the actual plural subject ('The + Adjective').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, when the definite article 'the' is prefixed to an adjective to denote a collective group or a specific class of persons possessing a particular characteristic, the resulting phrase functions as a plural noun (referred to as a nominal adjective). Although the phrase lacks an explicit plural noun such as 'people' or 'citizens', the subject is conceptually plural and therefore mandates a plural verb. This construction is a staple in academic and administrative writing to describe socio-economic categories.

>> When the definite article 'the' is prefixed to an adjective to denote a collective group or a specific class of persons, it functions as a nominal adjective.

>> Despite the absence of an explicit plural noun (like 'people' or 'citizens'), the subject is conceptually plural.

>> A plural verb must be used to maintain grammatical agreement with the implied collective group.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The elderly is often overlooked in the design of modern urban infrastructure.

OK CORRECT

The elderly are often overlooked in the design of modern urban infrastructure.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy noted that much grievances had been overlooked during the preliminary negotiations.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy noted that many grievances had been overlooked during the preliminary negotiations.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The displaced, having lost their ancestral lands to rising sea levels, is now seeking asylum in neighboring territories under international law.

OK CORRECT

The displaced, having lost their ancestral lands to rising sea levels, are now seeking asylum in neighboring territories under international law.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The plural rule applies only when the phrase refers to a class of people.

>> If the adjective is followed by a singular noun (e.g., 'The rich merchant'), the verb must be singular.

>> Additionally, if 'the + adjective' refers to a singular abstract quality rather than a group of people (e.g., 'The unknown is often terrifying'), a singular verb is used.

PRO-TIP

Tip: To avoid errors in complex sentences, mentally replace the 'The + Adjective' phrase with 'The group of people who are...' If the sentence still makes sense with a plural verb, your identification of the nominal adjective is correct. Always isolate the core subject from intervening modifiers.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: The digitally illiterate, despite the widespread availability of low-cost smartphones and subsidized data plans, _____ (remains/remain) largely excluded from essential e-governance services.



RULE 117

Importance: 70/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Paired Items ('Scissors', 'Trousers')

Nouns like 'scissors', 'trousers', 'spectacles', 'pants' are always plural and take a plural verb, unless preceded by 'a pair of', in which case the verb is singular.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently insert complex modifiers, such as relative clauses ('which were used by...') or long prepositional phrases, between 'a pair of' and the verb. This creates a 'proximity error' where the candidate instinctively matches the verb with the nearest plural noun instead of the actual singular subject, 'pair'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Certain nouns in English refer to objects that consist of two symmetrical parts joined together, such as scissors, trousers, pants, spectacles, pliers, and binoculars. In grammatical terms, these are treated as plural nouns and must be accompanied by a plural verb. However, when these nouns are modified by the phrase 'a pair of', the grammatical focus shifts from the individual parts to the single unit (the pair). Consequently, the subject becomes 'pair' (singular), and the verb must be singular to maintain agreement.

>> Nouns that consist of two symmetrical parts joined together (e.g., scissors, binoculars, pliers, trousers, spectacles) are treated as grammatically plural.

>> When these nouns are used as the subject without a quantifying phrase, they must be accompanied by a plural verb.

>> When the phrase 'a pair of' precedes these nouns, the word 'pair' becomes the grammatical head of the subject phrase.

>> Since 'pair' is singular, the verb must be singular to maintain subject-verb agreement, regardless of the plural noun that follows it.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The industrial pliers is required for this assembly task.

OK CORRECT

The industrial pliers are required for this assembly task.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy negotiated the treaty good, ensuring a mutually beneficial agreement for both sovereign nations.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy negotiated the treaty well, ensuring a mutually beneficial agreement for both sovereign nations.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

A pair of vintage spectacles, discovered during the excavation of the ancient library, offer a glimpse into the optical technology of the era.

OK CORRECT

A pair of vintage spectacles, discovered during the excavation of the ancient library, offers a glimpse into the optical technology of the era.

EXCEPTIONS

>> If the phrase 'pairs of' (plural) is used, the verb must remain plural.

>> For example: 'Multiple pairs of binoculars were distributed to the naval surveillance team.'

PRO-TIP

Tip: Employ the 'Core Subject Isolation' technique: mentally bracket the 'of [plural noun]' part and any intervening descriptive phrases. If the sentence simplifies to 'A pair... is/are', the correct choice is always 'is'.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'A pair of high-precision calipers, essential for measuring the minute thickness of the semiconductor wafer, have been misplaced in the laboratory.'

RULE 118

Importance: 70/100

Tenses: 'Would rather/sooner'

When expressing a preference for someone else's action, 'would rather/sooner' is followed by a subject and a verb in the simple past tense.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Natural Sound' Trap: Examiners often use the present tense or a modal verb (like 'should') after a subject change because it sounds colloquially correct. In competitive exams, however, this is a grammatical error. The presence of a new subject after 'would rather' is a trigger to look for the Simple Past verb.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, when 'would rather' or 'would sooner' is used to express a preference regarding the action of another person (i.e., there is a change of subject between the main clause and the subordinate clause), the verb in the subordinate clause must be in the Simple Past tense. This is an application of the subjunctive mood, used to denote a hypothetical preference or a wish for a different state of affairs. Despite the use of the past tense form, the sense of the sentence remains present or future. If the subject remains the same, the bare infinitive is used; however, for a change of subject, the Simple Past is mandatory.

>> When 'would rather' or 'would sooner' is used to express a preference regarding the action of another person (resulting in a change of subject), the verb in the subordinate clause must be in the Simple Past tense.

>> This structure utilizes the subjunctive mood to denote a hypothetical preference or a wish for a specific state of affairs.

>> Although the Simple Past form is used, the temporal sense of the sentence remains grounded in the present or future.

>> Crucially, if the subject remains the same across both clauses, the bare infinitive (verb without 'to') is used instead of the past tense.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The environmentalist would rather the city council implement stricter emissions standards.

OK CORRECT

The environmentalist would rather the city council implemented stricter emissions standards.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The seasoned diplomat stepped in the conference hall to address the delegates of the G20 summit.

OK CORRECT

The seasoned diplomat stepped into the conference hall to address the delegates of the G20 summit.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The constitutional bench would rather the legislature enact a more comprehensive privacy law to safeguard citizen data before the next judicial review.

OK CORRECT

The constitutional bench would rather the legislature enacted a more comprehensive privacy law to safeguard citizen data before the next judicial review.

EXCEPTIONS

>> 1.

>> Same Subject: If the subject of 'would rather' and the subsequent action are the same, use the bare infinitive (e.g., 'The lead scientist would rather delay the launch than risk a catastrophic failure').

>> 2.

>> Past Preferences: To express a preference about a past action that cannot be altered, the Past Perfect tense is used (e.g., 'The diplomatic corps would rather the envoy had exercised more discretion during the summit last month').

**PRO-TIP**

Tip: Develop a 'Subject-Gap' reflex. Whenever you encounter 'would rather' in an Error Spotting question, immediately check if there is a second subject. If [Subject A] + [would rather] + [Subject B] appears, the verb must be in the past tense. If there is no [Subject B], ensure the verb is a bare infinitive.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The archaeological society would rather the curator restore the ancient frescoes using organic solvents to prevent permanent degradation.'

RULE 119

Importance: 70/100

Pronouns: Relative Pronoun 'Whose'

'Whose' is a possessive relative pronoun used for both people and things, indicating ownership or association.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most common trap is the phonetic similarity between 'whose' (possessive) and 'who's' (contraction of 'who is' or 'who has'). Examiners frequently substitute the contraction for the possessive in complex sentences to mislead candidates.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The relative pronoun 'whose' is the possessive form of 'who' and 'which'. It is employed to introduce a relative clause that indicates ownership, possession, or a specific association with the antecedent. While primarily used for persons, 'whose' is also grammatically acceptable for inanimate objects, animals, and abstract concepts to avoid the cumbersome 'of which' construction. In a sentence, 'whose' always precedes a noun that belongs to or is associated with the antecedent, functioning as a determiner within the relative clause.

- >> Functions as the possessive form of the relative pronouns 'who' and 'which'.
- >> Introduces a relative clause that specifies ownership, possession, or a direct association with the preceding antecedent.
- >> Used for animate beings (people and animals) as well as inanimate objects and abstract concepts.
- >> Serves as a determiner within the relative clause and must immediately precede the noun it modifies.
- >> Acts as a more concise and fluid alternative to the 'of which' construction when referring to non-human entities.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The activist, who's research on urban poverty gained international acclaim, was awarded a fellowship.

OK CORRECT

The activist, whose research on urban poverty gained international acclaim, was awarded a fellowship.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The ambassador is currently stationed in the consulate at New York.

OK CORRECT

The ambassador is currently stationed at the consulate in New York.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The sophisticated quantum computing architecture, who's processing capabilities exceed classical limits, is currently being tested by the national laboratory.

OK CORRECT

The sophisticated quantum computing architecture, whose processing capabilities exceed classical limits, is currently being tested by the national laboratory.

EXCEPTIONS

>> While 'whose' is widely accepted for non-humans in modern English, some strict traditionalists prefer the use of 'of which' for inanimate objects (e.g., 'The treaty, the terms of which were contested...').

>> However, in competitive exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL, 'whose' is recognized as grammatically correct for both animate and inanimate antecedents.

PRO-TIP

Tip: To verify correctness, apply the 'Substitution Test': replace the word with 'who is' or 'who has'. If the sentence becomes logically incoherent, the contraction 'who's' is incorrect, and the possessive 'whose' must be used.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Magna Carta, who's principles laid the foundational groundwork for modern constitutional law, was signed in 1215 at Runnymede.'

RULE 120

Importance: 70/100

Pronouns: After 'Let'

Pronouns immediately following the verb 'let' should always be in the objective case (e.g., 'Let him go', 'Let us try').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often insert a relative clause immediately after the pronoun (e.g., 'let he who...'). This tricks the candidate into thinking the pronoun is the subject of the relative clause, prompting them to incorrectly use the subjective case ('he') instead of the objective case ('him').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, the verb 'let' is a causative verb. According to the fundamental rules of case, the object of any verb must be in the objective case (also known as the accusative case). Therefore, any pronoun that immediately follows 'let' must be in the objective case (e.g., me, us, him, her, them, whom), regardless of whether that pronoun serves as the logical subject of the subsequent infinitive verb. This is a frequent trap in competitive examinations like SBI PO and SSC CGL, where the subjective case (I, we, he, she, they) is erroneously used in place of the objective case.

- >> Identify the verb 'let' when used as a causative or permissive verb.
- >> Ensure that any pronoun immediately following 'let' is in the objective case (e.g., me, us, him, her, them, whom).
- >> Maintain the objective case even if the pronoun serves as the logical subject of a subsequent infinitive verb.
- >> Avoid using the subjective case (e.g., I, we, he, she, they) in the object position of the verb 'let'.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

Let I present the findings of the environmental impact assessment.

OK CORRECT

Let me present the findings of the environmental impact assessment.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The diplomatic envoy is expected to arrive in 0600 hours at the winter of 2025.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy is expected to arrive at 0600 hours in the winter of 2025.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

In the interest of constitutional propriety, let he who is appointed as the interim ombudsman oversee the investigation into the municipal irregularities.

OK CORRECT

In the interest of constitutional propriety, let him who is appointed as the interim ombudsman oversee the investigation into the municipal irregularities.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> No major exceptions.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Regardless of the complexity of the sentence or the length of the phrase following the pronoun, always prioritize the grammatical requirement of the verb 'let'. Since 'let' is a transitive verb, it must be followed by an object; therefore, the objective case is mandatory.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'To prevent any bias in the selection of the new Chief Justice, the committee suggested that let they who have a documented conflict of interest recuse themselves from the voting process.'

RULE 121

Importance: 70/100

Prepositions: 'Die off/from'

'Die of' is used for diseases (e.g., 'die of cancer'). 'Die from' is used for other causes (e.g., 'die from an accident', 'die from hunger').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often use nouns that seem medical but are actually situational, such as 'injuries', 'exhaustion', or 'complications'. For instance, 'died of injuries' is a common error; it must be 'died from injuries' because an injury is an external trauma, not a disease.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar and competitive examinations, the distinction between 'die of' and 'die from' is based on the nature of the cause of death. 'Die of' is used when the cause is a direct internal factor, specifically a disease (e.g., tuberculosis, malaria, cancer) or a profound emotion (e.g., grief, heartbreak). In contrast, 'Die from' is employed when the cause is an indirect or external factor, such as an accident, a wound, overwork, starvation, or exposure to extreme weather. A simple mnemonic for aspirants: Internal/Clinical cause = 'of'; External/Situational cause = 'from'.

- >> Use 'die of' when the cause of death is a direct internal factor, specifically a clinical disease or a medical diagnosis (e.g., leukemia, cardiac arrest).
- >> Use 'die of' when the cause is a profound internal emotional state, such as grief, heartbreak, or shame.
- >> Use 'die from' when the cause is an external or indirect factor, such as an accident, physical injury, or environmental exposure.
- >> Use 'die from' for situational causes including starvation, exhaustion, or complications arising from a particular event.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The elderly patient died from a sudden heart attack.

OK CORRECT

The elderly patient died of a sudden heart attack.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The ancient sculpture was meticulously restored by a precision laser.

OK CORRECT

The ancient sculpture was meticulously restored with a precision laser.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

Archaeological evidence suggests that the ancient civilization's leaders died of prolonged famine and severe drought.

OK CORRECT

Archaeological evidence suggests that the ancient civilization's leaders died from prolonged famine and severe drought.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Distinct from this rule are 'die for' (used when sacrificing one's life for a cause or country, e.g., 'The soldiers died for the sovereignty of their nation') and 'die away' (used when a sound gradually fades into silence).

PRO-TIP

Tip: To differentiate quickly, ask: 'Is this a diagnosis from a doctor (Clinical) or a result of a circumstance (Situational)?' Clinical diagnosis \$ \rightarrow \$ 'of'; Situational result \$ \rightarrow \$ 'from'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Despite the advanced medical intervention available at the facility, the diplomat eventually died ____ the complications arising from the surgical procedure. (Fill in the blank)



RULE 122

Importance: 70/100

Nouns: Compound Nouns (Pluralization)

For compound nouns, the plural is usually formed by adding 's' to the main word (e.g., 'mothers-in-law', 'passers-by').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently place the plural suffix on the terminal word of a prepositional phrase (e.g., using 'brothers-in-laws' instead of 'brothers-in-law'). They rely on the candidate's auditory instinct to pluralize the end of the word group rather than identifying the semantic head.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

A compound noun is a noun made up of two or more words acting as a single semantic unit. According to traditional English grammar (Wren & Martin), the plural of a compound noun is formed by adding the plural suffix ('s' or 'es') to the principal word—also known as the 'head word'—which carries the primary meaning of the compound. If the compound noun is composed of a noun and a modifying phrase (such as a prepositional phrase), the noun is pluralized, while the modifier remains singular. For example, in the term 'editor-in-chief', the core entity is the 'editor', making the plural 'editors-in-chief'.

- >> Identify the 'head word' or 'principal word'—the core noun that defines the identity of the compound.
- >> Attach the plural suffix ('-s' or '-es') exclusively to this principal word.
- >> Maintain the singular form for all modifiers, including adjectives or prepositional phrases that follow the head word.
- >> In compounds where no single word dominates or the entity is viewed as a single cohesive unit, pluralize the final element.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The legal proceedings required the testimonies of several attorney-generals from different jurisdictions.

OK CORRECT

The legal proceedings required the testimonies of several attorneys-general from different jurisdictions.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The geopolitical tensions were such acute that the diplomatic envoy decided to postpone the summit indefinitely.

OK CORRECT

The geopolitical tensions were so acute that the diplomatic envoy decided to postpone the summit indefinitely.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

Historical records indicate that multiple court-martials were convened to address the insubordination within the naval ranks.

OK CORRECT

Historical records indicate that multiple courts-martial were convened to address the insubordination within the naval ranks.

EXCEPTIONS

>> 1.

>> For compound nouns lacking a distinct head word or treated as a single semantic unit, the plural suffix is added to the end (e.g., 'cupful' becomes 'cupfuls', 'handful' becomes 'handfuls').

>> 2.

>> In compounds consisting of an adjective and a noun, only the noun is pluralized (e.g., 'full moon' becomes 'full moons').

PRO-TIP



Tip: Apply the 'Counting Logic' test: Ask yourself, 'What is actually being counted?' You are counting 'passers', not 'bys'; you are counting 'courts', not 'martials'. Pluralize the essence, not the modifier.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The diplomatic envoy noted that the various governor-generals of the Commonwealth had divergent views on the proposed trade treaty.'



RULE 123

Importance: 70/100

Nouns: Nouns Used as Adjectives

When a noun modifies another noun, it acts as an adjective and remains in its singular form, especially in hyphenated compound adjectives (e.g., 'a ten-year-old boy', 'a five-star hotel').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often insert a plural noun within a hyphenated modifier (e.g., 'a five-miles radius') to tempt candidates into matching the noun to the plural number, distracting them from the fact that the entire phrase is modifying a subsequent noun.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, when a noun is employed to modify another noun, it functions as an adjective (often termed an 'attributive noun'). A critical convention in competitive examinations is that such nouns—particularly when they form part of a hyphenated compound adjective—must remain in the singular form, regardless of the numerical value that precedes them. For example, in the phrase 'a ten-page document,' the word 'page' is a noun acting as an adjective for 'document'; therefore, it cannot be pluralized. This rule is frequently tested to distinguish between a compound adjective and a possessive construction (e.g., 'a ten-page report' vs. 'ten pages of the report').

>> When a noun is used to modify another noun, it functions as an 'attributive noun' and behaves like an adjective.

>> In hyphenated compound adjectives composed of a number and a noun, the noun must always remain in the singular form, regardless of the numerical value preceding it.

>> This rule applies when the compound phrase describes the quality or type of the subsequent noun rather than indicating possession.

>> The structure differs from possessive constructions (e.g., 'a ten-day trip' vs. 'ten days' worth of travel').

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The laboratory technician conducted a two-hours experiment to observe the chemical reaction.

OK CORRECT

The laboratory technician conducted a two-hour experiment to observe the chemical reaction.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The exhausted diplomat laid on the sofa for an hour after the grueling summit concluded.

OK CORRECT

The exhausted diplomat lay on the sofa for an hour after the grueling summit concluded.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislative body proposed a twenty-years plan to overhaul the national healthcare infrastructure and reduce rural disparity.

OK CORRECT

The legislative body proposed a twenty-year plan to overhaul the national healthcare infrastructure and reduce rural disparity.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain nouns that are inherently plural or lack a singular form (e.g., 'sports car', 'arms race', 'clothes brush') retain their plural form even when acting as adjectives.

>> Additionally, this rule does not apply to possessive cases (e.g., 'two weeks' notice' is correct because it denotes possession, not a compound adjective).

PRO-TIP

Tip: Identify the 'Head Noun' (the main person, place, or thing being described). If the number-noun combination immediately precedes the Head Noun, it is a compound adjective and must be singular. If the phrase is followed by 'of' (e.g., 'a period of five years'), the noun is no longer an adjective and must be plural.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The urban planning committee suggested a six-months moratorium on the construction of high-rise buildings in the coastal zone.'



RULE 124

Importance: 70/100

Pronouns: Possessive Pronouns vs. Possessive Adjectives

Possessive pronouns (mine, yours, his, hers, its, ours, theirs) stand alone, while possessive adjectives (my, your, his, her, its, our, their) modify a noun.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently place a possessive adjective (like 'their' or 'our') at the end of a long, complex sentence or clause. Because the noun it refers to is far back in the sentence, the candidate may overlook the fact that a standalone possessive pronoun (theirs/ours) is required.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, possession is indicated by two distinct categories of words: Possessive Adjectives and Possessive Pronouns. Although they share the same semantic meaning of ownership, their syntactic functions are fundamentally different. 1. Possessive Adjectives (my, your, his, her, its, our, their): These function as determiners. They cannot stand alone and must always be followed by a noun which they modify. For example, in 'my portfolio,' 'my' describes the portfolio. 2. Possessive Pronouns (mine, yours, his, hers, its, ours, theirs): These function as nominals (nouns). They replace the entire noun phrase (Possessive Adjective + Noun) to avoid redundancy. For example, instead of saying 'This is my portfolio,' one says 'This is mine.' A critical error in competitive exams is the interchange of these two, such as using a possessive adjective where a pronoun is required, or vice versa.

>> Possessive Adjectives (my, your, his, her, its, our, their) function as determiners and must always be immediately followed by a noun (e.g., 'their mandate').

>> Possessive Pronouns (mine, yours, his, hers, its, ours, theirs) function as nominals and replace a noun phrase to avoid repetition (e.g., 'the mandate is theirs').

>> A possessive adjective cannot stand alone as the subject or object of a sentence; it requires a noun to complete its meaning.

>> A possessive pronoun essentially incorporates both the possessive adjective and the noun it refers to (Possessive Pronoun = Possessive Adjective + Noun).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The responsibility for the project's failure is their.

OK CORRECT

The responsibility for the project's failure is theirs.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The Monetary Policy Committee decided to rise the benchmark interest rates to mitigate the risks of surging inflation.

OK CORRECT

The Monetary Policy Committee decided to raise the benchmark interest rates to mitigate the risks of surging inflation.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

While the Ministry of External Affairs claimed the diplomatic victory was our, the Prime Minister's Office insisted the credit be shared among all stakeholders.

OK CORRECT

While the Ministry of External Affairs claimed the diplomatic victory was ours, the Prime Minister's Office insisted the credit be shared among all stakeholders.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The word 'its' is predominantly used as a possessive adjective.

>> While grammatically possible as a possessive pronoun, it is extremely rare in modern standard English and is typically avoided in formal writing to prevent confusion with the contraction 'it's'.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Always check for a noun following the possessive word. If there is no noun, you must use the pronoun form. Additionally, remember that possessive pronouns never take apostrophes; forms like 'your's', 'their's', or 'her's' are fundamentally incorrect.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead scientists at the CERN facility argued that the discovery of the Higgs boson was their, although the global collaboration played a pivotal role.'



RULE 125

Importance: 70/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Elder' vs. 'Older'

'Elder' and 'eldest' are used for family members and usually refer to age within a family. 'Older' and 'oldest' are used for age in general, for people or things.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often employ a 'bait-and-switch' tactic where they use 'elder' correctly as an attribute (e.g., 'the elder brother') in the first clause, then sneakily pair it with 'than' in the second clause to test if the candidate is paying attention to the comparative structure.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, 'elder' and 'eldest' are reserved exclusively for members of the same family. They function as adjectives of comparison but are primarily used attributively (placed before the noun). A critical distinction for competitive examinations is that 'elder' cannot be followed by the conjunction 'than'. Conversely, 'older' and 'oldest' are used for general comparisons of age involving any people, animals, or inanimate objects. Unlike 'elder', 'older' is the standard comparative form used in constructions involving 'than'.

- >> Reserve 'elder' and 'eldest' exclusively for members of the same family.
- >> Use 'elder' primarily as an attributive adjective, meaning it is placed immediately before the noun it modifies.
- >> Crucially, 'elder' must never be followed by the conjunction 'than'; 'older' is the only permissible form for such comparative constructions.
- >> Utilize 'older' and 'oldest' for all general comparisons of age involving any individuals, animals, or inanimate objects.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The elder sister is elder than the youngest sibling.

OK CORRECT

The elder sister is older than the youngest sibling.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy worked hardly to negotiate a ceasefire between the warring factions.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy worked hard to negotiate a ceasefire between the warring factions.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

While the elder sibling among the research team specialized in glaciology, she is not elder than the lead climatologist of the institute.

OK CORRECT

While the elder sibling among the research team specialized in glaciology, she is not older than the lead climatologist of the institute.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The word 'elder' can be used as a noun to refer to people of greater age or higher rank in a community (e.g., 'One must always respect the elders of the village').

PRO-TIP

Tip: In Error Detection tasks, scan for the word 'than'. If 'elder' precedes it, the sentence is grammatically incorrect regardless of the familial context. Immediate substitution with 'older' is required.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Spot the error in the following sentence: 'The elder daughter of the former Governor, who currently serves as a diplomat, is not elder than the Ambassador to the United Kingdom.'

RULE 126

Importance: 70/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Late' vs. 'Lately'

'Late' can be an adjective (not on time) or an adverb (after the usual time). 'Lately' is an adverb meaning 'recently'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often substitute 'late' with 'lately' in highly formal sentences. They rely on the candidate's instinct to assume that an '-ly' suffix is required for an adverb in a professional context, even when the intended meaning is 'tardy' rather than 'recent'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, 'late' and 'lately' are not interchangeable, as they serve different grammatical functions and carry distinct meanings. 1. 'Late' as an Adjective: It is used to describe a noun, indicating that something is behind schedule or occurs after the expected time (e.g., 'The late train'). 2. 'Late' as an Adverb: It is a 'flat adverb,' meaning it retains the same form as the adjective. It modifies a verb to indicate that an action took place after the appointed time (e.g., 'He arrived late'). 3. 'Lately' as an Adverb: This is an adverb of time meaning 'recently' or 'in the period of time just before now.' It does not refer to punctuality or tardiness, but rather to a recent occurrence. In competitive examinations, 'lately' is almost exclusively used with the Present Perfect or Present Perfect Continuous tense.

>> Use 'late' as an adjective to describe a noun that is behind schedule or occurs after the expected time.

>> Use 'late' as a 'flat adverb' to modify a verb when indicating that an action took place after the appointed time (tardiness).

>> Use 'lately' as an adverb of time to convey the meaning of 'recently' or 'in the period of time just before now'.

>> In formal contexts, 'lately' is typically paired with the Present Perfect or Present Perfect Continuous tense.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The legislative session began lately due to a quorum shortage.

OK CORRECT

The legislative session began late due to a quorum shortage.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The Chief Financial Officer sat besides the CEO during the strategic board meeting to provide real-time fiscal data.

OK CORRECT

The Chief Financial Officer sat beside the CEO during the strategic board meeting to provide real-time fiscal data.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

Despite the urgent nature of the climate summit, the delegation from the island nation arrived lately, missing the critical opening plenary on rising sea levels.

OK CORRECT

Despite the urgent nature of the climate summit, the delegation from the island nation arrived late, missing the critical opening plenary on rising sea levels.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The adjective 'late' is frequently used as a euphemism to refer to a person who has recently deceased (e.g., 'The late Chief Justice's opinions on constitutional law remain influential').

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Recently Test': Replace the word with 'recently'. If the sentence remains logically sound, 'lately' is correct. If the sentence requires a meaning related to punctuality or being behind schedule, 'late' must be used, regardless of whether it functions as an adjective or an adverb.

TEST YOURSELF



Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead astrophysicist has been analyzing the telemetry data from the James Webb Telescope lately, but she submitted the final research paper lately to the peer-review committee.'

RULE 127

Importance: 70/100

Adjectives & Adverbs: 'So...as' vs. 'As...as'

'So...as' is typically used in negative comparisons (e.g., 'not so tall as'). 'As...as' is used in positive comparisons (e.g., 'as tall as').

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often embed 'so...as' within lengthy, sophisticated affirmative sentences to deceive the candidate into believing the formality of the vocabulary justifies the usage, despite the absence of a negative modifier (such as 'not', 'never', or 'hardly').

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, particularly within the framework of traditional competitive examinations, a distinction is made between positive and negative comparisons of equality. The construction 'as + adjective/adverb + as' is used in affirmative (positive) sentences to indicate that two entities possess a quality to the same degree. Conversely, when the comparison is negative (preceded by 'not'), the construction 'not so + adjective/adverb + as' is the preferred and more formal choice. While modern colloquial English frequently uses 'as...as' for both, the strict conventions of SBI PO and SSC CGL prioritize 'so...as' in negative contexts to highlight the disparity between the two subjects.

- >> Employ the construction 'as + adjective/adverb + as' in affirmative sentences to indicate an equal degree of a quality between two entities.
- >> Utilize 'not so + adjective/adverb + as' in negative sentences to denote a lack of equality, prioritizing this form in formal or academic writing.
- >> Strictly avoid using 'so...as' in affirmative statements; it is grammatically incorrect to use 'so' as the first correlative in a positive comparison of equality.
- >> Recognize that while 'not as...as' is widely accepted in contemporary English, 'not so...as' remains the preferred choice for high-stakes competitive examinations like SBI PO and SSC CGL.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The digital archive is so accessible as the physical registry.

OK CORRECT

The digital archive is as accessible as the physical registry.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The diplomatic envoy maintained a stoic expression while the negotiation of the bilateral treaty.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy maintained a stoic expression during the negotiation of the bilateral treaty.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The recently implemented urban planning strategy is so sustainable as the ecological models proposed by the international committee.

OK CORRECT

The recently implemented urban planning strategy is as sustainable as the ecological models proposed by the international committee.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> While 'not as...as' is increasingly accepted in modern usage, 'so...as' can NEVER be used in an affirmative sentence.
- >> Therefore, 'as...as' is versatile (used in both positive and negative), but 'so...as' is restricted exclusively to negative comparisons.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Scan the sentence first for negative markers. If the sentence is affirmative and contains 'so...as', it is a definitive error. In 'Sentence Improvement' questions, if both 'not as...as' and 'not so...as' are options for a negative sentence, select 'not so...as' for maximum formal precision.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: The newly appointed ombudsman is (A) so impartial as (B) his predecessor (C) in handling public grievances (D) No Error.



RULE 128

Importance: 70/100

Modals: 'Should' vs. 'Ought to'

Both 'should' and 'ought to' express advice, recommendation, or mild obligation. 'Ought to' often carries a stronger sense of moral duty or correctness.

EXAMINER TRAP: The most common trap is the omission of 'to' after 'ought' to mimic the structure of 'should', or the erroneous insertion of 'to' after 'should'. Additionally, examiners test the nuance between a personal suggestion (should) and a systemic or moral imperative (ought to).

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Both 'should' and 'ought to' are used to convey advice, recommendation, or obligation, but they differ in nuance and grammatical construction. 'Should' is generally used for subjective advice, personal opinions, or expectations (e.g., 'You should read this report'). 'Ought to', however, carries a stronger connotation of moral obligation, duty, or correctness based on an objective standard, law, or social norm (e.g., 'One ought to respect the law'). Grammatically, 'should' is a modal verb followed by a bare infinitive (verb without 'to'), whereas 'ought' is always followed by the full infinitive 'to' + verb.

- >> Both modals are used to convey advice, recommendations, or mild obligations.
- >> 'Should' is generally employed for subjective advice, personal opinions, or expectations.
- >> 'Ought to' implies a stronger connotation of moral obligation, duty, or correctness based on objective standards, legal frameworks, or social norms.
- >> Grammatically, 'should' is a modal verb followed by a bare infinitive (verb without 'to').
- >> Conversely, 'ought' is strictly followed by the full infinitive ('to' + base verb).

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The administrative staff ought maintain a detailed record of all incoming correspondence.

OK CORRECT

The administrative staff ought to maintain a detailed record of all incoming correspondence.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The two contending candidates for the presidency accused one another of manipulating the electoral data.

OK CORRECT

The two contending candidates for the presidency accused each other of manipulating the electoral data.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

To preserve the integrity of the judicial process, the presiding judge ought ensure that no biased evidence is admitted during the trial.

OK CORRECT

To preserve the integrity of the judicial process, the presiding judge ought to ensure that no biased evidence is admitted during the trial.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In negative constructions, 'ought not to' is used, although 'should not' is more prevalent in modern formal English.

>> In rare, archaic interrogative forms, 'ought' may appear without 'to'; however, for competitive exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL, the 'ought to' structure is the absolute standard.

PRO-TIP

Tip: When encountering an error-spotting question, first verify the structural integrity: 'should' + 'to' is always incorrect, and 'ought' without 'to' is always incorrect. If the structure is sound, apply the 'Moral Compass Test': if the sentence refers to an ethical duty, a legal mandate, or a social standard, 'ought to' is the more precise choice.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: The constitutional body (A) / ought to promoting (B) / transparency and accountability (C) / in public administration. (D) / No Error (E)



RULE 129

Importance: 65/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: Subjects ending in '-ics'

Nouns like 'mathematics', 'physics', 'economics', 'politics', 'ethics' take a singular verb when referring to a subject or field of study, but can take a plural verb if referring to practices or data.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently use words like 'Politics' or 'Ethics' in a personal or practical context (e.g., 'their politics' or 'the ethics of the board') but pair them with a singular verb to trick candidates who believe all '-ics' words are inherently singular because they look like academic subjects.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

Nouns ending in '-ics', such as Mathematics, Physics, Economics, Politics, and Ethics, typically possess a plural form but are singular in meaning when they refer to a branch of study, a science, or a professional field. In such instances, they must be paired with a singular verb. However, when these nouns are used to denote practical applications, specific traits, personal beliefs, or a collection of numerical data (particularly in the case of 'statistics' and 'politics'), they function as plural nouns and require a plural verb.

>> Nouns ending in '-ics' are treated as singular when they denote a branch of knowledge, a science, or a formal professional field of study.

>> These nouns function as plural nouns when they refer to specific practical applications, individual beliefs, personal behaviors, or a collection of numerical data.

>> The grammatical number of the verb is determined by the semantic context—whether the word refers to the discipline as a whole or to the manifestations of that discipline.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

Astrophysics are essential for understanding the expansion of the early universe.

OK CORRECT

Astrophysics is essential for understanding the expansion of the early universe.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The board of directors requested farther deliberation on the merger proposal to mitigate potential financial risks.

OK CORRECT

The board of directors requested further deliberation on the merger proposal to mitigate potential financial risks.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The politics of the regional coalition is deeply rooted in ancestral tribal loyalties and resource disputes.

OK CORRECT

The politics of the regional coalition are deeply rooted in ancestral tribal loyalties and resource disputes.

EXCEPTIONS

>> The term 'Statistics' takes a plural verb when referencing numerical data.

>> 'Politics' becomes plural when referring to political maneuvers or beliefs.

>> 'Ethics' is plural when it refers to a set of moral principles rather than the philosophical study of ethics.

PRO-TIP

Tip: To determine the correct verb, ask yourself: 'Am I talking about a textbook/degree (singular) or a real-world application/set of data (plural)?' If the noun is modified by a possessive adjective like 'his', 'her', or 'their', it almost always indicates the plural sense.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: The statistics regarding the decline of biodiversity in the Amazon rainforest _____ (indicate/indicates) a critical tipping point for the global climate.



RULE 130

Importance: 65/100

Pronouns: Order of Pronouns (Good Manners)

When referring to multiple people in a positive context, the order of pronouns is typically 2nd person, 3rd person, 1st person (you, he/she, I).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often use sophisticated, high-register vocabulary and formal settings (like international summits or legal proceedings) to make the sentence sound authoritative. They place 'I' at the beginning, relying on the candidate's tendency to overlook a modesty rule when the overall tone of the sentence seems professional.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, when multiple pronouns of different persons are used as the subject of a sentence, their sequence is governed by the context of the statement. For positive, neutral, or general contexts, the convention of 'good manners' requires the speaker to place themselves last. The prescribed order is: Second Person (You) → Third Person (He, She, It, They) → First Person (I, We). This sequence (2-3-1) is strictly followed in competitive examinations to test a candidate's grasp of traditional grammatical etiquette.

>> In formal English, when multiple pronouns of different persons serve as the subject, their sequence depends on the context of the statement.

>> For positive, neutral, or general contexts, the 'rule of etiquette' dictates the sequence: Second Person (You) → Third Person (He, She, It, They) → First Person (I, We).

>> This 2-3-1 order is used to show modesty by placing the speaker last.

>> This specific sequence is a frequent testing point in competitive examinations for error spotting and sentence improvement.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

I and you will present the findings of the archaeological survey.

OK CORRECT

You and I will present the findings of the archaeological survey.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The diplomatic envoy set patiently in the waiting lounge while the treaty was being finalized.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy sat patiently in the waiting lounge while the treaty was being finalized.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

I, you, and the Chief Election Commissioner must oversee the integrity of the electronic voting machines to ensure a fair democratic process.

OK CORRECT

You, the Chief Election Commissioner, and I must oversee the integrity of the electronic voting machines to ensure a fair democratic process.

EXCEPTIONS

>> 1.

>> Confessional/Negative Context: When the sentence expresses a mistake, crime, or fault, the order is 1-2-3 (First Person → Second Person → Third Person) to accept primary responsibility.

>> Example: 'I, you, and he are responsible for the failure of the diplomatic mission.'

>> Plural Pronouns: When pronouns are plural, the order is always 1-2-3 (We → You → They), regardless of context.

>> Example: 'We, you, and they must collaborate to mitigate the effects of climate change.'

**PRO-TIP**

Tip: To solve these quickly in an exam, first identify the 'emotional valence' of the verb. If the action is a virtue, a duty, or a routine task, apply the 2-3-1 sequence. If the action is a vice, a lapse, or an error, apply 1-2-3. If the pronouns are plural (We/You/They), disregard the valence and always use 1-2-3.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'I, you, and the Secretary-General are expected to sign the peace treaty during the summit in Brussels.'



RULE 131

Importance: 65/100

Prepositions: 'On' vs. 'Upon'

'On' indicates position on a surface. 'Upon' is often used to indicate movement onto a surface, or in more formal contexts as a synonym for 'on'.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently substitute 'on' for 'upon' before a gerund (e.g., 'On reviewing the files...'). In formal competitive English, 'Upon' is the preferred choice to denote a sequence of events where one action triggers another.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In traditional English grammar, 'On' is primarily used to denote a static position where one object is supported by a surface (e.g., 'The report is on the desk'). 'Upon' is a more formal variant that serves two specific functions: first, it is used to indicate movement or the act of landing onto a surface (dynamic position), and second, it is used as a temporal preposition meaning 'immediately after' an event occurs. While often interchangeable in casual speech, competitive examinations follow the strict convention that 'on' is for static contact and 'upon' is for movement or formal temporal sequences.

- >> Use 'on' to denote a static position where one object is supported by or in contact with a surface.
- >> Use 'upon' to indicate movement, the act of landing, or a dynamic transition onto a surface.
- >> Use 'upon' as a temporal preposition to signify that an action occurs immediately after another event.
- >> Prefer 'upon' in formal, legal, or academic contexts, especially when referring to abstract burdens or responsibilities.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The official memorandum was placed upon the notice board for all employees to see.

OK CORRECT

The official memorandum was placed on the notice board for all employees to see.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Although the strategic blueprint was developed by the consultant, the ultimate intellectual property remains our.

OK CORRECT

Although the strategic blueprint was developed by the consultant, the ultimate intellectual property remains ours.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

On discovering the discrepancy in the archaeological strata, the team paused the excavation to re-evaluate their hypothesis.

OK CORRECT

Upon discovering the discrepancy in the archaeological strata, the team paused the excavation to re-evaluate their hypothesis.

EXCEPTIONS

>> Certain fixed idiomatic expressions require 'upon' regardless of the static or dynamic nature of the sentence, such as 'Once upon a time' or 'to depend upon'.

PRO-TIP

Tip: When you encounter a sentence starting with an '-ing' phrase that implies a chronological trigger (Event A → Event B), look for 'Upon'. If the preposition refers to a physical, stationary location, 'on' is almost always the correct choice.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The weight of the geopolitical tension now rests on the diplomacy of the neutral nations to prevent a full-scale conflict.'

RULE 132
Importance: 65/100
Adjectives & Adverbs: 'Too' vs. 'Very'

'Too' implies an excessive or undesirable degree (negative connotation). 'Very' simply intensifies an adjective or adverb without implying excess.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often place 'very' in a sentence that concludes with a 'to + infinitive' clause. Because the sentence sounds naturally emphatic, students often overlook that 'very' cannot logically lead to a limitation; only 'too' can bridge the gap between a high degree of a quality and the resulting inability to perform an action.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English and competitive examinations, a sharp distinction is drawn between 'very' and 'too'. 'Very' is an intensifier used to emphasize a high degree of a quality, whether positive or negative, without implying any adverse consequence (e.g., 'The report is very detailed'). Conversely, 'too' denotes an excessive degree—meaning 'more than enough' or 'more than is desirable'. It carries a negative connotation, implying that the quality has reached a limit that prevents a certain outcome. This is most frequently tested in the 'too + adjective + to + verb' construction, where 'too' indicates that the intensity of the adjective makes the subsequent action impossible.

>> 'Very' serves as a neutral intensifier used to emphasize a high degree of a quality, whether the attribute is positive, negative, or neutral, without suggesting a failure or adverse result.

>> 'Too' denotes an excessive degree—meaning 'more than is desirable' or 'more than enough'—and inherently carries a negative connotation.

>> In formal English, 'too' is specifically used in the construction 'too + adjective + to + verb' (or 'too... for someone to...'), indicating that the intensity of the adjective prevents the subsequent action from occurring.

>> While 'very' describes a state, 'too' describes a limitation.

EXAMPLES
1. Basic Level
X INCORRECT

The newly discovered exoplanet is too luminous for astronomers to observe its atmospheric composition.

OK CORRECT

The newly discovered exoplanet is very luminous, making it a primary subject for astronomical research.

2. Standard Level
X INCORRECT

The elder son of the magistrate is elder than his younger brother.

OK CORRECT

The elder son of the magistrate has been appointed as the District Attorney.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)
X INCORRECT

The administrative reforms proposed by the committee were very comprehensive for the local government to implement within a single fiscal year.

OK CORRECT

The administrative reforms proposed by the committee were too comprehensive for the local government to implement within a single fiscal year.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In colloquial or informal speech, 'too' is frequently used as a synonym for 'very' to express high praise (e.g., 'This symphony is too beautiful!').

>> However, in competitive exams like SBI PO and SSC CGL, this is grammatically incorrect.

>> Additionally, 'too' can function as an adverb meaning 'also' (e.g., 'The senator attended the summit, and the prime minister did too'), which is independent of the degree of an adjective.

PRO-TIP



Tip: When analyzing 'Sentence Improvement' questions, immediately scan for the 'to + verb' or 'for [noun] + to + verb' structure. If the sentence implies that a certain threshold has been crossed, rendering a result impossible, the modifier must be 'too'. If the sentence is merely describing a high intensity without a consequential limitation, use 'very'.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The computational demands of the neural network were very intensive for the existing server architecture to sustain without overheating.'

RULE 133

Importance: 65/100

Modals: 'Will' vs. 'Shall'

'Will' is generally used for future actions and predictions. 'Shall' is used for formal offers/suggestions (with I/we) or to express strong determination/command (with any subject).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often insert 'will' into sentences that describe constitutional mandates, legal contracts, or bylaws. Since 'will' sounds natural in spoken English, students overlook that 'shall' is required to denote a compulsory legal obligation.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In traditional English grammar, the distinction between 'Will' and 'Shall' is based on person and intent. For simple future assertions, 'Shall' is used with the first person (I, We), while 'Will' is used with the second and third persons (You, He, She, It, They). However, to express determination, a promise, or a threat, these roles are interchanged: 'Will' is used with the first person and 'Shall' with the second/third. Additionally, 'Shall' is the exclusive modal used in interrogative sentences to make formal suggestions or offers (e.g., 'Shall I...?' or 'Shall we...?'). In legal, official, or statutory contexts, 'Shall' is employed with any subject to denote a compulsory obligation or a mandate.

>> For simple future assertions in traditional grammar, 'Shall' is used with the first person (I, We), while 'Will' is used with the second and third persons (You, He, She, It, They).

>> To express determination, a promise, or a threat, the roles are reversed: 'Will' is used with the first person (I, We) and 'Shall' with the second/third person.

>> In interrogative sentences, 'Shall' is the exclusive modal used with 'I' or 'We' to make formal suggestions, offers, or to seek advice.

>> In legal, statutory, or official contexts, 'Shall' is employed regardless of the subject to denote a compulsory obligation, a mandate, or a requirement.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

Will I facilitate the registration process for the incoming delegates?

OK CORRECT

Shall I facilitate the registration process for the incoming delegates?

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

The diplomatic envoy arrived lately for the summit, causing a significant delay in the commencement of the bilateral talks.

OK CORRECT

The diplomatic envoy arrived late for the summit, causing a significant delay in the commencement of the bilateral talks.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The treaty stipulates that the member states will allocate at least two percent of their annual GDP toward the preservation of endangered rainforests.

OK CORRECT

The treaty stipulates that the member states shall allocate at least two percent of their annual GDP toward the preservation of endangered rainforests.

EXCEPTIONS

>> In modern colloquial English, 'will' is frequently used for all persons in the simple future.

>> However, for competitive examinations like SBI PO and SSC CGL, the traditional Wren & Martin distinction—especially regarding suggestions and legal obligations—must be strictly followed.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Apply the 'Mandate vs. Prediction' test: If the sentence describes a legal requirement or a formal command, use 'Shall'. If it is a simple prediction of a future event, use 'Will'. For questions starting with 'I' or 'We' that imply a suggestion, 'Shall' is the only correct choice.

**TEST YOURSELF**

Q: Error Detection: 'The presiding officer will ensure that the quorum is present before the legislative assembly commences the deliberation on the new education policy.' (Identify the modal error).



RULE 134

Importance: 60/100

Subject-Verb Agreement: 'News'

The noun 'news' is always singular and takes a singular verb, despite its 's' ending.

EXAMINER TRAP: The examiner often employs 'Proximity Error' traps by inserting complex prepositional phrases (e.g., 'of the casualties', 'regarding the various sanctions') between the subject 'news' and the verb. The candidate is tempted to match the verb with the nearest plural noun in the phrase rather than the singular subject 'news'.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In English grammar, the noun 'news' is classified as an uncountable (non-count) noun. Despite the presence of the terminal 's', which typically denotes plurality in English nouns, 'news' does not have a plural form and cannot be counted. Consequently, it is treated as a singular entity and must always be paired with a singular verb. This is a frequent trap in competitive examinations where examiners place a plural noun or a complex prepositional phrase between the subject 'news' and the verb to mislead the candidate into using a plural verb.

- >> Classify 'news' as an uncountable (non-count) noun, meaning it does not have a plural form.
- >> Always pair 'news' with a singular verb (e.g., 'is', 'was', 'has', 'seems'), regardless of the 's' at the end of the word.
- >> Avoid using plural determiners such as 'these' or 'those' when referring to 'news'; use 'this' or 'that' instead.
- >> When referring to a specific instance of news, use the quantifier 'a piece of news' or 'an item of news' rather than 'a news'.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

These news about the archaeological discovery are quite intriguing.

OK CORRECT

This news about the archaeological discovery is quite intriguing.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The current fiscal policy is so stringent as the one implemented during the previous economic recession.

OK CORRECT

The current fiscal policy is not so stringent as the one implemented during the previous economic recession.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The news of the systemic failures in the provincial administrative machinery and the subsequent civil unrest have forced the ministry to implement urgent structural reforms.

OK CORRECT

The news of the systemic failures in the provincial administrative machinery and the subsequent civil unrest has forced the ministry to implement urgent structural reforms.

EXCEPTIONS

>> There are no exceptions to the singular nature of the verb; however, to count 'news', one must use collective phrases like 'a piece of news' or 'several items of news' since 'news' cannot be pluralized directly.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Utilize the 'Strip-Down Method': Mentally eliminate all intervening phrases between the subject and the verb. In the sentence 'The news of the various geopolitical shifts has...', stripping it down to 'The news... has' immediately reveals the correct singular agreement.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Error Detection: The news of the discovery of the ancient manuscripts (A) / and the associated artifacts from the Indus Valley (B) / were broadcasted (C) / across all major international networks (D) / No Error (E).

RULE 135

Importance: 60/100

Pronouns: Order of Pronouns (Confession/Bad Actions)

When confessing a mistake or referring to negative actions, the order of pronouns is typically 1st person, 2nd person, 3rd person (I, you, he/she).

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners often place pronouns in the 'courtesy order' (2-3-1) within a sentence that describes a failure or a crime. They rely on the candidate's habit of applying the general politeness rule without analyzing the negative sentiment of the sentence.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In standard English grammar, the sequence of personal pronouns varies based on the context of the sentence. While the general rule for positive or neutral statements follows the 2-3-1 order (Second Person, Third Person, First Person), a specific convention is applied when the sentence involves a confession, an admission of guilt, or the attribution of a mistake. In such negative contexts, the order must be 1-2-3 (First Person, Second Person, Third Person). This is based on the grammatical etiquette of taking primary responsibility for an error before mentioning others.

>> In neutral or positive contexts, the standard pronoun order follows the courtesy rule: 2nd person, 3rd person, then 1st person (2-3-1).

>> When the sentence conveys a sense of confession, admission of guilt, attribution of a mistake, or responsibility for a failure, the order must shift to 1st person, 2nd person, then 3rd person (1-2-3).

>> This sequence is based on the grammatical etiquette of accepting primary responsibility for an error before mentioning other parties involved.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

You and I are responsible for the damage caused to the laboratory equipment.

OK CORRECT

I and you are responsible for the damage caused to the laboratory equipment.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

As a conscientious professional, one ought maintain the utmost confidentiality regarding the organization's proprietary data.

OK CORRECT

As a conscientious professional, one ought to maintain the utmost confidentiality regarding the organization's proprietary data.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The Ministry of Urban Development, the municipal commissioner, and I failed to implement the waste management protocols before the monsoon onset.

OK CORRECT

I, the Ministry of Urban Development, and the municipal commissioner failed to implement the waste management protocols before the monsoon onset.

EXCEPTIONS

>> If the sentence is a neutral statement of fact or describes a positive achievement, the standard 2-3-1 (or 3-1) order must be strictly maintained.

PRO-TIP

Tip: Scan for 'negative trigger words' such as 'to blame', 'guilty', 'failed', 'responsible for the error', or 'discrepancy'. If these are present, immediately check if the first-person pronoun ('I' or 'we') is at the beginning of the list.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The chief architect, the structural engineer, and I are to be blamed for the collapse of the bridge during the inspection.'



RULE 136

Importance: 60/100

Punctuation: Hyphen Usage (Compound Adjectives)

Hyphens are used to join two or more words that function as a single adjective before a noun (e.g., 'well-known author', 'long-term plan').

EXAMINER TRAP: The primary trap involves shifting the compound modifier from a pre-noun position to a post-noun position. Examiners may either omit the hyphen where it is required (before the noun) or incorrectly include it where it is prohibited (after the noun), testing the candidate's awareness of syntactic positioning.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

In formal English grammar, a hyphen is employed to link two or more words that collectively function as a single adjective (a compound modifier) when they precede the noun they modify. This prevents ambiguity by signaling to the reader that the words operate as a unified conceptual unit rather than as separate modifiers. For instance, in the phrase 'high-level meeting,' the hyphen clarifies that the meeting is of a 'high level,' rather than a 'level meeting' that happens to be 'high.' Crucially, if the compound modifier follows the noun it describes, the hyphen is generally omitted unless the compound is a permanent entry in the dictionary.

>> Use a hyphen to link two or more words when they collectively function as a single compound modifier preceding the noun they describe.

>> The hyphen signals to the reader that the words operate as a unified conceptual unit, thereby eliminating ambiguity in the sentence structure.

>> If the compound modifier follows the noun it describes, the hyphen is generally omitted unless the term is a permanent entry in a standard dictionary.

>> Do not employ a hyphen when the first word of the compound modifier is an adverb ending in '-ly'.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The municipal council requires a cost effective solution to manage urban waste.

OK CORRECT

The municipal council requires a cost-effective solution to manage urban waste.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

On the conclusion of the bilateral summit, the two heads of state issued a joint communique to the press.

OK CORRECT

Upon the conclusion of the bilateral summit, the two heads of state issued a joint communique to the press.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The administration has implemented a carbon neutral framework to mitigate the environmental impact of industrial emissions.

OK CORRECT

The administration has implemented a carbon-neutral framework to mitigate the environmental impact of industrial emissions.

EXCEPTIONS

>> 1.

>> Adverbs ending in '-ly' are never hyphenated when used in a compound modifier (e.g., 'a highly sophisticated system', NOT 'a highly-sophisticated system').

>> 2.

>> Proper nouns used as modifiers typically do not take hyphens (e.g., 'a South Asian diplomatic crisis').

PRO-TIP



Tip: When encountering a compound modifier in 'Sentence Improvement' questions, apply the 'Substitution Test': if you cannot move the words independently without altering the intended meaning (e.g., you cannot say 'a term long strategy'), they must be hyphenated when preceding the noun.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The board of directors (A) / endorsed a state of the art (B) / infrastructure project (C) / to enhance digital connectivity (D).'

**RULE 137****Importance: 50/100****Punctuation: Semicolon Usage**

Semicolons are used to join two closely related independent clauses without a coordinating conjunction, or to separate items in a complex list where items themselves contain commas.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently use conjunctive adverbs like 'however' or 'consequently' flanked by commas to link two independent clauses. This creates a classic comma splice error that candidates often overlook because the sentence sounds fluid when read aloud.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

A semicolon (;) is a punctuation mark that represents a pause stronger than a comma but weaker than a full stop. In formal English and competitive examinations, it serves two primary functions: 1. Linking Independent Clauses: It connects two independent clauses (complete sentences) that are logically related, removing the need for a coordinating conjunction (such as 'and', 'but', or 'or'). Using a comma instead of a semicolon to join two independent clauses creates a grammatical error known as a 'comma splice.' 2. Complex Lists: It acts as a 'super comma' to separate items in a series when the items themselves already contain internal commas. This prevents ambiguity and ensures the reader can distinguish between the primary separators and the descriptive modifiers within the list.

>> Use a semicolon to link two independent clauses that are logically connected and are not joined by a coordinating conjunction (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so).

>> Employ a semicolon to prevent 'comma splices,' which occur when two complete sentences are incorrectly joined by only a comma.

>> Utilize a semicolon as a 'super comma' to separate items in a series when the individual items already contain internal commas, thereby avoiding ambiguity.

>> Use a semicolon before a conjunctive adverb (e.g., however, therefore, moreover, nevertheless) when it introduces a second independent clause.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The legislative session was adjourned, the members failed to reach a consensus.

OK CORRECT

The legislative session was adjourned; the members failed to reach a consensus.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

The fiscal policy implemented by the central bank is very stringent for the small-scale industries to sustain.

OK CORRECT

The fiscal policy implemented by the central bank is too stringent for the small-scale industries to sustain.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The government implemented stringent emission norms to curtail urban smog, nevertheless, the industrial sector resisted the transition due to high compliance costs.

OK CORRECT

The government implemented stringent emission norms to curtail urban smog; nevertheless, the industrial sector resisted the transition due to high compliance costs.

EXCEPTIONS

>> A semicolon must not be used to connect a dependent (subordinate) clause to an independent clause; a comma is required in such instances.

>> Additionally, a semicolon cannot be used to introduce a list or a quotation, as that is the specific function of a colon.

PRO-TIP



Tip: For SBI PO and SSC CGL exams, remember the 'Semicolon-Adverb-Comma' formula: [Independent Clause] + ; + [Conjunctive Adverb] + , + [Independent Clause]. This structure is the hallmark of formal, academic writing.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the punctuation error in the following sentence: 'The integration of generative AI into healthcare could revolutionize diagnostics, moreover, it raises significant ethical concerns regarding patient data privacy.'



RULE 138

Importance: 45/100

Punctuation: Colon Usage

Colons are used to introduce a list, an explanation, an example, or a quotation, typically after a complete independent clause.

EXAMINER TRAP: Examiners frequently place a colon after words that naturally introduce a list, such as 'including', 'namely', or 'such as'. Since these words are part of the predicate, placing a colon after them creates a fragment before the colon, violating the fundamental rule that a colon must follow a complete independent clause.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The colon (:) acts as a signal that the information following it expands upon, explains, or lists what was mentioned previously. In competitive examinations, the most critical requirement is that the colon must be preceded by a complete independent clause—a group of words that can stand alone as a grammatically correct sentence. It is primarily employed in four scenarios: 1) To introduce a list of items. 2) To provide a detailed explanation or a summary of the preceding clause. 3) To introduce a formal quotation. 4) To provide a specific example that illustrates the general point made in the first clause.

>> A colon must be preceded by a complete independent clause—a group of words that can stand alone as a grammatically correct sentence.

>> Use a colon to introduce a list of items that expands upon the preceding independent clause.

>> Use a colon to provide a detailed explanation, summary, or clarification of the information mentioned in the first clause.

>> Use a colon to introduce a formal quotation, especially when the introduction is a complete sentence.

>> Use a colon to introduce a specific example that serves as a direct illustration of the general point made previously.

EXAMPLES**1. Basic Level****X INCORRECT**

The primary catalysts for the reaction are: temperature, pressure, and catalyst concentration.

OK CORRECT

The reaction is driven by three primary catalysts: temperature, pressure, and catalyst concentration.

2. Standard Level**X INCORRECT**

Will we deliberate upon the proposed amendments to the corporate governance framework before the board meeting?

OK CORRECT

Shall we deliberate upon the proposed amendments to the corporate governance framework before the board meeting?

3. Exam Level (Tricky)**X INCORRECT**

The legislative assembly debated the new bill, which focused on: the decriminalization of minor offenses and the overhaul of the judicial appointment process.

OK CORRECT

The legislative assembly debated the new bill, which focused on a singular objective: the decriminalization of minor offenses and the overhaul of the judicial appointment process.

EXCEPTIONS

>> A colon must never be placed immediately after a verb (e.g., 'is', 'are', 'include', 'consists of') or a preposition (e.g., 'such as', 'including').

>> For instance, writing 'The requirements are: X, Y, and Z' is grammatically incorrect; it should be 'The requirements are X, Y, and Z' or 'The requirements are as follows: X, Y, and Z'.

PRO-TIP



Tip: Apply the 'Full Stop Test': Replace the colon with a period. If the text preceding the colon remains a grammatically complete and logical sentence, the colon is likely used correctly. If the preceding phrase is a fragment, the colon is misplaced.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The rapid advancement of Artificial Intelligence presents several ethical dilemmas: including the potential for algorithmic bias and the displacement of human labor in creative industries.'

RULE 139

Importance: 30/100

Punctuation: Dash Usage (Emphatic Break)

Dashes (em-dashes) are used to indicate an abrupt change in thought, to set off an emphatic appositive, or to create a strong pause.

EXAMINER TRAP: The 'Punctuation Mismatch' trap: Examiners frequently introduce a parenthetical phrase with a comma and close it with an em-dash (or vice versa). To maintain grammatical parallelism, the punctuation marks used to bracket an inserted phrase must be identical.

CONCEPT EXPLANATION

The em-dash (—) is a versatile punctuation mark used to signal a sudden break in thought, a sharp interruption, or to set off a parenthetical element with greater emphasis than commas or parentheses. Unlike the comma, which provides a soft pause, the em-dash creates a strong, emphatic break that draws the reader's attention to the inserted information. It is frequently employed to replace a colon when the introduction to a list or a concluding thought is intended to be abrupt or dramatic, or to isolate an appositive that contains internal punctuation, thereby preventing reader confusion.

- >> Use the em-dash (—) to signal a sudden break in thought, a sharp interruption, or a rhetorical shift within a sentence.
- >> Employ em-dashes to isolate a parenthetical element or an appositive when you wish to provide greater emphasis than commas or parentheses would allow.
- >> Utilize em-dashes to replace a colon when the introduction to a list or a concluding summary is intended to be abrupt, dramatic, or less formal.
- >> Use pairs of em-dashes to set off an internal phrase that already contains commas, thereby preventing syntactic ambiguity and improving readability.

EXAMPLES

1. Basic Level

X INCORRECT

The municipal council - failing to secure the necessary grants - postponed the infrastructure project indefinitely.

OK CORRECT

The municipal council — failing to secure the necessary grants — postponed the infrastructure project indefinitely.

2. Standard Level

X INCORRECT

You had better to leave now before it rains.

OK CORRECT

You had better leave now before it rains.

3. Exam Level (Tricky)

X INCORRECT

The rapid depletion of Arctic permafrost, a phenomenon that significantly accelerates global warming — threatens to release vast amounts of sequestered methane into the atmosphere.

OK CORRECT

The rapid depletion of Arctic permafrost — a phenomenon that significantly accelerates global warming — threatens to release vast amounts of sequestered methane into the atmosphere.

EXCEPTIONS

- >> Avoid em-dashes in highly formal legal drafting or strict academic monographs where objective precision outweighs rhetorical emphasis; in such contexts, commas or parentheses are preferred.
- >> Additionally, do not use a dash to separate a subject from its verb unless the interruption is substantial and intended for specific stylistic effect.

PRO-TIP



Tip: For SBI PO and SSC CGL, strictly distinguish between the Hyphen (-), En-dash (–), and Em-dash (—). A hyphen joins compound words (e.g., 'state-of-the-art'); an en-dash indicates ranges or connections (e.g., '1914–1918' or 'the New York–London flight'); an em-dash indicates a structural break. In 'Error Detection' questions, using a short hyphen to set off a phrase is technically a punctuation error.

TEST YOURSELF

Q: Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The recent advancements in quantum computing, which could render current encryption protocols obsolete — present both an unprecedented opportunity and a severe security risk.'

PRACTICE EXERCISES

Attempt all questions before checking the Answer Key. One question per rule.

- Q1. Detect the error in the following sentence: 'The persistent erosion of traditional cultural values, exacerbated by the globalized nature of digital media, indicate a profound shift in societal norms.'
- Q2. Spot the error in the following sentence: 'Each of the social workers assigned to the rural development project has documented their observations regarding the groundwater crisis.' (A) Each of the (B) social workers assigned (C) to the rural development project (D) has documented their observations (E) No error
- Q3. The legislative committee noted that the unchecked proliferation of deepfake technology (poses/posed) a severe threat to the integrity of democratic elections.
- Q4. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The proposed digital privacy framework is ostensibly designed to protect citizens, yet it remains impervious for scrutiny by independent auditing bodies.'
- Q5. Identify the error in the following sentence: The proliferation of artificial intelligence not only threatens traditional employment sectors but also it raises profound ethical questions regarding data privacy and algorithmic bias.
- Q6. Error Detection: 'Artificial Intelligence has revolutionized the accuracy of diagnostic medicine in several premier hospitals during the clinical trials conducted in 2022.'
- Q7. Spot the Error: The excavation team discovered that the local villagers had altered the site before the government had designated it as a protected monument. (A) The excavation team (B) discovered that the local villagers (C) had altered the site before (D) the government had designated it as a protected monument. (E) No Error
- Q8. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The space agency will commence the lunar landing sequence once the lander will establish a secure communication link with the orbiting module.'
- Q9. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The algorithm functioned efficient, ensuring that the urban planning software remained accurate despite the massive influx of real-time data.'
- Q10. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The archaeological site comprises of several subterranean chambers and intricate frescoes dating back to the Mauryan Empire.'
- Q11. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The emerging AI architecture not only optimizes data processing speeds but it also enhances the predictive accuracy of the neural network.'
- Q12. Identify the error in the following sentence: The Lead Architect explained that the structural integrity of the skyscraper will be compromised if the foundation is not reinforced by next month.
- Q13. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The research paper argues that the integration of Artificial Intelligence into healthcare can lead to more accurate diagnoses, the reduction of human error, and providing personalized patient care.'
- Q14. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Using a sophisticated CRISPR-Cas9 technique, the gene mutation was successfully edited by the research team.'
- Q15. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The software architect developed an algorithm to detect anomalies in network traffic that was capable of processing petabytes of data in real-time.'
- Q16. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Despite the systemic failures of the urban planning commission, the lead architect refused to throw in his towel until the revised blueprints were approved.'
- Q17. Despite the initial setbacks and the volatility of the experimental data, the research team refused to give _____ the quest for a sustainable fusion reactor. (Fill in the blank: up / away / out)
- Q18. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead astrophysicist insisted that the research team conducts a double-blind analysis of the telemetry data to eliminate observational bias before the findings are submitted to the journal.'

Q19. Identify the segment containing the error: 'The research team has been monitoring the seismic activity for the deployment of the high-sensitivity sensors last month (A)/ to ascertain if the tectonic (B)/ shifts have intensified (C)/ in the oceanic ridge (D)/ No Error (E).'

Q20. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Ministry of External Affairs clarified that the diplomatic impasse was resolved through a series of clandestine negotiations between the Prime Minister and he.'

Q21. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The diplomatic mission failed because there were less opportunities for dialogue between the two warring factions than the international community had anticipated.'

Q22. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The cybersecurity firm reported that a significant amount of softwares used by the government were outdated and vulnerable to zero-day exploits.'

Q23. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead architect had better to refine the structural blueprints immediately, as the construction crew is not used to operate with such imprecise specifications.' (A) had better to refine (B) structural blueprints immediately (C) is not used to operate (D) No Error

Q24. The implementation of the new data privacy framework has hardly mitigated the risks of cyber espionage, _____?

Q25. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'While the delegates debated the terms of the climate accord, everyone among the participating nations were urged to reduce carbon emissions by 2030.'

Q26. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Governor-General, in addition to the provincial administrators and the local chieftains, were tasked with implementing the land revenue reforms.' (A) The Governor-General (B) in addition to the provincial administrators (C) and the local chieftains (D) were tasked with implementing (E) No Error

Q27. Either the archival records of the colonial era or the testimony of the surviving witnesses _____ (confirm/confirms) the occurrence of the uprising in the southern province.

Q28. Error Spotting: 'Universal Basic Income is one of those socio-economic proposals that seeks to alleviate extreme poverty by providing a guaranteed financial floor for all citizens.' (Identify the error).

Q29. Identify and correct the error: 'If the research team will discover a more efficient catalyst, the cost of hydrogen production will decrease significantly.'

Q30. Identify the part containing the error: If the telescope was capable (A) of detecting dark matter (B), astronomers (C) would gain a deeper understanding of the early universe (D). No Error (E).

Q31. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'If the software architects would have anticipated the vulnerability in the encryption protocol, the catastrophic data breach of 2023 could have been prevented.'

Q32. Identify the segment that contains a grammatical error: 'The newly implemented (A) / digital infrastructure (B) / is comprising of (C) / several cloud-based modules to streamline public service delivery (D) / No error (E).'

Q33. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The integration of Large Language Models into healthcare diagnostics has made the triage process most easiest for clinicians, although ethical concerns regarding data privacy persist.'

Q34. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'No sooner the cybersecurity agency detected the breach then the critical servers were shut down to prevent further data leakage.'

Q35. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'Hardly the legislative assembly had passed the land reform bill than the opposition filed a petition in the High Court.'

Q36. Identify the errors in the following sentence: 'French Revolution marked first major upheaval in European history, profoundly impacting the way the people perceived the power of monarchy and the influence of Catholic Church.'

Q37. Spot the error: 'The archaeological team reported that the debris found at the site of the ancient civilization provided invaluable insights into the social hierarchy of the era.' (A) The archaeological team (B) reported that the debris (C) found at the site of the ancient civilization (D) provided invaluable insights into



the social hierarchy of the era. (E) No Error

Q38. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The new urban planning strategy was designed to reduce congestion, but the implementation of the project is being hindered by a lack of municipal funding.'

Q39. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The aerospace engineers decided to merge together the two propulsion systems to optimize the satellite's fuel efficiency.'

Q40. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Only after the cybersecurity agency detected the breach the government implemented the new encryption protocols across all administrative departments.'

Q41. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The colonial administration might have overlooked the indigenous land rights of the tribal population during the 19th-century land acquisition process.' (A) might to have (B) overlooked the indigenous (C) during the 19th-century (D) No error

Q42. Error Spotting: The number of sophisticated cyber-attacks targeting critical infrastructure during the geopolitical conflict were significantly higher than the intelligence agencies had projected. (Identify the error)

Q43. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead archaeologist who the government commissioned to supervise the excavation of the Indus Valley site has uncovered several rare artifacts.'

Q44. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Great Barrier Reef, that suffers from extensive coral bleaching due to rising sea temperatures, is a critical biodiversity hotspot.'

Q45. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The scientific community is concerned that the glacier's rapid melting indicates that its structural integrity has been permanently compromised by rising global temperatures.'

Q46. The responsibility for implementing the new environmental protocols was divided _____ the various municipal corporations across the metropolitan area. (Fill in the blank)

Q47. Identify the part containing the error: 'The digital divide (A) / in rural hinterlands (B) / will persist unless (C) / the state government does not subsidize (D) / high-speed broadband infrastructure. (E) / No error'

Q48. The ethics committee stopped _____ (to evaluate / evaluating) the AI's algorithmic bias once the developer provided the comprehensive transparency report.

Q49. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The aerospace agency developed a revolutionary, cylindrical, American, new, carbon-fiber propulsion system.'

Q50. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The aerospace engineer presented the prototype to the board of directors that featured an innovative propulsion system.'

Q51. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Many a tech startup, driven by the ambition to disrupt the global logistics market through generative AI, have failed to secure sustainable venture capital in the current fiscal climate.'

Q52. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'More than one geothermal vent were discovered during the deep-sea exploration of the Mid-Atlantic Ridge.'

Q53. Identify the error in the following sentence: The legislative baggage (A)/ associated with the proposed land reform (B)/ were considered too cumbersome (C)/ for the parliamentary committee to address (D).

Q54. Error Detection: 'Any of the evidence (A)/ presented by the medical board (B)/ were found to be (C)/ inconsistent with the autopsy report (D)/ No Error (E).'

Q55. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Ministry of External Affairs is knowing the geopolitical implications of the proposed bilateral treaty on regional stability.'

Q56. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The cybersecurity agency is monitoring the network traffic for anomalous patterns since the detection of the first breach last Tuesday.'

Q57. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The climatologist argued that the increase in atmospheric carbon dioxide levels led to a gradual rise in global mean temperatures.'

Q58. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead climatologist, along with her team of researchers, found themselves unable to reconcile the discrepancies in the glacial melt data.'



- Q59. Spot the error in the following sentence: 'The ethical implications of generative AI and its impact on labor markets were discussed at length by the research panel and we.'
- Q60. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The administrative framework of the newly autonomous region is considered superior than the previous centralized model.'
- Q61. Identify the segment that contains a grammatical error: 'The legislative council (A) / argued that the amendment (B) / only should be adopted (C) / after a comprehensive review. (D) / No Error (E)'
- Q62. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The legislative body only allowed the deployment of autonomous drones once the safety protocols were ratified by the international ethics committee.'
- Q63. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Although the integration of generative AI in healthcare promises unprecedented diagnostic accuracy, but the ethical concerns regarding data privacy and algorithmic bias remain largely unresolved.'
- Q64. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The legal counsel advised the CEO that filing an FIR would be a essential step in the litigation process.'
- Q65. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Integration of artificial intelligence into healthcare system necessitates stringent regulatory framework to prevent data breach.'
- Q66. Identify the error in the following sentence: (A) The artificial intelligence / (B) is fundamentally / (C) reshaping the global / (D) landscape of labor markets. (E) No Error
- Q67. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The remnants of the coral reef, severely degraded by ocean acidification and rising sea temperatures, remains the only evidence of the region's former biodiversity.'
- Q68. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Prime Minister's's address to the United Nations emphasized the need for global cooperation in combating pandemic-related economic instability.'
- Q69. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The excavation at Harappa revealed a sophisticated urban planning system, it underscores the advanced architectural knowledge of the Indus Valley Civilization.'
- Q70. Spot the error: 'The cybersecurity firm discovered that many evidence of a systemic data breach had been meticulously erased by the sophisticated malware.'
- Q71. Error Spotting: The environmental agency noted that the municipal corporation managed the waste segregation drive good, leading to a 30% reduction in landfill volume. (Identify and correct the error)
- Q72. The sudden surge in volatility caused the investor's portfolio to plunge ____ a deep deficit within a matter of hours. (Fill in the blank with 'in' or 'into')
- Q73. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The technological symposium was organized at Tokyo, and the keynote speaker arrived in the main auditorium at noon.' (A) at Tokyo (B) and the keynote (C) in the main auditorium (D) No error
- Q74. Identify the error: The Ministry of Environment (A) / intends to implement the new carbon credits policy (B) / at the autumn of 2025 (C) / to mitigate industrial emissions (D) / No error (E).
- Q75. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The urban planning commission redesigned the metropolitan transit map by a sophisticated geospatial modeling tool to mitigate traffic congestion.'
- Q76. The archaeological discovery in the Indus Valley was ____ a profound revelation that it forced historians to rewrite the timeline of urban civilization. (Fill in the blank with 'so' or 'such')
- Q77. The ancient treaty, which redefined the borders of the two warring empires, had ____ forgotten in the royal archives for centuries. (Fill in the blank: lain / laid)
- Q78. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The sudden surge in cosmic radiation levels caused the sensor's thermal output to raise beyond the permissible safety threshold.'
- Q79. The lead researcher emphasized that (this / these) sort of genetic mutation occurs rarely in nature but can be induced in controlled laboratory settings.
- Q80. What (a / -) disruptive potential the emergence of quantum computing possesses!

- Q81. The research consortium (is/are) presenting their findings on the exoplanet's atmospheric composition at the international symposium.
- Q82. Identify the error: 'There is (A) a wide range of discrepancies (B) between the two reports (C) submitted by the auditing firm (D) regarding the project's expenditure. (E) No Error.'
- Q83. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The updated firmware for the satellite array update automatically every quarter to optimize signal transmission.'
- Q84. Detect the error: 'The global semiconductor industry has encountered a severe supply chain disruption during the 2021 pandemic peak, leading to widespread production delays.'
- Q85. Error Detection: The colonial administration (A) had been implementing (B) stringent land reforms for decades (C) until the indigenous population revolted (D). No Error (E).
- Q86. Error Detection: If the global community had acted decisively (A) / on carbon emissions during the 1990s, (B) / the current rate of glacial melt (C) / would have been significantly slower. (D) / No Error (E)
- Q87. Identify the error: It is high time (A) / that the industrial sectors (B) / transition to renewable energy (C) / to mitigate ecological collapse. (D) / No Error (E)
- Q88. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The artificial intelligence system processes information as though it has a consciousness similar to that of a human being.'
- Q89. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'To truly comprehend the intricacies of the Magna Carta, one must immerse himself in the socio-political climate of 13th-century England.'
- Q90. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The judicial review of the proposed legislation was deemed to be the most complete evaluation of the bill's constitutionality to date.'
- Q91. Identify the error: 'Despite having (A) a little expertise (B) in quantum computing, the researcher (C) was unable to resolve (D) the anomalies in the simulation.'
- Q92. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'While the archaeological excavation yielded numerous shards of pottery, a few artifacts of significant historical value were recovered, leaving the lead historians profoundly dissatisfied with the results.'
- Q93. The governing council reluctantly agreed ____ the stringent austerity measures imposed by the International Monetary Fund to stabilize the national economy. (Fill in the blank)
- Q94. Error Detection: The cybersecurity firm implemented a multi-layered encryption protocol (A) / lest the sensitive data (B) / could be intercepted (C) / by malicious actors during transit (D).
- Q95. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The legislative assembly debated whether the proficiency in the Arabic would be an asset for the diplomatic corps in the Middle East.'
- Q96. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The environmental activist spent six months in the prison for protesting against the illegal dredging of the riverbed.' (A) The environmental activist (B) spent six months (C) in the prison (D) No error
- Q97. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The geopolitical analyses of the conflict conducted by the think-tank was found to be superficial and lacking in empirical evidence.'
- Q98. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The adjudication of the territorial dispute, accompanied by numerous appeals from the affected provinces, were delayed due to the lack of a quorum in the Supreme Court.'
- Q99. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The archaeological team uncovered, during the excavation of the third stratum in the Indus Valley site, several ivory ornaments and prehistoric clay seals.'
- Q100. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'Given the sensitivity of the geopolitical climate, the diplomatic envoy would rather to defer the bilateral talks until the ceasefire is ratified.'
- Q101. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The tech consortium managed to get the regulatory body waive the licensing fees for emerging AI startups to foster innovation.'



Q102. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The oncology team studied hardly for months to synthesize the compound, yet the patient could hardly tolerate the side effects of the chemotherapy.'

Q103. Fill in the blank: '_____ the ability to process vast datasets in seconds, the new AI architecture demonstrates an unprecedented capacity for nuanced linguistic reasoning.'

Q104. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The diplomat refused to concede any territory while the strategic negotiations between the two sovereign nations.'

Q105. Forty-five percent of the specialized laboratory equipment _____ (was/were) damaged during the seismic event.

Q106. Error Detection: Six light-years (A) / are an immense distance (B) / for a space probe (C) / to travel in a single decade. (D) / No Error (E)

Q107. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The legislative body was debating the controversial amendment when the Speaker is calling for a vote of confidence.'

Q108. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'While the geopolitical climate remained volatile, the two heads of state interacted friendly during the summit to prevent an escalation of the conflict.'

Q109. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'Many a historian have contested the validity of the primary sources used to document the colonial administration's impact on indigenous populations.'

Q110. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The administration has implemented stringent emission norms to combat urban smog, consequently, the manufacturing sector is facing a sudden spike in operational costs.'

Q111. Identify the segment containing the error: (A) The municipal corporation has initiated a comprehensive waste management project / (B) to mitigate the growing landfill crisis in the metropolis / (C) Since the objective is to achieve a zero-waste city / (D) by the end of the current fiscal year. / (E) No Error

Q112. The diverse architectural frameworks of the competing Large Language Models were analyzed by the researchers to determine how they optimize weights relative to _____ to enhance inference speed. (Fill in the blank: each other / one another)

Q113. The scientific community believes that the deep-space probe must travel _____ into the Oort Cloud to retrieve viable interstellar data.

Q114. Identify the error: The specialized sensor (A) / set on the seabed (B) / for three months (C) / monitoring seismic activity (D) / No Error (E).

Q115. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The United States of America (A)/ have consistently advocated (B)/ for a multilateral approach (C)/ to global security (D)/ No Error (E).'

Q116. The digitally illiterate, despite the widespread availability of low-cost smartphones and subsidized data plans, _____ (remains/remain) largely excluded from essential e-governance services.

Q117. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'A pair of high-precision calipers, essential for measuring the minute thickness of the semiconductor wafer, have been misplaced in the laboratory.'

Q118. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The archaeological society would rather the curator restore the ancient frescoes using organic solvents to prevent permanent degradation.'

Q119. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The Magna Carta, who's principles laid the foundational groundwork for modern constitutional law, was signed in 1215 at Runnymede.'

Q120. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'To prevent any bias in the selection of the new Chief Justice, the committee suggested that let they who have a documented conflict of interest recuse themselves from the voting process.'

Q121. Despite the advanced medical intervention available at the facility, the diplomat eventually died _____ the complications arising from the surgical procedure. (Fill in the blank)

Q122. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The diplomatic envoy noted that the various governor-generals of the Commonwealth had divergent views on the proposed trade treaty.'

Q123. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The urban planning committee suggested a six-months moratorium on the construction of high-rise buildings in the coastal zone.'

Q124. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead scientists at the CERN facility argued that the discovery of the Higgs boson was their, although the global collaboration played a pivotal role.'

Q125. Spot the error in the following sentence: 'The elder daughter of the former Governor, who currently serves as a diplomat, is not elder than the Ambassador to the United Kingdom.'

Q126. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The lead astrophysicist has been analyzing the telemetry data from the James Webb Telescope lately, but she submitted the final research paper lately to the peer-review committee.'

Q127. The newly appointed ombudsman is (A) so impartial as (B) his predecessor (C) in handling public grievances (D) No Error.

Q128. Identify the error in the following sentence: The constitutional body (A) / ought to promoting (B) / transparency and accountability (C) / in public administration. (D) / No Error (E)

Q129. The statistics regarding the decline of biodiversity in the Amazon rainforest _____ (indicate/indicates) a critical tipping point for the global climate.

Q130. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'I, you, and the Secretary-General are expected to sign the peace treaty during the summit in Brussels.'

Q131. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The weight of the geopolitical tension now rests on the diplomacy of the neutral nations to prevent a full-scale conflict.'

Q132. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The computational demands of the neural network were very intensive for the existing server architecture to sustain without overheating.'

Q133. Error Detection: 'The presiding officer will ensure that the quorum is present before the legislative assembly commences the deliberation on the new education policy.' (Identify the modal error).

Q134. Error Detection: The news of the discovery of the ancient manuscripts (A) / and the associated artifacts from the Indus Valley (B) / were broadcasted (C) / across all major international networks (D) / No Error (E).

Q135. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The chief architect, the structural engineer, and I are to be blamed for the collapse of the bridge during the inspection.'

Q136. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The board of directors (A) / endorsed a state of the art (B) / infrastructure project (C) / to enhance digital connectivity (D).'

Q137. Identify the punctuation error in the following sentence: 'The integration of generative AI into healthcare could revolutionize diagnostics, moreover, it raises significant ethical concerns regarding patient data privacy.'

Q138. Identify the error in the following sentence: 'The rapid advancement of Artificial Intelligence presents several ethical dilemmas: including the potential for algorithmic bias and the displacement of human labor in creative industries.'

Q139. Identify and correct the error in the following sentence: 'The recent advancements in quantum computing, which could render current encryption protocols obsolete — present both an unprecedented opportunity and a severe security risk.'

TEST YOURSELF - ANSWER KEY

Ans 1: The error is the verb 'indicate'. The primary subject is 'erosion' (singular), not 'values' or 'media'. The intervening phrase 'exacerbated by the globalized nature of digital media' does not change the number of the subject. Therefore, 'indicate' must be replaced with 'indicates'.

Ans 2: The error is in part (D). The subject 'Each' is a singular distributive pronoun; therefore, the plural possessive pronoun 'their' is grammatically incorrect and must be replaced with 'his or her' to maintain strict pronoun-antecedent agreement.

Ans 3: posed; The principal verb 'noted' anchors the sentence in the past. Since the threat to elections is a specific observation made by the committee at that time (and not an immutable law of nature), the subordinate verb must shift to the past tense 'posed' to maintain temporal harmony.

Ans 4: The error is 'impervious for'. The adjective 'impervious' (meaning not allowing fluid to pass through or unable to be affected by) always takes the fixed preposition 'to'. The correct phrase is 'impervious to scrutiny'.

Ans 5: Error: 'but also it raises'. Correction: 'but also raises'. Reason: The phrase 'not only' is followed by the verb 'threatens'. To maintain grammatical parallelism, 'but also' must be followed immediately by the verb 'raises' without the intervening subject pronoun 'it'.

Ans 6: Incorrect. The phrase 'during the clinical trials conducted in 2022' provides a specific, concluded time frame. Consequently, the Present Perfect 'has revolutionized' must be replaced with the Simple Past 'revolutionized'.

Ans 7: D; The alteration of the site occurred first (Past Perfect), and the government designation occurred second. Therefore, the second action must be in the Simple Past. 'had designated' should be replaced with 'designated'.

Ans 8: Error: 'will establish'. Correction: 'establishes'. Reason: The clause introduced by 'once' is a time clause referring to a future action; therefore, it must be expressed in the Simple Present tense.

Ans 9: The adjective 'efficient' is incorrectly used to modify the verb 'functioned'. It must be replaced by the adverb 'efficiently' to correctly describe the manner in which the algorithm operated.

Ans 10: Error: 'comprises of'. Correction: 'comprises'. Reason: In the active voice, the verb 'comprise' means 'to be composed of' and does not take the preposition 'of'.

Ans 11: The error lies in the phrase 'but it also enhances'. To maintain parallelism with the verb phrase 'optimizes data processing speeds', the second part must be 'but also enhances'. The insertion of the subject 'it' breaks the parallel structure, as 'not only' is followed directly by a verb.

Ans 12: Error: 'will be' and 'is' should be replaced by 'would be' and 'was'. Reason: The reporting verb 'explained' is in the past tense, necessitating a backshift of the future and present tenses within the reported speech to maintain temporal consistency.

Ans 13: The error lies in the phrase 'providing personalized patient care'. To maintain parallelism with the preceding noun phrases ('more accurate diagnoses' and 'the reduction of human error'), it should be replaced with 'the provision of personalized patient care'.

Ans 14: Error: The modifying phrase 'Using a sophisticated CRISPR-Cas9 technique' incorrectly modifies 'the gene mutation.' A mutation cannot use a technique. Correct: 'Using a sophisticated CRISPR-Cas9 technique, the research team successfully edited the gene mutation.'

Ans 15: Error: The relative clause 'that was capable of processing petabytes of data in real-time' is misplaced, suggesting that the 'network traffic' (rather than the 'algorithm') possesses the processing capability. Correct: 'The software architect developed an algorithm, capable of processing petabytes of data in real-time, to detect anomalies in network traffic.'

Ans 16: Error: 'throw in his towel'. Correction: 'throw in the towel'. Reason: The idiom 'throw in the towel' (meaning to admit defeat) is a fixed expression; adding a possessive pronoun like 'his' alters the fixed structure and renders it incorrect.

Ans 17: up; 'Give up' means to cease making an effort or to surrender, which is the only logically appropriate choice in the context of persisting despite setbacks.

Ans 18: The error is 'conducts'. Because the sentence follows the verb 'insisted', it triggers the subjunctive mood, necessitating the base form 'conduct' regardless of the singular collective noun 'research team'.

Ans 19: The error is in segment (A). Replace 'for' with 'since'. Reason: 'The deployment of the high-sensitivity sensors last month' refers to a specific event/point in time, not a duration of time.

Ans 20: Replace 'he' with 'him'. Reason: The pronoun is the object of the preposition 'between', which strictly requires the objective case.

Ans 21: Replace 'less' with 'fewer'. Reason: 'Opportunities' is a plural countable noun (you can have one opportunity or several opportunities), which necessitates the use of 'fewer' to denote a smaller number of discrete instances.

Ans 22: Error: 'softwares'. Correction: 'software'. 'Software' is an uncountable noun and cannot be pluralized. Consequently, the verb 'were' should be changed to 'was' to maintain subject-verb agreement.

Ans 23: The sentence contains two errors: (A) should be 'had better refine' (no 'to' after had better) and (C) should be 'is not used to operating' (gerund required after 'be used to').

Ans 24: has it?

Ans 25: The error is 'were urged'. The subject is 'everyone', which is a singular indefinite pronoun. Therefore, the verb must be singular: 'everyone among the participating nations was urged'.

Ans 26: (D) 'were tasked with implementing' should be 'was tasked with implementing' because the verb must agree with the singular primary subject 'The Governor-General'.

Ans 27: confirms; The verb must agree with the subject closest to it, which is 'the testimony of the surviving witnesses'. Since the headword 'testimony' is singular, the singular verb 'confirms' is required.

Ans 28: The error is 'seeks'. The relative pronoun 'that' refers to the plural antecedent 'socio-economic proposals'; therefore, the verb must be the plural form 'seek'.

Ans 29: Error: 'will discover'. Correction: 'discovers'. Reason: In Type 1 conditional sentences, the if-clause must be in the Simple Present tense to express a probable future condition.

Ans 30: A; The sentence expresses a hypothetical condition (Subjunctive Mood), which requires the use of 'were' instead of 'was', regardless of the subject's number.

Ans 31: The error lies in the phrase 'would have anticipated'. In a Type 3 conditional, the if-clause must be in the Past Perfect tense. The correct phrase is 'had anticipated'.

Ans 32: Correct Option: (C). Error: 'is comprising of'. Correct: 'comprises' or 'is composed of'. Reason: 'Comprise' is a stative verb of composition and cannot be used in the continuous form to describe the makeup of a system.

Ans 33: Error: 'most easiest'. Correct: 'easiest'. Reason: 'Easiest' is the superlative form of 'easy'; adding 'most' creates a redundant double superlative.

Ans 34: There are two errors: First, the lack of inversion; 'the cybersecurity agency detected' should be 'had the cybersecurity agency detected' or 'did the cybersecurity agency detect'. Second, the use of 'then' instead of the required correlative conjunction 'than'.

Ans 35: The sentence contains two errors: (1) Lack of inversion and (2) incorrect conjunction. The correct version is: 'Hardly had the legislative assembly passed the land reform bill when the opposition filed a petition in the High Court.'

Ans 36: There are three errors: 1. 'first major upheaval' should be 'the first major upheaval' (Ordinal number). 2. 'power of monarchy' should be 'the power of the monarchy' (Specific institution). 3. 'Catholic Church' should be 'the Catholic Church' (Established institution).

Ans 37: The error is in part (B). 'Debris' is an uncountable noun and cannot be pluralized as 'debrises'. The correct sentence should use 'debris'. Since 'debris' is singular, if the verb had been a present-tense singular/plural choice, it would have required a singular verb.

Ans 38: The error is in the phrase 'is being hinder'. The correct form is 'is being hindered'. In any passive construction, the main verb must invariably be in the past participle (V3) form.

Ans 39: Error: 'merge together'. Reason: 'Merge' means to combine or join together; therefore, the word 'together' is a superfluous addition.

Ans 40: Incorrect: '...the government implemented...'; Correct: '...did the government implement...'. Reason: The sentence begins with the restrictive phrase 'Only after', which triggers mandatory inversion in the main clause. Therefore, the auxiliary 'did' must precede the subject 'the government'.

Ans 41: (A) might to have - The modal 'might' must be followed by the bare infinitive 'have' without the preposition 'to'.

Ans 42: The error is the word 'were'. The subject is 'The number', which refers to a singular total count of attacks; therefore, the verb must be the singular 'was'.

Ans 43: Replace 'who' with 'whom'. Reason: The pronoun functions as the object of the verb 'commissioned' (The government commissioned him), not the subject of the clause.

Ans 44: The error is the use of 'that'. Because the clause is non-restrictive (providing additional information about a unique entity) and is set off by commas, 'that' must be replaced with 'which'.

Ans 45: Error: 'it's' should be 'its'. Reason: The sentence requires a possessive determiner to refer to the structural integrity belonging to the glacier, not a contraction of 'it is' or 'it has'.

Ans 46: Among; 'the various municipal corporations' refers to an undefined collective group rather than a list of specifically named entities.

Ans 47: The error is in part (D). Since 'Unless' already carries a negative meaning ('if not'), the addition of 'does not' creates a redundant double negative. The correct phrasing is 'unless the state government subsidizes high-speed broadband infrastructure'.

Ans 48: evaluating; 'stop' followed by a gerund indicates the cessation of an ongoing activity, whereas 'stop to evaluate' would imply pausing another activity in order to start the evaluation.

Ans 49: The adjectives are incorrectly sequenced. Following the OSASCOMP order (Opinion > Age > Shape > Origin > Material), the correct sequence is: 'revolutionary (Opinion), new (Age), cylindrical (Shape), American (Origin), carbon-fiber (Material) propulsion system.'

Ans 50: Error: Misplaced Modifier. The adjective clause 'that featured an innovative propulsion system' incorrectly modifies 'board of directors' instead of 'prototype'. Correct version: 'The aerospace engineer presented the prototype, which featured an innovative propulsion system, to the board of directors.'

Ans 51: Error: 'have' should be replaced by 'has'. Reason: The subject 'Many a tech startup' is grammatically singular, necessitating the singular verb 'has' despite the plural connotation of the phrase.

Ans 52: The error is 'were'; it should be replaced with 'was'. Reason: The phrase 'more than one' modifies the singular noun 'vent', which grammatically necessitates a singular verb, regardless of the plural logical meaning.

Ans 53: C; The subject 'baggage' is an uncountable noun and therefore requires a singular verb. The plural verb 'were' must be replaced with the singular 'was'.

Ans 54: Part (C) is incorrect. The noun 'evidence' is an uncountable (mass) noun; therefore, the verb must be singular. 'Were found to be' should be replaced with 'was found to be'.

Ans 55: Error: 'is knowing'. Reason: 'Know' is a stative verb of cognition that describes a state of awareness rather than a physical action. Therefore, it cannot be used in the continuous tense and should be replaced with the simple present form 'knows'.

Ans 56: The error is 'is monitoring'. It must be replaced with 'has been monitoring' because the phrase 'since the detection of the first breach' indicates a specific starting point in the past for an action that is still ongoing.

Ans 57: Error: 'led' should be 'leads'. Reason: The correlation between carbon dioxide levels and global temperature rise is a scientific fact (a universal truth in environmental science), which necessitates the Simple Present Tense regardless of the past tense reporting verb 'argued'.

Ans 58: Error: 'themselves' should be replaced by 'herself'. The grammatical subject is 'The lead climatologist' (singular). Phrases such as 'along with', 'as well as', and 'together with' do not alter the number of the subject; therefore, the reflexive pronoun must maintain agreement with the singular subject.

Ans 59: Error: 'we'. Correction: 'us'. The pronoun is the object of the preposition 'by' and must therefore be in the objective case.

Ans 60: Replace 'superior than' with 'superior to'. Reason: 'Superior' is a Latin comparative adjective and must be followed by the preposition 'to' to maintain grammatical correctness.

Ans 61: (C) The adverb 'only' is misplaced. According to the rules of placement, it should follow the modal auxiliary 'should' to correctly modify the verb phrase. Correct: 'should only be adopted'.

Ans 62: Error: Misplaced modifier 'only'. The restriction applies to the condition of deployment (once protocols were ratified), not to the act of allowing. Correct: 'The legislative body allowed the deployment of autonomous drones only once the safety protocols were ratified by the international ethics committee.'

Ans 63: Error: 'but'. Correction: Replace 'but' with 'yet' or a comma. 'Although' is a subordinating conjunction that already establishes contrast; adding 'but' creates a grammatically redundant double-conjunction error.

Ans 64: Replace 'a essential' with 'an essential'. Reason: 'Essential' begins with a vowel sound (/ɛ/), requiring the indefinite article 'an'. Note: 'an FIR' is correct because the letter 'F' is pronounced as 'ef', which starts with a vowel sound.

Ans 65: The sentence contains multiple omissions of the definite article. Corrected: 'The integration of artificial intelligence into the healthcare system necessitates a stringent regulatory framework to prevent the data breach.' (Note: 'the' is required for 'integration' and 'healthcare system' as they are specified by their subsequent phrases).

Ans 66: (A) Remove 'The'. Reason: 'Artificial intelligence' is an uncountable noun used in a general sense to describe a technology/concept; therefore, the definite article is not required.

Ans 67: Error: 'remains' should be replaced by 'remain'. Reason: The subject 'remnants' is a noun that exists only in the plural form (pluralia tantum) and therefore requires the plural verb 'remain'.

Ans 68: Incorrect: Minister's's. Correct: Minister's. Reason: 'Prime Minister' is a singular compound noun; therefore, it requires a single 's' after the apostrophe at the end of the final word.

Ans 69: Error: Comma Splice. The comma after 'system' erroneously joins two independent clauses. It should be replaced by a semicolon, a full stop, or a coordinating conjunction (e.g., 'and it underscores...').

Ans 70: Replace 'many' with 'much'. Reason: 'Evidence' is an uncountable noun and cannot be quantified with 'many', regardless of the amount of proof present.

Ans 71: Replace 'good' with 'well'. The word modifies the action verb 'managed', which describes the manner of the administration's performance, requiring an adverb rather than an adjective.

Ans 72: into; The verb 'plunge' indicates a dynamic movement from a previous state (stability/profit) into a new state (deficit).

Ans 73: (A) at Tokyo. Correction: 'in Tokyo'. Cities are large geographical areas and must be preceded by the preposition 'in', not 'at'.

Ans 74: C; 'At' must be replaced by 'in' because 'the autumn of 2025' refers to a season/extended period of time, not a precise moment.

Ans 75: The error is the use of 'by'. It should be replaced with 'with' because the 'sophisticated geospatial modeling tool' is the instrument employed by the commission, not the agent performing the action of redesigning.

Ans 76: such; Reason: The blank is followed by the noun phrase 'a profound revelation' (Article + Adjective + Noun), which mandates the use of 'such' to indicate the cause of the subsequent result.

Ans 77: lain; The subject (the treaty) was in a state of resting/remaining (intransitive), and the past perfect construction ('had') necessitates the past participle of 'lie', which is 'lain'.

Ans 78: Replace 'raise' with 'rise'. Reason: 'Thermal output' is the subject that is increasing on its own; there is no direct object receiving the action, making the verb intransitive.

Ans 79: this

Ans 80: -

Ans 81: are; the use of the plural possessive pronoun 'their' indicates that the members of the consortium are being viewed as individuals presenting their respective findings, necessitating a plural verb.

Ans 82: A; 'is' should be replaced by 'are' because the real subject 'a wide range of discrepancies' functions as a plural subject in this context.

Ans 83: Replace 'update' with 'updates'. The subject 'The updated firmware' is third-person singular, and the sentence describes a habitual/scheduled action.

Ans 84: Replace 'has encountered' with 'encountered'. Reason: The phrase 'during the 2021 pandemic peak' specifies a definite time in the past, necessitating the Simple Past tense.

Ans 85: No Error (E). The sentence correctly employs the Past Perfect Continuous ('had been implementing') to illustrate a prolonged action that persisted up until a definitive past event ('revolted').

Ans 86: D. The sentence describes a past condition (had acted) with a present result (current rate). Therefore, the Mixed Conditional structure 'would be' must be used instead of the Type 3 'would have been'.

Ans 87: C; 'transition' should be replaced with 'transitioned' because the phrase 'It is high time' followed by a subject requires the simple past tense to express an overdue action.

Ans 88: Replace 'has' with 'had'. Because the AI does not actually possess consciousness, the situation is unreal/hypothetical, requiring the Simple Past (subjunctive) to express a present unreality.

Ans 89: The error is the use of 'himself'. Since the sentence begins with the indefinite pronoun 'one', the reflexive pronoun must be 'oneself' to maintain grammatical consistency.

Ans 90: Error: 'most complete'. Reason: 'Complete' is an absolute adjective. A thing is either complete or it is not; it cannot be 'more' or 'most' complete. The word 'most' should be removed.

Ans 91: Part (A); 'a little' should be replaced by 'little' because the context 'unable to resolve' indicates a negative sense of insufficiency, meaning the researcher lacked enough expertise to solve the problem.

Ans 92: The error is the use of 'a few'. The phrase 'leaving the lead historians profoundly dissatisfied' indicates a negative outcome and a lack of sufficient artifacts. Therefore, the positive quantifier 'a few' should be replaced with the negative quantifier 'few'.

Ans 93: to; the sentence refers to granting consent to a set of formal terms or a proposal (austerity measures).

Ans 94: (C) Replace 'could be intercepted' with 'should be intercepted'. The conjunction 'lest' is exclusively paired with 'should' in standard examination grammar to express a negative purpose.

Ans 95: Error: 'the Arabic'. Correct: 'Arabic'. Reason: Articles are omitted before the names of languages when referring to the language itself.

Ans 96: (C) in prison; Since the activist was incarcerated, which is the primary purpose of a prison, the definite article 'the' should be omitted.

Ans 97: The error lies in the verb 'was'. The noun 'analyses' is the irregular plural of 'analysis'; therefore, it requires the plural verb 'were' to maintain subject-verb agreement.

Ans 98: Replace 'were' with 'was'. The primary subject is 'adjudication' (singular), and the intervening phrase 'accompanied by numerous appeals from the affected provinces' does not change the subject's number.

Ans 99: Error: The prepositional phrase 'during the excavation of the third stratum in the Indus Valley site' separates the transitive verb 'uncovered' from its direct object 'several ivory ornaments and prehistoric clay seals.' Correction: 'During the excavation of the third stratum in the Indus Valley site, the archaeological team uncovered several ivory ornaments and prehistoric clay seals.'

Ans 100: Error: 'to defer'. Correction: 'defer'. Reason: The idiomatic expression 'would rather' must be followed by a bare infinitive, making the use of 'to' grammatically incorrect.

Ans 101: Error: 'waive' should be 'to waive'. Reason: The causative verb 'get' must be followed by a to-infinitive when the agent (the regulatory body) is explicitly mentioned as the performer of the action.

Ans 102: Replace 'studied hardly' with 'studied hard'. The first instance requires an adverb of effort (hard) to describe the team's dedication, whereas the second instance correctly uses 'hardly' to mean 'scarcely' in relation to the patient's tolerance.

Ans 103: Besides; the context implies that the capacity for reasoning is an additional attribute beyond the ability to process data.

Ans 104: The error is the word 'while'. It should be replaced with 'during' because 'the strategic negotiations between the two sovereign nations' is a noun phrase lacking a finite verb, making it a prepositional object rather than a subordinate clause.

Ans 105: was; 'equipment' is an uncountable noun, necessitating a singular verb.

Ans 106: B - 'are' should be replaced by 'is' because 'Six light-years' is treated as a single collective measurement of distance, not as individual years.

Ans 107: The phrase 'is calling' is grammatically incorrect. Since the sentence describes a past event ('was debating'), the interrupting action must be in the Simple Past. The correct form is 'called'.

Ans 108: The word 'friendly' is an adjective and cannot modify the verb 'interacted'. It must be replaced with the phrase 'in a friendly manner' to function adverbially.

Ans 109: Error: 'historian have'. Correct: 'historian has'. Reason: The expression 'Many a' requires a singular noun ('historian') followed by a singular verb ('has') to maintain grammatical correctness.

Ans 110: Error: Comma Splice. The sentence incorrectly joins two independent clauses using only a comma before the conjunctive adverb 'consequently'. Correction: Replace the first comma with a semicolon or a full stop. Correct version: 'The administration has implemented stringent emission norms to combat urban smog; consequently, the manufacturing sector is facing a sudden spike in operational costs.'

Ans 111: Part (C) is the error. The segment 'Since the objective is to achieve a zero-waste city by the end of the current fiscal year' is a dependent clause acting as a sentence fragment. It should be joined to the previous sentence with a comma instead of starting with a capital letter after a full stop.

Ans 112: one another; The phrase 'diverse architectural frameworks' indicates a group comprising more than two entities.

Ans 113: farther. Reason: The sentence refers to a tangible, measurable physical distance in space.

Ans 114: Part (B); 'set' must be replaced by 'sat' because the sensor is occupying a position (intransitive use), and there is no direct object being placed by the sensor.

Ans 115: B; 'have' should be replaced by 'has' because 'The United States of America' is the name of a single sovereign nation.

Ans 116: remain; 'The digitally illiterate' refers to a collective class of individuals, which necessitates a plural verb regardless of the singular nouns present in the intervening phrase.

Ans 117: Error: 'have' should be replaced with 'has'. The subject is the singular noun 'pair', not the plural noun 'calipers'.

Ans 118: Replace 'restore' with 'restored'. Reason: There is a change of subject from 'The archaeological society' to 'the curator'; therefore, the verb must be in the Simple Past tense to correctly express the hypothetical preference.

Ans 119: The error is the use of 'who's'. It should be replaced by 'whose' because the sentence requires a possessive pronoun to indicate that the principles belong to the Magna Carta, not a contraction of 'who is' or 'who has'.

Ans 120: The error is the use of 'they'. It should be replaced with 'them' because the pronoun following the verb 'let' must be in the objective case.

Ans 121: from; Complications from a procedure are considered indirect/external results rather than a primary clinical disease.

Ans 122: Error: 'governor-generals'. Correct: 'governors-general'. Reason: The principal word is 'governor', as it represents the person being counted. 'General' serves as a modifier and must remain singular.

Ans 123: Incorrect: 'six-months'; Correct: 'six-month'. Reason: 'Six-month' acts as a compound adjective modifying the noun 'moratorium' and must therefore be in the singular form.

Ans 124: Replace 'their' with 'theirs'. Reason: The word is functioning as a possessive pronoun replacing 'their discovery' and must stand alone without a following noun.

Ans 125: Replace the second occurrence of 'elder' with 'older'. Reason: While the first 'elder' is correct as it describes a family relationship attributively, the second instance is used in a comparative construction followed by 'than', which necessitates the use of 'older'.

Ans 126: The second instance of 'lately' is incorrect. It should be replaced with 'late' because it refers to the timing of the submission (tardiness), whereas the first 'lately' is correct as it denotes a recent ongoing action.

Ans 127: Part (A); the sentence is affirmative, meaning the comparison of equality must use the 'as...as' construction. Therefore, 'so impartial as' must be replaced with 'as impartial as'.

Ans 128: Part (B). The modal 'ought to' must be followed by the base form of the verb (bare infinitive), not a gerund. 'Ought to promoting' must be corrected to 'ought to promote'.

Ans 129: indicate; in this context, 'statistics' refers to the numerical data collected on biodiversity loss, not the academic discipline of statistics.

Ans 130: The correct order should be 'You, the Secretary-General, and I'. Reason: The sentence describes a positive/neutral diplomatic action, which necessitates the 2-3-1 pronoun sequence for formal etiquette.

Ans 131: The error is the use of 'on'. In formal contexts involving abstract burdens, pressures, or responsibilities, 'upon' is the grammatically superior choice. Correct sentence: 'The weight of the geopolitical tension now rests upon the diplomacy of the neutral nations to prevent a full-scale conflict.'

Ans 132: Replace 'very' with 'too'. Reason: The clause 'for the existing server architecture to sustain without overheating' indicates a limitation or a negative consequence resulting from the intensity of the demands, which necessitates the use of 'too' rather than the simple intensifier 'very'.

Ans 133: Replace 'will' with 'shall'. In the context of a formal procedure or a mandate assigned to an official (the presiding officer), 'shall' is the appropriate modal to denote a compulsory duty.

Ans 134: C; The subject of the sentence is 'The news', which is an uncountable singular noun. Therefore, the plural verb 'were' must be replaced with the singular verb 'was'.

Ans 135: The error lies in the pronoun order. Since the sentence expresses blame/failure, it must follow the 1-2-3 sequence. The correct version is: 'I, the chief architect, and the structural engineer are to be blamed for the collapse of the bridge during the inspection.'

Ans 136: (B) - It should be 'state-of-the-art infrastructure project' because 'state of the art' forms a compound adjective preceding the noun 'infrastructure project' and must be hyphenated.

Ans 137: Error: Comma Splice. The comma before 'moreover' must be replaced by a semicolon because 'moreover' is a conjunctive adverb linking two independent clauses.

Ans 138: Error: The colon is incorrectly placed before 'including'. A colon should not follow a word that introduces a list or example. The correct sentence should be: 'The rapid advancement of Artificial Intelligence presents several ethical



dilemmas, including the potential for algorithmic bias and the displacement of human labor in creative industries.'

Ans 139: The error is a punctuation mismatch. The parenthetical clause is opened with a comma ('...computing,') but closed with an em-dash ('...obsolete —'). Corrected version: 'The recent advancements in quantum computing — which could render current encryption protocols obsolete — present both an unprecedented opportunity and a severe security risk.' (Alternatively, both could be commas).

APPENDIX A: Top 100 Fixed Prepositions

Word	Preposition	Meaning	Example
Abide	by	To accept or act in accordance with a rule or decision.	You must abide by the rules of the competition.
Abstain	from	To restrain oneself from doing or enjoying something.	He decided to abstain from drinking alcohol.
Accede	to	To agree to a demand, request, or treaty.	The government finally acceded to the protesters' demands.
Accused	of	Charged with a fault or offense	He was accused of stealing the documents.
Accustomed	to	Customary or usual; used to something.	She is accustomed to waking up early.
Acquainted	with	Familiar with something	I am not acquainted with the new regulations.
Acquiesce	in	To accept something reluctantly but without protest.	He acquiesced in the decision of the committee.
Addicted	to	Physically and mentally dependent on a particular substance	The youth are becoming addicted to social media.
Adhere	to	To stick to a surface or follow a practice/belief.	Members must adhere to the club's code of conduct.
Adjacent	to	Next to or adjoining something else.	The park is adjacent to the library.
Admit	to	To confess to a crime or an error.	The suspect admitted to the robbery.
Advantageous	to	Providing an advantage; helpful.	The new trade agreement is advantageous to both nations.
Afflicted	with	Suffering from a disease or pain.	Many people in the region are afflicted with malaria.
Agree	with	To have the same opinion as someone.	I completely agree with your assessment of the situation.
Agree	to	To consent to a proposal or plan.	They agreed to the terms of the contract.
Aim	at	To point a weapon or direct an effort toward a goal.	The program is aimed at reducing poverty.
Alarmed	at	Frightened or worried by something.	We were alarmed at the sudden increase in prices.
Alien	to	Unfamiliar or foreign to a person or place.	The concept of privacy is alien to some cultures.
Allude	to	To suggest or call attention to indirectly.	The speaker alluded to the recent scandal.
Amenable	to	Open and responsive to suggestion.	The staff are amenable to the new working hours.
Amount	to	To be equivalent to.	His silence amounts to an admission of guilt.
Analogous	to	Comparable in certain respects.	The human brain is often compared as being analogous to a computer.
Annoyed	with	Irritated by a person.	She was annoyed with her brother for being late.
Apologize	to	To express regret to a person.	You should apologize to your teacher.



Word	Preposition	Meaning	Example
Appeal	to	To make a serious or urgent request.	The charity appealed to the public for donations.
Apprehensive	of	Anxious or fearful that something bad will happen.	He was apprehensive of the upcoming exam.
Apprise	of	To inform or tell someone.	Please apprise me of any changes in the schedule.
Approve	of	To have a positive opinion of someone or something	Her parents did not approve of her decision to quit her job.
Aptitude	for	A natural ability to do something.	She has a remarkable aptitude for mathematics.
Ashamed	of	Feeling guilt or embarrassment	He was deeply ashamed of his rude behavior.
Aspire	to	To direct one's hopes or ambitions toward achieving something.	Many young athletes aspire to the Olympic Games.
Assent	to	The expression of approval or agreement.	The President gave his assent to the bill.
Associate	with	To connect someone or something with something else in one's mind.	Most people associate the color red with danger.
Astonished	at	Greatly surprised or impressed.	I was astonished at her courage.
Attentive	to	Paying close attention to something.	The students were very attentive to the lecture.
Attributed	to	Regarded as being caused by.	The success was attributed to hard work.
Avail	of	To make use of an opportunity.	You should avail yourself of this opportunity.
Averse	to	Having a strong dislike of or opposition to.	He is averse to taking risks.
Believe	in	To be convinced of the truth or existence of something.	Do you believe in ghosts?
Belong	to	To be the property of.	This book belongs to the library.
Bent	on	Determined to do something.	He is bent on winning the championship.
Bereft	of	Deprived of or lacking something.	The room was bereft of any furniture.
Beset	with	Troubled or threatened persistently.	The project was beset with difficulties from the start.
Bestow	on	To confer or present an honor or gift.	The university bestowed an honorary degree on him.
Beware	of	To be cautious of a danger.	Beware of the dog.
Biased	towards	Unfairly prejudiced in favor of.	The judge was biased towards the defendant.
Blame	for	To assign responsibility for a mistake or wrongdoing.	Don't blame me for your own mistakes.
Blind	to	Unable to see or recognize the truth	A mother is often blind to the faults of her children.
Boast	of	To talk with excessive pride about something.	He boasts of his wealth and power.
Bound	for	Heading toward a specific destination.	This train is bound for New Delhi.



Word	Preposition	Meaning	Example
Capable	of	Having the ability or quality necessary to do something.	She is capable of handling the pressure.
Care	for	To look after someone or to like something.	She spends her time caring for the elderly.
Caution	against	To warn someone about a potential danger.	The doctor cautioned him against smoking.
Cede	to	To give up power or territory.	The defeated army was forced to cede territory to the enemy.
Censure	for	To express severe disapproval of someone.	The politician was censured for his misconduct.
Certain	of	Confident about something.	I am certain of my success.
Cling	to	To hold on tightly to something or a belief.	He clings to the hope that she will return.
Close	to	Near in space or relationship.	The hotel is very close to the airport.
Coincide	with	To happen at the same time.	My holiday coincides with the festival.
Compliant	with	Meeting or obeying a set of rules.	The product is compliant with safety standards.
Comply	with	To act in accordance with a wish or command	All citizens must comply with the law.
Condemn	to	Sentence someone to a particular punishment	The murderer was condemned to death.
Confide	in	To tell someone a secret because you trust them.	She confided in her best friend about her problems.
Confident	of	Feeling or showing certainty about something	The team is confident of winning the championship.
Confine	to	To keep someone or something within certain limits.	Please confine your remarks to the topic.
Congratulate	on	To praise someone for an achievement.	I congratulated him on his promotion.
Conscious	of	Aware of something.	He was conscious of the danger.
Consent	to	To give permission for something to happen.	The parents consented to the marriage.
Consist	of	To be composed or made up of.	The team consists of eleven players.
Contrary	to	Opposite in nature, direction, or meaning.	Contrary to popular belief, cats can be trained.
Contribute	to	To give something in order to help achieve or provide something.	Many people contributed to the relief fund.
Converge	on	To meet at a point.	The two roads converge on the city center.
Convict	of	To declare someone guilty of a criminal offense.	He was convicted of murder.



Word	Preposition	Meaning	Example
Cope	with	To deal effectively with something difficult.	It is hard to cope with the loss of a loved one.
Correlate	with	To have a mutual relationship or connection.	Diet often correlates with overall health.
Count	on	To rely on someone.	You can always count on me for help.
Cure	of	To make someone healthy again after an illness.	The medicine cured him of the infection.
Depend	on	To rely on or be determined by.	Our success depends on your hard work.
Deprive	of	To prevent someone from having something.	Sleep deprivation deprives the brain of essential rest.
Desirous	of	Having or characterized by desire.	He was desirous of fame and fortune.
Despair	of	To lose all hope of something.	Do not despair of success.
Detach	from	To disconnect or separate.	Detach the coupon from the flyer.
Deter	from	To discourage someone from doing something.	The high price deters people from buying the car.
Devoid	of	Entirely lacking or free from.	His voice was devoid of emotion.
Devote	to	To give all or a large part of one's time or resources to.	She devoted her life to helping the poor.
Differ	from	To be unlike or distinct.	This model differs from the previous one in several ways.
Differ	with	To disagree with someone	I must differ with you on that point.
Diffident	of	Lacking self-confidence.	He was diffident of his own abilities.
Digress	from	To leave the main subject temporarily in speech or writing.	Let me digress from the main point for a moment.
Disagree	with	To have a different opinion.	I disagree with your conclusion.
Disappointed	with	Sad or displeased because someone or something failed to fulfill hopes.	I was disappointed with the results of the test.
Disapprove	of	To have a poor opinion of something.	My parents disapprove of my choice of career.
Dispose	of	To get rid of something.	Please dispose of the waste properly.
Disqualified	from	To be officially stopped from participating.	He was disqualified from the race for cheating.
Dissatisfied	with	Not content or happy with something.	The customer was dissatisfied with the service.
Distinguish	from	To recognize the difference between two things.	It is hard to distinguish the twin brothers from each other.
Diverge	from	To separate from another route or opinion.	His views diverge from the party line.
Divest	of	To deprive someone of power, rights, or possessions.	The king was divested of his power.



Word	Preposition	Meaning	Example
Dwell	on	To think or speak about something for too long.	There is no need to dwell on past mistakes.
Eager	for	Strongly wanting to do or have something.	The children were eager for the holidays.
Eligible	for	Having the right to do or obtain something.	You are eligible for a promotion.
Emanate	from	To spread out from a source.	A strange smell emanated from the kitchen.
Embark	on	To begin a new venture or journey.	She is about to embark on a new career.
Enamoured	of	Be filled with a feeling of love for.	He became enamoured of the local culture.
Engaged	in	Participating in an activity.	They were engaged in a heated debate.
Enquire	into	To investigate a matter.	The police are enquiring into the cause of the accident.
Enraged	at	Very angry about something.	He was enraged at the injustice.
Enrolled	in	Officially registered as a member of a course.	She enrolled in a photography class.
Entitled	to	Having a right to something.	Everyone is entitled to their own opinion.
Envious	of	Feeling or showing envy.	She was envious of her sister's success.
Exempt	from	Free from an obligation or liability imposed on others	His income is exempt from taxation.
Fatal	to	Causing death or disaster	This mistake proved fatal to his career.
Fond	of	Having an affection or liking for	Children are fond of sweets and chocolates.
Guilty	of	Culpable of or responsible for a specified wrongdoing	The jury found him guilty of murder.
Ignorant	of	Lacking knowledge or awareness in general	She was totally ignorant of the conspiracy against her.
Indebted	to	Owing gratitude for a service or favor	I am deeply indebted to you for your timely help.
Indifferent	to	Having no particular interest or sympathy; unconcerned	The authorities seem indifferent to the plight of the poor.
Inferior	to	Lower in rank, status, or quality	This fabric is inferior to the one we bought yesterday.
Injurious	to	Causing or likely to cause damage or harm	Smoking is injurious to health.
Jealous	of	Feeling or showing envy of someone or their achievements and advantages	He was terribly jealous of his brother's success.
Junior	to	Lower in rank or length of service	He is junior to me in service by three years.
Key	to	The crucial step or element in achieving something	Hard work is the key to success.
Liable	to	Likely to do or to be something	If you drive recklessly, you are liable to get into an accident.



Word	Preposition	Meaning	Example
Liabe	for	Responsible by law; legally answerable	The company is liable for any damage caused.
Obedient	to	Complying or willing to comply with orders or requests	A student should be obedient to his teachers.
Object	to	Say something to express one's disapproval of or disagreement with something	Many local residents object to the new building plans.
Part	with	To give something to someone else, especially when you do not want to	A miser cannot part with his money.
Part	from	To leave someone	He parted from his friends with a heavy heart.
Peculiar	to	Belonging exclusively to	This custom is peculiar to the tribal people of this region.
Prefer	to	Like one thing or person better than another or others	I prefer tea to coffee.
Prior	to	Existing or coming before in time, order, or importance	The contract must be signed prior to the commencement of work.
Prohibit	from	Formally forbid a person or group from doing something	Employees are prohibited from smoking inside the office.
Senior	to	Of a higher age, rank, or status than another	She is senior to me in this department.
Superior	to	Higher in rank, status, or quality	German cars are generally considered superior to others.
Sympathize	with	Agree with a sentiment or opinion	We deeply sympathize with the flood victims.
Teem	with	Be full of or swarming with	The river is teeming with fish.
Yield	to	Give way to arguments, demands, or pressure	He refused to yield to their unjust demands.

APPENDIX B: Top 100 Phrasal Verbs

Verb	Meaning	Example
Back	To support or copy data.	I will back you up in the meeting.
Back	To withdraw a claim.	He refused to back down from his position.
Back	To withdraw from a commitment or agreement	He promised to invest, but backed out at the last minute.
Bear	To be patient with	Please bear with me while I find the required documents.
Blow	To explode; to become angry suddenly	The terrorist tried to blow up the bridge.
Break	To stop functioning.	My car broke down on the way to the office.
Break	To start suddenly (war, fire, disease).	Cholera broke out in the village.
Break	To make a discovery or overcome a barrier.	Scientists have broken through in cancer research.
Break	To end a relationship.	They broke up after three years of dating.
Break	To stop abruptly.	She broke off in the middle of her sentence.
Break	To enter by force	Burglars broke into the house while we were asleep.
Bring	To raise a child or mention a topic.	She was brought up by her grandparents.
Bring	To cause to happen.	The new law brought about significant changes.
Bring	To publish or make prominent.	The author is bringing out a new book next month.
Bring	To reduce or overthrow.	The scandal brought down the government.
Bring	To return or recall to mind.	This song brings back old memories.
Call	To cancel.	The match was called off due to heavy rain.
Call	To shout or summon.	The teacher called out the students' names.
Call	To return a phone call.	I will call you back in ten minutes.
Call	To visit someone.	I will call on you tomorrow evening.
Call	To demand or require.	This situation calls for immediate action.
Carry	To execute or perform a task.	The soldiers carried out the orders.
Carry	To continue.	Please carry on with your work.
Carry	To be overwhelmed by emotion.	He got carried away by the applause.
Carry	To complete successfully.	His determination carried him through the crisis.
Come	To find by chance.	I came across an old friend at the mall.
Come	To obtain something.	How did you come by this rare coin?
Come	To happen.	How did this misunderstanding come about?
Come	To recover consciousness.	The patient finally came round after the surgery.
Come	To suggest an idea.	She came up with a brilliant plan.
Cut	To reduce the amount of something.	The doctor told him to cut down on sugar.



Verb	Meaning	Example
Cut	To disconnect or interrupt.	The electricity was cut off due to non-payment.
Cut	To remove or stop doing something.	You must cut out junk food from your diet.
Cut	To take a shorter route.	We cut across the field to reach the station.
Cut	To reduce the amount of something	The doctor advised him to cut down on sugar.
Do	To abolish or get rid of.	We should do away with these outdated rules.
Do	To fasten or decorate.	Do up your shoelaces before you fall.
Do	To repeat.	The teacher asked him to do the assignment over.
Fall	To quarrel or argue.	The two brothers fell out over a property dispute.
Fall	To fail to happen.	The deal fell through at the last minute.
Fall	To break into pieces.	The old book fell apart in my hands.
Fall	To fail to keep pace.	He fell behind in his studies due to illness.
Get	To have a friendly relationship.	I get along well with my colleagues.
Get	To recover from.	It took her months to get over the breakup.
Get	To escape.	The thief managed to get away from the police.
Get	To manage to survive.	It is hard to get by on a minimum wage.
Get	To finish or connect by phone.	I couldn't get through to the customer care.
Get	To rise from bed.	I get up at 5 AM every morning.
Get	To leave a vehicle.	We get off the bus at the next stop.
Give	To stop trying or surrender.	He gave up smoking last year.
Give	To surrender.	The rebels finally gave in to the army.
Give	To reveal a secret or donate.	Don't give away the ending of the movie.
Give	To distribute or stop working.	The teacher gave out the question papers.
Give	To emit.	The chemical gave off a strange smell.
Go	To examine carefully or experience difficulty.	She went through a lot of pain after the accident.
Go	To continue.	The meeting went on for three hours.
Go	To review.	Let's go over the notes once more.
Go	To explode or ring.	The alarm went off at 6 AM.
Go	To return.	I want to go back to my hometown.
Hold	To wait for a short time.	Please hold on while I check the files.
Hold	To delay or rob.	Traffic held us up for an hour.
Hold	To restrain.	She struggled to hold back her tears.
Hold	To resist or last.	The soldiers held out against the enemy for weeks.
Keep	To maintain a certain pace or level.	You are doing great; keep up the good work!



Verb	Meaning	Example
Keep	To continue doing something.	Keep on trying until you succeed.
Keep	To avoid.	Keep away from the edge of the cliff.
Keep	To avoid touching or stay away.	Please keep off the grass.
Keep	To maintain distance.	The police told the crowd to keep back.
Keep	To progress at the same rate as someone or something else	He found it hard to keep up with the rest of the class.
Look	To investigate.	The police will look into the matter.
Look	To take care of.	She looks after her elderly parents.
Look	To search.	I am looking for my lost keys.
Look	To search for information in a book/list.	Look up the word in the dictionary.
Look	To despise.	He looks down on people who are not educated.
Look	To anticipate with pleasure.	I look forward to meeting you.
Look	To examine quickly.	Please look over the contract before signing.
Look	To regard with contempt or feeling of superiority	One should never look down upon the poor.
Make	To invent a story or reconcile.	He made up an excuse for being late.
Make	To discern or understand.	I cannot make out what he is saying.
Make	To move towards.	As soon as the bell rang, the students made for the exit.
Make	To leave hurriedly.	The thief made off with the jewelry.
Make	To compensate for	Nothing can make up for the loss of a parent.
Pass	To die	His grandfather passed away peacefully in his sleep.
Put	To postpone.	Never put off until tomorrow what you can do today.
Put	To extinguish.	Firefighters worked hard to put out the fire.
Put	To tolerate.	I cannot put up with his rude behavior.
Put	To communicate clearly.	He put his ideas across very effectively.
Put	To insult or write down.	Stop putting me down in front of others.
Run	To have no more of something.	We have run out of petrol.
Run	To meet by chance.	I ran into my old teacher at the airport.
Run	To hit with a vehicle.	The cat was almost run over by the car.
Run	To escape.	The dog ran away from the house.
Set	To establish or start a business.	He set up his own consultancy firm.
Set	To start a journey.	They set off for the mountains at dawn.
Set	To begin a task or journey.	He set out to prove the theory.
Set	To delay.	The rain set back the construction work.



Verb	Meaning	Example
Set	To begin (usually weather/season).	Winter has set in early this year.
Set	To save for a special purpose; to annul	The High Court set aside the lower court's verdict.
Stand	To support; to be ready for action	A true friend will stand by you in times of trouble.
Take	To leave the ground (plane) or remove clothing.	The plane took off at 6 PM.
Take	To assume control.	The company was taken over by a rival.
Take	To start a hobby or occupy space.	He took up painting in his retirement.
Take	To resemble a parent.	She takes after her mother.
Take	To write notes or dismantle.	Please take down the minutes of the meeting.
Turn	To reject an offer or lower volume.	She turned down the job offer.
Turn	To arrive or increase volume.	He turned up late for the interview.
Turn	To stop a device.	Turn off the lights before you leave.
Turn	To result or prove to be.	The party turned out to be a great success.
Turn	To become.	The caterpillar turned into a butterfly.
Work	To solve a problem or exercise.	I cannot work out this math problem.
Work	To develop (emotion/appetite).	He worked up the courage to ask her out.



APPENDIX C: Confusing Word Pairs

Word1	Meaning1	Word2	Meaning2
Affect	(Verb) To influence.	Effect	(Noun) The result.
Elicit	To draw out.	Illicit	Illegal.
Stationary	Not moving.	Stationery	Writing materials.
Principal	Head of school/Main.	Principle	A fundamental truth.
Compliment	Praise.	Complement	To complete or make perfect.
Allusion	An indirect reference.	Illusion	A false perception.
Eminent	Famous and respected.	Imminent	About to happen.
Loose	Not tight.	Lose	To fail to win / misplace.
Council	An advisory body.	Counsel	Advice.
Capital	City / Wealth.	Capitol	Building where legislature meets.
Accept	To receive.	Except	To exclude.
Adapt	To adjust.	Adopt	To take as one's own.
Advice	(Noun) Recommendation.	Advise	(Verb) To recommend.
Altar	Sacred table.	Alter	To change.
Ascent	Upward movement.	Assent	Agreement.
Brake	Stopping device.	Break	To smash.
Canvas	Heavy cloth.	Canvass	To solicit votes.
Chord	Musical notes.	Cord	Rope.
Coarse	Rough.	Course	Path / Class.
Desert	Arid land / Abandon.	Dessert	Sweet food.
Discreet	Careful in speech.	Discrete	Separate/distinct.
Dual	Twofold.	Duel	Fight.
Envelop	To wrap.	Envelope	Paper container.
Fair	Just / Event.	Fare	Cost of travel.
Flair	Talent.	Flare	Burst of light.
Grate	Shred / Irritate.	Great	Large / Excellent.
Hoard	Hidden supply.	Horde	Large crowd.
Hole	Empty space.	Whole	Entire.
Lead	Metal.	Led	Past tense of lead.
Lessen	To reduce.	Lesson	Something learned.
Lightning	Flash from sky.	Lightening	Making lighter.
Meat	Animal flesh.	Meet	To encounter.



Word1	Meaning1	Word2	Meaning2
Miner	Worker in a mine.	Minor	Underage / Lesser.
Moral	Ethical.	Morale	Mental/emotional state.
Naval	Related to navy.	Navel	Belly button.
Palate	Roof of mouth / Taste.	Palette	Artist board.
Passed	Went by.	Past	Time gone by.
Peace	Tranquility.	Piece	Portion.
Peak	Top.	Peek	Quick look.
Pedal	Foot lever.	Peddle	To sell.
Access	Approach or admittance.	Excess	More than enough.
Censor	To remove objectionable material.	Sensor	A device that detects.
Cite	To quote.	Site	A location.
Complement	To complete or make perfect.	Compliment	Praise.
Conscious	Awake; aware.	Conscience	Moral sense.
Device	A tool or machine (noun).	Devise	To invent (verb).
Emigrate	To leave a country.	Immigrate	To enter a country.
Ensure	To make certain.	Insure	To protect against loss.
Farther	Physical distance.	Further	Metaphorical distance or additional.
Flaunt	To show off.	Flout	To disregard a rule.
Forth	Forward.	Fourth	Number four.
Imply	To suggest indirectly.	Infer	To deduce or conclude.
It's	It is or it has.	Its	Belonging to it.
Later	After some time.	Latter	The second of two things.
Lay	To put something down (requires object).	Lie	To rest or recline.
Meter	A unit of length.	Metre	Rhythm in poetry (or British spelling of meter).
Personal	Private.	Personnel	Employees.
Plain	Simple; flat land.	Plane	Aircraft; flat surface.
Pore	To study carefully; a tiny opening.	Pour	To flow continuously.
Prophecy	A prediction (noun).	Prophesy	To predict (verb).
Quiet	Silent.	Quite	Very; completely.
Right	Correct; direction.	Write	To put words on paper.
Role	A part played by an actor.	Roll	To turn over; bread.



Word1	Meaning1	Word2	Meaning2
Scene	A view; part of a play.	Seen	Past participle of see.
Sight	Vision.	Site	Location.
Than	Used for comparison.	Then	At that time.
Their	Belonging to them.	There	In that place.
To	Direction.	Too	Also; excessively.
Vain	Conceited; useless.	Vein	Blood vessel.
Weather	Atmospheric conditions.	Whether	If; indicating a choice.
Whose	Belonging to whom.	Who's	Who is or who has.



APPENDIX D: Confusing Word Triplets

Word1	Meaning1	Word2	Meaning2	Word3	Meaning3
Ensure	Make certain.	Insure	Protect against loss.	Assure	Give confidence to.
Cite	Quote.	Site	Location.	Sight	Vision.
There	Place.	Their	Possessive of they.	They're	They are.
Right	Correct.	Write	To form letters.	Rite	Ceremony.
Cent	Coin.	Scent	Smell.	Sent	Dispatched.
Vain	Conceited.	Vane	Weather pointer.	Vein	Blood vessel.
To	Preposition.	Too	Also / Excess.	Two	Number 2.
Palate	Taste.	Palette	Paint board.	Pallet	Wooden platform.
Rain	Water.	Reign	Rule.	Rein	Strap for horse.
Bite	Use teeth.	Bight	Curve in coast.	Byte	Computer data.
Sight	Vision.	Site	Location.	Cite	To quote.
Heal	To cure.	Heel	Back part of foot.	He'll	He will.
Idle	Not working.	Idol	Object of worship.	Idyll	Peaceful rural scene.
Medal	Award.	Meddle	Interfere.	Metal	Solid material.
Peak	Top.	Peek	Quick look.	Pique	Irritation or interest.
Raise	Lift up.	Raze	Destroy completely.	Rays	Beams of light.
Soar	Fly high.	Sore	Painful.	Source	Origin.
Suite	Set of rooms.	Sweet	Sugary taste.	Suit	Set of clothes or court case.
Tear	Drop from eye.	Tare	Weight of empty container.	Tier	Level or rank.
Ware	Goods.	Wear	To have on body.	Where	In what place.
By	Near.	Buy	Purchase.	Bye	Farewell.

QUICK REFERENCE TABLES

These 9 highly-detailed reference tables summarize the most tested grammatical concepts, exceptions, and examiner traps in banking and SSC exams.

1. Personal Pronouns & Cases

Person	Subjective (Does action)	Objective (Receives action)	Possessive Adj. (Needs noun)	Possessive Pron. (Stands alone)	Reflexive (Self)
1st (Singular)	I	Me	My (my book)	Mine (is mine)	Myself
1st (Plural)	We	Us	Our (our house)	Ours (is ours)	Ourselves
2nd (Singular)	You	You	Your	Yours	Yourself
2nd (Plural)	You	You	Your	Yours	Yourselves
3rd (Male)	He	Him	His	His	Himself
3rd (Female)	She	Her	Her	Hers	Herself
3rd (Neutral)	It	It	Its	N/A	Itself
3rd (Plural)	They	Them	Their	Theirs	Themselves
Indefinite	One	One	One's	N/A	Oneself

2. Conditional Sentences (Tense Pairing & Inversions)

Condition Type	If-Clause (Condition)	Main Clause (Result)	Example / Inversion (Trap)
Zero (Universal Truth)	Simple Present	Simple Present	If you heat ice, it melts.
Type 1 (Real Future)	Simple Present	Simple Future (will+V1)	If he studies, he will pass.
Type 2 (Unreal Present)	Simple Past (V2 / were)	Would + V1	If I were rich, I would travel. (Were I rich, I would travel.)
Type 3 (Unreal Past)	Past Perfect (had + V3)	Would have + V3	If he had run, he would have won. (Had he run, he would have won.)

Mixed Conditional	Past Perfect (had + V3)	Would + V1 (now)	If I had studied, I would be a doctor now.
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3. Prepositions of Time (Complete Chart)

Preposition	Usage / Context	Exam Examples
In	Months, Years, Seasons, Centuries, Parts of day	In May, In 2024, In Summer, In the morning
On	Days, Dates, Specific days, Occasions	On Sunday, On 15th August, On Diwali day
At	Precise clock time, Festivals, Night, Noon	At 5 PM, At Diwali, At night, At noon
Since	Starting point of an action (Perfect tenses)	Since 1990, Since Monday, Since childhood
For	Duration / Period of time (Perfect tenses)	For 5 years, For two months, For a long time
By	Deadlines (Not later than)	Submit the report by Monday / by 5 PM.
From... To	Starting and ending points	The bank is open from 9 AM to 4 PM.

4. Prepositions of Place & Direction

Preposition	Usage / Context	Exam Examples
In	Enclosed spaces, Large cities, Countries	In a room, In Delhi, In India, In the bag
On	Surfaces, Streets, Floors, Lines	On the table, On MG Road, On the 2nd floor
At	Specific points, Addresses, Exact Locations	At the bus stop, At 123 Baker St, At the door
Over	Vertically above (not touching), Covering	The fan is over my head. Put a blanket over him.
Under	Vertically below, Covered by	The cat is under the table. Under pressure.
Above	Higher than (level/scale)	His score is above average. Lake is above sea level.
Below	Lower than (level/scale)	Temperature is below zero. Below the poverty line.
Into	Movement from outside to inside	He jumped into the river.
Onto	Movement to a surface	The cat jumped onto the table.

5. Active vs. Passive Voice (Complete Tense Rules)

Tense / Structure	Active Voice	Passive Voice
Simple Present	He writes a letter.	A letter is written by him.
Present Continuous	He is writing a letter.	A letter is being written by him.
Present Perfect	He has written a letter.	A letter has been written by him.
Simple Past	He wrote a letter.	A letter was written by him.
Past Continuous	He was writing a letter.	A letter was being written by him.
Past Perfect	He had written a letter.	A letter had been written by him.
Simple Future	He will write a letter.	A letter will be written by him.
Future Perfect	He will have written a letter.	A letter will have been written by him.
Modals (Can/Must)	He must write a letter.	A letter must be written by him.
Imperative (Command)	Open the door.	Let the door be opened.
Infinitive (To + V1)	I have to write a letter.	A letter has to be written by me.

6. Direct vs. Indirect Speech (Backshift & Time Words)

Category	Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Tense: Present	Simple Present, Present Cont.	Simple Past, Past Cont.
Tense: Past	Simple Past, Past Cont.	Past Perfect, Past Perfect Cont.
Modals	Will, Shall, Can, May	Would, Should, Could, Might
Time Words 1	Now, Today, Tonight	Then, That day, That night
Time Words 2	Tomorrow, Yesterday	The next day, The previous day
Place Words	Here, This, These	There, That, Those
Universal Truths	The sun rises in the east.	NO TENSE CHANGE (The sun rises...)

7. Countable vs. Uncountable Nouns (High-Frequency Traps)



Category	Countable Nouns	Uncountable Nouns (Never take s/es or a/an)
Grammar Rules	Use: Many, Few, A/An Take singular OR plural verbs	Use: Much, Little, Some ALWAYS take singular verbs
Knowledge / Data	Fact, Idea, Report, Detail	Information, Knowledge, Evidence, Advice, News
Household / Travel	Bag, Suitcase, Chair, Table	Luggage, Baggage, Furniture, Equipment, Machinery
Nature / Arts	Poem, View, Song, Job	Poetry, Scenery, Music, Work, Mischief, Alphabet
Food / Materials	Loaf, Bottle, Coin	Bread, Water, Money, Hair, Paper, Wood, Glass
Exceptions (Trap)	A piece of advice, A strand of hair	Cannot say: "advices", "furnitures", "informations"

8. Confusing Adjectives (Comparative & Superlative Traps)

Positive	Comparative	Superlative	Usage / Context in Exams
Old	Older / Elder	Oldest / Eldest	Elder/Eldest = Blood relations. Older = Age/Things.
Far	Farther / Further	Farthest / Furthest	Farther = Physical distance. Further = Additional/Next.
Late	Later / Latter	Latest / Last	Latter = Second of two. Latest = Time. Last = Order.
Little	Less / Lesser	Least	Less = Quantity (Uncountable). Fewer = Number (Countable).
Much/Many	More	Most	Much = Uncountable noun. Many = Countable noun.
Good/Well	Better	Best	Good is an adjective. Well is an adverb (usually).

9. Transitive Verbs (NO Prepositions in Active Voice)

Verb	Incorrect Usage (Examiner Trap)	Correct Usage (Active Voice)
Discuss	Discuss about the matter	Discuss the matter



Describe	Describe about the event	Describe the event
Order	Order for a coffee	Order a coffee
Emphasize	Emphasize on the point	Emphasize the point
Attack	Attack on the enemy	Attack the enemy
Investigate	Investigate into the case	Investigate the case
Comprise	Comprise of 10 members	Comprise 10 members (Passive: is comprised of)
Enter	Enter into the room	Enter the room (Enter into an agreement is correct)
Resemble	Resemble to/with his father	Resemble his father
Accompany	Accompanied with his friend	Accompanied by his friend
Sign	Sign on the paper	Sign the paper



150-QUESTION MEGA MOCK TEST

Time Limit: 30 Minutes | 1 Mark per Question | No Negative Marking

Q1. While the government proclaimed that the consolidation of public sector banks would yield immense operational synergies, labor unions feared that the massive integration process would only _____ existing administrative redundancies and _____ customer service during the transition phase.

- A) exacerbate, deteriorate
- B) alleviate, compound
- C) obviate, compromise
- D) accentuate, ameliorate
- E) mitigate, jeopardize

Q2. Many central banks are exploring digital currencies to _____ the transaction costs associated with printing and distributing physical fiat money.

- A) mitigate
- B) escalate
- C) stagnate
- D) accumulate
- E) advocate

Q3. (A) The implementation of macroprudential measures, / (B) along with stringent capital adequacy ratios and enhanced liquidity buffers, / (C) are projected to fortify the domestic banking sector / (D) against systemic shocks arising from volatile global capital flows.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q4. (A) Amid growing regulatory scrutiny over greenwashing, / (B) several prominent investment funds have publicly committed to align / (C) their portfolio allocations with strict ESG benchmarks / (D) through the implementation of rigorous carbon-accounting frameworks.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q5. In its relentless pursuit of price stability, the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee sought to _____ the persistent overnight liquidity overhang via targeted variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auctions, fearing that an unaddressed cash surplus would compromise policy transmission and plunge the money market into a highly volatile _____, even as older, quantitative easing-era liquidity conduits fell into _____.

- A) sterilize ... epoch ... desuetude
- B) exacerbate ... interregnum ... abeyance
- C) amortize ... welter ... resonance
- D) attenuate ... quietude ... provenance
- E) subsume ... imbroglio ... stasis

Q6. (A) Amid growing concerns over capital flight, / (B) the central bank has aggressively intervened in the spot market / (C) with a view to bolster its depleting forex reserves / (D) and shielding the domestic currency from speculative attacks.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error



Q7. As decentralized finance platforms scale rapidly, developers must ****iron out the kinks**** in the consensus algorithm to prevent potential vulnerabilities during high-frequency transaction periods.

- A) sweep under the rug
- B) resolve the technical imperfections
- C) flesh out the details
- D) bridge the gap
- E) No improvement needed

Q8. The NPCI's mandate for the integration of Unified Payments Interface (UPI) with the Digital Rupee (CBDC) framework aims to mitigate the friction of cross-platform liquidity management, provided that the settlement protocols ****are aligned to the real-time gross settlement (RTGS) standards for precluding latent discrepancy in the ledger reconciliation processes.****

- A) are aligned with the real-time gross settlement (RTGS) standards to preclude latent discrepancies in the ledger reconciliation process
- B) are aligned with the real-time gross settlement (RTGS) standards for precluding latent discrepancies in the ledger reconciliation processes
- C) are aligned with the real-time gross settlement (RTGS) standards to preclude latent discrepancy in the ledger reconciliation process
- D) are aligned with the real-time gross settlement (RTGS) standards to preclude latent discrepancies in the ledger reconciliation processes
- E) No correction required

Q9. Under the stringent capital adequacy mandates of Basel III, national regulators are forcing systemically important financial institutions (G-SIBs) to _____ their Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) capital ratios, while simultaneously _____ the internal rating-based (IRB) models used for risk-weighted assets, effectively relegating legacy, non-compliant hybrid instruments to a state of regulatory _____.

- A) bolster ... recalibrating ... desuetude
- B) attenuate ... proselytizing ... limbo
- C) amortize ... obfuscating ... abeyance
- D) dilute ... circumscribing ... permanence
- E) liquidate ... deprecating ... resonance

Q10. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) Seldom have the members of the Monetary Policy Committee exhibited such deep division over the trajectory of the repo rate, / (B) as persistent food inflation continues to de-anchor inflationary expectations despite a prolonged pause in rate hikes, / (C) and under no circumstances the central bank can afford to lower its guard / (D) lest a premature pivot should jeopardize the hard-won gains of macroeconomic stability.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q11. To prevent hostile takeovers of undervalued domestic firms during global market downturns, the government decided to _____ FDI inflows under the automatic route, forcing foreign entities through a tedious regulatory _____ designed to preserve national _____ over strategic infrastructure.

- A) circumscribe ... rigmarole ... prerogative
- B) proscribe ... quietude ... desuetude
- C) subsume ... imbroglia ... aberration
- D) expatriate ... welter ... resonance
- E) interdict ... synergy ... autarky

Q12. Read the sentence: (A) The compliance committee confirmed that the unclaimed offshore assets, / (B) which are currently belonging to the subsidiary of the multinational conglomerate, / (C) must be frozen immediately in accordance with / (D) the newly amended anti-money laundering directives.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C



- D) D
- E) No Error

Q13. Investors have grown increasingly skeptical of oil conglomerates that use green bond proceeds as ****smoke and mirrors**** to distract from their continued expansion of fossil fuel extraction projects.

- A) a facade to obscure reality
- B) a blueprint for transition
- C) an attempt to bridge the gap
- D) a catalyst for greenwashing
- E) No improvement needed

Q14. (A) Amid persistent food price shocks and volatile global commodity markets, / (B) the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee has decided to retain its hawkish stance, / (C) remaining resolutely committed to align inflation with the four percent target / (D) while it closely monitors the pass-through of past policy rate hikes.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q15. (A) Despite facing headwinds from volatile global commodity prices, / (B) the fiscal policy committee remains committed to implement / (C) targeted structural reforms aimed at fostering long-term productivity growth / (D) while gradually consolidating the sovereign debt-to-GDP ratio.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q16. The government decided to consolidate several public sector banks in order to _____ their capital base and reduce operational redundancies across the banking sector.

- A) bolster
- B) deplete
- C) jeopardize
- D) disrupt
- E) stagnate

Q17. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) No sooner had the banking regulator mandated a stringent, asset-quality review to identify hidden non-performing assets / (B) than the state-run lenders scrambled to provision for these toxic loans, significantly eroding their capital adequacy ratios / (C) and triggering a sharp contraction in credit growth, nor has the structural bottlenecks inherent in the insolvency framework / (D) expedited the resolution process as seamlessly as the policymakers had originally envisioned.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q18. In its bid to curb persistent inflationary pressures without disrupting a fragile post-pandemic recovery, the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee scrambled to _____ the surplus liquidity sloshing in the banking system, even as retail inflation threatened to push real interest rates into a depressing _____, forcing the central bank to keep its aggressive stance of 'accommodation withdrawal' in temporary _____ pending clearer growth indicators.

- A) sterilize ... nadir ... abeyance
- B) amortize ... apogee ... desuetude
- C) expatriate ... welter ... limbo
- D) demarcate ... zenith ... moratorium
- E) assuage ... vertex ... recession



Q19. Read the sentence: (A) The senior portfolio managers at the sovereign wealth fund / (B) consistently executed high-yield transactions / (C) with far greater precision and market foresight / (D) than him.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q20. (A) In an effort to bolster rural financial inclusion, / (B) the National Payments Corporation of India has upgraded the UPI Lite platform / (C) with a view to expand offline transaction limits / (D) and facilitating seamless micro-payments in low-connectivity zones.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q21. Central banks have decided to scale down their stimulus packages as inflation continues to dampen economic recovery efforts during the global recession.

- A) scale back
- B) scale off
- C) scale away
- D) scale into
- E) No replacement

Q22. As the surge in toxic assets threatens bank liquidity, the regulator must ****paint themselves into a corner**** to ensure rigorous debt recovery without triggering a catastrophic credit crunch for the MSME sector.

- A) tread a fine line
- B) call the shots
- C) flesh out the details
- D) dig their heels in
- E) No improvement needed

Q23. The integration of the UPI framework with cross-border payment rails necessitates that the settlement obligations of participating member banks ****is reconciled in a manner which precludes any temporal mismatch between the debiting of the remitting entity and the crediting of the beneficiary account.****

- A) be reconciled in a manner that preclude any temporal mismatch between the debiting of the remitting entity and the crediting of the beneficiary account
- B) be reconciled in a manner that precludes any temporal mismatch between the debiting of the remitting entity and the crediting of the beneficiary account
- C) are reconciled in a manner that precludes any temporal mismatch between the debiting of the remitting entity and the crediting of the beneficiary account
- D) be reconciled in a manner which precludes any temporal mismatch between the debiting of the remitting entity and the crediting of the beneficiary account
- E) No correction required

Q24. During the high-stakes consolidation of India's public sector banks, the Herculean task to _____ incompatible Core Banking Solution (CBS) architectures across the merged entities plunged the transitional IT steering committees into an administrative _____, leaving critical middle-market loan approvals in a state of operational _____ until unified credit-appraisal policies could be gazetted.

- A) reconcile ... welter ... purgatory
- B) extirpate ... quietude ... abeyance
- C) demarcate ... imbroglio ... resonance
- D) obfuscate ... schism ... desuetude
- E) assuage ... nexus ... stagnation

Q25. The Reserve Bank of India decided to hike the repo rate in its recent monetary policy review to _____ the surging inflation caused by global supply chain disruptions.

- A) mitigate



- B) exacerbate
- C) prolong
- D) stimulate
- E) induce

Q26. The recent surge in slippages within the infrastructure sector has compelled the credit committee to **ensure the adequacy of provisions made against non-performing advances so as to mitigate any potential erosions of the capital adequacy ratio**.

- A) ensure the adequacy of provisions made against non-performing advances so as to mitigate any potential erosion of the capital adequacy ratio
- B) ensure the adequacy of provision made against non-performing advances so as to mitigate any potential erosion of the capital adequacy ratio
- C) ensure the adequacy of provisions made against non-performing advances so as to mitigate any potential erosion to the capital adequacy ratio
- D) ensure an adequacy of provisions made against non-performing advances so as to mitigate any potential erosion of the capital adequacy ratio
- E) No correction required

Q27. By issuing its maiden sovereign green bonds, the government aims to _____ capital specifically for projects that reduce the carbon intensity of the economy.

- A) mobilize
- B) deplete
- C) divert
- D) forfeit
- E) balk

Q28. Read the sentence: (A) The central bank's newly issued sovereign green bond is / (B) structured such that its yield profile is / (C) secure than lucrative, appealing primarily to risk-averse institutional investors / (D) seeking long-term capital preservation over high speculative returns.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q29. To _____ the high volatility risks associated with decentralized finance (DeFi), global regulators are planning to introduce a standardized framework for stablecoins.

- A) mitigate
- B) aggravate
- C) foster
- D) neglect
- E) manipulate

Q30. Analysts warn that the central bank's _____ response to supply-chain disruptions risks _____ inflationary expectations among consumers, making the price spiral much harder to reverse.

- A) dilatory, entrenching
- B) proactive, dampening
- C) resolute, exacerbating
- D) vacillating, alleviating
- E) precipitous, stabilizing

Q31. The Reserve Bank of India has mandated stricter capital adequacy ratios under the Basel III framework to _____ the banking sector against systemic financial shocks.

- A) bolster
- B) jeopardize
- C) dilute
- D) destabilize
- E) bypass



Q32. In response to heightened stock market volatility, retail investors are restructuring their portfolios to include defensive assets that can _____ potential capital losses.

- A) mitigate
- B) exacerbate
- C) precipitate
- D) forecast
- E) undergo

Q33. As global central banks tighten monetary policy to combat stagflation, emerging market sovereigns must preemptively fortify their foreign exchange reserves, lest they **fail to avert the risk of massive currency depreciations resulting from heightened liquidity stresses triggered by a global recession.**

- A) fail to avert a risk of massive currency depreciation resulting from heightened liquidity stresses triggered by a global recession
- B) fail in averting the risk of massive currency depreciation resulting from heightened liquidity stress triggered by a global recession
- C) fail to avert the risk of massive currency depreciation resulting from heightened liquidity stress triggered by a global recession
- D) fail in averting the risk of massive currency depreciations resulting from heightened liquidity stress triggered by a global recession
- E) No correction required

Q34. The central bank has decided to **hold the feet to the fire** of microfinance institutions regarding their aggressive loan recovery tactics and lack of transparent interest disclosure.

- A) turn a blind eye to the actions
- B) subject to rigorous accountability
- C) provide a clean bill of health
- D) wrestle with the burden of proof
- E) No improvement needed

Q35. Despite the rapid _____ of green bonds in global capital markets, the lack of standardized ESG reporting frameworks continues to _____ the actual environmental impact of these sustainable investments, fueling concerns of greenwashing.

- A) proliferation, obfuscate
- B) stagnation, elucidate
- C) contraction, illuminate
- D) moderation, compound
- E) decline, ameliorate

Q36. The Monetary Policy Committee must account to the rising food inflation figures before deciding on the repo rate.

- A) account for
- B) account with
- C) account in
- D) account by
- E) No replacement

Q37. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) Seldom has the Reserve Bank of India's Monetary Policy Committee faced such a delicate balancing act, / (B) tasked as it is with anchoring stubborn inflationary expectations while simultaneously nurturing a fragile post-pandemic economic recovery, / (C) nor has the compounding effects of global supply-chain disruptions and aggressive Federal Reserve rate hikes / (D) made the task of maintaining exchange rate stability any easier for the central bank's policymakers.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error



Q38. The government's decision to permit 100% FDI under the automatic route in the defense sector was intended to _____ domestic manufacturing, yet the persistent lack of technology transfer has left local firms in a state of technological _____, while foreign original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) continue to _____ their intellectual property through convoluted licensing agreements.

- A) galvanize ... vassalage ... husband
- B) stymie ... hegemony ... squander
- C) obviate ... desuetude ... proscribe
- D) foment ... autonomy ... disperse
- E) attenuate ... limbo ... aggregate

Q39. The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has introduced offline UPI features primarily to _____ transaction failures in areas with poor internet connectivity.

- A) mitigate
- B) aggravate
- C) prolong
- D) escalate
- E) overlook

Q40. While the government's decision to relax equity caps in the retail sector was designed to attract foreign direct investment (FDI), critics argue that the lack of clear regulatory guidelines has _____ foreign investors and _____ the country's reputation as a stable market.

- A) stymied, tarnished
- B) galvanized, bolstered
- C) incentivized, imperiled
- D) deterred, vindicated
- E) placated, undermined

Q41. The government decided to liberalize the FDI policy in the manufacturing sector to _____ domestic production and create millions of new job opportunities.

- A) hinder
- B) stagnate
- C) stimulate
- D) deplete
- E) regulate

Q42. The regional manager initiated several digital initiatives to bring about a change in the rural credit delivery system.

- A) bring for a change
- B) bring of a change
- C) bring on a change
- D) bring with a change
- E) No replacement

Q43. The sharp contraction in market liquidity, precipitated by the sudden spike in the VIX, has led the regulatory body to **stipulate that the clearinghouse implements more rigorous collateral hair-cuts to mitigate the risk of a systemic default during periods of extreme volatility.**

- A) stipulate that the clearinghouse implement more rigorous collateral hair-cut to mitigate the risk of a systemic default during periods of extreme volatility
- B) stipulate that the clearinghouse implement more rigorous collateral hair-cuts to mitigate the risk of a systemic default during periods of extreme volatility
- C) stipulate that the clearinghouse implement more rigorous collateral hair-cuts to mitigate against the risk of a systemic default during periods of extreme volatility
- D) stipulate for the clearinghouse to implement more rigorous collateral hair-cuts to mitigate the risk of a systemic default during periods of extreme volatility
- E) No correction required

Q44. The regulatory insistence on a more stringent Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) ratio underscores the necessity for banks to bolster their loss-absorbency capacity, lest the systemic volatility **precipitates a breach of the minimum capital requirements during periods of acute liquidity stress.**



- A) precipitate a breach of the minimum capital requirements during periods of acute liquidity stress
- B) precipitate a breach to the minimum capital requirements during periods of acute liquidity stress
- C) precipitate the breach of minimum capital requirements throughout periods of acute liquidity stress
- D) precipitate a breach of minimum capital requirement during periods of acute liquidity stress
- E) No correction required

Q45. The recent hike in repo rates will account of the inflationary pressures building up in the domestic economy.

- A) account to
- B) account for
- C) account with
- D) account by
- E) No replacement

Q46. The government decided to liberalize the FDI policy in the manufacturing sector to _____ domestic production and reduce the country's heavy reliance on costly imports.

- A) bolster
- B) stifle
- C) deplete
- D) fluctuate
- E) jeopardize

Q47. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) No sooner had the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade relaxed the FDI equity caps in the defense sector to attract yield-hungry global conglomerates, / (B) hoping to catalyze domestic manufacturing through technology transfers and joint ventures with local defense public sector undertakings, / (C) than did there emerges a series of regulatory bottlenecks concerning intellectual property rights, / (D) which ultimately deterred foreign institutional investors from committing long-term capital to these capital-intensive projects.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q48. As microfinance institutions (MFIs) navigate the post-pandemic credit cycle, their capacity to _____ the systemic risk of over-indebtedness among rural borrowers is severely tested, forcing joint-liability groups into a state of structural _____ while the Reserve Bank of India's revised regulatory framework remains in _____ pending operational clarity.

- A) temper ... disarray ... abeyance
- B) exacerbate ... friction ... desuetude
- C) demarcate ... equilibrium ... limbo
- D) amortize ... stasis ... resonance
- E) obviate ... synergy ... transition

Q49. While the _____ adoption of UPI has revolutionized peer-to-peer transactions across both urban and rural landscapes, a persistent deficit in digital literacy continues to _____ the threat of sophisticated phishing and cyber frauds.

- A) ubiquitous, exacerbate
- B) erratic, alleviate
- C) negligible, compound
- D) sporadic, mitigate
- E) ostentatious, forestall

Q50. Read the sentence: (A) Being a public holiday, the treasury department could not process / (B) the high-value interbank settlements, forcing several commercial banks / (C) to temporarily utilize their marginal standing facility / (D) to meet their daily liquidity coverage ratio requirements.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C



- D) D
- E) No Error

Q51. The NPCI is mandated to ****keep a weather eye on**** the transaction failure rates across third-party UPI applications to ensure that the payment infrastructure remains resilient during peak festive surges.

- A) keep a close tab on
- B) turn a blind eye to
- C) see eye to eye with
- D) blow hot and cold on
- E) No improvement needed

Q52. The local MFI has decided to rely on digital transaction records to assess the creditworthiness of small-scale rural borrowers.

- A) rely in
- B) rely at
- C) rely through
- D) rely with
- E) No replacement

Q53. (A) Despite facing headwinds from volatile global commodity prices, / (B) the monetary policy committee remains resolutely committed to stabilize / (C) domestic inflation within the mandated target band / (D) while the fiscal authority seeks to manage the widening current account deficit.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q54. Read the sentence: (A) The central bank's supervisory board / (B) has issued a vital information regarding / (C) the liquidity coverage ratio requirements / (D) for all scheduled commercial banks.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q55. The regulatory body's decision to mandate _____ validation frameworks for green bonds is expected to _____ investor skepticism regarding corporate greenwashing.

- A) rigorous, mitigate
- B) lax, compound
- C) perfunctory, alleviate
- D) stringent, exacerbate
- E) equivocal, reinforce

Q56. The implementation of an automated market maker (AMM) within a decentralized exchange requires the precise calibration of the bonding curve, lest the liquidity providers ****are exposed to a risk of impermanent loss that arises from the divergent price trajectories of the paired assets.****

- A) be exposed to a risk of impermanent loss arising from divergent price trajectory of the paired assets
- B) be exposed to a risk of impermanent loss that arise from the divergent price trajectories of the paired assets
- C) be exposed to the risk of impermanent loss that arises from the divergent price trajectories of the paired assets
- D) be exposed to risk of impermanent loss that arises from the divergent price trajectories of the paired assets
- E) No correction required

Q57. As global supply chains fracture under the weight of surging protectionism, many emerging economies are struggling to ****weather the storm**** of a protracted recession.

- A) sail through the hurricane
- B) ride out the turbulence
- C) brave the economic deluge
- D) survive the financial crisis
- E) No improvement needed



Q58. The smaller regional financial institution decided to merge with the larger nationalized bank to improve its overall capital adequacy ratio.

- A) merge into
- B) merge at
- C) merge of
- D) merge from
- E) No replacement

Q59. The regional rural bank launched a comprehensive digital appraisal system to ****cut the Gordian knot**** of collateral documentation that has historically prevented small-scale tenant farmers from accessing formal credit.

- A) resolve the fundamental bottleneck
- B) untie the complex knots
- C) sever the legal ties
- D) bypass the regulatory hurdles
- E) No improvement needed

Q60. In a bid to _____ the adverse effects of soaring food inflation on low-income households, the government has decided to release buffer stocks of wheat and rice into the open market.

- A) mitigate
- B) exacerbate
- C) catalyze
- D) simulate
- E) withhold

Q61. In the wake of heightened stock market volatility, quantitative funds have been compelled to recalibrate their risk-parity models, lest their automated strategies ****be predicated on an assumption of mean reversion that fails to account for the persistence of volatility clusters.****

- A) be predicated on an assumption of mean reversion which fail to account for the persistence of volatility clusters
- B) are predicated on an assumption of mean reversion that fails to account for the persistence of volatility clusters
- C) be predicated on an assumption of mean reversion that fails to account for the persistence of volatility cluster
- D) be predicated on an assumption of mean reversion that fail to account for the persistence of volatility clusters
- E) No correction required

Q62. The State Bank of India recently issued green bonds to _____ capital specifically for eco-friendly projects, ensuring that the proceeds are directed toward renewable energy and sustainable waste management.

- A) mobilize
- B) deplete
- C) squander
- D) withhold
- E) forfeit

Q63. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) No sooner had the synchronized contraction in global manufacturing PMI signaled the onset of a severe economic recession, / (B) prompting central banks to exhaust their conventional monetary policy ammunition through aggressive rate cuts, / (C) than not only did the sovereign debt yields of emerging markets spike to historic highs / (D) but also has the cascading defaults in the highly leveraged corporate sector threatened to trigger a systemic banking crisis.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q64. The Reserve Bank of India has introduced a framework for green deposits to _____ the flow of credit to environmentally sustainable projects and combat greenwashing.

- A) accelerate
- B) stifle
- C) deter
- D) fluctuate



E) compromise

Q65. The central bank decided to maintain the repo rate tethered to the prevailing inflation target to ensure price stability.

- A) tethered with
- B) tethered by
- C) tethered in
- D) tethered at
- E) No replacement

Q66. The sudden contraction of global liquidity, alongside the systemic failure of several shadow banking entities, ****have exacerbated the liquidity crunch, rendering the traditional mechanisms of monetary transmission ineffective**** in the face of a deepening global recession.

- A) have exacerbated the liquidity crunch, rendering the traditional mechanism of monetary transmission ineffective
- B) has exacerbated the liquidity crunch, rendering the traditional mechanisms of monetary transmission ineffective
- C) has exacerbated the liquidity crunch, rendered the traditional mechanisms of monetary transmission ineffective
- D) has exacerbated the liquidity crunch, rendering the traditional mechanisms of monetary transmission ineffectiveness
- E) No correction required

Q67. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) Scarcely had the monetary policy committee announced its decision to maintain a hawkish stance on key policy rates, / (B) than the domestic equity markets experienced a sharp sell-off, with foreign institutional investors liquidating their holdings / (C) in anticipation of prolonged liquidity tightening, which many fear could stifle credit growth / (D) and derail the fragile economic recovery of the capital-intensive manufacturing sector.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q68. (A) Although the central bank's monetary policy committee remains deeply divided on the terminal rate, / (B) the macroeconomics of supply-side shocks, when taught as a core academic discipline, / (C) clearly demonstrate that aggressive tightening during structural bottlenecks / (D) can inadvertently suppress long-term capital formation and aggregate demand.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q69. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) Not only did the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) roll out advanced cryptographic protocols to secure UPI transactions against quantum-computing threats, / (B) thereby bolstering global confidence in the sovereign real-time retail payment architecture, / (C) but also has the cross-border linkages established with Singapore's PayNow and the UAE's IPP catalyzed / (D) an unprecedented surge in low-value remittance flows without disrupting domestic settlement liquidity.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q70. The RBI Monetary Policy Committee's decision to maintain a hawkish stance was intended to _____ entrenched inflationary expectations, yet the central bank had to simultaneously deploy fine-tuning variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) operations to manage a transient liquidity surplus, thereby preventing a systemic _____ in the overnight call money market while keeping its broader forward guidance in _____ pending clearer fiscal cues.



- A) temper ... surfeit ... abeyance
- B) anchor ... tailspin ... abeyance
- C) exacerbate ... gridlock ... desuetude
- D) stultify ... renaissance ... limbo
- E) mollify ... vacuum ... obsolescence

Q71. Read the sentence: (A) The internal audit team recently confirmed that, / (B) despite the substantial budget deficit in the third quarter, / (C) the compliance department has procured all the necessary digital ledger equipments / (D) required to secure the bank's offshore transaction database.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q72. The trade ministry officials are working overtime to ****burn the midnight oil**** of the bilateral investment treaty to ensure that the terms are favorable for attracting long-term FDI in the semiconductor sector.

- A) hammer out the details of
- B) keep the pot boiling for
- C) see eye to eye on
- D) beat about the bush regarding
- E) No improvement needed

Q73. By issuing its maiden sovereign green bonds, the government aims to _____ the capital costs required for executing large-scale renewable energy projects across the country.

- A) mitigate
- B) escalate
- C) jeopardize
- D) forfeit
- E) undermine

Q74. In response to the sudden global sell-off, domestic institutional investors stepped in with massive purchases to _____ the extreme stock market volatility and prevent a complete panic in the trading session.

- A) mitigate
- B) exacerbate
- C) trigger
- D) forecast
- E) ignore

Q75. The government decided to merge several public sector banks in order to _____ their capital base and create stronger global-sized lenders.

- A) consolidate
- B) deplete
- C) jeopardize
- D) constrain
- E) dilute

Q76. Read the sentence: (A) During the global financial summit, / (B) the chief economist explained that / (C) a high rate of inflation always eroded / (D) the purchasing power of consumer savings.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q77. Despite the implementation of rigorous insolvency frameworks to resolve the banking sector's toxic debt, the uncooperative stance of _____ borrowers continues to _____ the systemic vulnerability of public sector banks.

- A) recalcitrant, exacerbate
- B) compliant, alleviate



- C) transient, mitigate
- D) magnanimous, compound
- E) indigent, forestall

Q78. (A) The implementation of stringent capital adequacy ratios, / (B) along with the newly introduced systemic risk buffers, / (C) have significantly enhanced the resilience of the banking sector / (D) against sudden macroeconomic shocks and liquidity contractions.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q79. The central bank decided to roll out with a new feature to enhance the security of peer-to-peer UPI transactions.

- A) roll out on
- B) roll out
- C) roll out at
- D) roll out into
- E) No replacement

Q80. (A) As core inflation continues to hover well above the comfort zone, / (B) the monetary policy committee remains committed to maintain / (C) a restrictive stance for an extended period, / (D) and aims to anchor long-term inflation expectations effectively.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q81. To prevent rural borrowers from slipping into a cycle of perpetual debt, the MFI has restructured its repayment schedule to help them ****keep their books in the black**** despite the recent crop failure.

- A) keep their heads above water
- B) turn the corner
- C) flesh out the details
- D) break the back of the beast
- E) No improvement needed

Q82. The central bank's decision to hike interest rates by 75 basis points is expected to ****take the wind out of the sails**** of the overheated consumer price index by curbing excess liquidity.

- A) dampen the momentum
- B) foster the inflationary trend
- C) accelerate the purchasing power
- D) inflate the market expectations
- E) No improvement needed

Q83. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) Not only did the market regulator mandate comprehensive impact reporting for sovereign green bonds to curb greenwashing, / (B) thereby fostering greater transparency and boosting foreign institutional investor confidence in sustainable debt instruments, / (C) but also has the stringent disclosure norms governing ESG-focused mutual funds / (D) forced asset management companies to completely overhaul their portfolio allocation strategies.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q84. The Reserve Bank of India decided to keep the repo rate unchanged in its latest monetary policy review to _____ the impact of global commodity price shocks on domestic inflation.



- A) mitigate
- B) aggravate
- C) procure
- D) intensify
- E) abandon

Q85. The firm's latest sustainability report fails to account of the emissions generated by its Green Bond-funded infrastructure projects.

- A) account for
- B) account in
- C) account to
- D) account at
- E) No replacement

Q86. Read the sentence: (A) Despite the recent stabilization of the interbank lending rate, / (B) conservative portfolio managers must keep themselves away from / (C) highly speculative derivative instruments that lack adequate backing / (D) by high-quality liquid assets.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q87. Read the sentence: (A) Following the unprecedented liquidity crisis, the board of directors clarified that / (B) it was them who initiated the comprehensive restructuring of the bank's non-performing assets, / (C) rather than the external consultants appointed by the regulatory authority / (D) during the previous quarter.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q88. To _____ the high volatility risks associated with digital assets, several central banks are actively developing their own sovereign Central Bank Digital Currencies (CBDCs).

- A) mitigate
- B) exacerbate
- C) propagate
- D) stagnate
- E) precipitate

Q89. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) Scarcely had the monetary policy committee announced its decision to maintain a hawkish stance on key policy rates / (B) than the domestic equity markets plummeted, wiping out billions in investor wealth / (C) and prompting foreign institutional investors to aggressively liquidate their holdings in high-yield debt instruments, / (D) which further exacerbated the liquidity crunch in the shadow banking sector.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q90. (A) Despite the recent stabilization of the domestic currency, / (B) portfolio managers remain cautious about increasing their exposure to sovereign bonds / (C) that are currently belonging to highly leveraged emerging economies / (D) due to the looming threat of a coordinated interest rate hike by Western central banks.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D



E) No Error

Q91. Although regulatory authorities have introduced more _____ disclosure requirements for ESG-labelled debt, the highly fragmented nature of global ratings continues to _____ the risk of widespread greenwashing.

- A) stringent, exacerbate
- B) lax, ameliorate
- C) perfunctory, mitigate
- D) equivocal, forestall
- E) negligible, compound

Q92. While the government's _____ fiscal stimulus prevented an immediate depression, the central bank's subsequent monetary easing has still failed to _____ the persistent deflationary pressures gripping the domestic market.

- A) unprecedented, alleviate
- B) negligible, compound
- C) sporadic, intensify
- D) equivocal, exacerbate
- E) parsimonious, trigger

Q93. The foreign investment entity's strategic pivot toward divestiture of its equity stake in the domestic joint venture remains contingent upon the apex regulator's validation of the fair-value appraisal, **lest the exit pricing is deemed non-compliant to the pricing guidelines prescribed under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA).**

- A) lest the exit pricing be deemed non-compliant with the pricing guidelines prescribing under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA)
- B) lest the exit pricing be deemed non-compliant to the pricing guidelines prescribed under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA)
- C) lest the exit pricing be deemed non-compliant with the pricing guidelines prescribed under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA)
- D) lest the exit pricing should be deemed non-compliant to the pricing guidelines prescribed under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA)
- E) No correction required

Q94. In response to the rising prices of essential commodities, the central bank decided to hike the policy repo rate to _____ the surging inflation rate.

- A) escalate
- B) mitigate
- C) stimulate
- D) prolong
- E) aggravate

Q95. To bolster the asset quality of Regional Rural Banks (RRBs) plagued by legacy non-performing assets, the board must mandate aggressive provisioning against anticipated credit impairment, failing which the capital adequacy ratio would remain **susceptible to erode under the strain of high-frequency defaults occurring within the micro-credit portfolios.**

- A) susceptible to erosion under the strain of high-frequency default occurring within the micro-credit portfolios
- B) susceptible to eroding under the strain of high-frequency default occurring within the micro-credit portfolios
- C) susceptible to eroding under the strain of high-frequency defaults occurring within the micro-credit portfolios
- D) susceptible for erosion under the strain of high-frequency defaults occurring within the micro-credit portfolios
- E) No correction required

Q96. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) To curb widespread greenwashing and restore investor confidence in sustainable finance, / (B) the regulatory board now mandates that not only must a green bond issuer disclose the precise allocation of proceeds, / (C) but also that an independent third-party auditor verifies the environmental impact metrics / (D) before any sovereign or corporate debt instrument can officially receive the coveted ESG certification.

- A) A
- B) B



- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q97. (A) Despite the country's remarkable fiscal recovery, / (B) the World Bank's latest macroeconomic outlook report / (C) surprisingly omitted the nation's mention / (D) among the fastest-growing economies in the region.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q98. Small-scale regional rural banks that over-leverage their loan portfolios while ignoring local market volatility are often ****sailing close to the wind****, risking severe liquidity crunches during harvest cycles.

- A) treading on thin ice
- B) stretching their credit capacity
- C) operating with excessive risk
- D) bearing the brunt of the loss
- E) No improvement needed

Q99. Read the sentence: (A) Let us formulate a strategic plan / (B) to hedge against foreign exchange fluctuations / (C) and protect our net interest margins, / (D) shouldn't we?

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q100. To mitigate the systemic risk associated with sectoral exposure, the apex regulator requires that each lending institution ****is proactive in the identification of early warning signals (EWS) to preclude the migration of standard assets into the non-performing category.****

- A) be proactive in the identification of early warning signals (EWS) for precluding the migration of standard assets into the non-performing category
- B) be proactive in the identification of early warning signals (EWS) to preclude the migration of standard assets into the non-performing category
- C) be proactive in the identification of early warning signals (EWS) to preclude the migration of standard assets within the non-performing category
- D) are proactive in the identification of early warning signals (EWS) to preclude the migration of standard assets into the non-performing category
- E) No correction required

Q101. During a severe global economic recession, central banks often lower benchmark interest rates to _____ borrowing costs and stimulate consumer spending.

- A) mitigate
- B) escalate
- C) prolong
- D) jeopardize
- E) fluctuate

Q102. The sudden escalation of geopolitical tensions triggered a massive sell-off, forcing the market regulator to intervene as algorithmic trading systems began to _____ the downward spiral, thereby throwing the clearing corporations into a state of operational _____ while proposals for emergency circuit breakers were held in _____ until the volatility index stabilized.

- A) exacerbate ... quietude ... perpetuity
- B) attenuate ... paralysis ... desuetude
- C) exasperate ... quagmire ... suspension
- D) acuate ... chaos ... limbo
- E) acerbate ... welter ... abeyance



Q103. Read the sentence: (A) The compliance committee confirmed that, despite the recent market downturn, / (B) our both domestic branches have successfully maintained / (C) the required liquidity coverage ratio to mitigate systemic risk / (D) during the first half of the current fiscal year.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q104. The central bank's stringent directive on securing APIs in open banking frameworks has forced lenders to _____ legacy perimeter-based defenses, but the rapid rollout of zero-trust verification protocols has plunged security operations centers into a noisy _____ of false-positive alerts, leaving critical vulnerability patches in _____ while analysts triage immediate operational disruptions.

- A) obviate ... cacophony ... abeyance
- B) extirpate ... quietude ... desuetude
- C) disintermediate ... welter ... desuetude
- D) amortize ... synergy ... provenance
- E) assuage ... imbroglio ... vanguard

Q105. The bank decided to beef up its firewall protocols to prevent potential unauthorized access to customer databases.

- A) beef on
- B) beef at
- C) beef into
- D) beef over
- E) No replacement

Q106. The NPCI's directive to mandate Tokenization for all merchant-side credential storage aims to fortify the payment ecosystem, yet the fragmented nature of legacy acquirer platforms continues to pose significant hurdles, **as the existing technical frameworks lack the necessary interoperabilities to facilitate seamless multi-factor authentication across disparate UPI-enabled payment gateways.**

- A) as the existing technical frameworks lack the necessary interoperability for facilitating seamless multi-factor authentication across disparate UPI-enabled payment gateways
- B) as the existing technical frameworks lack the necessary interoperability to facilitate seamless multi-factor authentication across disparate UPI-enabled payment gateways
- C) as the existing technical frameworks lack the necessary interoperability in facilitating seamless multi-factor authentication across disparate UPI-enabled payment gateways
- D) since the existing technical frameworks lack the necessary interoperabilities to facilitate seamless multi-factor authentication across disparate UPI-enabled payment gateways
- E) No correction required

Q107. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) Under the stringent Basel III framework, commercial banks are mandated to maintain a robust Common Equity Tier 1 capital ratio, / (B) with a view to bolstering their loss-absorbency capacity during periods of acute macroeconomic stress / (C) and mitigate the systemic risks arising from unhedged foreign currency exposures / (D) that could otherwise destabilize the domestic financial architecture.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q108. The regulator's stringent decree to enforce daily multi-factor authentication on UPI-based micro-transactions was expected to _____ payment fraud, but it instead plunged payment aggregators into a technological _____, forcing them to hold high-volume settlements in _____ until their processing architectures could handle the increased latency.

- A) obviate ... welter ... abeyance
- B) extirpate ... quietude ... perpetuity



- C) foment ... quagmire ... desuetude
- D) palliate ... sycophancy ... limbo
- E) preclude ... consensus ... stagnation

Q109. Read the sentence: (A) Despite facing severe macroeconomic headwinds, / (B) the board of directors already approved / (C) the proposed merger between the two public sector banks / (D) to optimize operational efficiency.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q110. Developers often have to trade off against speed and security when building decentralized applications on the Ethereum network.

- A) trade off between
- B) trade off with
- C) trade off from
- D) trade off for
- E) No replacement

Q111. Commercial banks are struggling to ensure their Liquidity Coverage Ratios remain **at sixes and sevens** with the stringent Basel III norms implemented by the central bank.

- A) in lockstep with
- B) at loggerheads with
- C) under the cloud of
- D) out of the woods with
- E) No improvement needed

Q112. The structural changes brought about by the recent merger of the two nationalized banks have led to increased operational efficiency.

- A) brought out in
- B) brought up with
- C) brought down at
- D) brought over from
- E) No replacement

Q113. (A) To mitigate the systemic risks posed by shadow banking, / (B) the regulatory authority has proposed a comprehensive overhaul of the supervisory frameworks, / (C) aiming to streamline the complex administrative machineries / (D) that govern non-banking financial companies operating across the country.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q114. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) While the mega-merger of public sector banks was ostensibly engineered to achieve economies of scale / (B) and clean up the mountain of non-performing assets plaguing the sovereign balance sheet, / (C) having consolidated their disparate balance sheets into a singular balance sheet, / (D) the integration of legacy IT systems and divergent corporate cultures remains a formidable challenge for the management.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q115. Read the sentence: (A) The board of directors unanimously agreed that, despite the sudden monetary policy tightening, / (B) all members of the risk assessment committee except he / (C) had adequately prepared the



commercial bank's portfolio / (D) for the stringent new liquidity requirements.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q116. (A) Amid growing concerns over global macroeconomic headwinds and capital outflows, / (B) and with the explicit objective of shielding the domestic currency from speculative attacks, / (C) the central bank remains committed in bolstering the country's import cover / (D) by aggressively accumulating foreign exchange reserves through strategic market interventions.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q117. While proponents argue that the _____ nature of public ledgers ensures absolute transparency, skeptics contend that the lack of centralized oversight will only _____ illicit activities like money laundering.

- A) immutable, facilitate
- B) transitory, impede
- C) opaque, exacerbate
- D) malleable, obstruct
- E) ephemeral, catalyze

Q118. The Monetary Policy Committee's strategy to calibrate the liquidity surplus via the Standing Deposit Facility (SDF) is predicated on the assumption that the banking system **will not fail to transmit these tightening signals to the real economy, lest the resulting lag in policy transmission undermines the desired inflation trajectory.**

- A) will not fail to transmit these tightening signals to the real economy, lest the resulting lag in policy transmission may undermine the desired inflation trajectory
- B) will not fail to transmit these tightening signals through the real economy, lest the resulting lag in policy transmission should undermine the desired inflation trajectory
- C) will not fail to transmit these tightening signals to the real economy, lest the resulting lag in policy transmission would undermine the desired inflation trajectory
- D) will not fail to transmit these tightening signals to the real economy, lest the resulting lag in policy transmission should undermine the desired inflation trajectory
- E) No correction required

Q119. Read the sentence: (A) The central bank has been closely monitoring / (B) the liquidity levels in the banking system / (C) since several consecutive quarters / (D) to prevent any sudden spike in short-term interest rates.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q120. (A) The monetary policy committee's latest communique indicates / (B) that the current stance of the central bank is / (C) pragmaticer than dogmatic in its approach to inflation targeting, / (D) as it prioritizes growth stabilization over rigid adherence to pre-set interest rate paths.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q121. To remain competitive, traditional banks must ____ their legacy systems and embrace cloud computing technologies.

- A) overhaul
- B) preserve



- C) ignore
- D) worship
- E) abandon

Q122. The management decided to phase out of the redundant operational branches following the mega merger of the two nationalized banks.

- A) phase out
- B) phase into
- C) phase down from
- D) phase away
- E) No replacement

Q123. Banks are required to set aside for additional high-quality liquid assets to meet the stringent liquidity coverage ratio mandated by Basel III norms.

- A) set aside
- B) set aside into
- C) set aside with
- D) set aside by
- E) No replacement

Q124. (A) As sovereign debt yields surge to unprecedented levels, / (B) several highly leveraged emerging market economies / (C) have reluctantly committed to implement stringent austerity measures / (D) amidst a deepening global economic recession.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q125. (A) Despite the regulatory overhaul aimed at stabilizing the shadow banking sector, / (B) several non-banking financial companies are still belonging to / (C) highly leveraged conglomerate structures that pose systemic risks / (D) to the broader domestic credit market.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q126. Read the sentence: (A) The newly structured investment portfolio / (B) designed by the wealth management division / (C) is considered safer than profitable / (D) under the current volatile macroeconomic conditions.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q127. In the wake of several high-profile exchange collapses, global financial regulators have struggled to _____ the systemic contagion risks posed by algorithmic stablecoins, leaving cross-border jurisdictional frameworks in a complex _____ while highly anticipated guidelines on cryptographic proof-of-reserves are kept in _____ pending a unified G20 consensus.

- A) attenuate ... quagmire ... abeyance
- B) exacerbate ... transition ... desuetude
- C) demarcate ... gridlock ... perpetuity
- D) obfuscate ... consensus ... limbo
- E) amortize ... impasse ... stagnation

Q128. The regulator's stringent asset quality review was designed to prevent commercial banks from attempting to _____ their deteriorating balance sheets through systemic evergreening, a practice that only served to defer the recognition of NPAs and plunge the lenders into a deeper regulatory _____ while their capital adequacy ratios remained _____ below the mandated threshold.



- A) varnish ... morass ... perilously
- B) exculpate ... quietude ... marginally
- C) extirpate ... transition ... soundly
- D) obviate ... windfall ... precariously
- E) palliate ... zenith ... inherently

Q129. The consolidation of the anchor bank's disparate legacy IT systems with those of the merged entities necessitates a comprehensive data reconciliation process, **which not only complicate the migration timeline but also exacerbates the risk of operational glitches during the transition phase.**

- A) that not only complicate the migration timeline but also exacerbate the risk of operational glitches during the transition phase
- B) which not only complicates the migration timeline but also exacerbates the risk of operational glitches during the transition phase
- C) that not only complicates the migration timeline but also exacerbate the risk of operational glitches during the transition phase
- D) which not only complicates the migration timeline but also exacerbate the risk of operational glitches during the transition phase
- E) No correction required

Q130. The bank was forced to write down the bad loans as the recovery process stalled.

- A) write off
- B) write away
- C) write over
- D) write across
- E) No replacement

Q131. The local NGO decided to provide the villagers with small-scale credit to help them start sustainable businesses.

- A) provide the villagers of
- B) provide to the villagers
- C) provide the villagers by
- D) provide for the villagers at
- E) No replacement

Q132. Many regional banks were found to be **at sixes and sevens** regarding the technical reporting requirements mandated by the latest Basel III capital adequacy guidelines.

- A) in a state of absolute disarray
- B) at the end of their tether
- C) behind the eight ball
- D) on the horns of a dilemma
- E) No improvement needed

Q133. Institutional investors have decided to **give a wide berth to** highly leveraged mid-cap stocks as the volatility index continues to signal potential turbulence in the equities market.

- A) adopt a wait-and-watch approach
- B) exercise extreme caution regarding
- C) distance themselves entirely from
- D) liquidate their holdings in
- E) No improvement needed

Q134. The mandate for the seamless interoperability of UPI-based credit lines, aimed at enhancing financial inclusion, stipulates that the settlement protocols **be calibrated in such a way to preclude the possibility of liquidity mismatch between the credit-extending bank and the nodal agency.**

- A) be calibrated in such a way as to preclude the possibility of liquidity mismatches between the credit-extending bank and the nodal agency
- B) be calibrated in such a way as to preclude the possibility of liquidity mismatch between the credit-extending bank and the nodal agency
- C) be calibrated in a way to preclude the possibility of liquidity mismatches between the credit-extending bank and the nodal agency



- D) be calibrated in such a way that precludes the possibility of liquidity mismatch between the credit-extending bank and the nodal agency
E) No correction required

Q135. Read the sentence: (A) Despite the volatile market conditions, / (B) the central bank implemented strategic policies / (C) to ensure very best economic outcomes / (D) for the developing domestic financial sectors.

- A) A
B) B
C) C
D) D
E) No Error

Q136. Read the sentence: (A) To bolster cybersecurity defenses across all regional branches, / (B) the board of directors recently approved a substantial capital expenditure / (C) for upgrading the mainframe servers and other critical IT equipments / (D) that process high-volume electronic fund transfers daily.

- A) A
B) B
C) C
D) D
E) No Error

Q137. Read the sentence: (A) The board of directors confirmed that the newly appointed compliance officer / (B) has already restructured the internal auditing protocols and / (C) successfully mitigated quite all the operational risks / (D) associated with the high-volume cross-border transactions.

- A) A
B) B
C) C
D) D
E) No Error

Q138. The government initiated the consolidation of several public sector banks to _____ operational efficiency and create global-sized lenders capable of supporting India's growing economic demands.

- A) enhance
B) stagnate
C) constrain
D) jeopardize
E) dilute

Q139. In response to the looming global economic recession, several central banks have coordinated interest rate cuts to _____ the severe impact of declining industrial output and reduced consumer spending.

- A) mitigate
B) exacerbate
C) prolong
D) overlook
E) precipitate

Q140. (A) Despite facing headwinds from volatile global commodity prices, / (B) the government remains firmly committed to achieve its fiscal deficit target / (C) by streamlining public expenditure and broadening the tax base / (D) through comprehensive digital compliance reforms.

- A) A
B) B
C) C
D) D
E) No Error

Q141. As the shadow of a prolonged global recession lengthened, central banks scrambled to _____ the impaired derivative exposures of systemic lenders, even as the interbank lending market lapsed into an icy _____, leaving cross-border capital flows dependent on emergency regulatory _____ that bypassed standard Basel-III capital-adequacy thresholds.

- A) extirpate ... stasis ... dispensations



- B) amortize ... welter ... strictures
- C) conflate ... quietude ... interdictions
- D) expatriate ... turbulence ... mandates
- E) obviate ... desuetude ... injunctions

Q142. The government decided to liberalize the FDI policy in the manufacturing sector to _____ economic growth and attract more foreign capital into the country.

- A) hinder
- B) foster
- C) deplete
- D) dampen
- E) fluctuate

Q143. The management team is working hard to smooth out the operational challenges emerging from the merger of the two public sector banks.

- A) smooth in
- B) smooth at
- C) smooth by
- D) smooth up
- E) No replacement

Q144. The timely intervention by the central bank helped to _____ an impending liquidity crisis in the shadow banking sector.

- A) avert
- B) precipitate
- C) accelerate
- D) ignore
- E) welcome

Q145. Read the sentence to find out whether there is any grammatical error in it. The error, if any, will be in one part of the sentence. (Ignore punctuation errors, if any). (A) Although the mega-merger of public sector banks was envisioned to streamline operational efficiencies and aggressively write off toxic assets, / (B) only after the consolidated entities integrated their disparate legacy IT platforms / (C) the newly formed board of directors realized that the cultural friction among staff members / (D) was severely impeding the seamless delivery of retail banking services across rural branches.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error

Q146. As the central bank tightened its oversight on non-bank lenders, Microfinance Institutions (MFIs) struggled to _____ the sudden compression of their net interest margins, which threw their field-level collection operations into a bureaucratic _____ while their applications for transition into Small Finance Banks were kept in _____ pending a comprehensive review of their promoter-group exposures.

- A) temper ... welter ... limbo
- B) obviate ... quietude ... abeyance
- C) exacerbate ... morass ... desuetude
- D) attenuate ... synergy ... purgatory
- E) amortize ... imbroglia ... resonance

Q147. As global supply chains fracture and consumer sentiment plummets, many emerging market economies remain ****in the doldrums****, struggling to regain their pre-recession growth trajectories.

- A) in the eye of the storm
- B) at the crossroads
- C) in the red
- D) under the weather
- E) No improvement needed



Q148. The banking consortium has decided to initiate a comprehensive asset quality review to **clear the decks** before the next fiscal quarter, as they struggle to contain the mounting pressure of legacy NPAs.

- A) liquidate the bad debts
- B) finalize the audit reports
- C) prepare for necessary action
- D) streamline the operational hierarchy
- E) No improvement needed

Q149. The acute surge in the volatility index, precipitated by an unforeseen hawkish shift in the monetary policy stance of the central bank, has left institutional investors vulnerable, **lest the ensuing volatility in asset valuations results in a precipitous erosion of the alphas generated during the preceding quarters.**

- A) lest the ensuing volatility in asset valuations result in a precipitous eroding of the alpha generated during the preceding quarters
- B) lest the ensuing volatility in asset valuations result in a precipitous erosion of the alpha generated during the preceding quarters
- C) lest the ensuing volatility in asset valuations result in a precipitous erosion of the alphas generated during the preceding quarters
- D) lest the ensuing volatility in asset valuations results in a precipitous erosion of the alpha generated during the preceding quarters
- E) No correction required

Q150. Read the sentence: (A) The branch manager explained that the applicant's credit score was sufficient, / (B) but his performance on the internal debt-to-income assessment / (C) fell short of the minimum passing marks / (D) required to secure the premium home loan rate.

- A) A
- B) B
- C) C
- D) D
- E) No Error



MOCK TEST ANSWER KEY

Q1. Answer: exacerbate, deteriorate — The sentence discusses the contrasting views on PSU bank mergers. While the government expects positive outcomes ('operational synergies'), labor unions have apprehensions. Therefore, the blanks must represent negative outcomes. 'Exacerbate' (to make a problem worse) fits the first blank, as integration could worsen existing administrative redundancies. 'Deteriorate' (to become progressively worse) or transitively 'deteriorate customer service' (or cause it to deteriorate) fits the second blank. Looking at the pairs: 'exacerbate, deteriorate' is the only pair where both words represent negative impacts that fit the grammatical and contextual structure. In other options: 'alleviate' (to lessen pain/difficulty) and 'mitigate' (to reduce severity) are positive; 'obviate' means to remove a need or difficulty, which contradicts the unions' fears.

Q2. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses the motivation behind central banks exploring digital currencies (CBDCs), which is to reduce or lessen the high transaction costs of physical money. 'Mitigate' means to make less severe, serious, or painful, which perfectly fits the context of reducing costs. The other options like 'escalate' (increase), 'stagnate' (stop flowing/developing), 'accumulate' (gather/collect), and 'advocate' (publicly support) do not make contextual sense.

Q3. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. According to grammatical rules, when two subjects are connected by 'along with', 'as well as', 'together with', 'in addition to', etc., the verb must agree in number with the first subject. Here, the first subject is 'The implementation' (singular), while the parenthetical phrase introduced by 'along with' contains plural nouns ('ratios', 'buffers'). Therefore, the verb must be singular ('is') to agree with 'The implementation'. The correct sentence should read: '...is projected to fortify the domestic banking sector...'

Q4. Answer: B — The error lies in Part B of the sentence. The phrase 'committed to' is a phrasal verb where 'to' acts as a preposition, not as part of an infinitive. Therefore, it must be followed by a gerund (V+ing) rather than a bare infinitive. The verb 'align' must be changed to 'aligning'. The correct sentence should read: '...several prominent investment funds have publicly committed to aligning their portfolio allocations...'

Q5. Answer: sterilize ... epoch ... desuetude — The sentence describes the RBI's liquidity management operations within its monetary policy framework. Blank 1 requires a technical central banking term for neutralizing or absorbing excess liquidity; 'sterilize' is the precise financial term used when a central bank neutralizes the effects of capital inflows or excess cash in the banking system. Blank 2 requires a noun to describe a distinct period or state characterized by volatility; 'epoch' (a period of time in history or a person's life, typically one marked by notable events or characteristics) fits the context of a new market regime. Blank 3 requires a noun representing a state of inactive disuse; 'desuetude' (a state of disuse) perfectly describes older monetary instruments or conduits that are no longer utilized by the central bank. Other options fail because 'amortize' (to gradually write off the initial cost of an asset) is economically incorrect for liquidity absorption, and 'exacerbate' (to make worse) contradicts the MPC's objective of stabilizing policy transmission.

Q6. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The idiomatic phrase 'with a view to' must be followed by a gerund (verb+ing) rather than an infinitive. Therefore, 'bolster' should be changed to 'bolstering'. This correction also maintains perfect grammatical parallelism with the gerund 'shielding' in Part D. The correct sentence should read: '...with a view to bolstering its depleting forex reserves and shielding the domestic currency...'

Q7. Answer: No improvement needed — The idiom 'iron out the kinks' is a standard and idiomatic way to describe the process of resolving minor problems or technical inefficiencies in a new system or plan. In the context of blockchain development, it is grammatically correct and stylistically appropriate. Since the original phrasing accurately conveys the need to fix technical flaws, 'No improvement needed' is the correct choice.

Q8. Answer: are aligned with the real-time gross settlement (RTGS) standards to preclude latent discrepancies in the ledger reconciliation process — The original phrase contains several subtle errors. First, 'aligned with' is the correct idiomatic preposition when referring to adherence to standards or guidelines, making 'aligned to' less appropriate. Second, 'to preclude' (the infinitive of purpose) is grammatically superior to 'for precluding' when expressing the intended objective of a requirement. Third, 'latent discrepancies' must be plural because the context refers to any and all potential errors that might arise during the process, rather than one

specific, singular discrepancy. Finally, 'ledger reconciliation process' should be singular as it refers to the collective systemic procedure of reconciliation rather than multiple different types of processes. Option E correctly addresses all these nuances.

Q9. Answer: bolster ... recalibrating ... desuetude — The sentence discusses the rigorous adjustments banks must make to comply with Basel III rules. Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to strengthen or increase, as Basel III requires banks to hold more high-quality capital; 'bolster' fits perfectly. Blank 2 requires a verb that represents modifying, adjusting, or mathematically correcting risk models; 'recalibrating' is the precise financial terminology used for updating IRB models. Blank 3 requires a noun representing a state of being phased out, discarded, or no longer used, because legacy hybrid instruments (like certain Tier 2 debt or innovative perpetual debt instruments) that do not meet strict Basel III criteria are grandfathered and phased into non-existence; 'desuetude' (a state of disuse or obsolescence) fits this regulatory phase-out context perfectly.

Q10. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. When a sentence or clause begins with a negative or restrictive adverbial phrase such as 'under no circumstances', subject-auxiliary inversion is mandatory. Therefore, the subject 'the central bank' and the auxiliary verb 'can' must be inverted. The correct structure should be: 'and under no circumstances can the central bank afford to lower its guard'. Part D is correct as 'lest' is properly paired with 'should' without any double negatives.

Q11. Answer: circumscribe ... rigmarole ... prerogative — The sentence describes regulatory intervention to restrict Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) inflows under the automatic route to protect domestic companies. Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to restrict, limit, or draw a line around; 'circumscribe' fits perfectly. Blank 2 requires a noun indicating a complicated, tedious, or confusing procedure; 'rigmarole' (a lengthy and complicated procedure) fits this context of bureaucratic red tape excellently. Blank 3 requires a noun representing sovereign control, rights, or exclusive privileges; 'prerogative' (a right or privilege exclusive to a particular individual or class, in this case, national sovereignty over key sectors) fits perfectly. Other options like 'desuetude' (disuse) are semantically incorrect, and 'synergy' or 'quietude' do not fit the restrictive, protective tone of the sentence.

Q12. Answer: B — The error lies in part B. According to Rule 28, certain stative verbs expressing possession, such as 'belong', do not exist in the continuous ('-ing') form. Therefore, 'are currently belonging' must be corrected to the simple present tense 'currently belong' to be grammatically correct.

Q13. Answer: a facade to obscure reality — The idiom 'smoke and mirrors' refers to methods of disguising or misrepresenting the truth. In the context of financial reporting and ESG, replacing this with 'a facade to obscure reality' elevates the tone to a more formal, analytical register appropriate for professional economic assessments.

Q14. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The adjective 'committed' is followed by the preposition 'to', which must be succeeded by a gerund (verb+ing) rather than a bare infinitive. Therefore, 'align' must be changed to 'aligning'. The correct sentence should read: '...remaining resolutely committed to aligning inflation with the four percent target...'

Q15. Answer: B — The error lies in Part B of the sentence. The phrase 'committed to' is a phrasal adjective where 'to' functions as a preposition, not as part of an infinitive verb. Therefore, it must be followed by a gerund (noun form of the verb) rather than the base form of the verb. The correct usage is 'committed to implementing' instead of 'committed to implement'. The corrected sentence should read: '...the fiscal policy committee remains committed to implementing targeted structural reforms...'

Q16. Answer: bolster — The sentence discusses the consolidation (merger) of public sector banks, which is aimed at strengthening or reinforcing their capital base. 'Bolster' means to support, strengthen, or build up, which perfectly fits this context. The other options, such as 'deplete' (empty/reduce), 'jeopardize' (endanger), 'disrupt' (interrupt), and 'stagnate' (stop growing), carry negative meanings that contradict the positive objective of bank consolidation.

Q17. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The clause introduced by the negative coordinating conjunction 'nor' requires subject-auxiliary inversion. In this inverted structure, the auxiliary verb must agree with the actual subject that follows it. The subject is the plural noun phrase 'the structural bottlenecks'. Therefore, the singular auxiliary verb 'has' is incorrect and must be replaced with the plural auxiliary verb 'have' to read: 'nor have the structural bottlenecks inherent in the insolvency framework'.



Q18. Answer: sterilize ... nadir ... abeyance — The sentence analyzes the RBI's monetary policy dilemmas. Blank 1 requires a technical central banking term for absorbing or neutralizing excess liquidity; 'sterilize' is the exact financial term used when a central bank mops up excess money supply. Blank 2 requires a word indicating the lowest point, as high inflation drags real interest rates (nominal rate minus inflation) down; 'nadir' (the lowest point) fits this perfectly (unlike 'apogee' or 'zenith', which mean the highest point). Blank 3 requires a word meaning temporary suspension or holding pattern; 'abeyance' fits perfectly as the policy stance is held in temporary suspension awaiting further macroeconomic data.

Q19. Answer: D — The error lies in part D. According to Rule 19 regarding pronoun cases, when making a comparison using 'than' or 'as', the pronoun following the conjunction should be in the nominative (subject) case, not the objective case, because it acts as the subject of an implied verb. Here, the sentence compares how the senior portfolio managers executed transactions to how 'he' executed them. Therefore, 'than him' must be corrected to 'than he' (which is short for 'than he did' or 'than he executed').

Q20. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The idiomatic phrase 'with a view to' functions as a prepositional phrase where 'to' is a preposition, not part of an infinitive. Therefore, it must be followed by a gerund (verb+ing) rather than a bare infinitive. 'Expand' must be changed to 'expanding'. This correction also perfectly aligns with the parallel gerund 'facilitating' in Part D ('with a view to expanding... and facilitating...').

Q21. Answer: scale back — The phrasal verb 'scale back' is the standard idiomatic expression used in economic and financial contexts to signify the reduction in the size, extent, or intensity of something like stimulus packages or production. 'Scale down' is less idiomatic in this specific context, making 'scale back' the preferred professional term.

Q22. Answer: tread a fine line — The idiom 'paint oneself into a corner' means to create a situation from which one cannot escape, which does not fit the context of a regulator trying to manage NPA recovery. 'Tread a fine line' is the appropriate idiomatic expression here, as it describes the delicate balance (the 'tightrope walk') the regulator must maintain between aggressive NPA resolution and preventing systemic liquidity issues.

Q23. Answer: be reconciled in a manner that precludes any temporal mismatch between the debiting of the remitting entity and the crediting of the beneficiary account — The original phrase contains two errors: first, the verb 'is reconciled' fails to use the mandative subjunctive mood required by the verb 'necessitates' (which demands the base form 'be reconciled' regardless of the subject's number). Second, 'which' is used to introduce a restrictive clause; in formal English, 'that' is the correct relative pronoun for restrictive clauses. Option C uses the indicative 'are reconciled', which is grammatically incorrect in this formal subjunctive construction. Option D retains the restrictive 'which'. Option E contains a subject-verb agreement error ('manner that preclude' instead of 'precludes'). Option B correctly applies both the mandative subjunctive and the restrictive 'that'.

Q24. Answer: reconcile ... welter ... purgatory — The sentence addresses the operational and technological hurdles faced during the mega-mergers of Public Sector Banks (PSBs). For Blank 1, 'reconcile' is the precise banking and IT term required for making different, incompatible Core Banking Solutions (like Finacle and BaNCS) compatible or aligned. For Blank 2, 'welter' (a state of turmoil, confusion, or a chaotic jumble) perfectly captures the administrative chaos of the transitional IT steering committees. For Blank 3, 'purgatory' (a place or state of temporary suffering or limbo) accurately describes the operational standstill or limbo that credit approvals were subjected to while waiting for unified policies to be established. Other options fail because 'extirpate' (to destroy completely) is contextually incorrect for CBS architectures, 'demarcate' does not apply to integrating software architectures, and 'obfuscate' means to make unclear, which contradicts the goal of integration.

Q25. Answer: mitigate — In banking and economy, when inflation is surging, the central bank (RBI) hikes the repo rate to control or reduce it. 'Mitigate' means to make something less severe, serious, or painful, which perfectly fits the context of controlling inflation. The other options are incorrect: 'exacerbate' means to make it worse, 'prolong' means to extend its duration, and 'stimulate' or 'induce' would mean to encourage or cause more inflation, which contradicts the purpose of raising the repo rate.

Q26. Answer: ensure the adequacy of provisions made against non-performing advances so as to mitigate any potential erosion of the capital adequacy ratio — The original phrase contains a countability error; 'erosion', when referring to the gradual decline of a financial metric like the capital adequacy ratio, is an uncountable noun and should not be pluralized as 'erosions'. Option B is incorrect because 'provision' should be



plural ('provisions') when referring to the aggregate allowances set aside for various non-performing assets in a banking context. Option C uses the incorrect preposition 'to'; the standard English collocation is 'erosion of'. Option D is grammatically incorrect as 'adequacy' is an uncountable noun and cannot be preceded by the indefinite article 'an'. Option E correctly addresses the countability of 'erosion' and maintains the correct technical terminology.

Q27. Answer: mobilize — In the context of green bonds and ESG financing, governments and institutions issue bonds to gather, assemble, or channel funds for environmental projects. 'Mobilize' means to organize and encourage resources to flow toward a specific goal, which perfectly fits the context of raising capital. 'Deplete' (exhaust), 'divert' (turn aside/distract), 'forfeit' (lose), and 'balk' (resist/refuse) do not fit the constructive action of raising funds through bond issuance.

Q28. Answer: C — The error lies in part C. According to Rule 36, when comparing two different qualities of the same object (in this case, the bond's yield profile being 'secure' versus 'lucrative'), we must use 'more [adjective]' rather than the comparative form or a simple adjective. Therefore, 'secure than lucrative' must be corrected to 'more secure than lucrative' to maintain grammatical accuracy.

Q29. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses global regulators planning to introduce a standardized framework for stablecoins in order to reduce or lessen the high volatility risks associated with decentralized finance (DeFi). 'Mitigate' means to make less severe, serious, or painful, which perfectly fits the context of managing financial risks. The other options like 'aggravate' (make worse), 'foster' (encourage/promote), 'neglect' (ignore), and 'manipulate' (control unfairly) do not fit the logical flow of regulatory risk management.

Q30. Answer: dilatory, entrenching — The sentence describes a scenario where a central bank's delayed action regarding supply-chain disruptions leads to a negative economic outcome (the price spiral becoming harder to reverse). 'Dilatory' means slow to act or intended to cause delay, which perfectly describes a sluggish monetary response. 'Entrenching' means establishing something firmly, which fits the context of inflation expectations becoming deeply rooted in the minds of consumers. Other options are incorrect: 'proactive' and 'resolute' would lead to 'dampening' or 'curbing' inflation rather than making it harder to reverse, while 'vacillating' (wavering) does not pair logically with 'alleviating' (reducing) in this context.

Q31. Answer: bolster — The sentence discusses the RBI's implementation of stricter capital adequacy ratios under the Basel III framework, which is aimed at strengthening the banking sector. 'Bolster' means to support or strengthen, which perfectly fits the context of reinforcing banks against financial shocks. Options like 'jeopardize' (endanger), 'dilute' (weaken), 'destabilize' (upset the stability of), and 'bypass' (avoid) are contextually incorrect as they represent negative or irrelevant actions.

Q32. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses how retail investors are restructuring their portfolios by adding defensive assets to reduce or lessen potential capital losses caused by stock market volatility. 'Mitigate' means to make something less severe, serious, or painful, which fits the context perfectly. 'Exacerbate' (make worse), 'precipitate' (cause to happen suddenly), 'forecast' (predict), and 'undergo' (experience) do not fit the logical flow of protecting a portfolio from losses.

Q33. Answer: fail to avert the risk of massive currency depreciation resulting from heightened liquidity stress triggered by a global recession — The original phrase is flawed because 'currency depreciation' and 'liquidity stress' function as uncountable, abstract nouns in formal economic discourse when referring to the general phenomenon. Using the plural forms 'depreciations' and 'stresses' incorrectly implies discrete, countable events rather than a systemic market condition. Furthermore, 'fail to avert' is the standard infinitive construction following 'lest' (in the subjunctive mood), whereas 'fail in averting' is structurally clunky and less precise. Option C correctly employs the uncountable noun forms, maintaining idiomatic precision required for high-level banking exams.

Q34. Answer: subject to rigorous accountability — The idiom 'hold someone's feet to the fire' means to force someone to be responsible for their actions or to ensure they are held accountable. While the idiom is grammatically correct, it is often considered too informal for formal banking discourse. 'Subject to rigorous accountability' provides the necessary professional, regulatory tone required for an SBI PO level context concerning MFI oversight.

Q35. Answer: proliferation, obfuscate — The sentence uses the contrast indicator 'Despite' to set up a tension between a positive trend in green bonds and a persistent problem that fuels greenwashing concerns. 'Proliferation' means a rapid increase in numbers, which fits the massive growth of the green bond market. 'Obfuscate' means to



render obscure, unclear, or unintelligible, which perfectly describes how a lack of standardized frameworks hides or muddies the actual environmental impact, leading to greenwashing. Other options do not fit: 'stagnation' contradicts the growth of the market, while 'elucidate' and 'illuminate' (meaning to make clear) would logically prevent greenwashing rather than fuel it.

Q36. Answer: account for — The phrasal verb 'account for' is required here, meaning to provide an explanation or to take something into consideration. 'Account to' implies reporting to an authority, which does not fit the context of analyzing inflation data.

Q37. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The sentence uses the negative correlative structure 'Seldom... nor...', which requires subject-auxiliary inversion in both clauses. In Part C, the auxiliary verb must agree with the plural subject 'the compounding effects of global supply-chain disruptions and aggressive Federal Reserve rate hikes'. Therefore, the singular auxiliary verb 'has' is incorrect and must be replaced with the plural 'have' to read: 'nor have the compounding effects...'

Q38. Answer: galvanize ... vassalage ... husband — The sentence analyzes the impact of FDI policy in the defense sector. Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to stimulate, shock, or excite into action. 'Galvanize' fits perfectly as the policy was intended to stimulate domestic manufacturing. Blank 2 requires a noun indicating a state of dependence, subordination, or lack of development due to the absence of technology transfer. 'Vassalage' (a state of submission or subordination, here used metaphorically to mean technological dependency on foreign OEMs) fits excellently. Blank 3 requires a verb meaning to use sparingly, conserve, or guard carefully, as foreign companies protect their proprietary technology. 'Husband' (to use resources economically or conserve/guard them closely) fits perfectly in this advanced economic context. 'Squander' (waste) and 'proscribe' (forbid) do not fit the context.

Q39. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses the introduction of offline UPI features by the NPCI to address the issue of transaction failures caused by poor internet connectivity. 'Mitigate' means to make something less severe, serious, or painful, which perfectly fits the context of reducing or minimizing transaction failures. The other options like 'aggravate' (make worse), 'prolong' (extend), 'escalate' (increase rapidly), and 'overlook' (ignore) are contextually inappropriate.

Q40. Answer: stymied, tarnished — The sentence discusses a policy meant to attract FDI that backfired due to a lack of clear regulatory guidelines. 'Stymied' means to prevent or hinder the progress of, which perfectly describes the negative impact of regulatory ambiguity on foreign investors. 'Tarnished' means to damage or ruin the reputation of something, fitting the second blank. Option B (galvanized, bolstered) is too positive; Option C (incentivized, imperiled) is contradictory because ambiguous regulations would not 'incentivize' investors; Option D (deterred, vindicated) does not fit because 'vindicated' means cleared of blame, which is illogical here; Option E (placated, undermined) is incorrect because unclear rules would frustrate rather than 'placate' (soothe/pacify) investors.

Q41. Answer: stimulate — The sentence discusses liberalizing the FDI (Foreign Direct Investment) policy in manufacturing to boost or encourage domestic production and create jobs. 'Stimulate' means to encourage development or increased activity, which perfectly fits the positive and growth-oriented context of the sentence. Options like 'hinder' (obstruct), 'stagnate' (stop developing), and 'deplete' (reduce) are negative and do not fit. 'Regulate' (control) does not align with the goal of expanding production and job creation through liberalization.

Q42. Answer: No replacement — The phrasal verb 'bring about' is correctly used here to mean 'to cause something to happen.' The sentence is grammatically sound, and no replacement is necessary.

Q43. Answer: stipulate that the clearinghouse implement more rigorous collateral hair-cuts to mitigate the risk of a systemic default during periods of extreme volatility — The original phrase uses the indicative 'implements', but the verb 'stipulate' triggers the mandative subjunctive mood, requiring the base form 'implement' regardless of the subject's number. Option C is incorrect because 'mitigate' is a transitive verb; 'mitigate against' is a redundant and formally incorrect construction (one hedges against a risk, but mitigates the risk itself). Option D is an idiomatic failure; the verb 'stipulate' is followed by a 'that'-clause, not an infinitive phrase ('stipulate for... to'). Option E is incorrect due to a countability error; 'collateral hair-cuts' must be plural as it refers to a general set of requirements across various asset classes in a clearinghouse context. Option B correctly applies the mandative subjunctive and maintains formal precision.



Q44. Answer: precipitate a breach of the minimum capital requirements during periods of acute liquidity stress — The sentence employs the conjunction 'lest', which is followed by the subjunctive mood. In the subjunctive mood, the base form of the verb ('precipitate') must be used regardless of the subject ('systemic volatility'), making the original 'precipitates' grammatically incorrect. Option B is incorrect because the noun 'breach' takes the preposition 'of' rather than 'to' when referring to a violation of a rule or limit. Option C is incorrect because 'the breach' implies a specific, previously mentioned event, whereas 'a breach' is required for a hypothetical scenario; furthermore, 'throughout' is less precise than 'during' in the context of a triggering event. Option D is incorrect because 'capital requirements' must be plural to refer to the set of regulatory standards mandated by Basel III. Option E correctly applies the subjunctive 'precipitate', the correct preposition 'of', and the appropriate plurality.

Q45. Answer: account for — The phrasal verb 'account for' is the correct idiomatic expression meaning to explain the cause of something or to constitute a part of a whole. 'Account of' is grammatically incorrect in this context as it functions as a noun phrase (e.g., 'on account of'), not a phrasal verb.

Q46. Answer: bolster — The sentence discusses liberalizing the Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) policy to strengthen or boost domestic production. 'Bolster' means to support, strengthen, or build up, which perfectly fits the positive intention of the policy action. 'Stifle' (suppress), 'deplete' (exhaust/reduce), 'fluctuate' (vary irregularly), and 'jeopardize' (endanger) are contextually incorrect.

Q47. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The sentence uses the correlative adverbial construction 'No sooner... than' to introduce two closely timed events. In Part C, the clause introduced by 'than' uses the dummy pronoun 'there' with subject-verb inversion triggered by the auxiliary verb 'did'. When the auxiliary verb 'did' (past tense of 'do') is used to show tense, the main verb that follows must be in its base form (bare infinitive). Therefore, the third-person singular verb 'emerges' must be replaced with the base form 'emerge' to read: 'than did there emerge a series of regulatory bottlenecks'.

Q48. Answer: temper ... disarray ... abeyance — The sentence analyzes the challenges faced by Microfinance Institutions (MFIs) regarding over-indebtedness and regulatory transitions. Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to moderate, soften, or lessen the severity of the systemic risk; 'temper' (to serve as a neutralizing or moderating force) fits perfectly. Blank 2 requires a noun indicating a state of confusion, breakdown, or lack of order within the joint-liability groups due to credit stress; 'disarray' fits the context of structural disruption. Blank 3 requires a noun representing a state of temporary suspension or inactivity while waiting for operational guidelines; 'abeyance' (temporary suspension) is the precise regulatory term. Other options are incorrect: 'amortize' is semantically incorrect for 'systemic risk'; 'demarcate' does not collocate with mitigating risk; and 'exacerbate' contradicts the intended goal of the MFIs' capacity management.

Q49. Answer: ubiquitous, exacerbate — The sentence presents a contrast using 'While'. The first blank describes the adoption of UPI, which has 'revolutionized' transactions; hence, a word meaning widespread or present everywhere like 'ubiquitous' is highly appropriate. The second blank must reflect the negative impact of a 'persistent deficit in digital literacy' on 'the threat of cyber frauds'. 'Exacerbate' means to make a problem worse, which fits the context perfectly. Other options fail because 'erratic' and 'sporadic' contradict the revolutionary success of UPI, 'negligible' is inaccurate, and 'alleviate' or 'forestall' would incorrectly imply that a lack of literacy decreases cyber fraud.

Q50. Answer: A — The error lies in part A. This sentence contains a dangling participle error under Rule 89 (Pseudo Subjects). The participle clause 'Being a public holiday' lacks a proper subject of its own, which grammatically implies that 'the treasury department' (the subject of the main clause) was a public holiday. To resolve this, an independent subject (pseudo subject) 'It' must be introduced to refer to the day. The correct phrasing is 'It being a public holiday, the treasury department could not process...'

Q51. Answer: keep a close tab on — The idiom 'keep a weather eye on' is typically used for monitoring potential threats in a nautical sense. In the context of financial regulations and digital payment monitoring, 'keep a close tab on' (meaning to monitor someone or something carefully) is the appropriate professional idiomatic expression.

Q52. Answer: No replacement — The phrasal verb 'rely on' is the correct idiomatic expression meaning to depend on something. The other options are grammatically incorrect prepositions when paired with the verb 'rely' in this context.



Q53. Answer: B — The error lies in Part B of the sentence. The phrase 'committed to' is a phrasal adjective where 'to' functions as a preposition, not as part of an infinitive. Therefore, it must be followed by a gerund (verb+ing) rather than a base verb. 'Stabilize' must be replaced with 'stabilizing' to make the sentence grammatically correct. The correct sentence should read: '...the monetary policy committee remains resolutely committed to stabilizing domestic inflation...'

Q54. Answer: B — The error lies in part (B). 'Information' is an uncountable noun and cannot be preceded by the indefinite article 'a'. To make the sentence grammatically correct, 'a vital information' should be replaced with 'vital information' or 'a vital piece of information'.

Q55. Answer: rigorous, mitigate — The sentence discusses the impact of new regulatory frameworks on investor skepticism about greenwashing. 'Rigorous' (extremely thorough and demanding) fits the first blank perfectly as it describes high-quality ESG validation frameworks. 'Mitigate' (to make less severe or serious) fits the second blank, as stricter regulations would naturally reduce or lessen investor skepticism. Other options are logically inconsistent: 'lax' (careless) would not 'compound' skepticism in a positive regulatory context; 'perfunctory' (carried out with minimum effort) would not 'alleviate' skepticism; 'stringent' (strict) is correct for the first blank but 'exacerbate' (make worse) is logically opposite to the expected outcome.

Q56. Answer: be exposed to the risk of impermanent loss that arises from the divergent price trajectories of the paired assets — The conjunction 'lest', meaning 'for fear that', formally triggers the subjunctive mood, requiring the base form of the verb ('be') rather than the indicative ('are'). Therefore, Option A is grammatically incorrect. Option B fails due to a subject-verb agreement error where the singular noun 'loss' is paired with the plural verb 'arise'. Option D is incorrect because 'risk' is a countable noun in this context and requires a determiner ('the' or 'a') to be grammatically sound. Option E contains a number mismatch, as 'trajectory' must be plural ('trajectories') to logically correspond with the 'paired assets'. Option C is correct as it employs the subjunctive 'be', uses the definite article 'the' to refer to the specific financial phenomenon of impermanent loss, and maintains correct subject-verb agreement and noun plurality.

Q57. Answer: No improvement needed — The idiom 'weather the storm' is a standard, highly idiomatic expression used to describe surviving a difficult or precarious situation, such as an economic recession. Since the original phrasing is precise and appropriate for the context, no improvement is required.

Q58. Answer: No replacement — In the context of corporate consolidation, 'merge with' is the standard idiomatic construction used when two entities combine to form a single unit or when one entity joins another. The original phrase is grammatically correct and appropriate for the context of bank mergers.

Q59. Answer: resolve the fundamental bottleneck — The idiom 'cut the Gordian knot' means to solve a notoriously difficult or complex problem in a decisive or bold manner. In the context of rural banking, it refers to overcoming the systemic, complicated documentation requirements that block credit flow to marginalized farmers.

Q60. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses the government's action of releasing buffer stocks to reduce or lessen the negative impact of soaring food inflation on poor households. 'Mitigate' means to make something less severe, serious, or painful, which fits the context perfectly. 'Exacerbate' means to make a problem worse, 'catalyze' means to accelerate, 'simulate' means to imitate, and 'withhold' means to refuse to give, none of which fit the constructive action taken by the government.

Q61. Answer: No correction required — The sentence requires the subjunctive mood because it follows the conjunction 'lest' (meaning 'for fear that'), which mandates the use of the base form of the verb ('be') rather than the indicative ('are'). Therefore, Option B is incorrect. In the relative clause, the subject is 'an assumption' (singular), requiring the singular verb 'fails'; Option D and Option E are incorrect due to the plural verb 'fail'. Furthermore, in financial econometrics, the term 'volatility clusters' is used in the plural to describe the phenomenon of volatility persistence; Option C is incorrect for using the singular 'cluster'. Option A is the only grammatically and technically accurate choice.

Q62. Answer: mobilize — The sentence discusses issuing green bonds to gather or assemble financial resources for eco-friendly projects. 'Mobilize' means to organize or bring resources together for action, which fits the context of raising capital. The other options like 'deplete' (empty/use up), 'squander' (waste), 'withhold' (refuse to give), and 'forfeit' (lose or give up) are contextually incorrect.



Q63. Answer: D — The error lies in Part D of the sentence. The sentence employs a complex structure involving two sets of correlative inversions: 'No sooner... than' and 'not only... but also'. In Part C, the clause following 'than' is correctly inverted using 'did' ('did the sovereign debt yields... spike'). In Part D, the parallel clause introduced by 'but also' must also undergo inversion to maintain structural parallelism. Furthermore, the auxiliary verb must agree in tense and number with the plural subject 'the cascading defaults'. The present singular auxiliary 'has' is grammatically incorrect here; it must be replaced with the plural past auxiliary 'had' (or 'did' to match the tense of the preceding clause) to maintain both subject-verb agreement and the past-tense narrative of the global recession. Thus, 'but also has the cascading defaults' should be corrected to 'but also had the cascading defaults' (or 'but also did the cascading defaults... threaten').

Q64. Answer: accelerate — The sentence discusses the Reserve Bank of India introducing a framework for green deposits to increase or speed up the flow of credit to eco-friendly projects. 'Accelerate' means to increase the speed or rate of something, which fits the positive regulatory objective of promoting green finance. The other options like 'stifle' (suppress), 'deter' (discourage), 'fluctuate' (vary), and 'compromise' (weaken/endanger) run contrary to the positive intent of the policy.

Q65. Answer: No replacement — The phrasal verb 'tethered to' is idiomatically correct in a financial context, meaning to connect or restrict something to a specific reference point or benchmark. The other prepositions do not convey this specific sense of linkage to a target.

Q66. Answer: has exacerbated the liquidity crunch, rendering the traditional mechanisms of monetary transmission ineffective — The subject of the sentence is 'The sudden contraction' (singular). The phrase 'alongside the systemic failure of several shadow banking entities' is a prepositional phrase and does not make the subject plural. Therefore, the verb must be the singular 'has exacerbated', not 'have exacerbated', eliminating options A and E. Option C is incorrect because 'rendered' would create a tense shift or a missing conjunction; the present participle 'rendering' is required to introduce the resultative clause. Option D is incorrect because 'ineffectiveness' is a noun, whereas the sentence requires the adjective 'ineffective' to describe the 'mechanisms'. Option B correctly applies subject-verb agreement and uses the correct participle and adjective forms.

Q67. Answer: B — The error lies in Part B of the sentence. The sentence begins with the adverbial phrase 'Scarcely had', which triggers subject-auxiliary inversion ('had the monetary policy committee announced'). In English grammar, the correlative conjunction pair for 'scarcely' (as well as 'hardly' and 'barely') is 'when' or 'before', not 'than' (which is paired with 'no sooner'). Therefore, 'than' in Part B must be replaced with 'when' to make the sentence grammatically correct: 'Scarcely had the monetary policy committee announced... when the domestic equity markets experienced...'

Q68. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The subject of the clause is 'the macroeconomics of supply-side shocks' (Part B). Nouns ending in '-ics' (such as Economics, Macroeconomics, Physics, Politics) are treated as singular when they refer to a singular academic discipline, field of study, or science. The parenthetical phrase 'when taught as a core academic discipline' confirms that 'macroeconomics' is used here in its singular academic sense. Therefore, it requires the singular verb 'demonstrates' instead of the plural verb 'demonstrate'. The correct sentence should read: '...the macroeconomics of supply-side shocks, when taught as a core academic discipline, clearly demonstrates that...'

Q69. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The sentence utilizes the correlative conjunction 'Not only... but also' to connect two independent clauses, both requiring subject-auxiliary inversion. In Part A, the inversion is correct ('did the National Payments Corporation of India... roll out'). In Part C, the auxiliary verb must agree with the plural subject 'the cross-border linkages'. Therefore, the singular auxiliary verb 'has' is grammatically incorrect and must be replaced with the plural auxiliary verb 'have' to read: 'but also have the cross-border linkages established with Singapore's PayNow and the UAE's IPP catalyzed'.

Q70. Answer: anchor ... tailspin ... abeyance — In central banking, particularly regarding the RBI's MPC, a primary objective of a hawkish stance is to 'anchor' inflationary expectations (ensuring they remain aligned with the target). Blank 1 requires 'anchor'. Blank 2 requires a noun that describes a chaotic or destabilizing market condition that the RBI's VRRR operations sought to prevent; 'tailspin' (a rapid and often chaotic descent or loss of control) fits perfectly, as excessive liquidity can drive overnight call money rates below the floor of the policy corridor, putting the market into a tailspin. Blank 3 requires a term indicating a state of temporary suspension or inactivity;



'abeyance' perfectly describes forward guidance being held in temporary suspension pending clearer fiscal signals. Therefore, 'anchor ... tailspin ... abeyance' is the only logically, economically, and grammatically sound option.

Q71. Answer: C — The error lies in part C. According to Rule 94, certain nouns such as 'equipment', 'information', 'machinery', and 'furniture' are uncountable and do not have a plural form. Therefore, the plural form 'equipments' is grammatically incorrect and must be replaced with the singular 'equipment' (or 'pieces of equipment').

Q72. Answer: hammer out the details of — The idiom 'burn the midnight oil' means to work late into the night, but it cannot be used with 'of' to describe a treaty. The context requires a phrasal verb that signifies the complex process of negotiating and finalizing agreement terms. 'Hammer out the details of' is a standard business idiom meaning to reach an agreement through persistent negotiation, making it the only logically and grammatically correct choice.

Q73. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses the government's aim in issuing sovereign green bonds, which is to reduce or lessen the high capital costs associated with large-scale renewable energy projects. 'Mitigate' means to make less severe, serious, or painful, which fits the context of lowering financial burdens. 'Escalate' (increase), 'jeopardize' (endanger), 'forfeit' (lose/give up), and 'undermine' (weaken) are contextually inappropriate as they imply negative outcomes for the government's green initiative.

Q74. Answer: mitigate — The sentence describes how domestic institutional investors made massive purchases to reduce or lessen the extreme volatility in the stock market during a global sell-off. 'Mitigate' means to make something less severe, serious, or painful, which perfectly fits the context of stabilizing the market. 'Exacerbate' (make worse) and 'trigger' (cause) contradict the intention of supportive buying, while 'forecast' (predict) and 'ignore' do not make sense in the context of active market intervention.

Q75. Answer: consolidate — In the context of PSU bank mergers, the objective is to combine resources to make the capital base stronger and more unified. 'Consolidate' means to combine a number of financial things into a single more effective or coherent whole, which perfectly fits the blank. The other options like 'deplete' (reduce), 'jeopardize' (endanger), 'constrain' (restrict), and 'dilute' (weaken) represent negative actions that contradict the goal of creating stronger global-sized lenders.

Q76. Answer: C — The error lies in part (C). According to the rules of narration and sequence of tenses, the tense of the verb in the reported speech does not change (it remains in the simple present tense) if it expresses a universal truth, habitual action, or permanent economic fact, even if the reporting verb ('explained') is in the past tense. Therefore, the past tense 'eroded' must be replaced with the present tense 'erodes' to correctly state this permanent economic principle.

Q77. Answer: recalcitrant, exacerbate — The sentence discusses how, despite strict insolvency frameworks designed to clean up NPAs, certain uncooperative borrowers continue to worsen the vulnerability of banks. 'Recalcitrant' means stubbornly uncooperative or resistant to authority, which perfectly describes borrowers who refuse to resolve their bad debts. 'Exacerbate' means to make a problem or bad situation worse, which fits the context of increasing systemic vulnerability. The other options are incorrect: 'compliant' contradicts 'uncooperative'; 'transient' (temporary) does not fit the persistent nature of chronic defaulters; 'magnanimous' (generous) is contextually inappropriate; and 'indigent' (poor) does not align with 'forestall' (which means to prevent, whereas these borrowers are worsening the situation).

Q78. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. According to grammatical rules, when two subjects are connected by 'along with', 'as well as', 'together with', 'in addition to', or 'accompanied by', the verb must agree in number with the first subject. Here, the first subject is 'The implementation' (singular), while 'systemic risk buffers' (plural) is the secondary subject introduced by 'along with'. Therefore, the singular verb 'has' must be used instead of the plural verb 'have'. The correct sentence should read: '...along with the newly introduced systemic risk buffers, has significantly enhanced...'

Q79. Answer: roll out — The phrasal verb 'roll out' is transitive and does not require the preposition 'with' when referring to the introduction of a new product or feature. Including 'with' makes the sentence grammatically incorrect.

Q80. Answer: B — The error lies in Part B of the sentence. The phrase 'committed to' is a phrasal preposition where 'to' functions as a preposition, not as part of an infinitive verb. Therefore, it must be followed by a gerund



(verb+ing) rather than a base verb. 'Maintain' must be changed to 'maintaining'. Part D uses an independent finite verb ('and aims to...') which is parallel to 'remains committed' in Part B, avoiding any cascading parallelism errors. The correct sentence should read: '...the monetary policy committee remains committed to maintaining a restrictive stance...'

Q81. Answer: keep their heads above water — The phrase 'keep their books in the black' refers to maintaining profitability (a business state), whereas 'keep their heads above water' is the appropriate idiom for individuals struggling to survive financially or manage debt amidst hardship. Since the context describes borrowers facing crop failure, survival rather than profitability is the intended meaning.

Q82. Answer: dampen the momentum — The idiom 'take the wind out of someone's (or something's) sails' means to make someone or something less confident or less effective, often by causing a sudden setback. In the context of macroeconomics, it refers to slowing down the growth or intensity of inflation.

Q83. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The sentence connects two independent clauses using the correlative conjunction 'Not only... but also', where both clauses undergo subject-auxiliary inversion. In Part C, the auxiliary verb must agree with the plural subject 'the stringent disclosure norms'. Therefore, the singular auxiliary verb 'has' is incorrect and must be replaced with the plural 'have' to read: 'but also have the stringent disclosure norms governing ESG-focused mutual funds'.

Q84. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses the RBI keeping the repo rate unchanged to control or reduce the impact of global commodity price shocks on domestic inflation. 'Mitigate' means to make something less severe, serious, or painful, which perfectly fits the central bank's objective of controlling inflation. Options like 'aggravate' and 'intensify' mean to make things worse, 'procure' means to obtain, and 'abandon' means to desert, none of which fit the context.

Q85. Answer: account for — The phrasal verb 'account for' is the correct idiomatic expression meaning to explain or provide a reason for something. 'Account of' is grammatically incorrect in this context.

Q86. Answer: B — The error lies in part B. According to Rule 15 regarding the use of reflexive pronouns, certain verbs such as 'keep', 'stop', 'turn', 'qualify', and 'move' do not take a reflexive pronoun as an object. Therefore, 'keep themselves away' is grammatically incorrect and should be corrected to 'keep away' to maintain standard formal usage.

Q87. Answer: B — The error lies in part B. According to Rule 116, when a pseudo-subject (such as 'it' followed by a form of the verb 'to be') is used to introduce a pronoun, the pronoun must be in the subjective (nominative) case, not the objective case. Therefore, 'it was them' must be corrected to 'it was they' because 'they' acts as the subject that performs the action of initiating the restructuring.

Q88. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses central banks developing CBDCs to address or reduce the high volatility risks of digital assets (cryptocurrencies). 'Mitigate' means to make something less severe, serious, or painful, which perfectly fits the context of reducing risk. 'Exacerbate' (to make worse), 'propagate' (to spread), 'stagnate' (to stop developing), and 'precipitate' (to cause to happen suddenly) do not fit the logical context of risk management.

Q89. Answer: B — The error lies in Part B of the sentence. The sentence begins with the adverbial phrase 'Scarcely had', which triggers subject-auxiliary inversion ('had the monetary policy committee announced'). In English grammar, the correlative conjunction 'scarcely' (as well as 'hardly' and 'barely') must be paired with 'when' or 'before', not 'than' (which is paired with 'no sooner'). Therefore, 'than' in Part B must be replaced with 'when' to make the sentence grammatically correct: 'when the domestic equity markets plummeted...'

Q90. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The verb 'belong' is a static verb of possession and cannot be used in the continuous ('-ing') form. Even though the sentence refers to a current state ('currently'), it must be expressed in the simple present tense. Therefore, 'that are currently belonging to' must be corrected to 'that currently belong to'. All other parts of the sentence are grammatically correct and structurally sound.

Q91. Answer: stringent, exacerbate — The sentence structure uses 'Although' to set up a contrast between a positive regulatory action and an ongoing negative outcome. 'Stringent' (strict, precise) fits the first blank, describing rigorous disclosure requirements meant to curb bad practices. Despite these strict rules, the fragmented nature of global ratings complicates matters and serves to 'exacerbate' (make worse or increase) the risk of



greenwashing. Other options fail logically: 'lax' (careless) would not contrast with 'although' to make things worse; 'perfunctory' (carried out with minimum effort) does not fit a constructive regulatory push, and 'mitigate' (to lessen) would mean the risk is decreasing, which contradicts the negative concession implied by 'Although... continues to'.

Q92. Answer: unprecedented, alleviate — The sentence uses 'While' to set up a contrast: the fiscal stimulus did something positive (prevented an immediate depression), but the monetary easing has 'still failed to' resolve the negative situation (persistent deflationary pressures). 'Unprecedented' (never done or known before) fits the scale of a massive stimulus package. 'Alleviate' (to make suffering or a problem less severe) fits the second blank perfectly, as the central bank has failed to lessen/ease the deflationary pressures. Other options fail logically: 'negligible' contradicts the idea of preventing a depression, 'sporadic' does not match the scale of such policy measures, and 'compound' or 'exacerbate' would mean they failed to make it worse, which is logically inverted.

Q93. Answer: lest the exit pricing be deemed non-compliant with the pricing guidelines prescribed under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA) — The original phrase contains two grammatical errors. First, the conjunction 'lest' (meaning 'for fear that') requires the use of the subjunctive mood (the base form of the verb 'be') or the auxiliary 'should'; the indicative 'is' is incorrect. Second, the adjective 'compliant' idiomatically requires the preposition 'with', not 'to'. Option B corrects the mood to the subjunctive 'be' but retains the incorrect preposition 'to'. Option D uses the acceptable 'should be' but fails on the preposition 'to'. Option E uses the present participle 'prescribing' where the past participle 'prescribed' is necessary to indicate that the guidelines were established by the Act. Option C is the only choice that correctly employs both the subjunctive mood ('be') and the correct preposition ('with').

Q94. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses the central bank hiking the repo rate in response to rising prices. Raising interest rates is a monetary policy tool used to control or reduce inflation. 'Mitigate' means to make less severe or serious, which perfectly fits the context of curbing inflation. The other options like 'escalate' (increase), 'stimulate' (encourage), 'prolong' (extend), and 'aggravate' (make worse) are counterproductive to the central bank's objective.

Q95. Answer: susceptible to eroding under the strain of high-frequency defaults occurring within the micro-credit portfolios — The original phrase is incorrect because 'susceptible to' must be followed by a gerund ('eroding') or a noun phrase, not the bare infinitive 'erode'. Option B is incorrect because 'default' as a countable phenomenon in credit risk should be pluralized as 'defaults' when referring to the aggregate occurrences in a portfolio. Option D uses the incorrect preposition 'for' instead of 'to'. Option E, while grammatically sound, uses the singular 'default', which is less idiomatic than the plural 'defaults' when describing the systemic impact of multiple micro-credit failures. Option C correctly uses the gerund 'eroding' and the plural 'defaults', adhering to standard banking risk nomenclature.

Q96. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The verb 'mandates' in Part B triggers a subjunctive noun clause introduced by 'that'. When using the correlative conjunction 'not only... but also' to connect two subjunctive clauses dependent on 'mandates', both clauses must use the subjunctive mood (the base form of the verb). In Part B, the first clause correctly uses the base form 'disclose' (assisted by the modal 'must'). To maintain grammatical parallelism and the subjunctive requirement in Part C, the inflected verb 'verifies' must be replaced with the base form 'verify' (i.e., 'but also that an independent third-party auditor verify the environmental impact metrics').

Q97. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. According to standard grammatical rules (Rule 21), certain nouns such as 'mention', 'separation', 'favour', 'leave', and 'sight' do not take a possessive case directly before them. Therefore, using the possessive form 'the nation's mention' is grammatically incorrect. It must be structured using 'of' to avoid the possessive case. The correct phrasing should be 'the mention of the nation'. Thus, Part C should be corrected to: 'surprisingly omitted the mention of the nation'.

Q98. Answer: operating with excessive risk — The idiom 'sailing close to the wind' implies moving dangerously close to breaking the rules or taking unnecessary risks. In the context of rural banking, 'operating with excessive risk' serves as a formal, precise, and contextually accurate replacement that clearly describes the financial imprudence mentioned in the sentence.

Q99. Answer: D — The error lies in part (D). In English grammar, when an imperative sentence represents a proposal or suggestion starting with 'Let us' (or 'Let's'), the correct question tag to use is always 'shall we'.

Therefore, 'shouldn't we' must be replaced with 'shall we' to make the sentence grammatically correct.

Q100. Answer: be proactive in the identification of early warning signals (EWS) to preclude the migration of standard assets into the non-performing category — The sentence employs the verb 'requires that', which is a classic trigger for the subjunctive mood in formal English. The subjunctive mood requires the base form of the verb ('be') regardless of the subject's person or number. Option A is incorrect because it uses the indicative 'is'. Option D is incorrect because it uses 'are', which violates both the subjunctive requirement and the subject-verb agreement (as 'each lending institution' is singular). Option C is logically flawed; using 'within' suggests the assets have already migrated, whereas 'into' is necessary to describe the transition into the NPA category. Option E uses 'for precluding', which is an unidiomatic construction for expressing purpose in this context; the infinitive 'to preclude' is the standard professional usage. Option B correctly applies the subjunctive 'be' and preserves the technical accuracy of the phrase.

Q101. Answer: mitigate — In the context of a global economic recession, central banks aim to make borrowing cheaper to encourage spending and investment. 'Mitigate' means to make something less severe, serious, or painful. Therefore, lowering interest rates to 'mitigate' (reduce/alleviate) borrowing costs fits the context perfectly. 'Escalate' (increase), 'prolong' (lengthen), 'jeopardize' (endanger), and 'fluctuate' (vary irregularly) do not fit the logical objective of central bank policy during a downturn.

Q102. Answer: acerbate ... welter ... abeyance — The sentence analyzes the systemic impact of algorithmic trading during a sudden stock market crash. Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to make a bad situation worse or more severe. While 'exacerbate' is common, 'acerbate' (to make sour, bitter, or severe/worse) is an advanced synonym that fits perfectly. Blank 2 requires a noun indicating a state of confusion, turmoil, or a chaotic mass. 'Welter' (a state of turmoil or chaotic jumble) fits the operational state of the clearing corporations perfectly. Blank 3 requires a noun indicating a state of temporary suspension or being set aside. 'Abeyance' means a state of temporary disuse or suspension, which perfectly fits the context of emergency circuit breakers being put on hold. Option 4's 'acuate' (to make sharp) is incorrect in this context, and 'limbo' is too informal. Option 1's 'quietude' (tranquility) and 'perpetuity' (forever) contradict the chaotic context of stock market volatility.

Q103. Answer: B — The error lies in part B. According to Rule 96, possessive determiners (such as 'our', 'my', 'their') must be placed after 'all' or 'both', not before them. Therefore, the phrase 'our both domestic branches' is grammatically incorrect and must be changed to 'both our domestic branches' to be correct.

Q104. Answer: obviate ... cacophony ... abeyance — The sentence discusses the transition from legacy perimeter security to zero-trust architecture in banking cybersecurity. Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to clear away, bypass, or make unnecessary; 'obviate' fits perfectly as zero-trust and API security directives render legacy perimeter-based defenses redundant or unnecessary. Blank 2 requires a noun indicating a harsh, discordant mixture of sounds or chaotic state caused by excessive false-positive alerts; 'cacophony' (a harsh, discordant mixture of sounds/signals) fits exceptionally well in the context of security analysts overwhelmed by alerts. Blank 3 requires a noun representing a state of temporary disuse or suspension; 'abeyance' fits perfectly because critical patches were temporarily put on hold or suspended while the analysts dealt with the immediate alert fatigue. Other options like 'disintermediate' are technically incorrect in this context, and 'desuetude' implies permanent disuse rather than a temporary holding state.

Q105. Answer: No replacement — The phrasal verb 'beef up' is an idiomatic expression that means to strengthen or add weight to something. In the context of cybersecurity, it is the correct and commonly used term for reinforcing digital defenses.

Q106. Answer: as the existing technical frameworks lack the necessary interoperability to facilitate seamless multi-factor authentication across disparate UPI-enabled payment gateways — The error in the original phrase is the usage of 'interoperabilities' in the plural form. In technical banking architecture, 'interoperability' is an abstract, uncountable noun denoting the capability of systems to communicate. Options A and D are incorrect due to this pluralization. Option C and E use gerundial phrases ('in facilitating' and 'for facilitating') which are grammatically acceptable but contextually inferior to the infinitive 'to facilitate', which expresses the purpose or intended function of the interoperability more directly. Option B correctly identifies the singular form and maintains the most precise infinitive construction for the given context.



Q107. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The phrase 'with a view to' in Part B acts as a prepositional phrasal verb where 'to' is a preposition, which correctly takes the gerund 'bolstering'. To maintain grammatical parallelism, the coordinating conjunction 'and' must connect elements of the same grammatical form. Therefore, the bare infinitive 'mitigate' in Part C must be changed to the gerund 'mitigating' to parallel 'bolstering' (i.e., 'with a view to bolstering... and mitigating...').

Q108. Answer: obviate ... welter ... abeyance — The sentence discusses the unintended operational consequences of a strict regulatory decree on UPI transactions. For Blank 1, we need a verb meaning to prevent, eliminate, or make unnecessary (as the decree was 'expected to' stop fraud). 'Obviate' (to remove a need or difficulty, or prevent) fits perfectly. 'Preclude' also works, but 'extirpate' (to root out/destroy completely) is too extreme for transactional fraud, and 'foment' (instigate) is the opposite of the intended goal. For Blank 2, we need a noun indicating a state of confusion, turmoil, or a chaotic mass because of the sudden technological burden; 'welter' (a state of turmoil or a chaotic jumble) fits beautifully. For Blank 3, we need a noun indicating a state of temporary suspension or holding pattern. 'Abeyance' means a state of temporary disuse or suspension, which perfectly fits 'holding settlements in abeyance'.

Q109. Answer: B — The error lies in part (B). Adverbs like 'already', 'yet', 'just now', and 'recently' indicate an action completed in the past that has relevance to the present, and thus they must be used with the Perfect Tense. Therefore, the simple past 'already approved' should be corrected to the present perfect 'has already approved' (or 'had already approved' depending on context) to be grammatically correct.

Q110. Answer: trade off between — The phrasal verb 'trade off' in this context requires the preposition 'between' to indicate the two competing factors (speed and security) that are being balanced. 'Trade off against' is incorrect as it implies opposition rather than a comparative compromise.

Q111. Answer: in lockstep with — The idiom 'at sixes and sevens' denotes a state of confusion or disarray, which does not contextually fit the requirement for banks to be in compliance or alignment with regulations. 'In lockstep with' refers to acting in perfect accordance or coordination, which is the required state for complying with Basel III mandates.

Q112. Answer: No replacement — The phrase 'brought about by' is the correct phrasal verb meaning 'caused by' or 'resulted from'. The other options either create incorrect idioms or change the meaning of the sentence entirely, making 'No replacement' the correct choice.

Q113. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The word 'machinery' is an uncountable (mass) noun and does not have a plural form ('machineries') when referring to a system, organization, or structure. Even when referring to multiple complex systems or administrative frameworks, the singular form 'machinery' must be used. Therefore, 'administrative machineries' should be corrected to 'administrative machinery'. The corrected sentence should read: '...aiming to streamline the complex administrative machinery...'

Q114. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence due to a dangling modifier. The perfect participle phrase 'having consolidated their disparate balance sheets into a singular balance sheet' must logically modify the entity that performed the consolidation (i.e., the newly merged banks or the management). However, the subject of the main clause in Part D is 'the integration of legacy IT systems', which cannot perform the action of consolidating balance sheets. To correct this dangling modifier and restore logical alignment, Part C and D should be restructured so that the subject of the main clause matches the modifier, for example: '...having consolidated their disparate balance sheets into a singular balance sheet, the newly formed entities still find the integration of legacy IT systems and divergent corporate cultures to be a formidable challenge...'

Q115. Answer: B — The error lies in part B. According to Rule 115, when words like 'but', 'except', or 'between' are used as prepositions, they must be followed by the objective case of the pronoun (me, him, her, us, them) rather than the nominative case (I, he, she, we, they). Therefore, 'except he' must be corrected to 'except him'.

Q116. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The adjective 'committed' must be followed by the preposition 'to' (not 'in') when expressing dedication to an action. Furthermore, in the construction 'committed to', the word 'to' acts as a preposition, which correctly requires the gerund form of the verb ('bolstering') that follows it. Therefore, 'committed in bolstering' must be corrected to 'committed to bolstering'. The corrected sentence reads: '...the central bank remains committed to bolstering the country's import cover...'



Q117. Answer: immutable, facilitate — The sentence contrasts the arguments of cryptocurrency proponents and skeptics. Public blockchains are famously 'immutable' (unchangeable, permanent), which ensures transparency. Skeptics argue that a lack of centralized control will 'facilitate' (make easy or assist) illicit activities. 'Immutable' and 'facilitate' provide the perfect semantic fit for both blanks. Other options like 'transitory' (temporary), 'opaque' (not transparent), and 'malleable' (pliant/changeable) contradict the established technical nature of public ledgers.

Q118. Answer: will not fail to transmit these tightening signals to the real economy, lest the resulting lag in policy transmission should undermine the desired inflation trajectory — The original phrase contains a grammatical error in the 'lest' clause; the conjunction 'lest' (meaning 'for fear that') must be followed by the subjunctive mood (the base form of the verb without 's') or the modal 'should' + base form. Therefore, 'undermines' (the indicative form) is incorrect. Option B is incorrect because 'transmit through the real economy' implies the economy is a medium or conduit, whereas in monetary policy, the economy is the destination/target, making 'transmit to the real economy' the correct technical phrasing. Options C and E are grammatically incorrect because 'lest' cannot be paired with 'would' or 'may'. Option D is the only choice that correctly applies the 'lest... should' construction and utilizes the correct preposition 'to' for policy transmission.

Q119. Answer: C — The error lies in part (C). The preposition 'since' is used to refer to a specific point in time (e.g., 'since 2020' or 'since last quarter'), whereas 'for' is used to denote a duration or period of time. Since 'several consecutive quarters' represents a duration, 'since' must be replaced with 'for' to make the sentence grammatically correct.

Q120. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. According to the grammatical rule for comparing two qualities of the same object/entity (the central bank's stance), we must always use 'more' followed by the positive degree of the adjectives, rather than using a comparative suffix or other structures. Here, the two qualities being compared are 'pragmatic' and 'dogmatic'. Therefore, instead of 'pragmaticer than dogmatic', the sentence must use 'more pragmatic than dogmatic'. The correct sentence should read: '...that the current stance of the central bank is more pragmatic than dogmatic in its approach...'

Q121. Answer: overhaul — The sentence requires a verb meaning to completely revise or repair. 'Overhaul' fits perfectly.

Q122. Answer: phase out — The phrasal verb 'phase out' means to gradually stop using or providing something. Adding the preposition 'of' is redundant and grammatically incorrect in this context. Therefore, 'phase out' is the correct form to describe the closure of redundant bank branches.

Q123. Answer: set aside — The phrasal verb 'set aside' means to reserve something for a specific purpose. Adding the preposition 'for' after 'set aside' in this context is redundant because the purpose (additional assets) follows the verb, making 'set aside' the grammatically correct and concise choice.

Q124. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. The preposition 'to' in the phrasal verb 'commit to' is a preposition, not part of an infinitive. Therefore, it must be followed by a gerund (verb+ing) or a noun phrase, rather than a bare infinitive. The verb 'implement' must be changed to 'implementing' to be grammatically correct. The corrected sentence should read: '...have reluctantly committed to implementing stringent austerity measures...'

Q125. Answer: B — The error lies in Part B of the sentence. The verb 'belong' is a static verb of possession and cannot be used in the continuous (-ing) form. Even though the action is ongoing, it must be expressed in the simple present tense. Therefore, 'are still belonging to' must be corrected to 'still belong to'. The corrected sentence should read: '...several non-banking financial companies still belong to highly leveraged conglomerate structures...'

Q126. Answer: C — The error lies in part (C). When comparing two different qualities of the same entity (the investment portfolio being 'safe' and 'profitable'), we must use 'more' with the positive degree of the adjective instead of the comparative form ending in '-er'. Therefore, 'safer than profitable' must be corrected to 'more safe than profitable'.

Q127. Answer: attenuate ... quagmire ... abeyance — The sentence discusses the regulatory challenges surrounding algorithmic stablecoins and cryptocurrency exchanges. Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to reduce the force, effect, or value of the systemic contagion risks; 'attenuate' (to reduce the force, effect, or value of) fits perfectly. Blank 2 requires a noun to describe the complicated, difficult situation the jurisdictional frameworks are left in; 'quagmire' (an awkward, complex, or hazardous situation) is highly appropriate. Blank 3 requires a noun

indicating a state of temporary suspension or being set aside; 'abeyance' (a state of temporary disuse or suspension) fits the context of guidelines being held back until a G20 consensus is reached. Other options contain mismatched terms: 'amortize' is financially incorrect here, 'demarcate' does not fit the mitigation of contagion risks, and 'exacerbate' would mean regulators are trying to make the risk worse, which is logically incorrect.

Q128. Answer: varnish ... morass ... perilously — The sentence discusses the regulator's attempt to stop banks from hiding the true state of their bad loans (NPAs). Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to gloss over, disguise, or give a deceptively attractive appearance to their balance sheets; 'varnish' fits this perfectly. Blank 2 requires a noun indicating a complicated, stagnant, or difficult situation; 'morass' (a complicated or confused situation which is difficult to escape from) fits the context of regulatory trouble. Blank 3 requires an adverb to describe how the capital adequacy ratios stood below the mandated threshold; 'perilously' (in a way that is full of danger or risk) fits perfectly because falling below capital requirements puts the bank at risk of regulatory sanctions or PCA (Prompt Corrective Action).

Q129. Answer: which not only complicates the migration timeline but also exacerbates the risk of operational glitches during the transition phase — The original sentence contains a subject-verb agreement error: the relative pronoun 'which' refers to the singular act of 'the consolidation' or the 'process', requiring the singular verbs 'complicates' and 'exacerbates'. Option A fails due to the plural verb 'complicate'. Options C and E incorrectly use 'that' for a non-restrictive clause and fail to maintain subject-verb agreement. Option D fails to maintain parallelism in verb conjugation. Option B is correct as it uses 'which' for a non-restrictive clause and applies the correct singular verb forms for both parts of the correlative conjunction 'not only... but also'.

Q130. Answer: write off — In banking terminology, 'write off' is the correct phrasal verb used when a bank removes a debt from its balance sheet that it no longer expects to recover. 'Write down' refers to reducing the book value of an asset, which is different from removing a bad loan entirely.

Q131. Answer: No replacement — The verb 'provide' is correctly followed by the direct object (the villagers) and the preposition 'with' when indicating what is being supplied. 'Provide the villagers with' is grammatically accurate and standard in formal microfinance documentation.

Q132. Answer: in a state of absolute disarray — The idiom 'at sixes and sevens' describes a state of confusion, disorder, or disorganization. In the context of banking regulations, it refers to the banks' lack of preparedness or confusion regarding compliance standards. 'In a state of absolute disarray' acts as a formal and precise functional replacement that maintains the intended meaning of the original sentence.

Q133. Answer: exercise extreme caution regarding — While 'give a wide berth' means to avoid someone or something, it is often too informal for institutional finance reporting. 'Exercise extreme caution regarding' is the most precise and formal replacement that reflects the deliberate risk-management strategy investors employ when facing high market volatility.

Q134. Answer: be calibrated in such a way as to preclude the possibility of liquidity mismatch between the credit-extending bank and the nodal agency — The original phrase contains an idiomatic error; the construction 'in such a way' requires 'as to' when followed by an infinitive to express purpose or result. Option A is incorrect for omitting 'as'. Option C is incorrect because 'in a way to' is colloquially acceptable but grammatically inferior to 'in a way that' or 'in such a way as to' in formal banking contexts. Option D is syntactically flawed because 'such a way that' typically introduces a full clause (e.g., 'such a way that it precludes'), making the direct use of the verb 'precludes' awkward. Option E introduces 'liquidity mismatches'; in financial risk management, 'liquidity mismatch' refers to a systemic state of imbalance and is treated as an uncountable noun. Therefore, Option B is the most precise and grammatically correct choice.

Q135. Answer: C — The error lies in part (C). According to the grammar rules, when 'very' is used with a superlative degree adjective (like 'best') to add emphasis, the definite article 'the' must always be placed before 'very' (i.e., 'the very superlative'). Therefore, 'very best' must be corrected to 'the very best'.

Q136. Answer: C — The error lies in part C. The word 'equipment' is an uncountable (mass) noun and does not have a plural form ('equipments'). To maintain grammatical correctness, 'IT equipments' must be changed to 'IT equipment' or 'pieces of IT equipment'.



Q137. Answer: C — The error lies in part C. According to the grammatical rule, the words 'quite' and 'all' should not be used together to modify a noun because they are redundant and grammatically incompatible in this context. To correct the sentence, 'quite' should be omitted, making the phrase 'successfully mitigated all the operational risks'.

Q138. Answer: enhance — The sentence discusses the positive objectives behind the government's consolidation (merger) of public sector banks, which is to improve or increase operational efficiency and create larger lenders. 'Enhance' means to intensify, increase, or further improve the quality or value of something, making it the perfect fit. Other options like 'stagnate' (stop developing), 'constrain' (restrict), 'jeopardize' (put into danger), and 'dilute' (make weaker) run contrary to the intended positive outcomes of the bank mergers.

Q139. Answer: mitigate — The sentence discusses central banks taking proactive measures (coordinating interest rate cuts) to lessen or soften the harsh effects of a global economic recession. 'Mitigate' means to make something less severe or painful, which perfectly fits the context. 'Exacerbate' (make worse), 'prolong' (extend), 'overlook' (ignore), and 'precipitate' (cause to happen suddenly) are contextually inappropriate as central banks aim to reduce, not increase or ignore, the damage of a recession.

Q140. Answer: B — The error lies in Part B of the sentence. The adjective 'committed' is followed by the preposition 'to'. Since 'to' functions as a preposition here (and not as part of an infinitive verb), it must be followed by a gerund (noun form of the verb). Therefore, the base verb 'achieve' must be replaced with the gerund 'achieving' to be grammatically correct. The corrected sentence should read: '...the government remains firmly committed to achieving its fiscal deficit target...'

Q141. Answer: extirpate ... stasis ... dispensations — The sentence describes the desperate interventions of central banks during a severe global recession. Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to root out, eliminate, or completely erase the toxic, impaired derivative exposures from the financial system; 'extirpate' (to destroy completely or wipe out) fits perfectly. Blank 2 requires a noun describing a state of complete freeze, inactivity, or paralysis in the interbank lending market; 'stasis' (a state of stability, stagnation, or inactivity) accurately depicts this financial freeze. Blank 3 requires a noun representing regulatory exemptions or special permissions that allowed banks to bypass strict capital-adequacy rules to keep capital flowing; 'dispensations' (systemic exemptions from a rule or law) fits perfectly. Other options like 'desuetude' (disuse of customs/laws) or 'strictures' (restrictions) fail to match the economic mechanisms described.

Q142. Answer: foster — The sentence discusses a positive government action (liberalizing the FDI policy) aimed at encouraging or promoting economic growth and attracting foreign capital. 'Foster' means to encourage the development of something desirable, which perfectly fits the context. The other options are incorrect: 'hinder' and 'dampen' mean to obstruct or reduce, 'deplete' means to use up, and 'fluctuate' means to rise and fall irregularly.

Q143. Answer: No replacement — The phrasal verb 'smooth out' is correct here as it means to resolve difficulties or problems. The other options are not idiomatic in this context.

Q144. Answer: avert — The sentence requires a verb meaning to prevent something bad from happening. 'Avert' means to prevent or ward off.

Q145. Answer: C — The error lies in Part C of the sentence. When a clause begins with a restrictive adverbial phrase starting with 'Only after' (as seen in Part B: 'only after the consolidated entities integrated...'), the main clause that follows must undergo subject-auxiliary inversion. Therefore, 'the newly formed board of directors realized' must be inverted to 'did the newly formed board of directors realize' to be grammatically correct.

Q146. Answer: temper ... welter ... limbo — The sentence analyzes the operational and regulatory hurdles faced by MFIs under strict central bank scrutiny. Blank 1 requires a verb meaning to moderate, soften, or mitigate the harsh impact of margin compression; 'temper' fits perfectly here as MFIs try to moderate the impact of reduced margins. Blank 2 requires a noun representing a state of confusion, turmoil, or a tangled mass of bureaucratic procedures caused by tightened rules; 'welter' (a state of confusion or a jumble) fits excellently. Blank 3 requires a noun indicating a state of being unresolved, neglected, or on hold; 'limbo' (an intermediate or transition state where things are forgotten or put on hold) fits the context of pending bank license applications perfectly. Other options fail because 'quietude' (calmness) and 'synergy' contradict the chaotic context, 'exacerbate' (to worsen) is counter-productive to the MFIs' goals, and 'amortize' is financially incorrect for managing margin compression.



Q147. Answer: No improvement needed — The idiom 'in the doldrums' describes a state of inactivity, stagnation, or depression, which is highly appropriate for describing economies experiencing a recession. 'In the red' refers specifically to financial loss, 'under the weather' refers to illness, and 'in the eye of the storm' implies being at the center of a crisis. Since the original usage is both idiomatic and contextually precise, no improvement is required.

Q148. Answer: prepare for necessary action — The idiom 'clear the decks' means to prepare for an event or task by removing obstacles or finishing preparatory work. In the context of NPAs, banks perform asset quality reviews to 'clear the decks'—or prepare for the difficult process of write-offs and provisioning—before closing their fiscal books.

Q149. Answer: lest the ensuing volatility in asset valuations result in a precipitous erosion of the alpha generated during the preceding quarters — The original phrase contains two distinct errors. First, the conjunction 'lest' (meaning 'for fear that') is traditionally followed by the subjunctive mood in formal English, which requires the base form of the verb ('result') rather than the indicative third-person singular ('results'). Second, in the context of portfolio management, 'alpha' refers to the measure of active return on an investment compared to a benchmark; as a conceptual financial metric, it is an uncountable noun, making the plural 'alphas' incorrect. Option A is the original flawed phrase. Option C fails due to the incorrect pluralization of 'alpha'. Option D fails because it uses the indicative 'results'. Option E is grammatically incorrect as it uses 'eroding' (a gerund/participle) where a noun ('erosion') is required to complete the phrase 'a precipitous erosion'. Option B correctly applies both the subjunctive mood and the uncountable nature of the technical term 'alpha'.

Q150. Answer: C — The error lies in part C. According to Rule 43 regarding superfluity and incorrect word usage, the expression 'passing marks' is grammatically incorrect and redundant in formal English. The correct term is 'pass marks'. Therefore, 'minimum passing marks' should be corrected to 'minimum pass marks'.